

ZHENSHUAI JIANG

Critical Spatiality in Genesis 1–11

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Mohr Siebeck

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Preface

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Space is an important dimension of human existence and perception of the world, yet the importance of space was to some extent ignored in traditional scholarship in the social sciences. Before the twentieth century, space was regarded as merely the stage for social relations, and discussion of space took place mainly in physics and philosophy. Prior to Immanuel Kant, the two disciplines considered similar concerns, such as the physical dimension of space and whether space is absolute or relative. After Kant, the study of space in physics and philosophy gradually moved in different directions, according to the interests of philosophers and physicists. Kant himself was more concerned with space in terms of geometry than mechanics. His work is often seen as the beginning of scholarship on space in religious and biblical studies.¹

Social space as a discipline did not attract the attention of scholars until the beginning of the twentieth century. Emile Durkheim was often cited by writers in this period as among the first to systematically discuss social dimensions of space.² Critical spatiality in sociology was established by the 1960s and continued to develop in the following decades. The influence of social dynamics on geography has brought the concept of space into the social sciences, leading to a reexamination of the social forms of space. As understood from a social-scientific perspective, space has come to constitute an important development in academia – no longer considered static and rigid, but rather dynamic and fluid. Since the 1960s, several scholars from different fields have paid close attention to critical spatiality: Henri Lefebvre, Yi-Fu Tuan, Michel Foucault, Gaston Bachelard, and Edward Soja.³

¹ M.K. GEORGE, “Space and History: Siting Critical Space for Biblical Studies,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 15–31, here 21.

² E. DURKHEIM, *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (trans. J.W. Swain; New York: Dover, 1915), 9, 37, 441–42.

³ H. LEFEBVRE, *The Production of Space* (trans. D. Nicholson-Smith; Oxford: Blackwell, 1991, French original 1974); LEFEBVRE, *Rhythmanalysis: Space, Time, and Everyday Life* (trans. S. Elden and G. Moore; Athlone Contemporary European Thinkers; New York: Continuum, 2004); Y.-F. TUAN, *Topophilia: A Study of Environmental Perception, Attitudes, and Values* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1974); TUAN, *Space and Place: The Perspective of Experience* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1977); G. BACHELARD, *The Poetics of Space* (trans. M. Jolas; Boston: Beacon, 1994); and E.W. SOJA,

Literary theory has also begun to pay increased attention to space in narrative. On the one hand, the narrative world in literature cannot be divorced from space; on the other hand, the spiritual world created in literature also contains a reflection of the real world and for this reason is not free from spatial concerns. Recognition of these issues has led to the formulation of a line of inquiry called “space narratology” or “spatial narrative.”⁴ Theoretically, it enables us to consider carefully not only the correlation of space and narratology in general, but also the interaction between them in specific texts.

Conceptions of space in the Bible have been of interest since the medieval period, when the focus was on the divinity of space and the religious meanings of geography. Medieval works discuss space in terms of the connection of God with space, that is, how God gives space its basic characteristics and the similarities between God and space.⁵ From the early modern period onward, space – more specifically, biblical geography – was studied more and more from a historical perspective.⁶ Since the late twentieth century, biblical scholars have

Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and other Real-and-Imagined Places (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 1996). Heterotopias are discussed in M. FOUCAULT, “Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias,” *Diacritics* 16 (1986), 22–27.

⁴ J. FRANK, “Spatial Form in Modern Literature,” in *The Widening Gyre, Crisis and Mastery in Modern Literature* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1963), 3–62, a revised version of “Spatial Form in Modern Literature: An Essay in Three Parts,” *Sewanee Review* 53 (1945), 221–40, 433–56, 643–53; D. HERMAN, *Story Logic: Problems and Possibilities of Narrative* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2002), 263–85; R. ALTMAN, *A Theory of Narrative* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2008), 191–240, 291–314; K. DEMMERLEIN, *Narratologie des Raumes* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 2009), 13–47; M.M. BAKHTIN, “Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel: Notes toward a Historical Poetics,” in *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays* (ed. M. Holquist; Austin: University of Texas Press, 1981), 84–258; M. BAL, *Narratology: Introduction to the Theory of Narrative* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997), 133–45; and G. ZORAN, “Towards the Theory of Space in Narrative,” *Poetics Today* 2 (1984), 309–35.

⁵ An important representative dealing with place and space in the medieval period (600–1500 CE) is T. AQUINAS, *In libros Physicorum Aristotelis expositio* (Turin: Marietti, 1965), book 4, lection 6. For discussion about Aquinas’s view about place and space, see P. DUHEM, *Medieval Cosmology: Theories of Infinity, Place, Time, Void, and the Plurality of Worlds* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1985), 153–59. For discussion of William Ockham’s research on place and space, see E. GRANT, “The Medieval Doctrine of Place: Some Fundamental Problems and Solutions,” in *Filosofia e scienze nella tarda scolastica: Studi sul XIV secolo in memoria di Anneliese Maier* (ed. A. Maierü and A. Paravicini-Bagliani; Rome: Edizioni di Storia e Letteratura, 1981), 57–79. N. ORESME, *Nicolaus Oresmes Kommentar zur Physik des Aristoteles. Kommentar mit Edition der Quaestiones zu Buch 3 und 4 der aristotelischen Physik sowie von vier Quaestiones zu Buch 5* (ed. S. Kirschner; Stuttgart: Steiner, 1997) also discussed place and space in his commentaries on Aristotle’s *Physics*.

⁶ M.K. GEORGE, *Israel’s Tabernacle as Social Space* (AIL 2; Leiden: Brill, 2009), 95–97. We must also keep in mind that biblical geography was already discussed in the medieval period.

increasingly focused on the social dimension of space rather than merely discussing the physical dimension and symbolic meanings of space. To accomplish this goal, traditional methods such as form criticism and literary criticism have been influenced by other disciplines, such as modern geography, philosophy, and sociology. “Critical spatiality” was first defined for biblical scholarship by Jon L. Berquist in his essays “Critical Spatiality and the Construction of the Ancient World”⁷ and “Introduction: Critical Spatiality and the Uses of Theory.”⁸ Critical spatiality not only emphasizes the study of the nature of space but also concentrates on the spatial nature of social reality, highlighting both the ontology and experience of space or place, and is interested in how space acquires symbolic meaning. Lefebvre and Soja’s theory of the trialectic of space in particular has become very common among biblical scholars who engage with spatial criticism.⁹ According to Lefebvre, the trialectic of space involves “perceived space” (which he also terms “spatial practice”), “conceived space” (which he also terms “representations of space”), and “lived space” (which he also terms “representational space”).¹⁰ Soja, following Lefebvre, retermed these three kinds of space as “firstspace,” “secondspace,” and “thirdspace,” and his approach to space is more steeped in postmodern theory.¹¹

The present work adopts this trialectic of space and adapts it as “physical space,” “conceptual space,” and “symbolic space.”¹² Physical space refers to the objective aspect of space. It contains the form, size, position, or direction of a material. It can generally be concrete and observed. For example, the arrangement of the temple and the complex of the tabernacle belong to the physical aspect of space. This space is constructed on the basis of geometry and can be measured. Conceptual space concerns the ideas of space in the mind. It is usually deduced from other media. A map is a typical depiction of conceptual space. That is, we can infer how people living in the medieval period thought about space through analyzing their maps. While a text is not itself a space, we

⁷ J.L. BERQUIST, “Critical Spatiality and the Construction of the Ancient World,” in *“Imagining” Biblical Worlds: Studies in Spatial, Social, and Historical Constructs in Honor of James W. Flanagan* (ed. D.M. Gunn and P.M. McNutt; JSOTSup 359; London: Sheffield Academic, 2002), 14–29.

⁸ J.L. BERQUIST, “Introduction: Critical Spatiality and the Uses of Theory,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 1–12.

⁹ E.g., T.B. DOZEMAN, “Biblical Geography and Critical Spatial Studies,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 87–108; GEORGE, *Israel’s Tabernacle* (see n. 6); and BERQUIST, “Critical Spatiality” (see n. 7).

¹⁰ LEFEBVRE, *Production* (see n. 3), 1–67.

¹¹ SOJA, *Thirdspace* (see n. 3), 53–70.

¹² See also GEORGE, *Israel’s Tabernacle* (see n. 6), 22.

still can infer what authors thought about space by analyzing their descriptions of space or place. Symbolic space is termed by Lefebvre “representational spaces” and by Soja “thirdspace.” Both focus on how the way people live in spaces and places gives them symbolic meanings. An objective place can be emotionally colored since people give it values and symbolic meanings. One and the same place can have different emotional affectivities for different individuals and groups, since different people can give different symbolic meanings to it. Discussion of symbolic space has two dimensions: one concerns the exact symbolic meaning of a certain space or place, and the other concerns how people give symbolic meanings to it. Critical spatiality is more concerned with the latter.

Spatiality in the Bible is very rich. Types of space include nature’s spaces, such as rivers or mountains, human geographical places, such as villages or cities, and even journeys through space, such as those undertaken by Abraham and Jacob in the patriarchal narratives. We can also discuss spatiality with respect to buildings, such as temples and the tabernacle. Another important subject is cosmic space, which is generally reflected in biblical creation accounts.

Biblical texts contain a variety of notions of space, such as cosmic space, mythical space, and architectural space. These types of space are frequently discussed in terms of physical space. In other words, scholars have long paid close attention to the physical characteristics of space. When discussing religious space, Roger Stump claims that physical space is “concerned less with religion per se than with its social, cultural, and environmental associations and effects.”¹³ Such discussion of space in the Bible started during the Renaissance and became increasingly influential after the Enlightenment, finally becoming mainstream at the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth centuries.

Space in biblical narrative was also understood in terms of conceptual space. Conceptual spaces are spaces that are only reflected in texts, such that modern readers cannot experience them in daily life. Some places have not been found by archaeologists. Some space is entirely imaginary. The space in texts is constructed by words, which stem from their authors’ ideas. For example, the design of the tabernacle and the arrangement of the temple, whether or not they existed, clearly reflect the ideas of space in the minds of the authors who describe them. We can also learn about the perception of the cosmos according to creation accounts.

Space in the Bible can, moreover, be discussed in terms of social convention, focusing on how ancient people experienced and used space. Space can acquire symbolic meaning when people give meaning to it. In Lefebvre’s ter-

¹³ R.W. STUMP, “The Geography of Religion: Introduction,” *Journal of Cultural Geography* 7 (1986), 1–3, here 1.

minology, this is “representational space.” In Soja’s terminology, this is “third-space.” Both representational space and thirdspace have to do with symbolic meanings of space. In contrast to the discussion of symbolic meanings in the medieval period, the notion of symbolic space aims to clarify how ancient people attributed meanings to space under certain cultural influences.

In the present work, the theory of critical spatiality will be applied to Gen 1–11 to discuss what concept(s) of space the Priestly and non-Priestly author(s) have and how they are influenced by social and cultural elements. I shall focus on Gen 1, 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. In contrast to the historical accounts, the forms of space found in these texts are more mythical. At first glance, it is hard to argue that there is any social dimension to space in them. For example, most studies on Gen 1 pay attention to cosmology or draw a comparison with the tabernacle narrative.¹⁴ In Gen 6–9, it is not easy to see that contemporaneous social and cultural elements influenced the construction of space in the flood narrative. More attention is paid to the connection of the flood narrative with other ancient Near Eastern flood myths.

As a methodology, I shall use spatial narrative theory to discuss how space is constructed in Gen 1–11. Spatial narrative is the literary treatment of spatial theory, which studies how and to what extent narrative strategy influences the idea of space present in literature. In other words, spatial theory analyzes how space is rhetorically constructed in texts, that is, how space in texts is constructed by narrative elements such as perspectives, characterization, and plot. Early representatives of spatial narrative theory include Mikhail Bakhtin, followed by Algirdas Julien Greimas, Joseph Frank, and Gabriel Zoran in the late

¹⁴ J. BLENKINSOPP, “The Structure of P,” *CBQ* 38 (1976), 275–92; T.E. FRETHEIM, *Exodus* (Louisville, KY: John Knox, 1991), 268–72; F.H. GORMAN, Jr., *The Ideology of Ritual: Space, Time, and Status in the Priestly Theology* (JSOTSup 91; Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1990), 39–60, esp. 42; P.J. KEARNEY, “Creation and Liturgy: The P Redaction of Ex 25–40,” *ZAW* 89 (1977), 375–87; J.D. LEVENSON, *Creation and the Persistence of Evil: The Jewish Drama of Divine Omnipotence* (San Francisco: Harper and Row, 1988), 84–86; M. BUBER, “People Today and the Jewish Bible: From a Lecture Series (November 1926),” in *Scripture and Translation* (ed. M. Buber and F. Rosenzweig; ISBL; Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1994), 4–26; F. ROSENZWEIG, “Scripture and Luther (July 1926),” in *Scripture and Translation* (ed. M. Buber and F. Rosenzweig; ISBL; Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1994), 47–69; U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Exodus* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1967), 476; M. WEINFELD, “Sabbath, Temple, and the Enthronement of the Lord: The Problem of the *Sitz im Leben* of Genesis 1:1–2:3,” in *Mélanges bibliques et orientaux en l’honneur de M. Henri Cazelles* (ed. A. Caquot and M. Delcor; AOAT 212; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1981), 501–12; E. BLUM, *Studien zur Komposition des Pentateuch* (BZAW 189; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1990), 306–12; B. JANOWSKI, “Tempel und Schöpfung: Schöpfungstheologische Aspekte der priester-schriftlichen Heiligtumskonzeption,” in *Schöpfung und Neuschöpfung* (ed. I. Baldermann et al.; JBTh 5; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1990), 37–69.

1960s.¹⁵ Rarely has biblical studies discussed space from a narrative perspective.¹⁶ I shall use spatial narrative theory to argue that the perspectives, characterization, motion verbs, prepositions, metaphors, and juxtapositions play a significant role in constructing space in narrative texts and influence the social dimension of space.

More specifically, this work tries to make a connection between social space and narrative space, asking various questions about the social dimension of space in Priestly and non-Priestly texts in Gen 1, 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. How does narrative space reflect the social dimension of space? Why is narrative space essential for constructing space in these texts? What are the connections between social space and narrative space? For instance, where is God when he creates the world in Gen 1? Does Gen 1 reflect anthropocentrism in terms of human space? What is space and spatial relation in Gen 1? Is it appropriate to say in the flood narrative that the world is destroyed and recreated, at least on the level of physical space?

The first two chapters introduce and give historical context for the study of space. Studies of space have focused mainly on the relationship between absolute space and relative space. In other words, is space relative or absolute? Is absolute space necessary? This is a significant problem that philosophers and physicists from Plato and Aristotle to Isaac Newton tried to resolve. Kant is discussed in the most depth since, after him, discussion of space is increasingly concerned with the social dimension of space. I shall then provide a survey of the field of critical spatiality over the last decades, when it became somewhat conventional to claim that space and spatiality are social and cultural constructions. According to this view, space is quasimaterial and sometimes it even can be understood as a social product. The main representatives of this position are Doreen Massey, David Harvey, Manuel Castells, and Lefebvre, who were anticipated by Durkheim and Georg Simmel.¹⁷

Chapters 3–6 discuss the formation, development, and basic characteristics of Priestly texts, especially Gen 1 and 6–9. Chapter 3 summarizes key features

¹⁵ BAKHTIN, “Forms of Time and of the Chronotope” (see n. 4); FRANK, “Spatial Form” (see n. 4); ZORAN, “Towards the Theory of Space” (see n. 4); and A.J. GREIMAS, *Maupassant, The Semiotics of Text* (trans. P. Perron; Amsterdam: J. Benjamins, 1988), 22–23, 76–100.

¹⁶ E.g., J.F.A. SAWYER, “Spaciousness: An Important Feature of Language about Salvation in the Old Testament,” in *ASTI* 6 (1968), 20–34 and L.I.J. STADELMANN, *The Hebrew Conception of the World: A Philological and Literary Study* (AnBib 39; Rome: Pontifical Biblical Institute, 1970), 1–36.

¹⁷ M. CASTELLS, *The Rise of the Network Society* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2010), 440–47; D. HARVEY, *The Condition of Postmodernity: An Enquiry into the Origins of Cultural Change* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1992), 201–328; LEFEBVRE, *Production* (see n. 3), 1–67, esp. 26–46; LEFEBVRE, *Rhythmanalysis* (see n. 3), 85–100; DURKHEIM, *Elementary Forms* (see n. 2), 9, 37, 441–42; and D. MASSEY, *For Space* (London: Sage, 2005), 61–104, 147–95.

of space in Priestly texts in order to understand space in the Priestly primeval history. It begins with a discussion of the structure of Priestly texts and then surveys some key concepts in the Priestly texts about three points: the primeval history, Noah's covenant, Abraham's blessing, and the tabernacle. Order and structure, universalism, the development of monotheism, and positive salvation theology will be shown to be significant characteristics of Priestly texts.

The discussion aims to clarify when Priestly texts were composed. Two methods are usually used for dating: text and social locus. In the present discussion, I assume that the Priestly texts date to the late exilic period and the beginning of the Persian Empire (539–331 BCE) in terms of the characteristics of social space they present. I shall therefore briefly review social space in the Babylonian exile in order to understand how the social locus influences the idea of space in Priestly texts.

After discussing the date and social locus of Priestly texts, I shall summarize several important characteristics of Priestly narrative space. Although there are many discussions of space in the Priestly texts, most of them are more concerned with the cosmic view reflected in narratives and well-structured space described in texts. For present purposes, we can acquire more information about spatial ideas and social dimensions of space through the discussion of narrative space. For example: Where exactly are God and humanity located in Priestly thinking? What is the Priestly religious and aesthetic attitude toward particular landscapes? How are the ideas of space reflected in the narrative? According to the structure of the Priestly texts, I shall concentrate on God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space.

Chapter 4 introduces physical space in Gen 1 and 6–9, discussing how physical space forms part of the narrative. Physical space is the foundation of conceptual space and symbolic space. Physical space generally refers to geographical space and architectural space. It can be constructed through expository prose introducing a certain place or a location. It can also be constructed more conceptually in a space-oriented narrative.

In terms of spatial narrative, physical space is constructed mainly through position words, prepositions, and motion verbs. When introducing form and position, the narrative perspective also plays an important role. Accordingly, this chapter discusses God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space in terms of prepositions, motion verbs, and narrative perspectives.

Genesis 1 tells how God creates the cosmos and the world where humans and animals live; the Priestly authors show a strong interest in nature's space. Prepositions, motion verbs, and narrative perspectives are significant in constructing nature's space. More importantly, Priestly authors are more concerned with spatial relations than with specific spatial locations. In comparison with Gen 1, the flood narrative has a more detailed description of God's space and humanity's space. God's space is divided into the space before the flood, the space during the flood, and the space after the flood. There are also some

typical spaces such as Noah's ark in the flood narrative. Noah's ark can be understood simultaneously as physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space.

Chapter 5 discusses conceptual space in Gen 1 and 6–9. We cannot experience physical space directly in a text, but we can come to know the conceptual space of its authors. For example, although we cannot experience the cosmos and the world that the Priestly authors describe in Gen 1, we know how the authors think about the cosmos. We cannot experience the flood that is described in the Priestly flood narrative, but we know the idea of a fluid boundary between natural and supernatural space. The space described in Gen 1 is, in principle, conceptual. Special attention will be paid to its order and structure.

In the present discussion, I shall first present the difference between the vertical view of the cosmos in Gen 1 and the vertical view of neighboring cultures. Then I will analyze how this order and structure is reflected in the narrative. As narrative strategies, the emphasis on spatial relations rather than place and the lack of words for the cardinal directions both play a significant role in constructing conceptual space. I shall also discuss how universalism as an important Priestly view influences the idea of space in Gen 1.

Another important conceptual space reflected in Gen 1 and Gen 6–9 is mythical space. Although it is agreed that Gen 6–9 is influenced by other ancient Near Eastern flood myths, the flood narrative is a part of the biblical historiographical narrative, and Gen 6–9 should thus be discussed in this context.¹⁸ The present discussion focuses on the way in which mythical space and nonmythical space are framed in the narrative. The aim is to see how Gen 1 keeps the mythical characteristic of space and at the same time actualizes mythical space in order to take it as the beginning of Israelite historical narrative.

Generally speaking, the conceptual space in Gen 6 corresponds to that in Gen 1. Genesis 6–9 recreates the space created in Gen 1. For example, Gen 6, like Gen 1, shows the traditional vertical view of the cosmos. Genesis 6–9 also presents mythical space as well as nonmythical space. The present discussion pays attention to how Priestly authors make space mythical and at the same time nonmythical, and it discusses how the two concepts of space are juxtaposed rhetorically in the same text.

Chapter 6 discusses what cultural and social factors might have influenced the construction of symbolic space in Gen 1 and 6–9. Symbolic space is not as abstract as conceptual space. Symbolic space is the space where people live and which they experience. Humans can live in a variety of spaces and use them, because humans can freely give symbolic meanings to space. Symbolic space can be constructed through conceptual symbolic meanings. It can also be

¹⁸ For this particular historical view of the Hebrew Bible, see K. SCHMID, "The Canon and the Cult: The Emergence of Book Religion in Ancient Israel and the Gradual Sublimation of the Temple Cult in Biblical Society," *JBL* 131 (2012), 289–305.

constructed through concrete material things. I discuss Gen 1 as an example of how space in Gen 1 is constructed symbolically by conceptual symbolic meanings, while I discuss the Priestly flood narrative as an example of how space is constructed symbolically through a visible phenomenon: the rainbow. The meanings of these symbols in appropriation of the authoritative space are emphasized in modern spatial theory, especially Soja's discussion of thirdspace. He pays close attention to the function of race, class, and gender. An important feature of symbolic space is struggle, appropriation, or adaption of the authoritative space. Accordingly, in the present discussion I shall analyze whether Priestly authors offer symbolic meanings in Gen 1 and Gen 6–9 while challenging other symbolic meanings in the culture.

Because symbolic meanings are influenced by society and culture directly, I shall first discuss the cultural milieu in which Gen 1 was written. Then we can understand why the Priestly authors described a well-ordered and well-structured cosmos. Spatial reality also influences the symbolic meanings of space. Landscapes, squares, and even public festivals are social spaces that influence and to some extent determine the symbolic meanings of space in Gen 1. It is reasonable to argue that symbolic space is constructed on the basis of physical space and conceptual space. For example, the emphasis on spatial relations influences symbolic meanings. How do the Priestly authors challenge the traditional meanings of space? How does the space in Gen 1 later become the authoritative space? I address this by comparing Gen 2 with some creation texts in Psalms.

The symbolic meanings of space are very rich in the Priestly flood narrative. It is noteworthy that a symbol is mentioned explicitly: the rainbow, a symbol of the covenant between God and humanity. I shall therefore discuss how the "bow" in Gen 9:13–17 moves from natural phenomenon to sign and how this sign acquires its symbolic meaning. The aura of the bow makes the concept of covenant spatial. Symbolic meaning is derived not just from signs but also from practices. A sign generally acquires its symbolic meaning through human practices. A certain space or place normally acquires symbolic meaning through human practices in it. For example, religious rituals play an essential role in giving symbolic meanings to ritual places. In the Priestly flood narrative, the bow becomes a sign through the act of God establishing a covenant with humans. Then Mount Ararat, as a unique, historical, and imagined place through retelling becomes a public, symbolic, and eternal place. As in Gen 1, the Priestly authors of the flood narrative challenged, appropriated, and adapted the traditional space. Different ideas of space are also juxtaposed in Gen 6–9 because the flood narrative is a juxtaposition of Priestly texts and non-Priestly texts. I shall compare space in Priestly and non-Priestly texts in order to see how the Priestly covenant space appropriates the traditional idea of sanctuaries and cult places.

In Chapters 7–10, I shall take Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9 as examples to describe how physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space are constructed rhetorically in the non-Priestly texts. Chapter 7 provides a brief review of the structure, the important concepts, and the possible compositional dates of Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. Compared to the Priestly texts, the non-Priestly material in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9 is made up of relatively independent narrative units. I shall also discuss the characteristics of narrative space in the non-Priestly texts. While the concepts at issue are difficult to summarize in the non-Priestly texts as a whole, the spaces and spatial settings in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9 can be described, as can those in the Priestly texts, from the perspective of God’s space, humanity’s space, and nature’s space.

Chapter 8 introduces the way in which physical space is constructed rhetorically in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. The garden in Gen 2–3 is the fundamental space. It is established as the center of the world. The garden contains a variety of spatial elements. The space associated with God is reflected mainly in God’s actions. God creates the world, plants the garden, and walks in the garden. The space associated with humanity is reflected in the actions of the first man and Eve. There are two types of nature’s space in the Eden narrative: the space of the world and the spatial settings in the garden in Eden. In the Eden narrative, Gen 2:10–14 describes four rivers with both locative and nonlocative elements, which makes the passage unique. In the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, God and Noah are the two main actors. The space associated with God and humanity can be described according to the actions of God and Noah, respectively. The ark is, as in the Priestly version, the most well-defined space in the non-Priestly flood narrative. As nature’s space, the most significant space in the non-Priestly flood narrative is the earth. Genesis 11:1–9 contains different kinds of spaces and places, which are essential narrative elements. The verbs of motion, narrative perspectives, and prepositions rhetorically construct God’s space, humanity’s space, and nature’s space.

Chapter 9 discusses the concepts of space in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. All three of these texts present a view of the cosmos. In Gen 2–3, the creation account appears mainly in Gen 2:4b–7 and reflects both horizontal and vertical views of the cosmos. Conceptual space is portrayed mainly with respect to the garden in Eden. The function of the garden is described from the perspective of two sets of relationships: the relationship between the garden in Eden and the earthly world, on the one hand, and the relationships among God, humanity, and the garden in Eden, on the other. On the whole, the garden in Eden is described intentionally by the non-Priestly narrator as an “other” space. On a thematic level, there is also an important type of conceptual space in the Eden narrative: the distance between God and humanity. The distance between God and humanity is reflected in the use of the verbs “command,” “call,” and “say.” Genesis 2–4 also involves spatial continuity. The structure of the cosmos is an important type of conceptual space in the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen

6–9 as well. The non-Priestly narrator pays close attention to the earth. The scale of the earth is an important aspect of conceptual space, and the earth remains the spatial focus throughout the non-Priestly flood narrative. Regarding the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9, the conceptual space is reflected mainly in three tensions: the tension between God’s space and humanity’s space; the tension between locative place and universal space; and the tensions among the city, the tower, and the whole earth.

Chapter 10 discusses symbolic space in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9. The garden is the most important symbolic space in Gen 2–3. That the garden may symbolize a place near Jerusalem is suggested mainly by the descriptions of rivers in Gen 2:10–14. At the same time, the narrative in Gen 2:10–14 juxtaposes the geographical and nongeographical dimensions of the rivers. The garden in Eden is on the whole nonlocative. The function of the cherubim relates to the garden more specifically with the Jerusalem Temple and sets the garden apart as a sacred space. The event of rebuilding the temple around 515 BCE might have influenced the symbolism of the garden in Eden. The non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 contains three important types of symbolic space. The correspondence between spatial settings in God’s speech in Gen 7:1–5 and spatial settings in Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23 symbolizes God’s absolute authority over the earth. Then, in Gen 8:6–13b, the ark, through Noah’s actions, symbolizes the center of the world, evident in the connection of the ark (תבת) and its cover (מכסה) with their descriptions in Exod 2 and certain tabernacle narratives (Exod 26:14; 36:19; 39:34; 40:19). After the flood, the primary symbolic space is the altar. God’s monologue beside the altar gives symbolic meaning to the altar. The description of the altar in Gen 8:20–22 indicates an anti-iconic concept. At the same time, the absence of the mountain, which is usually connected with the altar, suggests that the non-Priestly narrator of Gen 6–9 appropriates the traditional symbolic meaning of the altar. The discussion of symbolic space in Gen 11:1–9 limits itself to the city and the tower, which are used to show the power of humanity in having the same language. On the one hand, the rhetoric of the Babel narrative challenges the traditional symbolic meanings of the city in Gen 1–11. On the other hand, the function of the tower seems mainly to reflect the power of humanity. The tower itself is not the narrative focus, and its symbolic meaning is traditionally overemphasized. On a thematic level, the Babel narrative also reinterprets the relationship between the multiplying of people and the multiplying of language.

Finally, Chapter 11 elaborates on how space is described differently in Priestly texts (Gen 1, 6–9) and non-Priestly texts (Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9) of Gen 1–11. Specific texts are compared: Gen 1 and Gen 2–3, the Priestly version and non-Priestly version of Gen 6–9 (this chapter also discusses what characterizes space in the final text of Gen 6–9), Gen 1 and the non-Priestly flood narrative, the Priestly flood narrative and Gen 11:1–9, Gen 2–3 and the Priestly flood narrative, and Gen 1 and Gen 11:1–9. These comparisons will be

made in terms of physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space and will allow us to see whether the spaces in these texts interrelate, depend, adapt, appropriate, or are independent of each other.

Chapter 12 briefly reviews the contents of the present work, summarizes the basic arguments, and suggests three main contributions to the study of space in the Hebrew Bible.

Chapter 2

The Study of Space from Plato to the Present

This section presents a brief survey of studies of space from Plato to modern philosophers such as Henri Lefebvre. It contextualizes two concepts – social space and narrative space – within the history of the study of space and then seeks to understand both in the context of biblical space. Two key questions will be addressed: How does narrative space reflect the social dimension of space? and What is the connection between social space and narrative space? Before the spatial turn – a shift of focus to social space in modern sociology and human geography – the study of space followed two branches, physical space and philosophical space, although the boundary between physical space and philosophical space became clear only after the work of Immanuel Kant. After discussing both physical and philosophical space from Plato to Kant, I shall focus on the philosophical aspect of space that includes cultural space, religious space, and social space in the twentieth century and then discuss the concept of narrative space.

2.1. Classical Thoughts on Space

The word “space” is used commonly in daily life, but it is not necessarily well understood. Depending on their background and experience, different people have different definitions and concepts of space.

Space is usually defined in terms of place. The connection between space and place is another important issue in spatiality theory.¹ For Aristotle, space is the congregation of different places. In his theory of space, he discusses place instead of space. Subjects occupy their different places, while space is the congregation of places. For instance, in a residential neighborhood, every house has its own place, and all of these houses along with their places form a residential space. Place is fixed: a single house has just a location. Space, however, is very fluid. This is why there are so many kinds and so many definitions

¹ Y.-F. TUAN, *Space and Place: The Perspective of Experience* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1977), 6; K.E. FOOTE and M. AZARYAHU, “Social and Cultural Geography: Sense of Place,” in *The International Encyclopedia of Human Geography* (ed. N. Thrift; Oxford: Elsevier Science, 2009), 96–100; and M.-L. RYAN, “Space, Place and Story,” in *Medienkonvergenz-Transdisziplinär* (ed. S. Füssel; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2012), 109–28.

of space. Space involves not only the physical environment but also a conceptual and cultural area. Because space is not as fixed as place, mobility is an important characteristic of space. Yi-Fu Tuan puts it this way: "Space, we have noted, is given by the ability to move."²

Space is more abstract than place. People can give different meanings to space. Its function is not emphasized as much as place. For example, an opera house, a church, or a home are not merely natural spaces. We should also keep in mind that space has an essential connection with place. They require each other in order to be properly defined. From the security and stability of place, we are aware of the openness, freedom, and threat of space, and vice versa.³ For example, the garden in Eden is not just a physical place. It is a very complex space.

In our daily life, we have concepts such as private space, cyberspace, social space, physical space, and so on. Among different definitions of space, a popular one is that space is a free expanse. It can be like a container in which different things have their positions and move in different directions. Whether the different things in the container keep still or move freely, they always take up a position relative to the others. Space as a container provides a position for materials, yet materials in the container have nothing to do with the container itself. Nevertheless, space as a container, which is also termed "absolute space," was not proved and described systematically until Isaac Newton in the seventeenth century.⁴ Why was the concept of space as a container not proven until Newton? How did people understand space before Newton? I shall start the discussion from Plato, whose work framed the discussion for thousands of years.

Plato's ideas about space are found primarily in the *Timaeus*.⁵ He discussed his view of the cosmos dialectically. Plato called the world in which we live the "physical world," or the "world of physics," and argued that there is still another world called an "ideal world," or a "world of forms."⁶ This ideal world is made of perfect geometric shapes, and the elements of our living world are

² TUAN, *Space and Place* (see n. 1), 12.

³ *Ibid.*, 6.

⁴ For Newton's description of absolute space and its relationship to motion, see I. NEWTON, "On the Gravity and Equilibrium of Fluids (*De Gravitatione*)," in *Unpublished Papers of Isaac Newton: A Selection from the Portsmouth Collection in the University Library, Cambridge* (trans. and ed. A.R. Hall and M.B. Hall; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1962), 121–52.

⁵ PLATO, "Timaeus," in *Readings in Ancient Greek Philosophy: From Thales to Aristotle* (trans. D.J. Zeyl; ed. S.M. Cohen, P. Curd, and C.D.C. Reeve; Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, 1995), 463–66.

⁶ Plato used the cave as a symbol of this world in the *Republic*; see PLATO, *Republic* (trans. R. Waterfield; Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993), 244.

created in the image of such forms. According to this worldview, space mediated between his two worlds: when copies of forms in the ideal world were created in the world in which we live, they were created in space.

Furthermore, space for Plato was identical with matter. If space is identical with matter, however, why are we unable to experience it just as we experience other matter? If space is matter, how does it receive the other matter, and how does it share position with the other matter? Plato addresses these problems by arguing that space is mostly identical with matter, but it is different from matter because space is pure matter. Space provides the form to matter, but space does not have form itself, which implies the complex issue concerning the relationship between space and matter. Because space is at the same time matter and pure matter, Plato suggests that there are two ways to gain knowledge of space. One way is by reason, which allows us to know pure matter. Another way is by experience, which makes us know space in the physical world. Plato thus sets the tone for both rationalism and empiricism in later discussions of space.

Aristotle is one of the representatives of empiricism. In his *Physics*, he discusses place instead of space. For Aristotle, space is a congregation of places.⁷ Place is either shape, or matter, or some sort of extension between the extremities. Because space can be separated from matter, shape cannot be separated from matter; space is not shape. If place is identical with matter, it cannot be separated from itself. The extension between the extremities is the volume which “is not the matter enclosed, but something independent of the object.” This idea is incompatible with the notion that space is not matter. Only the extremities are possible.⁸

Plato and Aristotle influenced the discussion of space for the next two thousand years. Especially after René Descartes, physicists and philosophers sought to resolve questions such as whether or not space is matter and what the relationship is between space and matter. Before Descartes, the influence of Plato and Aristotle was mainly on Muslim scholars, while theological thought focused on the divine aspects of space and influenced both Descartes and Newton.⁹

The Hebrew Bible contains no direct mention of the concept of space as expressed in Plato’s *Timaeus* and Aristotle’s *Physics*. The basic concept of

⁷ ARISTOTLE, “Physics,” in *The Complete Works of Aristotle: The Revised Oxford Translation* (2 vols., trans. R.P. Hardie and R.K. Gaye; ed. J. Barnes; Bollingen Series 71.2; Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1995), 1:354–62.

⁸ N. HUGGETT (ed.), *Space from Zeno to Einstein: Classic Readings with a Contemporary Commentary* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1999), 76–77; M.K. GEORGE, “Space and History: Siting Critical Space for Biblical Studies,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 18.

⁹ M. JAMMER, *Concepts of Space: The History of Theories of Space in Physics* (New York: Dover, 1993), 27–52 and HUGGETT, *Space* (see n. 8), 85–90.

space in the Hebrew Bible is evident in how the authors structure space according to their view of the cosmos. Some texts involve no concept of the whole world in terms of a horizontal cosmos but show the idea of vertical cosmos instead. The world is classified into three levels: heaven, earth, and under earth (Gen 1:1; 2:1, 4, 5; 14:19, 22). This vertical axis of the world is interpreted theologically: God and heavenly beings live in heaven (Gen 6:1, 4; Job 1), humanity and other creatures live on earth, and dead people live underneath. In the center of the vertical axis of the cosmos is a temple.

A significant characteristic of the world in Gen 1 is that it is created and developed by one God. Genesis 1 describes a monotheistic world, in the development of which God intervenes freely, as reflected in the flood narrative of Gen 6–9. God can be here and there at the same time. This view led to the association of God and space as an expression of God's ubiquity.

In the modern period, Descartes was the first to discuss space in terms of the connection between matter and space. His basic philosophical principle is the distinction between mind and matter. As implied by his dictum *cogito, ergo sum* 'I think, therefore I am', mind is more reliable than matter. In other words, we can gain true knowledge only through reason. Such distinction became the basis of his argument that space was identical with matter, which is the same as Plato's rationalism and contrary to the empiricism of Aristotle. Descartes claimed that the essential nature of matter is its extension, meaning that matter can extend in three directions.¹⁰ Space is thus pure extension, as it can extend in three directions. Descartes thus identified space as matter.¹¹ Nevertheless, he also faced the problem that Aristotle posed: In our experience, matter can move from one place to another place, so is space not separated from matter? How can space be identified with matter? To answer this question, Descartes used the concept of relative space, the opposite of which is absolute space.

Descartes posited two kinds of space: general space and particular space. Consider a stone. Stone is matter, the essential characteristic of which is extension. When the stone moves from one place to another, its extension characteristic moves from the place where the stone was located, meaning that the stone's space also moves. Descartes calls this space "particular space" because it belongs only to this stone. On the other hand, volume provides a fixed place for the stone.

Matter cannot exist without such space, which does not belong to particular matter but is fixed relative to other matter. The space the matter takes is not space independent of matter; rather, it is the relative position. All matter thus exists relatively, and space is relative. The relative space of Descartes signified

¹⁰ R. DESCARTES, "Principles of Philosophy," in *The Philosophical Writings of Descartes* (3 vols.; trans. and ed. J. Cottingham, R. Stoothoff, and D. Murdoch; Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984–91), 1:193–291.

¹¹ HUGGETT, *Space* (see n. 8), 100–5.

the beginning of modern science and led to arguments about whether space is relative to other matter or independent of matter.

Newton argued that there must be absolute space in which matter has true motion. Such absolute space is like a chocolate box without boundaries. Each chocolate, whether it is stable or moving, takes up a certain independent place that has no relationship to the other chocolates. Why must an abstract absolute space exist? Absolute space is the presupposition for Newton's first law of motion: "Everybody perseveres in its state of being at rest or of moving uniformly straight forward, except insofar as it is compelled to change its state by forces impressed."¹² The inertial motion is absolute motion, which is called "true motion," implying that the motion we experience in reality is relative motion. We can justify whether or not we are moving only vis-à-vis a reference frame that we choose. Different from the motion observed in reality, however, inertial motion is absolute motion which needs an absolute reference frame. As discussed in Descartes, there is no absolute stable matter in the world, so all matter must move relatively. But if there is absolute space, then inertial motion – in other words, Newton's first law of motion – can be maintained.

Newton's absolute space has three important characteristics: absolute space is immutable, infinite, and three-dimensional – the Euclidean notion of space.¹³ Newton's concept of absolute space has two weaknesses: first, it is abstract and cannot be directly experienced or observed; second, it is immeasurable. These are the main targets for attack from relativists like Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz and Ernst Mach.

We know about Leibniz's view of space mainly from his correspondence with Samuel Clark (Newton's spokesperson). Leibniz is an important representative of the relativist view who argues that space is only the relationship between different material objects. Space is an order of coexistence. Leibniz used genealogical trees to illustrate the idea of relative space. Everyone in genealogical trees has a certain location relative to others. A location has meaning only in a relative frame of reference in the tree because every location needs the other locations to determine its meaning.

Leibniz's concept of relative space is further illustrated in his dispute with Newton's absolute space. First, in Newton's absolute space, all points of absolute space are the same. Absolute place cannot be *experimentally* distinguished from any other place. Furthermore, we cannot measure the velocity of an object. We can measure only the magnitude of an object's absolute acceleration. Leibniz illustrated this immeasurability of absolute position and velocity by

¹² I. NEWTON, *The Principia: Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy* (trans. I.B. Cohen and A. Whitman; Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), 416.

¹³ For an introduction to the Euclidean notion of space, see HUGGETT, *Space* (see n. 8), 15–27.

shift arguments.¹⁴ Based on his Principle of the Identity of Indiscernibles, or PII, Leibniz argues that absolute space does not need to exist at all, since the function of absolute space cannot be observed by experiment or experience. As a result, space cannot be independent of absolute space. Space is just a relative system reflecting the relationships among material objects, just as the relationships among humans are reflected in genealogical trees.¹⁵ After Leibniz and for the same reasons, relativists like Mach challenged the idea of absolute space and tried to find a different frame of reference instead of the absolute space of Newton's bucket experiment.¹⁶

It was in this context that Kant started to elaborate his view of space. His essay "Concerning the Ultimate Foundation of the Differentiation of Regions in Space" discusses the difference between relative space and absolute space.¹⁷ *Critique of Pure Reason*, published later, in 1781, signaled a shift in the discussion from relative and absolute space to the question of how we come to know the geometry of space. How did Kant approach the absolute-versus-relative controversy in his time? Is Kant an absolutist or a relativist? Kant tried to resolve questions such as whether space is absolute or relative in "Concerning the Ultimate Foundation of the Differentiation of Regions in Space"; in a way that is totally different from Newton or Leibniz, Kant proves that space is absolute.

Kant's argument started from two maps. If a map is printed mistakenly as a mirror image, the two maps are the same for relativists, because the distances and relationships among objects in the maps have no change. However, we might get the wrong place if we used one of the maps. They therefore do have differences, which implies that space is absolute.¹⁸ Kant's theory of handedness illustrated more clearly that space is absolute. In a three-dimensional world, a person's left and right hands have a strict mirror relationship. For relativists, there is no distinction between left and right hands because they have the same spatial relations. However, the fact that a left glove cannot fit on the right hand shows that the hands do have left and right. Kant called such a phenomenon an "incongruent counterpart."¹⁹ He argued that relativists cannot explain how a material object is still different from its mirror image when they

¹⁴ For the details, see *ibid.*, 162–63.

¹⁵ G.W. LEIBNIZ and S. CLARKE, *The Leibniz-Clarke Correspondence, Together with Extracts from Newton's Principia and Optics* (ed. H.G. Alexander; New York: Philosophical Library, 1956), 71.

¹⁶ HUGGETT, *Space* (see n. 8), 169–87.

¹⁷ I. KANT, "Concerning the Ultimate Foundation of the Differentiation of Regions in Space," in *Kant: Selected Pre-Critical Writings and Correspondence with Beck* (ed. G.B. Kerferd and D.E. Walford; Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1968), 36–43.

¹⁸ *Ibid.*, 36–43.

¹⁹ I. KANT, *Kant's Inaugural Dissertation and Early Writings on Space* (trans. J. Handy-side; Chicago: Open Court, 1929), 26.

have the same spatial relations. The distinction between left and right shows that space is absolute.

Though Kant's arguments about handedness have their weaknesses, they had a significant influence on subsequent geographical study, particularly humanistic geography.²⁰ A human body is a very important reference for the discussion of space. Kant put it this way:

Even our judgements about the cosmic regions are subordinated to the concept we have of regions in general, insofar as they are determined in relation to the sides of the body.... However well I know the order of the cardinal points, I can determine regions according to that order only insofar as I know towards which hand this order proceeds.... Similarly, our geographical knowledge, and even our commonest knowledge of the position of places, would be of no aid to us if we could not, by reference to the sides of our bodies, assign to regions the things so ordered and the whole system of mutually relative positions.²¹

We normally take our body as a reference for orienting ourselves. When a person cannot find where they are in fog, the only reliable method of orientation is their body, which helps them to justify "in front of," "at the back of," "left," and "right." From tiny things on the table to celestial bodies in the sky, the first reference is not other things but one's own body.

Around ten years later, Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason* denied the idea of absolute space, shifting the discussion of absolute and relative space to a discussion about how we can know and experience space. It was this shift that influenced the development of social space theory. Kant defined space on the basis of several distinctions. First, on an epistemological level, Kant distinguished between knowledge as pure and knowledge as empirical. Empirical knowledge is rooted in observation and experience. Kant called such knowledge *a posteriori*. Other knowledge not rooted in experience is pure knowledge, as in the case of some mathematical prepositions. Pure knowledge is termed by Kant *a priori* knowledge.²²

Kant's second distinction relates to methodology. There are two methods of using knowledge as justification: one is the analytic statement, and the other is the synthetic statement. Analytic judgement is based on the definition of an object (e.g., of space) without connection to the subject. We can gain such knowledge from the definition itself without experience and observation. For example, "the forest has trees" can be an analytic statement because it is true by virtue of the definition alone. The analytic statement is therefore necessarily and universally true, so the analytic statement is *a priori*. Other statements

²⁰ For the weaknesses of this theory, see HUGGETT, *Space* (see n. 8), 203–12 and J.Z. SMITH, *To Take Place: Toward Theory in Ritual* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987), 135–36 n. 17.

²¹ KANT, *Kant's Inaugural Dissertation* (see n. 19), 22–23.

²² I. KANT, *Critique of Pure Reason* (trans. W.S. Pluhar; Indianapolis, IN: Hackett, 1996), 43–44.

based on observation and experience are synthetic statements. Synthetic statements are *a posteriori*. Although a statement cannot be at the same time analytic and *a posteriori*, it may at the same time be both synthetic and *a priori*, that is, a synthetic *a priori* judgement. Geometry – more precisely, Euclidean geometry – is a system of synthetic *a priori* judgements, because a geometric axiom as an *a priori* truth always adds new information. For example, the *a priori* statement “two points define a circle” adds to the definitions of both a point and a circle.

Since Kant’s view of space is based on Euclidean geometry, his knowledge of space is *a priori*. Because Euclidean geometry is a system of synthetic *a priori* judgements, knowledge of space is synthetic, a precondition of perception. Then how do we acquire such knowledge? What is the property of such synthetic precondition of perception? The answers to these questions require a definition of “things in themselves.” When an object appears to us, its appearance is divided into two parts: on the one hand, the object itself gives us one visual representation; on the other hand, many of the object’s appearances are organized into a single visual field, which provides “the form of the experience.”²³ Kant claims that “the form of the experience” is always organized by space. When an object appears to us, we always see it in spatial appearances as “up,” “down,” “left,” and “right.” Space cannot be *a posteriori*; it is always in our mind as *a priori*. All objects appearing to us must be reworked by the spatial form already in our mind. Accordingly, space cannot be objective; we acquire knowledge of space only through our mind because it is pure intuition.

In Kant’s view, then, the space is *a priori*: the experience of space is dependent on the spatial form in the mind. Some later philosophers challenged his view in terms of the relationship between the experience of space and the spatial form because, if knowledge of space is pure intuition, it is difficult to understand the how different people or groups perceive space differently in terms of politics, literature, geography, and sociology.

2.2. Critical Spatiality in the Twentieth Century

After Kant, the discussion of space divided into two main categories. One focused on the physical properties of space, the other on cognitive and philosophical aspects of space, such as how communities and individuals experience and shape space. I adopt the latter approach in my study of space in the Hebrew Bible. I define “biblical space” as the various spatial settings – such as the Jerusalem Temple, cities, mountains, altars, cosmos – and spatial relationships – such as relative position and locations – described in the biblical narrative. Generally speaking, the theory of space in the twentieth century draws from a

²³ Ibid., 73.

broad range of approaches that embrace human and physical geography, anthropology, sociology, and critical theory. Space thus has numerous different meanings and is elusive. Although there is no all-encompassing theory, one characteristic that these various approaches share is being socioculturally oriented.

Around the beginning of the twentieth century, Emile Durkheim's idea of sociocultural nature of space already showed a quasispatial turn, which was elaborated upon after the 1970s by Michel de Certeau, Tuan, Michel Foucault, Lefebvre, and Edward Soja. Durkheim was influenced by Kant and the neo-Kantians.²⁴ But he differs from Kant in his emphasis on the role of society and culture in shaping the spatial form in a person's mind. Kant's intuition became the result of society. Spatial form in the mind does not involve pure intuition but is the result of social forces. Left and right, up and down, north and south, all have a particular valence under the influence of society and culture. An example is Num 2:1–3:51 where the cardinal directions are highlighted because they order how the Israelite tribes settled around the tabernacle.²⁵ In traditional China, south is *yang*, since the ruler facing south can receive the full rays of the noon sun. For this reason, the front of the body is also *yang* and the area behind the body is *yin*.²⁶ When the ruler faces south, his left side is the place of sun, then his left side is *yang*, and his right side is *yin*.²⁷ Space in these cases is hierarchically arranged, just as it is in the Hebrew Bible. Social forces rather than intuition result in particular ways of expressing orientation.

Gaston Bachelard also makes some important contributions to the discussion of space. Bachelard analyzes the complex connection between personal attachments to particular places. In *The Poetics of Space*, he is concerned mainly with a phenomenological perspective on the "inner space" of objective things and his special view of "material imagination."²⁸ For Bachelard, space exists in poetry as "image." For this kind of poetic image, he discusses space and how we live in space, how dwelling and space affect us and provide a deeper, more insightful relationship with space.

Tuan is a humanist geographer who interprets space in terms of humanism, emphasizing human experience, psychology, and ethics in geographical studies. For example, *Topophilia: A Study of Environmental Perception, Attitudes, and Values* argues that human senses like vision, touch, hearing, and smell are

²⁴ S. LUKES, *Emile Durkheim: His Life and Work: A Historical and Critical Study* (New York: Harper and Row, 1972), 54–58.

²⁵ See also M.K. GEORGE, *Israel's Tabernacle as Social Space* (AIL 2; Leiden: Brill, 2009), 79–82.

²⁶ M. GRANET, "Right and Left in China," in *Right and Left: Essays on Dual Symbolic Classification* (ed. R. Needham; Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1973), 49.

²⁷ TUAN, *Space and Place* (see n. 1), 44.

²⁸ G. BACHELARD, *The Poetics of Space* (trans. M. Jolas; Boston: Beacon, 1994), 102, 127, 206.

very important for the perception of space. Human psychology is significant for interpreting this sensory experience. He also illustrates how humans have historically changed their attitudes about a variety of familiar natural landscapes such as sea, mountain, and desert and how humans can develop a religious and aesthetic attitude toward these natural landscapes.²⁹

It was not until Foucault in the 1970s that critical spatiality was studied as a discipline. Though Foucault rarely discusses space directly, his discussions of specific sites such as schools, hospitals, libraries, and cities have numerous implications for conceptualizing space. One case is frequently cited by geographers, philosophers, and sociologists: heterotopia. Heterotopia, which Foucault lays out in “Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias,” is a space different from the space that we experience in daily life. Foucault puts it this way: “certain ones that have the curious property of being in relation with all the other sites, but in such a way as to suspect, neutralize, or invent the set of relations that they happen to designate, mirror, or reflect.”³⁰ These spaces – better, places – are linked to all others but contradict them as well. For example, the garden can symbolize the cosmos, yet it contradicts the cosmos because it is so tiny.³¹ A museum is also a heterotopia, as it exhibits different things from different times at different places but is simultaneously beyond the places where those things come from. “Of Other Spaces” systematically demonstrates six principles. A boat is a kind of heterotopia since it has no position but travels from one position to another position. The tabernacle is likewise a heterotopia, since its essential characteristic is portability.³²

It is not Foucault’s heterotopia but his idea that space is influenced deeply by politics that biblical scholars typically apply to the study of biblical space. Space is controlled by power of knowledge and discourse. Therefore, the distribution, arrangement, and design of space reflect power. Space is important when exploring the relationship between knowledge and power because space is the order of things. The order of things is the system of relationships between people and objects (including space). Space suggests how those relations are perceived, conceived, and therefore controlled.³³

²⁹ Y.-F. TUAN, *Topophilia: A Study of Environmental Perception, Attitudes, and Values* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1974), 98–128.

³⁰ M. FOUCAULT, “Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias,” *Diacritics* 16 (1986), 24.

³¹ For discussion of how place is related to the symbol and the role of symbol in social structure, see J.Z. SMITH, *Map is Not Territory: Studies in the History of Religions* (Leiden: Brill, 1978), 129–46.

³² For portability as an important characteristic of the tabernacle, see GEORGE, *Israel’s Tabernacle* (see n. 25), 75–79.

³³ The relationship between power and knowledge is an important theme in several works of Foucault; see, e.g., M. FOUCAULT, *The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences* (New York: Pantheon, 1971); FOUCAULT, *The Archaeology of Knowledge, and The*

Lefebvre elaborates on the idea of relationships between space and society, history and politics. His contributions have two aspects: one is the concept of the “production of space”; the other is the nature of the production of space, or “the trialectic of space.” The production of space views space as socially produced. Space is material, not abstract as Kant suggests; it is also not formed by society, as Durkheim thought. Lefebvre perceives it instead as a product; in other words, space is a commodity influenced by forces of production. This product, however, is not as the same as the other products: “(Social) space is not a thing among other things, nor a product among other product: rather, it subsumes things produced, and encompasses their interrelationships in their coexistence and simultaneity-their (relative) order and/or (relative) disorder.”³⁴

Generally speaking, production includes the production of the spiritual (e.g., religion, art, and music), as well as the production of the material (e.g., roads, bridges, and parks). Lefebvre emphasizes the material aspect of space and explores how material space reflects the elements of society and production. For instance, he is concerned with how nature’s space in modern society is transformed or produced by modern techniques. Although the design of a building by an architect seems politically neutral, it is still controlled by certain social conditions. How does space reflect the mode of production? To Lefebvre, such a question is like talking about the connection between space and politics. Although he emphasizes the spatiality of society, he always analyzes space in its historical context. For example, discussing roads in the medieval period involves discussing their various connections with knowledge, culture, and socio-economic conditions at that time. Accordingly, discussing the production of space means discussing how the forces of production at different historical periods determined different kinds of space.³⁵

What is the relationship between material space and mental space? In their efforts to answer this question, many scholars have tried to move beyond the binaries of absolute and relative, material and mental, perhaps none more than Lefebvre with his trialectic of space.³⁶ On the basis of the idea that space involves production, he argues that there is a third kind of space, lived space, in which people can experience and practice things. Space can thus be divided into material space, mental space, and lived space. Lefebvre uses many different terms for each throughout *The Production of Space*. Sometimes “perceived space,” “conceived space,” and “lived space”; sometimes “spatial practice,”

Discourse on Language (trans. A.M.S. Smith; New York: Pantheon, 1977); FOUCAULT, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison* (New York: Pantheon, 1977).

³⁴ H. LEFEBVRE, *The Production of Space* (trans. D. Nicholson-Smith; Oxford: Blackwell, 1991), 73.

³⁵ *Ibid.*, 31–32.

³⁶ *Ibid.*, 31.

“representations of space,” and “spaces of representation”; and sometimes “material,” “mental,” and “lived.”

Material space emphasizes the material aspect of space, such as a statue, a square, a temple, or a church. These spaces can be experienced or observed. Material space is essentially connected with the function of space, or spatial practice, which involves how people produce and transform space in which to live. Mental (or conceptual) space indicates the space that exists in our minds. It is imagined space, as with the design of church, the plan of a temple, a map of a city, or description of a building in a text. Mental spaces are produced by our minds and may also be measured. Mental space also involves the conceptual division of space, such as the division of a city into the industrial area and the other areas. Lived space is socially experienced space. People can adjust to different spaces because lived space is formed by people thorough symbols. People can construct or transform the meanings of space in order to live comfortably and naturally. The meanings and senses of lived space are given by culture and society.

Soja offers his own “trialectic of spatiality” by redescribing Lefebvre’s three kinds of space.³⁷ He redescribes spatial practice as “firstspace” and terms representations of space as “secondspace,” arguing that the latter is the dominant space, tied to the relations of production and the order or design.³⁸ Accordingly, secondspace represents power and ideology, control and surveillance. The lived space of “inhabitants” and “users,” or the people who experience a space is “spaces of representation.” This space, which involves complex symbolism, is most interesting to both Lefebvre and Soja and termed “thirdspace” by Soja. The difference between Lefebvre’s lived space and Soja’s thirdspace is that Soja is concerned more about the *practices* of thirdspace. This space is the terrain for the generation of “counterspaces,” spaces of resistance to the dominant order from subordinate, peripheral, or marginalized positions. He insists that thirdspace is constructed through social practices. Soja’s trialectic is thus a more action-oriented and politicized ontology and epistemology of space. All demonstrate that thirdspace, or symbolic space, is the result of social practices.

To sum up, critical spatiality has been developed since the 1970s by scholars from different disciplines such as philosophy, anthropology, sociology, geography, and historiography. Critical spatiality is concerned with the social and cultural nature of space and explores how space becomes rich and complex through social practices and forces. For various spaces in the Hebrew Bible – the land of Israel, Jerusalem, the temple, or the tabernacle – “critical spatiality provides scholars with a means of examining and analysing such spaces in

³⁷ E. SOJA, *Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and Other Real-and-Imagined Places* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 1996), 53–82.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, 67.

terms of the social practices and forces that created them.”³⁹ Lefebvre and Soja’s trialectic of space provides a useful analytical framework for understanding critical spatiality and therefore is of concern to biblical scholars.⁴⁰

2.3. Narrative Space

In his work “A Bakhtinian Reading of Narrative Space,” William Millar argues that narrative space is one of the tools available to an author in constructing a rhetorical strategy designed to persuade an audience of a particular idea.⁴¹ In this section, I shall explore the relationship between narrative space and social space.

Exposition, argumentation, description, and narration are four basic rhetorical modes in literature. These elements are usually interrelated. For example, an exposition can contain argumentation; a narrative also usually has numerous descriptions. As one of the basic rhetorical modes, narrative is any account of connected events presented to a reader or listener in a sequence of written or spoken words, or of moving pictures. Narrative has some basic elements such as time, plot, place, character, events, cause, and consequence. Among them, time has the closest relationship with narrative because the events necessarily happen in time. Compared to time, the descriptions of place in narrative strengthen the attractiveness and expressiveness of narrative. Examples in the Hebrew Bible include Exod 13:21–22 and 14:21–22 which demonstrate the miracle of God as well as the environmental description of God’s theophany in Exod 3:1–2; 13:21–22; and 19:16–25. These spatial descriptions enable readers to see the space vividly and feel that they are personally in the scene. The relationship between narrative and space has not always been emphasized. Space is generally seen as setting the scene, which is only a background for events. Readers can trace the plot without reading these spatial descriptions.

Emphasizing time (i.e., plot) over space (i.e., setting) does not mean that space is unimportant, however, because events necessarily develop in space as well. For example, even the phrase “he stretches his arm” implies a space. The

³⁹ GEORGE, “Space and History” (see n. 8), 29.

⁴⁰ For the application of this concept in biblical studies, see, e.g., GEORGE, *Israel’s Tabernacle* (see n. 25); J.W. FLANAGAN, “Ancient Perceptions of Space/Perceptions of Ancient Space,” in *Mappa Mundi: Mapping Culture/Mapping the World* (ed. J. Murray; Working Papers in the Humanities 9; Windsor: Humanities Research Group at the University of Windsor, 2001), 1–18; and C.M. MAIER, *Daughter Zion, Mother Zion: Gender, Space, and the Sacred in Ancient Israel* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2008).

⁴¹ W.R. MILLAR, “A Bakhtinian Reading of Narrative Space and its Relationship to Social Space,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T & T Clark, 2007), 130.

plot involves space as well as time, and “it includes routes, movement, directions, volume, simultaneity, etc., and thus is an active partner in the structuring of space in the text.”⁴² In some stories, the plot is space oriented. For example, the travels of Abraham and Jacob in the patriarchal narratives involves a space-driven plot since the itinerary of their journeys also illustrates the scale of the promised land (Gen 15). Space can become an essential element even in stories that are not space oriented.

Mikhail Bakhtin’s “chronotope” and Joseph Frank’s “spatial form” are the first theories to systematically analyze space in literature. In the 1930s, Bakhtin developed the chronotope theory to analyze how time and space together play a role in narrative. Space is highlighted as much as time: “In the literary artistic chronotope, spatial and temporal indicators are fused into one carefully thought-out, concrete whole. Time, as it were, thickens, takes on flesh, becomes artistically visible; likewise, space becomes charged and responsive to the movements of time, plot and history.”⁴³ In narrative, space must be transformed into time. But, as a narrative develops in time, it cannot reflect all aspects of space: some aspects are described in detail, while others are just mentioned casually, encouraging readers to complete the whole construction of space, a strategy that engages the participation of readers.

Frank’s spatial form is different. In his classic essay “Spatial Form in Modern Literature,” Frank conceptualizes spatial form and provides a frame for scholars discussing the spatial structure of a text. Consider several modern poems and novels, in which the traditional narrative logic is frequently interrupted, leaving the sense of sequence no longer as clear as in earlier literature. Furthermore, modern novelists and poets juxtapose various independent images and phrases. Images and phrases are thus interwoven spatially, independent of any time sequence of narrative action.⁴⁴ This happens in two ways: one is putting the different images together by analogy; the other is juxtaposing similar images by flashback or montage. The form that results from such juxtaposition or analogy is a kind of spatial form. To build up a sense of Dublin as a totality in the reader’s mind in *Dublin*, James Joyce interrupted the sequential relationships among events and characters, using numerous flashbacks and montages to make independent events and characters refer to each other at the same time. For this reason, these events and characters must be juxtaposed with one another and perceived simultaneously in order to be understood.⁴⁵

⁴² G. ZORAN, “Towards the Theory of Space in Narrative,” *Poetics Today* 2 (1984), 309–35, here 314.

⁴³ M.M. BAKHTIN, “Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel: Notes toward a Historical Poetics,” in *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays* (ed. M. Holquist; trans. C. Emerson and M. Holquist; Austin: University of Texas Press, 1981), 84–258, here 84.

⁴⁴ J. FRANK, “Spatial Form in Modern Literature,” in *The Widening Gyre, Crisis and Mastery in Modern Literature* (New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press, 1963), 3–62.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*, 16–21.

Marcel Proust also used spatial form in an attempt to communicate the extratemporal quality of his revelatory moments.⁴⁶

After the 1960s, when literary study was influenced by the spatial turn happening in other disciplines, scholars increasingly started to pay close attention to the spatial aspect of literature. In contemporary studies, spatial theory and literature influence each other significantly. Spatial theory is applied to examine the significance of interactions between space and society, and literature, as an important product of society, is understood to be necessarily influenced by space. Narrative space is further developed in this intellectual context. The work of Lefebvre and Soja is engaged, as their more refined categories are productive in an effort to understand the complicated nexus between the social space in the narrative and the external social space of author. Narrative space is the conceptual space or secondspace of Lefebvre and Soja, which is composed by text and signs. It is space which is narrated, while social space is a metaphor for the location, context, and atmosphere in which people practice; social space also may be treated as abstract like the relationships among people.⁴⁷

What is the relationship between social space and narrative space? Writing itself is a symbolic action trying to give symbolic meaning to the words written. It is reasonable to say that every word in a narrative has symbolic meaning. It is difficult to analyze how conceptual space reflects physical space. All spaces in a narrative are from the author's mind. For biblical studies, there is another difficulty: the sites mentioned in the Hebrew Bible are almost nonexistent today. However, this does not mean that we cannot trace physical space through narrative. The physical aspect of space must be transformed by the authors' imagination. We still can trace the physical aspect or read directly of the physical aspect of space from the conceptual space in narrative. To be sure, we should take into account all three aspects of space at once.

First, physical space described in a narrative includes the landscape, motion, places, locations, borders, and settings. When these physical spaces are described, they must be transformed by the authors' minds. Words are the tools to transform physical space into narrative. Readers must therefore trace physical space through the words that imply physical space, such as length, width, and height. Second, conceptual space is involved in the description of physical space. Conceptual space is concerned with questions such as whether the dominant perception of space is reflected in narrative and what narrative effect it has. Conceptual space as reflected in texts may be from a group's mind or from an individual's mind, but it is the result of social forces either way. Finally,

⁴⁶ Ibid., 21–28.

⁴⁷ C. EMMOTT, "Constructing Social Space: Sociocognitive Factors in the Interpretation of Character Relations," in *Narrative Theory and the Cognitive Sciences* (ed. D. Herman; Stanford, CA: CSLI, 2003), 295–321.

symbolic space analyzes what cultural and social context symbolic meanings are given, figures out the symbolic meanings of spaces through physical space, and explores how physical space and symbolic space are combined in conceptual space. In many cases, “abstract notions are often viewed using metaphors from physical domains.”⁴⁸ The physical distance can symbolize the abstract distance; in Judg 4:5, for example, the motion verbs “sit” and “rise” used in the description of Deborah symbolize a role conversion.⁴⁹ Readers should therefore analyze how symbolic space is given by a certain group or individual in a certain cultural context and whether this symbolic space is filled with protestation or helps to strengthen the socially dominant perception of space.

⁴⁸ Ibid., 315.

⁴⁹ M. STERNBERG, *The Poetics of Biblical Narrative: Ideological Literature and the Drama of Reading* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1985), 332–33.

Chapter 3

Space in the Priestly Texts

This section introduces the formation and development of the Priestly texts in the Pentateuch. The structure, theme, content, and date of the Priestly texts will be clarified. The historical and social context of Priestly texts will also be discussed, since the social space can be inferred from it. Some basic characteristics of spatial narrative in Priestly texts will then be analyzed. I shall argue that space is a fundamental element in Priestly texts and that social space is well reflected in Priestly texts.

3.1. Structure of the Priestly Texts

Beginning in the eighteenth century, scholars attempted to identify different sources in the Pentateuch based on the different designations for God: Elohim and YHWH. The discipline of source criticism was formed gradually on this basis.¹ Julius Wellhausen established a model of source criticism in the late nineteenth century that has provided the predominant literary approach to the study of Genesis and the Pentateuch in biblical scholarship for more than two hundred years.² According to this model, the different designations for God, parallels, repetitions, doublets, and contradictions in the Pentateuch allow the identification of four independent sources: the Yahwist (J), the Elohist (E), the Priestly source (P), and Deuteronomy (D), a valuable insight into the history of the composition of the Pentateuch.

Whether the four sources are original documents and even whether the overall theory of source criticism is correct, however, are debated issues within biblical scholarship. Many scholars now think that only P and D can be identified clearly,³ while the texts traditionally assigned to J and E are increasingly identified as a large literary block without distinctive differences and called, more generically, “non-Priestly” texts. The identification of the Priestly source

¹ J. BLENKINSOPP, *The Pentateuch: An Introduction to the First Five Books of the Bible* (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 4–9.

² Ibid., 9–12.

³ J.C. GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation Altes Testament: Eine Einführung in Literatur, Religion und Geschichte des Alten Testaments* (3rd ed.; UTB 2745; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2009), 204–12.

relies on its distinctive and uniform literary characteristics and its well-ordered structure. One of the structural characteristics of Priestly texts is the *toledot* formula, or genealogy, which is used mainly in the Priestly primeval history (Gen 6:9; 10:1; 11:10, 27; 25:12, 19; 36:1, 9) and only once in the patriarchal narratives (Gen 37:2). Another structural characteristic is the “overlapping system of cross-references.”⁴ Blessing and covenant are typical references beginning with creation, continuing through the making of a covenant with Noah after the flood (Gen 9) and the blessing and making of another covenant with Abraham (Gen 17) and then again with Moses (Exod 6:2–8), before ending with the glory of YHWH’s entry into the tabernacle (Exod 25:8; 29:45–46; 40:34).

The beginning of the Priestly source is generally seen in Gen 1. Where the Priestly source ends is very controversial.⁵ Deuteronomy 34:1, 7–9 has traditionally been seen as the ending.⁶ Nonetheless, recent research indicates that Deut 34 cannot be understood entirely as a Priestly text. The language it employs is both Priestly and Deuteronomistic.⁷ Another earlier influential theory is that Joshua marks the ending of the Priestly source.⁸ The more reasonable place to locate the ending of the Priestly source is the Sinai pericope. Judging from the cultic laws given at Sinai, the tabernacle is the purpose of cross references in the Priestly texts. Also, there is a striking literary *inclusio* between the narrative of creation (Gen 1:31a) and the Sinai pericope (Exod 39:43a).⁹ After the original ending at the Sinai pericope, the Priestly narrative was gradually extended to Lev 26. The Priestly texts can, on the whole, be divided into the original Priestly source (P^s) and additions to it (P^s):

P^s in Genesis:

The Creation of Heaven and Earth: 1:1–2:3

Toledot of Adam: 5:1–27, 30–31

Flood and Covenant with Noah: 6:9–22; Gen 7:6, 11, 13–16a, 18–21, 24; 8:1a, 2a, 3b–5, 13a, 14–19; 9:1–17

⁴ Ibid., 238–39.

⁵ Ibid., 242–43.

⁶ E.g., C. FREVEL, *Mit Blick auf das Land die Schöpfung erinnern: Zum Ende der Priestergrundschrift* (HBS 23; Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 2000).

⁷ GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation* (see n. 3), 242–43 and K. SCHMID, *Literaturgeschichte des Alten Testaments: Eine Einführung* (2nd ed; Studienausgabe; Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 2014), 147. See also L. PERLITT, “Priesterschrift im Deuteronomium?,” *ZAW* 100 (1988), 65–87 and A.R. ERISMAN, “Transjordan in Deuteronomy: The Promised Land and the Formation of the Pentateuch,” *JBL* 132 (2013), 769–89.

⁸ N. LOHFINK, *Studien zum Pentateuch* (SBAB 4; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 1988), 213–53; E.A. KNAUF, “Die Priesterschrift und die Geschichten der Deuteronomisten,” in *The Future of the Deuteronomistic History* (ed. T. Römer; BETL 174; Leuven: Leuven University Press, 2000), 101–18.

⁹ SCHMID, *Literaturgeschichte* (see n. 7), 147.

Toledot of Noah's Sons: 10:17, 20, 22–23, 31–32
 Toledot of Shem and Terah: 11:10–32; 12:4–5; 13:6, 11–12; 16:1, 3, 15–16; 19:29; 21:1–5;
 23:1–20; 25:7–11
 Covenant with Abraham: 17:1–27
 Toledot of Ishmael: 25:12–17
 Toledot of Isaac: 26:19–20; 26:34–35; 27:46; 28:1–8; 31:18; 33:18; 35:6, 9–13, 15, 22–29
 Toledot of Esau: 36:1–14
 Toledot of Jacob: 37:2; 41:46; 46:6–27; 47:27–28; 48:3–6; 49:1, 29–33; 50:12–13; Exod
 40:34

P^s in Exodus:

Israel in Egypt: 1:1–7, 13–14
 Call of Moses: 2:23–25; 6:2–30
 Plagues and Exodus: 7:1–13, 19–22; 8:1–3, 11–15; 9:8–12; 11:9–10; 12:1–20, 28, 40–51
 Miracle at the Sea and Wilderness: 14:1–4, 8–10, 15–18, 22–23, 26–29; 15:22, 27; 16:1–3,
 6, 8–27, 32–35; 17:1
 Foundation of the Cult at Sinai: 19:1–2; 24:15–18; 25:1–40; 26:1–37; 27:1–21; 28:1–43;
 29:1–46
 Building of the Tabernacle and Entrance of YHWH's Glory into the Sanctuary: 40:1–38¹⁰

P^s in Exodus and Leviticus:

Incense Altar and Sabbath Celebration: Exod 30:1–38; 31:1–18
 Report of Completion of Directives: Exod 25–31; 35:1–35; 36:1–38; 37:1–29; 38:1–31;
 39:1–43
 Cultic Laws: Lev 1–15
 Day of Atonement: Lev 16
 Holiness Code: Lev 17–26

P^s is probably an originally independent literary source, since most Priestly texts can be read on their own, independently of the non-Priestly parallel texts. Such typically independent Priestly texts include Gen 1, the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, and Exod 2:23–25; 6:2–30. Whether the Priestly texts were originally independent or not, their author(s) were familiar with the pre-Priestly tradition.¹¹ The Priestly texts to some degree altered older traditions to suit their own circumstances. Their characteristics become particularly evident when compared with Deuteronomistic tradition, ancient Near Eastern literary tradition, and older Israelite cultic traditions.

¹⁰ According to E. ZENGER, “Das priesterschriftliche Werk P,” in *Einleitung in das Alte Testament* (7th ed.; ed. E. Zenger et al.; Kohlhammer Studienbücher Theologie 1.1; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 2008), 159–75, the original Priestly document ends in Leviticus 9; according to C. NIHAN, *From Priestly Torah to Pentateuch: A Study in the Composition of the Book of Leviticus* (FAT II/25; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2007), 379–94, it ends in Leviticus 16.

¹¹ GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation* (see n. 3), 239–42.

3.2. Important Concepts in the Priestly Texts

The Priestly texts can be structured into three subunits within the overall Priestly source: the first is from Gen 1, the narrative of creation, to Gen 6–9, the flood narrative; the second is from Gen 9, the blessing and covenant with Noah, to Gen 10–11, the dispersal of the descendants of Noah; the third is from Gen 17, the blessing and covenant with Abraham, to Exod 40:16–17, 33b, 34, the entrance of YHWH's glory into the tabernacle (Exod 25:8; 29:45–46; 40:34). Most of these narratives focus on the salvation history of Israel. The salvation history developed through God's preplanned actions is emphasized by narrative characteristics such as a well-ordered structure and the use of repetition.

These three divisions of the Priestly narrative relate to three important characteristics of Priestly texts. The first characteristic is emphasis on the order and structure of world. This characteristic is reflected in Gen 1, where the world is well structured. The *toledot* narratives also emphasize order. Emphasis on order and structure probably serves the narrative purpose of these texts, namely, properly keeping the cult and emphasizing the purity of worship.

The second characteristic is universalism. The pre-Priestly cult tradition in the Hebrew Bible contains traces of polytheism (e.g., Deut 32). Polytheism is generally associated with the worship of local deities. It is therefore not strange that numerous places of worship are mentioned in the Hebrew Bible. After the fall of Samaria in 722 BCE, however, monotheism, specifically exclusive Yahwism, developed gradually and resulted in reforms carried out by Josiah aiming to centralize worship (622/621 BCE). At the same time, universalism developed alongside monotheism. Besides monotheism, another important reason for the development of universalism is the influence of Persian religion. In Persian culture, the Zoroastrian cult believes that Ahura Mazda created the cosmos and humanity – evident, for example, in Darius's Inscription at Naqshe Rostam: "A great god (is) Auramazda, who created this earth, who created yonder heaven, who created man, who created happiness for man, who made Darius king, one king of many, one lord of many"¹² – and is able to influence the different nations.¹³ (Note the similar notion in Isa 40–55, which describes the relationship between Israel and the other nations: YHWH controls all the nations in the world, while he has particular relationship with Israel.) The Priestly cosmic view of deity as "God in heaven" is probably reinforced by this

¹² A. KUERT, *The Persian Empire: A Corpus of Sources from the Achaemenid Period* (2 vols.; London: Routledge, 2007), 2:502.

¹³ This characteristic is extensively reflected in the "Bihistun inscription"; see *ibid.*, 1:141–51.

tradition.¹⁴ The decentered world of the Persian era may also influence the Priestly view of God's residential place. Nowhere in the Priestly texts can we infer exactly where God is. God is omnipresent and the portable tabernacle is only the place in the world he resides. In pre-Priestly tradition, God is closer to humanity. In the Priestly texts, God becomes more abstract. The universalistic tendencies of the Priestly texts can be also clarified by comparing them with Deuteronomistic tradition, which emphasizes centralized worship. In the Priestly texts, God is beyond the scope of humanity's living place. God has no place, he has only space.

The third characteristic of the Priestly texts is their positive salvation theology. This theology can also be inferred through comparison with Deuteronomistic traditions. Priestly texts oppose the covenant theology of the Deuteronomistic Sinai pericope, where Moses emphasizes the connection between law and covenant in his speech to Israelites. According to the covenant in Deuteronomy, Israel is the chosen people of God. They have the promise of blessings from God, their one and only God. As long as the Israelites are faithful and obedient to God, God will give them land and prosperity. Disobedience will lead to curses and punishment. In the Priestly texts, however, the covenant between God and Israel is unconditional. As in Deuteronomistic tradition, the Israelites should be faithful and obedient to God, while God gives them the blessings of land and prosperity. But God still blesses Israelites even in the face of guilt. The idea of a universal covenant may be strongly connected with the pro-Persian, anti-Deuteronomistic tendency of the Priestly texts.

3.3. Composition Date and Social Locus of the Priestly Texts

The overall framework of the Priestly texts is usually dated to the exilic or postexilic periods, namely, the sixth century BCE or later.¹⁵ This can be

¹⁴ For a discussion of the connection between God and heaven in the literature of the Second Temple period, see K. SCHMID, "Himmels-gott, Weltgott, und Schöpfer: 'Gott' und der 'Himmel' in der Literatur der Zeit des Zweiten Tempels," in *Der Himmel* (ed. D. Sattler and S. Vollenweider; JBTh 20; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 2006), 111–48.

¹⁵ The date of the Priestly document is a matter of debate. For a date in the exilic or early Persian period, see, e.g., SCHMID, *Literaturgeschichte* (see n. 7), 146–50; KNAUF, "Die Priesterschrift" (see n. 8); R.G. KRATZ, *Die Komposition der erzählenden Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Uni-Taschenbücher 2157; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2000), 247–48; and GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation* (see n. 3), 243–44. For a date in the preexilic period, see, e.g., A. HURVITZ, "Dating the Priestly Source in Light of the Historical Study of Biblical Hebrew: A Century after Wellhausen," in *Lebendige Forschung im Alten Testament* (ed. O. Kaiser; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1988), 88–100; HURVITZ, "Once Again: The Linguistic Profile of the Priestly Material in the Pentateuch and its Historical Age. A Response to J. Blen-

broadly inferred from the structure, theme, content, and social locus of Priestly texts. First, in terms of structure, the Priestly texts serve as a framework for numerous pre-Priestly texts. Since Wellhausen, non-Priestly sources have been dated to a period earlier than the Priestly texts, which became part of Pentateuch only gradually.¹⁶

Second, the Priestly texts can be dated by comparing them with other biblical literature. Most of the characteristics of Deuteronomistic tradition anticipate the Priestly texts. The key theme is that of worshipping only YHWH at one chosen cultic location. The Priestly texts seem to accept this theme and develop it further in their own way. The Priestly texts also further develop the monotheism emphasized in Deuteronomy. As a result, they demonstrate their monotheism and universalism. If the Priestly texts were written after the Deuteronomistic tradition, which probably originated around the end of the seventh century BCE and the beginning of sixth century BCE (i.e., the late preexilic period), then the Priestly texts would have been written after the seventh century BCE. The same conclusion can be reached in terms of content. Elements of the priestly texts are mentioned nowhere outside the Pentateuch until the books of Chronicles and Ezra-Nehemiah, which were written later. The Priestly texts also demonstrate a connection with the book of Ezekiel. Consequently, they were probably written in the exilic or postexilic period.

Social locus is a third important means of dating the Priestly texts. The themes and content reflect Persian society and culture. For example, the universalism implied in the Priestly primeval history may be influenced by the multiculturalism of the Persian Empire (550–330 BCE).

It is noteworthy, then, that the composition of the Priestly texts is closely connected with the Babylonian exile and the postexilic period. Exile became the context and social locus for Priestly writings. A brief review of the Babylonian exile and the Persian period will suggest how the social locus may have influenced the spatial narrative in the Priestly texts.

From the mid-eighth to the mid-sixth centuries BCE, the small kingdoms in the southern Levant experienced a very hard time at the hands of two Mesopotamian empires, first the Assyrian Empire (935–612 BCE), and then the Babylonian Empire (626–539 BCE). Among the small kingdoms was Judah. The biblical narrative describes the Israelites' survival under the control of Assyria and Babylonia and, furthermore, preserves their special ethnic character. When we examine carefully the reasons for and contexts of their survival, however, we find Judah's survival to be not so miraculous. Rather, it is a logical and to

kinsopp," *ZAW* 112 (2000), 180–91; M. HARAN, "Behind the Scenes of History: Determining the Date of the Priestly Source," *JBL* 100 (1981), 321–33, here 327–30; and R.E. FRIEDMAN, *Who Wrote the Bible?* (San Francisco: Harper, 1987), 161–216.

¹⁶ SCHMID, *Literaturgeschichte* (see n. 7), 146.

some extent natural result. Among various reasons, the regional policy of Babylon towards Judah is significant. In the case of the Assyrians, deportation could be seen as a process of assigning new space to Israelites. Some were deported to the new place, while the others who remained in the land also faced a new space, a space in which many new relations were produced. The scattered Israelites had no choice but to accept the new local space without bringing their former spatial relationship into this new space. We shall see later that this is very different from the spatial relationship during the Babylonian exile.

According to the Hebrew Bible, there were three deportations by Babylonia: 598/597, 587/586, and 582 BCE (Jer 52:30; 40:5–43:7). Unlike the Assyrians, the Babylonian monarchs did not use population exchange as a tool of imperial rule. To administer those Judeans still on the land, a native Judean from a prominent Jerusalem family and formerly in the royal service, Gedaliah son of Ahikam, was appointed governor of Judah, with his headquarters in the city of Mizpah, just north of Jerusalem.¹⁷ His appointment reflects the different mechanisms used by the Assyrian and Babylonian empires. We see that this new space was not arranged for the people from other places. Rather, there is just a substitute government in a new center not far from Jerusalem. If space is not a simple place but a conjunction of social relations, the space in Judah was not changed radically, even though the land was destroyed and burned. The people who remained in the land were able to maintain their ethnic unity as before, without being absorbed into a strange new space. Judah was thus not in the same situation as Israel, where ethnic unity was changed by force in a new space.

Judah was preserved as a concept of national unity. When we talk about Babylonia trying to maintain and acknowledge Judah as an important vassal state, however, this does not mean that Babylonia had nothing to do with the natives. On the contrary, the Hebrew Bible gives us a strong impression of Judah as an abandoned land, saying that almost all of the people were deported to Babylonia or elsewhere. The exile thus began. In the discussion of scholarship, “the empty land” gradually became a myth.¹⁸ Most think that 2 Kgs 24–25, 2 Chron 36, and the book of Jeremiah – the main biblical sources for the events leading up to the exile – are more ideological than historical. On the one hand, in terms of rhetoric, the accounts of the conquests of Jerusalem and Judah during the reigns of Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, and Zedekiah by Nebuchadnezzar

¹⁷ M. COGAN, “Into Exile,” in *The Oxford History of the Biblical World* (ed. M.D. Coogan; New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), 321–65, here 356.

¹⁸ H.M. BARSTAD, “The Myth of the Empty Land,” in *History and the Hebrew Bible: Studies in Ancient Israelites and Ancient Near Eastern Historiography* (FAT 61; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2008), 90–117; BARSTAD, “After the ‘Myth of the Empty Land’: Major Challenges in the Study of Neo-Babylonian Judah,” in *Judah and the Judeans in the Neo-Babylonian Period* (ed. O. Lipschits and J. Blenkinsopp; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2003), 3–20.

fits the literary structure underlying Assyrian and Hittite accounts. On the other hand, during this period some theological speculations such as the restoration flourished. The accounts of “the empty land” may thus have been invented as a justification for the return to Judah.

The majority of scholars now assume that a large population remained in Judah.¹⁹ According to Jer 39:8–9, “The Chaldeans burned the house of the king and the house of the people, and they broke down the walls of Jerusalem. Then Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard carried into exile to Babylon the rest of the people who remained in the city, those who had deserted to him, and the people who remained.”²⁰ What we can be sure of is that Nebuchadnezzar deported some of the people from Judah. These people are likely to have been the royal family, the upper class, and some artisans. Thanks to archaeological discoveries showing that many cities continued to develop without being destroyed in the following years, today we know that the majority of Judeans were probably not exiled.

In 538 BCE, Cyrus II (558–530 BCE) permitted the Jewish people to return to Palestine and rebuild the temple. At that time, the Israelites had been scattered in different places. There were Jews in Babylonia, Jews in Persia, Jews in Egypt, Jews in Samaria, Jews in Judah. Scholars agree that that the Persian period was critical for the formation of Pentateuch. The concept of Israel also changed in the Persian period. Israel was no longer seen as a political unity but became a multicentric people identified foremost by ethnicity. Persian culture may also have influenced many aspects of the Hebrew Bible. The Jews, whether in the diaspora or the Levantine homeland, were likely to have been influenced by Persian culture, although there is little evidence to show the influence of Persian culture on Israel, especially in comparison with Hellenistic influence.²¹ Another point we should pay attention to is that theological speculation flourished in this period. For instance, Gen 1, a typical Priestly text, describes the universe as God’s sanctuary, emphasizing sacred time (the Sabbath) as well as the structured cosmos.²² Chronicles and Ezra-Nehemiah contain narratives based on the famous decree of Cyrus II, allowing some Jews to return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple. With respect to this event, we should be cautious about the contemporaneous political context. It is known that Persian Empire allowed different regions to keep their own traditional cult and laws. Many nations in the Persian Empire were politically self-organizing.

¹⁹ The number of deportees is a matter of debate. O. LIPSCHITS, *The Fall and Rise of Jerusalem: Judah Under Babylonian Rule* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2005) suggests that this issue should be viewed differently in different parts of Judah.

²⁰ All translations of biblical texts are my own.

²¹ M. LEITH, “Israel among the Nations,” in *The Oxford History of the Biblical World* (ed. M. Coogan; New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), 367–419, here 368–71.

²² For discussion of an inclusion between the creation of the world and the construction of the tabernacle, see SCHMID, *Literaturgeschichte* (see n. 7), 147.

There was also some pressure on Cyrus to make such a policy. When Nehemiah returned to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple, he argued that it was for moral reasons (Ezra 1), but his main purpose was likely to increase his wealth and power.

A striking feature of the Persian period is the growth of power of the priests, the Zadokite priesthood in particular.²³ The Zadokite priestly families may have influenced politics over the next few centuries. The high priest exercised the function of the king until the mid-second century BCE, the Hasmonean period. However, in Isa 55–66; Ezek 38–39; Isa 24–27; and Zech 9–14, we also can see protests against the Zadokite priesthood. Another group that we should not forget is the postexilic prophets, who are very different from the preexilic prophets. The former group is mainly critical of ritual; the latter group is concerned with the proper maintenance of worship. During the rule of Darius, in 520 BCE, the prophets Zechariah and Haggai advocated rebuilding the temple. One of the characteristics of postexilic prophecy is that the maintenance of worship and prophetic speech increasingly follows liturgical forms used in public worship.²⁴ Nehemiah and Ezra are two significant figures for understanding the sociopolitical situation of Palestine and of the exiles in the Persian period. According to the Bible, Ezra is a lawgiver and also a priest-scribe (Ezra 7:12). His commission is described as keeping the law of the God of Israel and the law of the king, as well as distributing gifts and temple vessels to the God of Israel, whose dwelling is in Jerusalem (Ezra 7:14–15, 25–26). Ezra's main task, however, was resolving the problem of mixed marriage and defining the boundaries of Israelite ethnicity. Nehemiah was sent by the Persian Empire to build a city wall and an imperial fortress (Neh 2:8) outside Jerusalem. On the one hand, this task reflects the fact that the Persian Empire probably wanted to foster Judean loyalty; on the other hand, it demonstrates the high degree of religious authority of the Jewish people.

3.4. Narrative Space in the Priestly Texts

Biblical scholars have become increasingly interested in the concept of space in the Priestly texts.²⁵ Space in the Priestly texts is understood mainly in terms of the connection between the Priestly cosmos and the temple and tabernacle.

²³ LEITH, "Israel" (see n. 20), 395–96.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 399.

²⁵ F.H. GORMAN, Jr., *The Ideology of Ritual: Space, Time, and Status in the Priestly Theology* (JSOTSup 91; Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1990); J. BRINKMAN, *The Perception of Space in the Old Testament: An Exploration of the Methodological Problems of its Investigation, Exemplified by a Study of Exodus 25–31* (Kampen: Kok Pharos, 1992); and M.K. GEORGE, *Israel's Tabernacle as Social Space* (AIL 2; Leiden: Brill, 2009).

Two significant features of space in the Priestly texts are order and classification. Studies of space in the Priestly texts focus on objective space or place, such as the tabernacle or the cosmos, as well as their structure, function, and nature. Recently, under the influence of critical spatiality, and especially social space theory, scholars have started to discuss social space in the Bible. They also discuss the status and function of the Priestly school in terms of sociology. One such striking discussion is Mark George's *The Tabernacle as Social Space*, which constitutes a new direction in spatiality studies in Priestly texts. On the whole, both traditional and more recent studies pay close attention to objective space or place as cosmos or tabernacle rather than to the connection between narrative and space. Furthermore, most studies on space in Priestly texts focus on the patriarchal narratives and Exodus, in particular the Sinai pericope. Here, I shall take Gen 1 and Gen 6–9 as examples in order to extend discussion of the connection between narrative and space. In this section, I shall consider God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space – three distinct categories present in the Priestly texts. This will lay a foundation for the analysis of space in Gen 1 and the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9.

3.4.1. God's Space

God's space in the Priestly texts demonstrates universalism. God has no specific place whether in the sky or on the earth. Although there is no clear indication of where God is, the prepositions indicate that God is in a high place. After God appears to Abraham, God goes up (עלה) from Abraham (Gen 17:22), and when God appears to Jacob, he also goes up (עלה) from Jacob (Gen 35:13). God in his high place promises to control the whole earth and is ready to intervene in history. Narrative viewpoints also promise that God is in the high place. In Gen 1:29, God perceives every plant yielding seed that is on the surface of the earth as a whole from his perspective. This implies that the preposition "up" (על) establishes the conditions for God's controlling the whole earth.

There is also no specific description of the residential space of God in heaven in the Priestly texts. This is different from some verses in Ps 104²⁶. At the beginning of Ps 104, God has his own place in the sky: "Wrapped in light as with a garment, stretching out the heaven like a tent (עטה-אור בשלמה נוטה) (שמים כיריעה). He lays the beams of his chambers on the waters. He makes the clouds his chariot and walks upon the wings of the wind" (Ps 104:2–3). In the Priestly texts, there are rarely descriptions of God's appearance. One of them is when he appears to the Israelites in the Wilderness of Sin: "Behold, the glory

²⁶ For discussion of the cosmological view in Psalm 104, see T. KRÜGER, "'Kosmo-theologie' zwischen Mythos und Erfahrung. Psalm 104 im Horizont altorientalischer und alttestamentlicher 'Schöpfungs'-Konzepte," *BN* 68 (1993), 49–74.

of YHWH appeared in the cloud” (Exod 16:10). Even so, it is not God himself but the glory of God that appears in the cloud.

It seems that the Priestly texts are more concerned with God’s dwelling place on the earth. There are verses illustrating that God lives among the Israelites on the earth: “that I may dwell among them” (Exod 25:8); “I will dwell among the children of Israel and will be their God” (Exod 29:45); and “I may dwell among them” (Exod 29:46). The specific place where God dwells is not clearly mentioned. Rather, the tabernacle is a place where God and Israelites meet. God’s glory also can enter into it (Exod 42–43). God’s space on the earth mainly relates to the theophany. Priestly texts depict the distance between God and Israel as increasingly minimal. The distance between God and humans can also be seen from the perspective of the revelation of God’s name: God reveals himself to Noah as *Elohim*; then reveals himself to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob as “El Shadday”; then reveals himself to Moses by his name *YHWH*. Furthermore, Exod 2:23–25 implies that the distance between God and the Israelites is not metaphorical. God “heard” (שמע) their groaning and “saw” (ראה) them, and then took notice of them.

The distance between God and humanity is another kind of space. From the perspective of narrative, the distance between God and humanity can be illustrated by direct expression. This happens almost always through the appearance of God to the Israelites. First, he appears to the ancestors of the Israelites, especially when he makes the covenant with Abraham (Gen 17:1) and then with Jacob (Gen 35:9–13).

Indirect expression also effectively illustrates the distance between God and the Israelites. The fact that Moses can speak “before” (לפניה) God (Exod 6:30) indicates a proximity between God and Moses. God’s appearances to Moses (Exod 24:15) and the people of Israel (Exod 16:20; 24:15–18; 40:1–38) and the entrance of his glory into the tabernacle all indicate the distance between God and the Israelites in terms of indirect narrative. In addition, God himself emphasizes through direct speech that he dwells among the Israelites (Exod 25:8; 29:45, 46).²⁷

On the whole, God is everywhere and has no specific residence. The way in which his space is presented in the narrative emphasizes universalism. He is the one and only God and travels freely in space. From the ancestors to Moses, from Moses to Israelites, he becomes closer and closer to the chosen people. Moreover, God controls the whole of space. Such power is promised by his elevated position, which is indicated by the use of prepositions such as “up.”

²⁷ R. ALTER, *The Art of Biblical Narrative* (New York: Basic Books, 1981), 63–87, where he discusses the relationship between narration time and narration; he illustrates the relationships between dialogue and narration and between direct speech and indirect speech with an example from 1 Sam 21.

His control of space is vividly reflected in the narrative of the Reed Sea (Exod 14).

3.4.2. *Humanity's Space*

In the Priestly texts, humanity's space can be classified as the space of humanity as a whole, the space of the ancestors, and the space of the Israelites. The space of humanity is mainly illustrated in the flood narrative. Human space in the Priestly flood narrative has both mythical and nonmythical characteristics. The most mythical places found in this narrative are the windows (אֲרָבָה) of heaven opened by God in Noah's ark. The windows of heaven may seem to be just a simple metaphor. However, in Isa 24:18 and Mal 3:10, "the windows of heaven" is used as an idiomatic expression to claim that a thing could hardly happen even if the windows of heaven were opened by God. Accordingly, the windows of heaven can also be mythical. Noah's ark is mythologized in terms its function, but it is demythologized since it has real physical aspects.²⁸ This tension is caused mainly by the description of its spatial characteristics – its length, width, and height – based on real physical space and geographical space (Gen 6:14–16). Its mythical aspect consists in the interrelation between its three decks and the structured cosmos of Gen 1. Broadly speaking, the structured ark can be understood as representing the structured cosmos of the Priestly texts. The ark that is constructed on the basis of real physical principle is thus mythologized. The spatial narrative also strengthens the nonmythical characteristics of the flood narrative. The clear and accurate figures make the ark seem more real (Gen 7:20), and use of a verb such as "cover" (כָּסָה) emphasizes the real physical aspect of flood. Nouns that describe the natural landscape, such as "fountains" (מַעֲיִת) and "bow" (קֶשֶׁת), also accentuate the real physical aspects of human space.

The plot of the patriarchal narratives, particularly in the narratives about Abraham and Jacob, is typically oriented in terms of space. The connection between them can be summarized as:

Abram's father Terah brought Abram, his grandson Lot, and his daughter-in-law Sarai from Ur of the Chaldeans to go into the land of Canaan. When they came to Haran, they settled there (Gen 11:31).

Abram took his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, all the possessions they had accumulated and the people they had acquired in Haran, and they set out for the land of Canaan, and they arrived there (Gen 12:5).

Lot chose for himself the whole plain for the Jordan and set out toward the east. Abraham still lived in the land of Canaan (Gen 13:11–12).

²⁸ C. WESTERMANN, *Genesis 1–11* (BKAT I/1; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1974), 562–63.

God established the covenant with Abram, giving the whole land of Canaan as an everlasting possession to Abram and his descendants, giving Abram the new name Abraham (Gen 17:1–27).

Sarai was buried in Hebron in the land of Canaan (Gen 23:1–20).

Abraham was buried in Hebron, and his son Isaac lived near Beer Lahai Roi (Gen 25:7–11).

Jacob, son of Isaac went to Paddan Aram (Gen 28:1–8).

Jacob went from Paddan Aram to the land of Canaan. Jacob arrived at the city of Shechem in Canaan and camped before the city (Gen 33:18).

Jacob came to Bethel in the land of Canaan (Gen 35:6, 9–13, 15).

Jacob went from Bethel to Hebron (Gen 35:22–29).

Esau's journey (Gen 36:1–14).

Joseph went out from the presence of Pharaoh and went through all (כל) the land of Egypt (Gen 41:46).²⁹

Jacob and all his descendants came to Egypt (Gen 46:6–27).

Israel lived in the land of Egypt (Gen 47:27–28).

Jacob commanded to be buried in Hebron (Gen 49:29–33).

Jacob was buried in Hebron (Gen 50:12–13).

The space connected with the plot about Abraham in the Priestly texts, then, is *Ur–Haran–Canaan*, while the space connected with the plot of Jacob is *Canaan–Paddan Aram–Shechem (in Canaan)–Bethel–Hebron–Egypt–Canaan*. Canaan is emphasized in particular as a place where the Israelites are strangers and sojourners (Exod 6:4). The space-oriented plot is essentially interwoven with the themes and the theology of the patriarchal narratives. The emphasis on the extent of the land probably demonstrates the promise made by God about the extent of land (Gen 17).

In the Priestly texts, the Israelites are not active as an ethnic unit until Gen 47:27. Like the patriarchal narratives, the plot from Gen 47:27 to Exod 40:38 is also oriented in terms of space:

The Israelites were in Egypt and were fruitful, and the land of Egypt was filled with them (Exod 1:1–7).

The Israelites cried out because of their bondage and their cry came up unto God. God heard their groaning, which implies proximity between God and the Israelites (Exod 2:23–25).

God said he would bring the Israelites out of Egypt to Canaan. God spoke to Moses in Egypt (Exod 6:2–30).

God emphasized again that he would bring the Israelites out of Egypt (Exod 7:1–13).

The Israelites were still in Egypt because God hardened Pharaoh's heart (Exod 11:10).

God spoke to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt (Exod 12:1–20).

All the hosts of God went out from the land of Egypt (Exod 12:40–51).

The Israelites were wandering in the wilderness (through the indirect speech of Pharaoh) (Exod 14:1–4).

²⁹ Note the difference between Gen 41:45 and 46: verse 46 emphasizes “all the land of Egypt,” while verse 45 simply says “the land of Egypt.”

The Israelites crossed the Reed Sea (Exod 14:8–10, 15–18).

Moses led the Israelites from the Reed Sea, and they went out into the Wilderness of Shur.

There was no water (Exod 15:22).

The Israelites came to Elim where there were twelve springs of water and seventy date palms, and they camped there beside the waters (Exod 15:27).

The Israelites set out from Elim, and came to the Wilderness of Sin, which is between Elim and Sinai (Exod 16:1–3).

The Israelites journeyed by stages from the Wilderness of Sin and camped at Rephidim, where there was no water (Exod 17:1).

The Israelites came into the Wilderness of Sinai (Exod 19:1–2).

Moses went up to the mountain (Exod 24:15–18).

God said to Moses that the Israelites made God a holy place (Exod 25:1–40).

The construction of tabernacle by Israelites (Exod 27:1–21).

The priests and the tabernacle (Exod 28:1–43).

God and the Israelites and the tabernacle (Exod 29:1–46).

The space connected to the plot of the Israelites, then, is *Egypt–Wilderness–Reed Sea–Wilderness of Shur–Elim–Wilderness of Sin (between Elim and Sinai)–Rephidim–Wilderness of Sinai–Mount Sinai–tabernacle*. It is striking that God is the prime mover of this journey. God asks the Israelites to leave Egypt. God is wherever the Israelites are. God always goes with them. More important still, God is responsible for their journey being completed.

The main places and spaces for Israelites in the journey are the wilderness, Mount Sinai and the tabernacle. In the Hebrew Bible, wilderness has two contradictory symbolic meanings. On the one hand, it is a positive place of cho-seness and purgation (Hos 2:14). On the other hand, it is a negative place of desolation (Jer 25:38). In the Priestly texts, wilderness demonstrates such complex meanings both on the physical and the symbolic level. Wilderness is a physical space in which the Israelites face a very harsh environment. For example, Exod 15:22 and Exod 16:1–3 narrate that there is no water or food in the wilderness. The wilderness described in Exodus is also a symbolic space where the Israelites are purified, and it is a space in which God strengthens their faith.

Although Mount Sinai is a significant sacred place where God gives laws to Israelites in the non-Priestly texts, it does not play an important role in the Priestly texts. In the Priestly texts, Mount Sinai is mentioned in only two places: Exod 19:1–2, which simply says that the Israelites camp before the mountain (הר), and Exod 24:15–8, which recounts that Moses goes up on the mountain (הר). In the non-Priestly texts, God calls to Moses from the mountain (Exod 19:3), while in the Priestly texts this is not mentioned anywhere. In the pre-Priestly texts, the attitude of the Israelites to the mountain is usually awe, since the mountain as a physical environment was hard to control. Mountains are thus mythologized and made more aesthetic, as in the narratives that present mythical aspects of the mountain in Exod 19:1–25. Later, as urbanization

developed, people learned more and more about mountains, and mountains started to be demythologized, and their symbolic meaning decreased as well.³⁰

The tabernacle is a particular space in the Priestly texts. God and the Israelites are able to meet at the entrance (פֶּתַח) of the tabernacle (Exod 29:42–43). This space belongs both to God and to the Israelites. However, it is first and foremost a space constructed by Israelites and serves as an earthly vessel for the glory of God. It is different from sanctuaries such as the temple in older Israelite cultic traditions. It is portable and moves freely with the Israelites to the land of Canaan. Scholars have tended to connect the tabernacle with the narrative of creation. It also can be understood as the archetype of the Second Temple. In addition, “viewed against the backdrop of the psalmic temple theology, one might call this a rather minimalist account of the function and symbolic meaning of the temple of YHWH.”³¹

3.4.3. Nature's Space

The view of the cosmos found in the Priestly texts is similar to the ancient Near Eastern myth *Enuma Elish*.³² The original meaning of “the temple tower” in Babylon is “house, bond of heaven and earth.”³³ Cosmology in the Hebrew Bible is also connected with monotheism and the temple. However, the cosmology in *Enuma Elish* is more about the theogony reflected in its creation narrative. There is also no temple in the *Enuma Elish* creation narrative; the temple is not the center of the cosmos. The relationship between humanity and God is different in the two texts. In *Enuma Elish*, humanity is created in order to work for the gods. In biblical cosmology, humanity, the temple, and God are interrelated. According to Gen 1, God creates humanity for managing the world, and humanity afterwards builds the temple as God's residence on the earth.

Although the Hebrew Bible emphasizes the vertical axis of the world, the cosmos is also horizontal, reflected mainly in the journey from Egypt to the

³⁰ For the change in attitude toward mountains in historical terms, see Y.-F. TUAN, *Topophilia: A Study of Environmental Perception, Attitudes, and Values* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1974), 70–74.

³¹ A. SCHÜLE, “The Notion of Life נֶפֶשׁ and רִיחַ in the Anthropological Discourse of the Primeval History,” *HBAI* 1 (2012), 483–501, here 490.

³² For the structure of cosmos in *Enuma Elish*, see F. HARTENSTEIN, “Wolkendunkel und Himmelsfeste: Zur Genese und Kosmologie der Vorstellung des himmlischen Heiligtums JHWHs,” in *Das biblische Weltbild und seine altorientalischen Kontexte* (ed. B. Janowski and B. Ego; FAT 32; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2001), 125–79, here 172.

³³ SCHÜLE, “Notion” (see n. 30), 485 and S. MAUL, “Die altorientalische Hauptstadt-Abbild und Nabel der Welt,” in *Die Orientalische Stadt: Kontinuität. Wandel. Bruch. I Internationales Kolloquium der Deutschen Orient-Gesellschaft. 9.–10. Mai 1996* (ed. G. Wilhelm; Halle: Saarbrücker Zeitung, 1997), 109–24.

wilderness and from the wilderness to Canaan. Wilderness lies between the polarities of Egypt and Canaan.

Chapter 4

Physical Space in Genesis 1 and 6–9

This section shall discuss how physical space is constructed in Gen 1:1–2:3 (referred to hereafter as Gen 1) and in the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6:1–9:17 (referred to hereafter as Gen 6–9). I define physical space as the objective aspects of space: form, size, and material. Physical space can be experienced and observed, and it is related to motion and direction. Examples include heaven, earth, and the face of the earth in Gen 1 and the mountains, the ark, and the window of heaven in Gen 6. The motion and direction of physical space is not emphasized in Gen 1 or Gen 6–9.

4.1. Genesis 1 and Physical Space

Genesis 1 is the most prominent creation account in the Hebrew Bible. There is wide scholarly agreement that it is the product of priests.¹ God is described here as the one and only creator, who creates the world in an ordered pattern over seven days. He creates the world with the power of speech. Creation proceeds in an orderly fashion: he creates day and night on the first day, the sky on the second day, the earth and the seas on the third day, the lights in the expanse of the sky on the fourth day, living creatures in the sea and birds flying in the sky on the fifth day, and living creatures on the earth and humanity on the sixth day. God then rests on the seventh day. There is a correspondence between two sets of days from the first day through to the seventh day.² The correspondence is emphasized by the narrative structure: God's speech starts the process of creation, and each time he creates something, he sees that it is good. The whole process of creation is marked by day and night, and each thing is in its right place in the cosmos.

4.1.1. *Physical Space in Genesis 1*

Genesis 1 is about the creation of the cosmos and the creatures in it by God. Types of physical space in Gen 1 include God's space, humanity's space, and

¹ E. FIRMAGE, "Genesis 1 and the Priestly Agenda," *JSOT* 82 (1999), 97–114.

² K. SCHMID, *Schöpfung* (Themen der Theologie 4, Uni-Taschenbücher 3514; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2012), 79.

nature's space. First, God's space is divided into the space before creation (Gen 1:1–2), the space in the process of creation (Gen 1:3–2:2), and the space after creation (Gen 2:1–3), which means the space where God dwells. Humanity's space is mainly reflected mainly in Gen 1:26–29, which not only tells about the space created on the sixth day but also summarizes the space created in the first five days. Nature's space could therefore also be understood as humanity's space, which consists in sky, earth, and sea. There are also numerous kinds of spatial relationships among living creatures or plants and with the earth and seas where they live.

Since Gen 1 is mainly about the cosmology of the ancient Jews, the narrative about nature's space takes up most of the text. Nature's space in Gen 1 is constructed from the ordinary environments which people can experience in their daily life. The narrative of nature's space starts from the formless and empty earth, while the "deep" (תהום) and the "water" (המים) have form, implied by use of the phrase "the surface of" (על-פני): the darkness is over *the surface of* the deep and the spirit of God can move over *the surface of* waters (Gen 1:2). On the second day, the creation of space starts from the water. The expanse that God named "sky" is created in the spatial frame of reference of water (Gen 1:6–8). On the third day, in the spatial frame of reference of sky, the seas and the earth are created. Then the plants are created in the spatial frame of reference of earth (Gen 1:11–13). On the fourth day, the lights are created in the spatial frame of reference of the sky (Gen 1:14–19). On the fifth day, the living creatures are created in the spatial frame of reference of the seas (Gen 1:20–23). On the sixth day, the living creatures and the humans on the earth are created in the spatial frame of reference to the earth. The spatial settings described in Genesis 1 are shown in Table 1.

According to the sequence of descriptions, the physical spaces are the sky and the earth (Gen 1:1), the surface of deep and the surface of the waters (Gen

Table 1. Spatial Settings in Genesis 1

Days	Spatial Reference Points	Spaces and Spatial Settings
The first day	formless and empty earth	deep waters
The second day	waters	sky
The third day	sky earth	seas and earth plants
The fourth day	sky	lights
The fifth day	seas sky	living creatures in the sea birds
The sixth day	earth	living creatures humans

1:2), the seas (Gen 1:9–10), the face of the earth (Gen 1:12), the expanse of the sky (Gen 1:14), the earth and the heaven (Gen 1:20), the waters (Gen 1:21), seas, the earth (Gen 1:22), the earth (Gen 1:24), seas, the sky, the earth (Gen 1:26), the earth, seas, the sky (Gen 1:28), the earth (Gen 1:29), the earth, the sky (Gen 1:30), and the sky and the earth (Gen 2:1). All of these are the natural environments that humans experience daily and are necessary for human life. Over the course of the first three days, God creates the spaces of sky, earth, and seas which can be seen as physical spatial points. Over the course of the next three days these spatial points then offer the necessary spatial context for living creatures. From the narrative viewpoint, different scenes are constructed by these spatial points which refer to each other: The scene on the first day is constructed by the formless earth, the deep, and the surface of the waters on which God's spirit walks. The scene on the second day is constructed through reference to the waters and the sky. The scene on the third day is constructed through reference to the seas and the earth, then the earth and plants. After the third day, the creatures and the spaces they occupy refer to each other. The scene on the fourth day is constructed through reference to the sky and the lights, and on the fifth day through reference to the seas, the sky, and the creatures living in them. The scene on the sixth day is unique, since humanity is created and the whole of space is constructed by all the references found in the first five days.

4.1.2. God's Physical Space in Genesis 1

The types of physical space associated with God in Gen 1 include God's own space, the space during creation, the space where God speaks to humanity, and the space after creation.

First, God's own space is mentioned in Gen 1:1–2 and 2:3. Gen 1:1 is a summary of the whole space that God creates – heaven and earth – and is followed by the process of creation over seven days. “At the beginning” is a temporal expression that provides a spatial setting for the narrative, similar to the function of “a long, long time ago” in folklore. “God created heaven and earth” indicates a spatial relationship between God, on the one hand, and heaven and earth, on the other: heaven and earth are a point relative to God, while God occupies another space and is not in heaven and earth. The fact that God's spirit moves on the face of the waters implies that God himself is not in space before creation; it is merely the spirit of God that moves over the face of waters. Furthermore, the fact that God “rests” from all his work in Gen 2:3 implies that God has a place where he can rest. In the Priestly texts, it is not until the tabernacle is constructed that God has a place to rest on the earth. Gen 2:3 thus implies that the place where God rests is not in the space he creates.

The second and the third type of space associated with God are the space during creation and the space in which God spoke to humans. Space during

creation refers to where God is when he creates the world. If he is in his own space before creation, then does he necessarily create the world in his space? There is also no clear description of God's space during creation. In Gen 1, God creates the world with his speech rather than physically constructing the parts of world. The way God creates the world is so abstract that there is no indication of the real distance between God and the world. However, not all of God's speeches in Gen 1 are abstract. Those in Gen 1:26 and 1:28–29 are quite concrete: "God said: let us make man in our image, after our likeness" (וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה בְּצַלְמֵנוּ כְּדֹמוֹתֵנוּ) and "God said to them" (וַיֹּאמֶר לָהֶם אֱלֹהִים). Both of these indicate a proximity between God and the listeners, although this proximity is more a conceptual idea than a physical spatial relationship.

The viewpoints in the narrative can also clarify the position of God. The particular viewpoint suggested in Gen 1 comes from the phrase "God saw that it was good" (וַיֵּרָא אֱלֹהִים כִּי־טוֹב) at the end of each day of creation. Most viewpoints show that God is above the space he created. In Gen 1:10, 12, 18, 21, 25, and 31, God sees and declares "good" the earth and seas, the plants on the earth, the creatures in the seas, and the lights in the sky, which implies that God is above the world he has created. This is more clearly reflected in Gen 1:31: God sees that everything he had made is good. All these viewpoints indicate that God is above the world.

The fourth type of space associated with God is the space after creation. While Gen 1:26 gives the sense that the place where God gives the speech is a public place, Gen 2:2–3 not only indicates that God is in a place different from the human world but also gives the sense that God's place is like a dwelling place in which God can rest.

4.1.3. *Humanity's Physical Space in Genesis 1*

Humanity is depicted as an active agent in Gen 1:26–29. There are no clear spatial verbs and specific descriptions of human space. Consequently, we can only analyze human space as it is depicted in the texts. According to Gen 1:26, 28, although human beings should rule over the other creatures in the sea, in the sky, and on the earth, there are no viewpoints that can show clearly the spatial relationships among humanity and the creatures in these three realms. However, the phrase "fill the earth" (וּמְלֵאוּ אֶת־הָאָרֶץ) in Gen 1:28 indicates that the position of humanity is above the earth. It is not clear whether הָנָה in Gen 1:29 is best translated "see" or "behold." If it means "see," then the human viewpoint can be justified through the direct speech of God. The object of the verb "see" is the plants on the earth, suggesting that the position of humanity is above the earth. In addition, Gen 1:20 describes space from the point of view of humanity, since it is suggested that the birds fly above the earth in the expanse of the heaven. The birds do fly not above the heaven but "in the expanse of the heaven." The viewpoint seems to be that of humans living under the sky

and on the earth. On the whole, it is on the earth that humans rule over all the creatures in the sea, in the sky, and on the earth. The world is created for humanity. Although there are not any narratives specifically about human space, the characteristics of human space can be clarified through analysis of nature's space.

4.1.4. Nature's Physical Space in Genesis 1

Since God's creation of the world unfolds as the plot of Gen 1 unfolds, nature's space involves nature's space before creation, nature's space during creation, and nature's space after creation. Nature's space before creation is reflected in Gen 1:1–2. In Gen 1:2, the formless and void earth can be understood a kind of space, although there are no clear spatial relationships such as those evident in the spirit of God and the surface of the water.

Nature's space during creation is described in Gen 1:3–31. God creates the world over seven days. The first day describes the creation of time rather than space. On the second day, the waters constitute a spatial reference point, and the sky is created (Gen 1:6). On the third day, sky constitutes a spatial reference point, and the earth and the sea are created (Gen 1:10). On the same day, the sea constitutes a spatial reference point, while the earth and the sea are created. The basic spatial settings are thus created: sky, earth, and sea. As soon as the earth is created, it is taken as a spatial reference point for creating the plants. On the fourth day, the sky constitutes a spatial reference point, and the lights are created. On the fifth day, the sea (or waters) constitutes a spatial reference point for creation of aquatic creatures, while the sky constitutes a spatial reference point for creation of birds. The sixth day is unique since human beings are created on this day. On the one hand, the creatures are created with the earth as a spatial reference point; on the other hand, God says that humans should multiply, with the earth as spatial reference point. The verb "rule over" relates to all spatial reference points together.

We can now see that the reference points play an important role in constructing space in Gen 1. The reference points are identified through the use of reference words. The spatial relationships among different places and the spatial features of sky, earth, and sea can also be identified through analysis of reference words. On the second day, the reference word is "midst" (בתוך), which implies first the water as a whole, and then that the water is placed both above and under the sky. On the third day, the reference word is "on," which emphasizes that the plants grow up from the earth, and the earth becomes the spatial ground. The fourth day has two reference words: one is "in," emphasizing that the lights are in the sky, and the other is "on," emphasizing that the earth as a whole is a spatial frame relative to the lights. In Gen 1:17, the verb "set" (נתן) also indicates the position of lights in the sky. On the fifth day, the reference verb "brought forth" shows that the sea is the spatial frame of reference for

creatures in waters. At the same time, the earth and sky are the spatial frame of reference for birds flying above the earth in the expanse of the heaven (Gen 1:20). The reference words are two prepositions, “above” (על) and “in the open expanse of” (על-פני רקיע).

In Gen 1:22, it is the earth, not the sky, that has a spatial relationship to birds. The birds multiply “on” (ב) the earth. Gen 1:20 and Gen 1:22 have different spatial frames of reference for birds: one is the sky, the other is the earth. Gen 1:20 emphasizes the “flying” of birds, and Gen 1:22 emphasizes that they “multiply.” Consequently, birds have different spatial relationships with different spatial frames of reference through the reference word “multiply.” On the sixth day, on the one hand, the reference word “bring forth” indicates that the earth is the spatial frame of reference for all the creatures (Gen 1:24); on the other hand, the reference word “multiply” indicates that the earth is the spatial ground for humans (Gen 1:28). Finally, the word “rule over” (רדה) applies to the three dimensions of space as a whole (Gen 1:28).³

In addition to reference verbs, prepositions in Gen 1 indicate the relative position more directly. On the second day, “above” (על) and “below” (תחת) show not only the spatial relationship between the waters and the sky but also their specific position. On the third day, the phrase “on the earth” indicates a relative position of the earth and plants (Gen 1:11). On the fourth day, the fact that the lights are placed “in” the sky shows that the lights are contained in the sky. On the fifth day, “above” (על) and “below” (תחת) show the relative positions of the earth, the sky, and the birds (Gen 1:20) and that of the seas and the earth, as well as the terrestrial creatures and the birds (Gen 1:22). On the sixth day, the use of “above” shows the relative position of the earth and the creatures (Gen 1:25–26), that of the earth and humans (Gen 1:28), and that of the whole earth and the plants (Gen 1:29), as well as that of the earth and everything else (Gen 1:30).

4.2. Genesis 6–9 and Physical Space

Genesis 6–9 is the narrative about the flood. Based on repetitions in the text and similar phenomena, it has long since been agreed that Gen 6–9 consists in two different versions, a Priestly version and a non-Priestly version, that have been interwoven.⁴ I take the content of the Priestly version to include Gen 6:9–22; 7:6, 11, 13–16a, 18–21, 24; 8:1a, 2a, 3b–5, 13a, 14–19; 9:1–17.

³ In the context of Gen 1, “rule over” in verse 28 implies that humanity should rule over the world with care to keep the world well ordered; see, e.g., T.E. FRETHERM, “Genesis,” *NIB* 1:346.

⁴ C. WESTERMANN, *Genesis 1–11* (BKAT I/1; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1974), 491–661.

The Priestly version can be dated to the exile or postexilic period. It can also be read independently from the non-Priestly version. The Priestly version of the flood narrative was probably a self-contained story, and the non-Priestly version was interpolated later. The Priestly version recounts that, in the generation of Noah, the earth is corrupt and filled with violence, so God destroys the world. Because Noah is a righteous man, God makes a covenant with Noah and promises that Noah with his family and animals of each species will survive in an ark. Then the whole world is covered by the flood. After the flood, God makes a covenant with Noah again, promising that he will not destroy the world again; this promise can be seen as the narrative purpose of the Priestly flood narrative. The question is: does God destroy the world created in Genesis 1?

4.2.1. Physical Space in Genesis 6–9

First, from the viewpoint of God's space, Gen 6–9 tells how God destroys the world he created and rearranges its order. The "totality of space" is thus the whole cosmos.⁵ The beginning of the story shows that the world belongs to God. Another form of God's space is the space where God makes the covenants with Noah. There is no specific description of this space. The characteristics of it can be identified from Gen 6:13–22 and Gen 9:8–17.

Second, from the viewpoint of humanity, the important plot points are that God destroys the world and then makes the covenant with Noah. Noah in Gen 6–9 apparently represents humanity on earth. Human physical space therefore exists in the flood narrative. In addition to the world in which humans live, another important physical space belonging to humanity is the ark, which plays a very significant role in the flood narrative. Noah, as the representative of humanity, survives the flood on account of the ark. From Michel Foucault's perspective, the ark is a typical heterotopic space.⁶ As a boat, the ark does not occupy a particular place, it just floats (הלך) on the surface of the water.

Since God uses a flood, which is a natural thing, to destroy the world, this destruction happens mainly in nature. There are many more descriptions of the natural environment in the Priestly flood narrative. Many of the natural settings are similar to those in Gen 1, for instance, the earth, the surface of earth, below the sky, and so on. However, there are two striking differences between the natural environments in Gen 1 and Gen 6–9. The first difference is that the Priestly flood narrative identifies more specific places. The mountains appear and are mentioned several times in the Priestly flood narrative, while Gen 1 basically focuses on the sky, earth, and sea as three dimensions of nature's space. Second, there are more spatial elements among different places: there

⁵ For definition of "total space" in narrative, see G. ZORAN, "Towards the Theory of Space in Narrative," *Poetics Today* 2 (1984), 309–35, here 322–23.

⁶ M. FOUCAULT, "Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias," *Diacritics* 16 (1986), 22–27, here 27.

are windows in heaven (Gen 7:11), clouds covering the earth, and a bow in the cloud (Gen 9:14).

4.2.2. God's Physical Space in Genesis 6–9

The types of physical space associated with God in the Priestly flood narrative include the space where God is; the space where God talks to Noah, as well as the space where God makes covenant with Noah (this is also a space God occupies after the flood); and the space which God occupies during the flood.

According to Gen 6:11–12, the world is a point relative to God when he looks at it. Moreover, the position of God is higher than this world, which is implied by the verb “see” (ראה) (Gen 6:12). “Before (לפנה) the world” implies the relative positions of God and the world. God can also “see” (ראה) this world in a higher position (Gen 6:12). God is therefore not in this world but in his own world and sees the world from a higher position. Although the features of space God occupies are never mentioned, then, they can be illustrated from Gen 6:11–12: God is not in this world; he is beyond this space, in another space, and his position is higher than this world.

Although God is not in the world he creates, he is not limited by space. He can freely move between the world he creates and his own space. This point is illustrated in his speech to Noah (Gen 6:13–21; 8:15, 17). There are no specific details about God's appearance to Noah, only the phrase “then God said to Noah” (Gen 6:13), saying that he will establish his covenant with Noah, and that Noah will survive in the ark (Gen 6:14–21). The second speech of God to Noah is when he establishes a covenant with Noah after the flood. The speech of God to Noah after the flood is introduced not merely by “then God spoke to Noah” (Gen 8:15) but also by “And God blessed Noah and his sons and said to them” (Gen 9:1) and then “God spoke to Noah and to his sons with him” (Gen 9:8) immediately after they came out from the ark (Gen 8:18). In addition, the spatial context in which God establishes a covenant with Noah is more vivid. Most spatial settings are real in the world, especially the cloud and bow. All illustrate that God is very near to Noah and that he is in this world.

There is no specific narrative about God's space during the flood. God's space is illustrated only in Gen 8:1: during the flood, God “remembered” (זכר) Noah and all the beasts and all the cattle that were with Noah in the ark, then God caused a wind to pass over the earth, and the water subsided. Generally speaking, “remember” is used when God is about to help someone, such as when God remembers Abraham (Gen 19:29) and Rachel (Gen 30:22). God also causes the wind (רוח) to pass over the earth; the fact that the verb is causative emphasizes the proximity between God and the wind. However, רוח does not necessarily mean the natural “wind” but probably indicates the “spirit.” It thus aligns itself with the other uses of רוח in the flood narrative (Gen 6:17; 7:15).

4.2.3. Humanity's Physical Space in Genesis 6–9

In the Priestly flood narrative, it is Noah who is blessed by God, who enters the ark, and who experiences the flood. Noah can be interpreted as representative of humanity, especially in comparison to other species. Noah's space includes the world before creation (Gen 6:9–13), the ark (Gen 6:14–22), Noah's space during the flood (Gen 7:11, 13–16a, 18–21, 24; 8:1a, 2a, 3b–5, 13a, 14–19), and the space where Noah is blessed by God (Gen 6:13–21; 8:15, 17). The last aspect was analyzed when I discussed the space in which God talks to Noah and the space where God makes the covenant with Noah. The present section discusses only the first three aspects.

First, at the beginning of the Priestly flood narrative, the spatial context of Noah's generation is introduced by the author's viewpoint: Noah walked (התהלך) with God (Gen 6:9). In Gen 17:1, also a Priestly text, the narrative in which God establishes the covenant with Abraham is also introduced by God's direct speech: "I am God Almighty, walk before (לפנה) me, and be blameless." The difference between Gen 6:9 and Gen 17:1 is that "Noah walked *with* God" (את־האלהים התהלך־נח), whereas Abraham walked *before* God. Both indicate a kind of spatial relationship. As mentioned, God has no spatial limitation but can move freely between this world and his own space. That Noah can walk with God shows a proximity between them. Yet Noah's space is also limited. This is implied by the fact that he can know the situation of the world only through God's speech (Gen 6:13). Accordingly, the fact that Noah walks with God is more conceptual. The conceptual spatial relationship is demonstrated by a physical spatial relationship. Then the spatial context of Noah's world is introduced by God's viewpoint: "the earth was filled with violence, all flesh had corrupted his way on the earth" (Gen 6:11–12).

Second, the ark is a particular physical space within humanity's space during the flood. The word "ark" has different meanings in different biblical texts: it can be a box in which the testimony of God to the Israelites was placed (Exod 25:10–16) or it can be a box in which Moses was placed in order to survive the flood (Exod 2:3). Accordingly, "ark" is not a proper noun. When the word "ark" is used, the physical and material characteristics must be added to define the nature of the ark. In the flood narrative, while it is a material entity, it is more like a space. It is a space in which humans and animals can survive, a space that can get through the flood. The ark is also mentioned several times in the Priestly flood narrative, which illustrates its importance. The speech of God (Gen 6:14–16) contains a specific description of the ark that focuses on geometric features such as its length, width, height, and levels. The specific description of the ark on the one hand indicates that the Priestly texts are very attentive to the space of the ark; on the other hand, it illustrates that the ark

probably has an archetype, which helped the writers to design the ark in narrative. It is still not clear whether the archetype of the ark is to be found in ancient Near Eastern myths.

The third type of space associated with Noah is the space during and after the flood (Gen 8:1a, 2a, 3b–5, 13a, 14–19). When the flood happens, Noah, his family, and all kinds of animals on the earth come into the ark in pairs (Gen 7:13–16a). This illustrates the function of ark as physical space: a pair of every species on earth came to the ark and survived. “Each pair” emphasizes that the physical design of ark is determined by its function. The ark functions not only as a shelter but also as a boat. The ark floats on the surface of the water (Gen 7:18). The ark occupies no specific place but floats from one place to another. In this sense, the ark is a space rather than a place. This characteristic of the ark is prominent in the Priestly texts. The ark in the tabernacle can also be understood as space since it moves freely with the tabernacle. Portability is thus an important characteristic of the ark. After the flood, the ark rested upon the mountains of Ararat. The ark indicates the height of the flood since it floats on the surface of water. It can rest upon the mountain only if the height of flood is as high as the level of mountains (Gen 7:19–20).

4.2.4. *Nature's Physical Space in Genesis 6–9*

Nature's space can also be analyzed from the point of view of the space before the flood, the space during the flood, and the world after the flood.

The first type of nature's space is the nature's space before flood. The description of how the earth became corrupt in the sight of God and filled with violence focuses on the earth (Gen 6:11). It is the earth (הָאָרֶץ), not the surface of earth (עַל-הָאָרֶץ), that has the spatial relationship with violence (חֲמָס). In his speech to Noah, God again accentuates the fact that, since the earth is filled with violence, he will destroy it (Gen 6:13). Violence, which lends emotions and values to the concept of earth, and the earth are again put into spatial relationship by the word “fill.” Then God says he will bring the flood of water upon the earth (Gen 6:17), which includes a spatial relationship between the flood and the surface of earth. Accordingly, it can be argued that the earth normally relies on nouns to enter into spatial relationships and does not need a verb, yet the phrase “the surface of earth” does need a verb. Moreover, it can be argued that it is the earth as a component of the world that is filled with violence. The other space in the Priestly flood narrative is neutral. It is only the earth and the flesh on the earth that are destroyed by God. It is thus not very accurate to argue that the Priestly flood narrative is the second creation.

The second type of nature's space is space during the flood, which includes the fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven, as well as the earth and the mountains. “Windows of heaven” here should be understood metaphorically. The windows constitute not a physical space but a conceptual space

which is usually used to express a surprising image (e.g., Isa 24:18; Mal 3:10). It is noteworthy that, while Gen 1 does not mention mountains, mountains are very important in the Priestly flood narrative. They can measure the size and form of space. In Gen 7:19–20 “high mountains” show the height of the flood, while “mountains” show the scale of flood. Also, “and the water receded gradually until the tenth month” (Gen 8:5) shows how a temporal word can describe a physical space.

The third type of nature’s space is the space after the flood. It includes the mountains of Ararat, the tops of the mountains, and the earth. When God establishes the covenant with Noah, a variety of spaces are described (Gen 9:13–17): “cloud” (ענן), “earth” (ארץ), and “rainbow” (קשת). These physical spaces are almost natural landscapes. Nevertheless, since the special context of establishing the covenant, most of them have symbolic meanings. They should thus be understood symbolically.

Chapter 5

Conceptual Space in Genesis 1 and 6–9

This chapter analyzes the conceptual space in Gen 1 and the Priestly flood narrative of Genesis 6–9. Conceptual space is the idea of space in people's minds; it is usually reflected in maps, signs, and texts.¹ Conceptual space is typically embedded in the rhetoric of texts. The key questions are: What is the perception of space in the mind of Priestly authors? To what extent do we know how Priestly authors think about space in Gen 1 and the Priestly flood narrative? Generally, the space we experience in texts is conceptual space; in other words, narrative space is essentially conceptual space because it is constructed by signs. Accordingly, narrative style and narrative mode deeply influence the construction of conceptual space, and conceptual space can be discussed through narrative modes such as exposition, argumentation, description, and narration. For example, we can know which aspect of space an author emphasizes by analyzing which aspect of space is described with more details. We can also know roughly how an author thinks about the scale of the world in his contemporary period through his descriptions of space or place in the narrative. In the present chapter, Section 5.1 will discuss conceptual space in the Priestly creation narrative of Gen 1, and Section 5.2 will discuss conceptual space in the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9.

5.1. Genesis 1 and Conceptual Space

The most prominent characteristic of conceptual space in Gen 1 is its well-structured cosmos. God creates the world over seven days, the spatial settings of the cosmos are constructed in a pattern, and their spatial relationships are constructed elaborately. The structure is both horizontal and vertical. This vertical axis of the cosmos is stratified. Another characteristic of conceptual space in Gen 1 is universalism. In the present discussion, universalism means that the description of space does not emphasize a certain place and does not describe a certain place in detail. The spatial settings are created against the background of the cosmos. The aim is to construct three dimensions of space: sky, seas,

¹ E. SOJA, *Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and Other Real-and-Imagined Places* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 1996), 66–67.

and earth. In addition, the etiology of space can generally be analyzed from the conceptual space in Gen 1. In Gen 1, the spatial settings in the world are created by God, and the divine origin of space is reflected by God's speech. Moreover, although it has similarities with ancient Near Eastern creation myths, Gen 1 offers a new vision of a less mythological view of space because it is written or edited as a component of Israel's historiographical narrative. The present discussion focuses on how these characteristics of conceptual space are constructed within the Priestly narrative and how other elements of that narrative influenced the expression of these ideas of space.

5.1.1. *The Ordered and Well-Structured Cosmos in Genesis 1*

The Priestly view of cosmic structure is, on the one hand, horizontal. Abraham's journey is *Ur–Haran–Canaan*. Jacob's journey is *Canaan–Paddan Aram–Shechem (in Canaan)–Bethel–Hebron–Egypt–Canaan*. For the Israelites as an ethnic unit, the journey is *Egypt–Wilderness–Reed Sea–Wilderness of Shur–Elim–Wilderness of Sin (between Elim and Sinai)–Rephidim–Wilderness of Sinai–Mount Sinai–tabernacle*. Viewed broadly, it is a journey from Ur to Canaan, from Canaan to Egypt, from Egypt to the wilderness, then through wilderness to Canaan: *Ur–Canaan–Egypt–wilderness–Canaan*. Wilderness becomes a medium between two polarities, Canaan and Egypt. It can therefore be understood as a horizontal axis. This horizontal axis is composed of earthly spatial settings such as rivers, trees, and mountains. Canaan, Egypt, wilderness, and the other cities or villages are all the social or natural landscapes.

Genesis 1, however, expresses a vertical view of the cosmos. According to Gen 1, creation proceeds in an orderly structure in seven days. "Divine speech proposing creation of some part of the universe; the creation (or 'letting there be') of what is proposed in the divine speech; the divine separation of elements of creation; the divine naming of these components; God seeing that it is good; the mention of evening and morning, numbered as successive days of the week."² Then, we see a balance between two sets of corresponding days from the first day through the seventh day.

There is a correspondence between days one to three and days four to six (1/4, 2/5, 3/6), which heightens the symmetry and order of God's creation. Here, God's creation of heavenly lights on the fourth day corresponds to creation of light, day, and night on the first. In a critical response to non-Israelite cultures who worshiped these heavenly bodies, the bodies are not named and are identified as mere timekeepers.³

² M.S. SMITH, *The Priestly Vision of Genesis 1* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2010), 89.

³ M.D. Coogan (ed.), *The New Oxford Annotated Bible* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2001), 11.

In the pattern of creation in Gen 1, spatial settings are created on the basis of well-structured spatial relationships. First of all, the whole structure of the cosmos is a circle. This circle is from water to earth. The importance of water and the earth is emphasized in this circle. In ancient Near Eastern creation stories, the primordial material for creation is water.⁴ Although the starting point of creation is God's space, as implied by Gen 1:1, the starting point of the "internal circle" of creation is the earth (formless and empty earth) and the primordial water. The earth as starting point is formless, then it becomes the center of different spatial relationships. This may indicate the conceptual importance of and emphasis on the earth in Gen 1. As one of the three dimensions, the sky is an important spatial reference point because the waters and the earth were created within the spatial framework of the sky. These three dimensions of space are created in an ordered pattern. On the one hand, the spatial relationships are symmetrical and well structured; on the other hand, they show the conceptual emphasis on the earth. On the fourth, fifth, and sixth days, these spatial settings are defined further as the text describes the creation of plants, creatures, and humans. These are all created in days four, five, and six in the spatial framework of three-dimensional space. The spatial order and balances mean that there are harmonious relations among these spatial settings, which is illustrated in Table 2.

Table 2. Spatial Relationships in Genesis 1

Days	Spatial Reference Points	Spaces and Spatial Settings
The first day	formless and empty earth	deep waters
The second day	waters	sky
The third day	sky	seas and earth
	earth	plants
The fourth day	sky	lights
The fifth day	seas sky	living creatures in the sea birds
The sixth day	earth	living creatures humans

⁴ SMITH, *Priestly Vision* (see n. 2), 50.

5.1.2. Genesis 1 and Universalism

Genesis 1 emphasizes spatial relationships rather than specific places.⁵ There is a lack of detailed description of any particular place. Even on the fourth, fifth and sixth days, when space is transformed into specific places through definition of their features, the description of space focuses on their function. For instance, the waters, sky, and earth each serve as spatial reference points at first. In this respect, they are space defined as spatial relationships: sky is created in the spatial framework of water, then seas and earth are created in the spatial framework of the sky. When they are transformed into places for plants, creatures, and humans, the transformation is completed by spatial reference words such as “above” and “in the expanse of.” Plants are created in the framework of the earth, and lights are created in the framework of sky. Then the living creatures are created in the framework of seas, and birds are created in the framework of the sky. On the sixth day, living creatures and humans are created on the earth. Generally speaking, spatial relationships imply a static space rather than a fluid place. Whatever the transformations of places, the basic spatial relationships are static. Spatial relationships are thus concerned more with the nature of space than with the characteristics of place.

The universality of space is also illustrated by the lack of cardinal directions. Cardinal directions normally help people to discover or locate positions. For example, groups relying on celestial bodies usually use cardinal directions to discover and locate their position. People living on the plateau or in a zone where there is much sunshine usually used cardinal points for finding a place. Because the main function of cardinal directions is to locate a position, they can make a fluid space a specific and static place.

Cardinal directions also imply anthropocentrism, because justifying the cardinal direction needs the human body.⁶ Genesis 1 also implies anthropocentrism, but it does not rely on the description of cardinal directions. Humanity becomes the center in terms of functionalism.⁷ It is not a center in the geographical and physical sense.

Among the four cardinal directions used in the Pentateuch—north, east, south, and west—the most frequent is east, then south, then north and west. South, north, and west also tend to appear together in the same account. The prominent cases are the description of the tabernacle (east: Exod 27:13; 38:13;

⁵ For a brief history of the concepts of monotheism, see J. BLENKINSOPP, *Treasures Old and New: Essays in the Theology of the Pentateuch* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994), 78–80.

⁶ For the function of cardinal points in culture, see Y.-F. TUAN, *Space and Place: The Perspective of Experience* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1977), 88–100.

⁷ For a functionalist interpretation of Genesis 1, see J.H. WALTON, *The Lost World of Genesis One: Ancient Cosmology and the Origins Debate* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009).

west: Exod 27:12; 38:12; north: Exod 26:20, 35; 38:11; 40:22; south: Exod 26:18, 35; 27:9; 36:23; 38:9; 40:24) and the description of the twelve tribes of Israel camping before their entrance into Canaan (Num 2:3–25).

East, as the most cited cardinal direction, is generally used to describe an abstract geographical place, as in Gen 28:14: “your offspring shall also be like the dust of the earth, and you shall spread out to the west and to the east and to the north and to the south; and in you and in your offspring shall all the families of the earth be blessed.” East can describe the specific place in ethnogeographical terms, such as the garden in Eden and some cities (Gen 3:24; 4:16; Num 2:3; 10:5; 34:11). East can also describe an element of the natural landscape such as a mountain (Gen 10:30; 12:8; Num 23:7; Deut 3:17, 27), a river (Num 32:19; Deut 4:41, 47, 49), or a natural phenomenon such as the wind (Gen 41:6, 23, 27; Exod 10:13; 14:21). In some cases, east takes the human as a spatial reference point (Gen 16:12; 25:18), although it may also take an element of architecture such as the tabernacle as a reference point (Exod 27:13; 38:13; Lev 16:14; Num 35:5).

West usually describes specific geographical places (Gen 12:8; Num 2:18; 34:6; Deut 33:23) or architecture such as the tabernacle (Exod 27:12; 38:12; Num 35:5). Similarly, north is usually used with a specific place (Num 2:25; 34:7, 9; 35:5) as well as in connection with the tabernacle (Exod 26:20, 35; 38:11; 40:22). South is used to describe a specific place (Num 2:10; 10:6; 34:4; 35:5; Deut 33:23) as well as the tabernacle (Exod 26:18, 35; 27:9; 36:23; 38:9; 40:24). It is only in Gen 28:14 that cardinal directions are used to describe abstract geographical space.

Priestly texts rarely use cardinal directions. Even in the wilderness, where the Israelites could have used cardinal directions to locate their position, the narrative lacks them. Cardinal directions appear together only in the account of the tabernacle, and their main function is to locate the specific objects around or in the tabernacle: “east” (קדם): Exod 27:13; 38:13; “west” (ים): Exod 27:12; 38:12; “north” (צפון): Exod 26:20, 35; 38:11; 40:22; “south” (נגב): Exod 26:18, 35; 27:9; 36:23; 38:9; 40:24. In the account of the tabernacle, given that the spatial reference point is the tabernacle (Exod 26:18, 20, 35; 36:23; 40:22, 24) or the court of the tabernacle (Exod 27:9, 12, 13; 38:11, 12, 13), the four cardinal directions appear in order to first introduce the position of the objects and, more importantly, to locate the specific position of the objects. In their use of the cardinal directions, both Exod 27:9 and 27:12 illustrate the different relative positions of hangings with different lengths. Among the four cardinal directions, south appeared most frequently, as in Exod 26:18–23: south is the first direction mentioned, the north side is called the second side (Exod 26:20), and then the west. The Priestly tabernacle narrative is different from the non-Priestly texts in which east is highlighted, as in Num 2:3–25 where east is the side of the tabernacle where Judah is camping.

It can be argued from the above discussion that Gen 1 does not organize nature in terms of the cardinal directions. It is spatial relationships that organize the world and the cosmos. The main function of the cardinal directions is to discover and locate the specific position of objects, as illustrated in the account of the tabernacle. In Gen 1, nature is constructed through spatial relationships, evident from verbs or prepositions that convey the relationship of one element to another. The lack of cardinal directions in Gen 1 implies that the Priestly cosmic view is not concerned with the symbolic meanings of the cardinal points. The cosmological system in Gen 1 is not built on the cardinal directions. The lack of cardinal directions contributed to Gen 1's vision of universal space.

5.1.3. *Mythical and Less Mythical Visions of Space*

If we study the Bible in the context of ancient Near Eastern literature, Gen 1 is to some extent a creation myth, since it shares many characteristics with other Near Eastern creation myths or epics:⁸ creation is not *ex nihilo*, the primordial material is water, and the process of creation involves transforming a disordered world into an ordered world. That said, Gen 1 has its own particularities in comparison with other creation myths or epics, such as *Enuma Elish* – which tells how the world is created through the battle between Marduk and Tiamat – *Atrahasis*, the Descent of Ishtar, Anzu, and Erra and Ishum. In Gen 1, however, the world is not created through a divine battle. Since Gen 1 is a component of the historiographical narrative from Genesis through 2 Kings, the discussion of its genre becomes more complicated. These accounts can be read as myths, especially according to Michael Fishbane. He does not see the myth in terms of a genre; rather he sees a myth as a kind of account. He argues: “We shall understand the word ‘Myth’ to refer to (sacred and authoritative) accounts of the deeds and personalities of the gods and heroes during the formative events of primordial times, or during the subsequent historical interventions or actions of these figures which are constitutive for the founding of a given culture and its rituals.”⁹ According to this approach, Gen 1 is to some extent a creation myth, since not only does it share many characteristics with ancient Near Eastern creation myths and epics, it also includes most of the features that Fishbane proposes.

⁸ For a discussion of reading creation accounts as myth, see, e.g., W.H. SCHMIDT, *Einführung in das Alte Testament* (Berlin: de Gruyter, 1982), 59–65; R. BLOCH, *Moses und der Mythos Die Auseinandersetzung mit der griechischen Mythologie bei Jüdisch-Hellenistischen Autoren* (Supplements to the Journal for the Study of Judaism 145; Leiden: Brill, 2011), 55–70; and M.A. FISHBANE, *Biblical Myth and Rabbinic Mythmaking* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003). For a discussion of both mythical and nonmythical natures of Genesis 1, see SMITH, *Priestly Vision* (see n. 2), 139–59.

⁹ See FISHBANE, *Biblical Myth and Rabbinic Mythmaking* (see n. 8), 11.

Yet the genre of Gen 1 is blurred. Although one of the creation myths in the Hebrew Bible, it was transformed by Priestly authors to become a component of the historiographical narrative from Genesis through 2 Kings.¹⁰ To what extent, then, does Gen 1 conform with a new vision of a nonmythological narrative? How is the nonmythological vision of space demonstrated through narrative? In the present discussion, I shall analyze how the conceptual space in Gen 1 shows its mythological traditions as well as its nonmythological elements, in comparison with other creation accounts and texts dealing with the notion of creation in the Hebrew Bible.

What is mythical space? What are the characteristics of mythical space? In *Space and Place: The Perspective of Experience*, Yi-Fu Tuan argues: “it is an intellectual construct. It can be very elaborate. Mythical space is also a response of feeling and imagination to fundamental human need. It differs from pragmatic and scientifically conceived spaces in that it ignores the logic of exclusion and contradiction. It does not necessarily obey the human logic.”¹¹ On the one hand, mythical space usually has gods and divine events and contains a great number of imagined places or spatial relationships. Mythical space cannot be experienced in ordinary life. Yet mythical space can also be constructed on the basis of spatial settings experienced by humanity. The mythical space in texts is generally described to show a particular view of the cosmos.¹² The conceptual space in Gen 1 is to some extent a mythical space, since at least it is God who creates the space and spatial relations.

Some creation texts in the Hebrew Bible, such as Pss 24, 29, 48, and 93, are dated earlier than Gen 1, while others, such as Ps 19, are dated later than Gen 1. Conceptual space in these texts is generally perceived as mythical, exemplified by Pss 24 and 26, where God is personified. He founds the world upon the seas and establishes the world upon rivers (Ps 24:2). The voice of God is mentioned as being upon the waters, powerful and majestic (Ps 29). God’s residence is described: “Who shall ascend into the hill of YHWH? And who shall stand in his divine holy place?” (Ps 24:3). The text also mentions the “throne” of God (Ps 93:2). There is a more specific description of God’s appearance: “Wrapped in light as with a garment, stretching out the heaven like a tent” (Ps 104:2). The voice of God can also travel through various kinds of space. A variety of spatial settings are constructed by God himself. Sometimes God is like an architect using his design capacity to construct the places. The conceptual space in other creation accounts is rich with mythical meanings.

¹⁰ The creation accounts and texts including the notion of creation in the Hebrew Bible are Gen 1–3; Job 38–41; Pss 8, 19, 24, 29, 48, 51, 89, 93, 104, and 136; Eccl 3; Isa 40 and 45; Jer 31; and Ezek 36.

¹¹ TUAN, *Space and Place* (see n. 6), 99.

¹² *Ibid.*, 86–100.

How does Gen 1 provide a new vision of space that is less mythical than its biblical and ancient Near Eastern counterparts? First, although the world created by God's speech is mythical, its main function is not only to show the power and influence of God on the earth but also to emphasize that speech is the most important medium for creation. God in Gen 1 creates the world through speech rather than physical activity. Moreover, creation is completed by establishing spatial relationships rather than just by creating specific materials. Offering a less mythical space, Gen 1 provides a structured world. Lack of an anthropological perspective also makes space in Gen 1 less mythical. Furthermore, God's space in Gen 1 is shown only through indirect expressions. Only by analyzing the narrative perspective can we know that God is not in the world he created. God can, however, travel freely between his space and the created world, which demonstrates universalism. There is no specific description of God's residence. It is only through Gen 1:26, 28; 2:3 that we know some traits of God's dwelling space. According to Gen 1:26, God's space is like a dwelling space. Furthermore, according to Gen 2:3, this dwelling space is like a home where God can rest. The lack of a specific description of God's residential space makes God's space more abstract and, thus, less mythical.

In Gen 1, monotheism is apparent throughout creation. God creates the world through his speech with no assistance. Accordingly, the places, spaces, and spatial relationships are created by only one God. Genesis 1 is also unlike the other ancient Near Eastern creation myths such as *Enuma Elish* where the world is created through divine battles.¹³ Creation in Gen 1 is peaceful, and the world is created simply through divine speech. These elements in Gen 1 are therefore simultaneously mythical and less mythical; "as a result, it becomes 'a sacred tale about past events that justify social action in the present.'"¹⁴

5.2. Genesis 6–9 and Conceptual Space

The Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 not only demonstrates a cosmic view of the world as Gen 1 does but also has conceptual and textual correspondences with it.¹⁵ Both reflect the vertical cosmic view. The Priestly flood narrative finds its completion in the covenant of God with Noah, the representative of humanity (Gen 9:1–17). On the one hand, the narrative demonstrates why God

¹³ For a comparison of Gen 1 and *Enuma Elish*, see K. SPARKS, "Enuma Elish and Priestly Mimesis: Elite Emulation in Nascent Judaism," *JBL* 126 (2007), 625–48.

¹⁴ SMITH, *Priestly Vision* (see n. 2), 144.

¹⁵ I define the cosmic view of the world as an understanding of the structure and function of the world, as well as of the interrelationship between humans and the world.

destroys the world he created; on the other hand, it explains why God establishes the covenant with humanity after flood. Noah's covenant is the first covenant established by God with humanity.

The flood narrative is the transition from good creation to destroying the world, from the narrative of the universe to the history of humanity – as claimed in Gen 6:1 (non-P) when humans begin to multiply on the face of the land – and from human history to Israelite history. Correspondingly, the conceptual boundary between God's space and humanity's space is blurred and fluid. The blurred spatial opposition between mythical space and nonmythical space is also maintained in the Priestly flood narrative. Nonmythical space is generally constructed with geographical terms, while mythical space is constructed through the description of mythical environments which humans cannot experience. The two kinds of space are juxtaposed in the flood narrative, which also demonstrates a fluid boundary between mythical and nonmythical space and offers a particular understanding of mythical space. The etiology of space is also addressed in the Priestly flood narrative: the spatial relationships among the natural settings, and the spatial relationships between humans and the world are sacred and influenced by God. Space can be hostile to humanity. I shall first discuss the cosmic view demonstrated in the Priestly flood narrative, then I shall analyze the fluid boundary, the zone between God's space and humanity's space, as well as between mythical and nonmythical space in the context of Near Eastern flood myths.¹⁶

5.2.1. Vertical Cosmic View

The flood narrative has a vertical and stratified view of the cosmos like Gen 1.¹⁷ There is, however, an important difference: the conceptual space in Gen 1 is a circular three-dimensional cosmos, while the conceptual space in the flood narrative is emphasized by its vertical characteristic, and the direction of the vertical axis is shown as being from earth to heaven, from down to up.

The flood originates when “all the fountains of the *great deep* (תהום רבה) burst forth, and the *windows of heaven* (אֲרָבַת הַשָּׁמַיִם) were opened” (Gen 7:11). The text first emphasizes that the origin is the great deep, which is in the earth (Gen 1:2); only after that does it state that the windows of heaven are opened, emphasizing the upwards direction of the flood. This verse thus not only sets the flood in a vertical space but also emphasizes the vertical axis from down to up through the sequence of words. When the flood recedes, it is “the

¹⁶ For an introduction to the Gilgamesh Epic, see A.R. GEORGE, *The Babylonian Gilgamesh Epic: Introduction, Critical Edition, and Cuneiform Texts* (2 vols., Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003) 1:29–33.

¹⁷ For a discussion of the similarities between Gen 1:1–2:3 and the Priestly flood account and coordination between the two, see D.M. CARR, *Reading the Fractures of Genesis: Historical and Literary Approaches* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1996), 64–68.

fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven” that close (Gen 8:2a). The flood recedes first because the fountains of the deep are closed, and then because the windows of heaven are closed. Accordingly, the description of the flood gives a sense of vertical space from down on the earth to up in the sky.

Thus Gen 7:11 and 8:2a both provide a vertical view of space. This vertical view, along with the position of heaven, echoes the stratified view of the cosmos suggested in Gen 1. In Gen 1, the water is both above and below the heaven (Gen 1:7–9), which is protecting the world, nature, and humanity. The water below the heaven is the sea (Gen 1:7–9). In the Priestly flood narrative, the waters below and above heaven again get together as they were before creation, which implies that chaos returns. The windows of heaven are opened, and the water behind the windows pours out from the windows and blends into the water under the windows. The stratified view of the cosmos is thus demonstrated by the destruction of the stratified cosmos.

This stratified view of the cosmos is based on the spatial relationships described in Gen 1 (e.g., Gen 1:3–15). Taking the waters as the medium, the flood narrative makes this cosmology more specific and vivid. The conceptual space in the Priestly flood story corresponds to Gen 1 and at the same time emphasizes its vertical rather than circular characteristic.

5.2.2. *Mythical Space and Less Mythical Space*

Flood is a natural phenomenon, especially in Mesopotamia where various flood myths were deeply influenced by nature. Although the Mesopotamian plateau is lacking in precipitation, the economic and cultural life of Mesopotamians is dependent on the rivers. Accordingly, Mesopotamian flood myths may be seen as projecting the area’s practical social life. Flood myths occur in a number of Mesopotamian stories such as Atrahasis and tablet X of the Gilgamesh Epic.¹⁸ Scholars basically agree that the flood narrative in the Hebrew Bible is influenced by Near Eastern flood myths, or at least its authors were familiar with the flood myth tradition, evident in the mythical elements or motifs that remain in the flood narrative. Because the flood narrative is to some extent a projection of nature, nature’s space and mythical space are interwoven. Genesis 6:9 is an example of the tension between natural and mythical space. First, the temporal expression in Gen 6:9 makes the mythical scene more real: “These are the generations of Noah: Noah was a righteous man and blameless in his generations.” In the same words, actual scenes are transformed through supernatural terms into mythic scenes: “and Noah walked with God” (Gen 6:9b). In the flood nar-

¹⁸ For a survey of ancient Near Eastern traditions about the flood, see B.B. SCHMIDT, “Flood Narratives of Ancient Western Asia,” in *Civilizations of the Ancient Near East* (4 vols.; ed. J.M. Sasson; Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1995), 2:2337–51.

rative, mythical and less mythical space are primarily constructed by supernatural terms and by natural geographical terms, respectively; then they are reflected through the spatial correspondence between God and the human realms.

Nature's space is constructed with words for natural environments that humans can easily experience in their daily lives. Spatial relationships are also readily perceived in natural environments. In the Priestly flood narrative, such nature's space is indicated primarily through shifts from mythic scenes to historiographical narrative. The foundation of the flood narrative is thus historical and the spatial scenery has historicity. Another narrative strategy is describing Noah's ark with geometrical and natural terms (e.g., Gen 6:15), while its function remains mythical.

A more effective narrative strategy is describing the course of the flood using natural geographical terms. At the beginning of Priestly flood account, the setting is introduced by the Priestly *toledot*, a temporal expression: "These are the generations of Noah: Noah was a righteous man and blameless in his generations" (Gen 6:9). This verse therefore sets the flood narrative in the broader historical arc of pentateuchal narrative. When the historical scene is described, the specific time in the narrative makes the narrative less mythical, indicating the mixture of mythical and historical elements: "and in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, the ark rested upon the mountains of Ararat, and the water receded gradually until the tenth month, in the tenth month, on the first day of the month, the tops of the mountains were seen" (Gen 8:4–5). Although mythical and superlogical elements or motifs remain, Priestly authors offered a new vision of less mythical space if we read the flood narrative in the context of Israel's historiographical narrative.

As humanity's space, Noah's ark plays an important role in constructing a less mythical space. The ark is described by geographical terms; the width and length are logical and standard. The materials for constructing the ark are real. The physical material is "gopher wood," and the plan of construction is also realistic (Gen 6:14–16). These elements construct a less mythical space on a conceptual level. Even the mythical function demonstrates less mythical traits such as taking people and floating on the surface of water (Gen 6:19), while the function of the ark surviving humanity is essentially mythical.

Less mythical space is also constructed by the many natural and geographical terms describing the course of the flood. For example, "the waters swelled and increased greatly upon the earth" (Gen 7:18). Measurement terms are also used: "The waters swelled fifteen cubits higher, and the mountains were covered" (Gen 7:20). Historicized time also contributes to constructing less mythical space: "And the waters swelled upon the earth one hundred and fifty days" (Gen 7:24). Natural geographical terms are also used to describe the setting after the flood. These include names of known geographical places like Mount Ararat (Gen 8:4) and realistic descriptions such as "the tops of the mountains"

(Gen 8:5). Mountains are natural components at this stage and are not mythical at all.

These less mythical spatial elements usually occur together with the mythical elements in the flood narrative. Although a temporal expression is used to set the narrative, it is not logical time, at least in the modern sense: “In the six hundredth year of Noah’s life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month” (Gen 7:6). During the course of the flood, the water swelled upon the earth one hundred and fifty days (Gen 7:24). After the flood, the narrative setting is again established with a temporal expression: “at the end of one hundred and fifty days the water decreased” (Gen 8:3b). Numbers such as six hundredth year, hundredth year, one hundred and fifty days seem to be symbolic numbers. They therefore keep the spatial scenery mythical. Although they are not logical, they are put in the historical narrative and juxtaposed with the historicized temporal expression.

The mythical features and natural features of the flood narrative are in many cases juxtaposed in the same word or scene, constructing a conceptual space that is simultaneously mythical and less mythical. In Gen 6:14–16, the ark is both mythical and less mythical. In terms of scale, materials, and form, the ark was real space. Nevertheless, the ark can also be understood conceptually as mythical and imagined space in terms of its function. The ark can save all the species on earth; it can float on the water and not be destroyed (Gen 7:18). These features make the ark simultaneously a real and an imagined space.

It is very common in the flood narrative for natural geographical terms to be juxtaposed in the same sentence or scene with mythical words or motifs. Mythical space is not only constructed by words but also indicated by a narrative perspective, an omniscient perspective in particular – for instance, Noah is narrated as “walking with God” (Gen 6:9). In Gen 7:19, the description of mountains also indicates a mythical vision through an omniscient perspective: while “mountain” is a geographical word, “all the high mountains everywhere under the heaven were covered” implies an omniscient narrator because of the word “all.” The vision of mythical space is strengthened by “all” because “all” makes the flood space grander than one person, from a spatial vantage point on earth, can see.

Figurative expressions also contribute to the construction of mythical space. A typical case in the flood narrative is the “windows of heaven” in Gen 7:11 and Gen 8:2. In the Hebrew Bible, “windows” are physical objects or architectural features (1 Kgs 6:4; 7:4–5; Eccl 12:3; Ps 2:9; Isa 60:8; Jer 9:21; 22:14; Ezek 40:16, 22, 25, 29, 33, 36; 41:16, 26; Dan 6:10; Joel 2:9; Zeph 2:14). The word can also be used as a metaphor (2 Kgs 7:2, 19; Isa 24:18; Mal 3:10). In 2 Kgs 7:2, 19 and Isa 24:18, “windows of heaven” is used to express a sense of astonishment. Malachi 3:10 effectively demonstrates the spatial characteristics of mythical windows: God’s storehouse is behind the windows of heaven; God

uses windows to communicate to humans on the earth and can pour blessing to them through windows. In this respect, “windows of heaven” is a metaphor and a typical conceptual space in the narrative of the Hebrew Bible. The use of metaphor thus makes space more mythical.

5.2.3. *Fluid Zone between God’s Space and Humanity’s Space*

In polytheistic religious systems, the boundary between God’s space and humanity’s space is not so clear. In the flood narrative, although it is a monotheistic text, the boundary between God’s space and humanity’s space is also fluid and blurred. How does a transcendent God reveal himself in a monotheist text? How does God appear throughout history?

The scenes of God’s activity and of humanity’s activities in the flood narrative shift together and sometimes stand together, constructing a blurred boundary between God’s space and humanity’s space. Consider Gen 6:9, where Noah appears in humanity’s space: “These are the records of the generations of Noah. Noah was a righteous man, blameless in his generations.” Then God’s space is juxtaposed in the same verse: “Noah walked with God” (Gen 6:9). Genesis 6:9 may thus be seen as a prologue to the spatial settings in the Priestly flood narrative. The world is before God, and God sees the world from a vantage point outside of it. The relative position of God is above the earth and beyond this world, which is also demonstrated by the opened windows of heaven. It is not clear whether “then God said to Noah” in Gen 6:13 indicates that God is on the earth (i.e., in humanity’s space) or outside it (i.e., in God’s space). It also cannot be justified by the phrase “Noah walked with God” (אֶת־הָאֱלֹהִים הֵתְהַלֵּךְ־נֹחַ), because such a phrase can be used in a metaphorical way.

The authors of the Priestly flood narrative probably intended to blur the boundary of God’s space and humanity’s space at this point, perhaps to pave the way for the following narratives where God intervenes in history more freely and gets increasingly closer to this world. However, if we understand “see” in Gen 6:17 as sight vision, then it corresponds with Gen 6:12, where the object of “see” is the earth under heaven, given that Noah is in the same place as God. Accordingly, neither God nor Noah are in the human realm; their space is beyond the human world. The scene then shifts to human space through the introduction of the ark (Gen 6:14–22). The ark is made of gopher wood and described with geometrical terms such as “three hundred cubits” (Gen 6:15). Then the flood begins and Noah comes into the ark. That the ark floats on water rather than being destroyed (Gen 7:18) demonstrates its mythical nature. During the course of the flood, the stratified view of the cosmos is again expressed. The connection between the rain from heaven and the water under the earth shows a vertical axis. Then the narrative focuses on the earthly settings (Gen 7:11, 13–16a, 18–21, 24). After that, Gen 8:2a, 3b–5 demonstrates a spatial juxtaposition of God’s space and humanity’s space: the windows of heaven are

closed and the mountains on the earth can be seen. Then, in Gen 8:13a, 14–19, the scene shifts to earth again. The phrase “God spoke to Noah” (Gen 8:15) probably illustrates that God is in the human realm. The ark has already rested upon the mountains of Ararat (Gen 8:4), and the surface of the ground has dried up (Gen 8:13a). The place where God blesses and establishes the covenant is in humanity’s space, as also indicated in Gen 9:1 and Gen 9:8: Noah and his sons go out from the ark and then make the covenant with God. The descriptions of natural and geographical objects in Gen 9:12–17 also imply that the scene is on the earth.

Chapter 6

Symbolic Space in Genesis 1 and 6–9

A symbol is an abstracted sign and does not necessarily have a direct link with a human subject.¹ Rather, a symbol has more connections with the material object. In most cases, the connection between a symbol and an object is culture-bound and usually formed in a group rather than by an individual. Sometimes the symbolic meaning does not promise direct connection with a material object, as metaphor. Symbolic meaning is arbitrary.

A spatial symbol is a symbol relating to a space, place, spatial setting, or spatial relationship. For example, the temple symbolizes the conceptual center in ancient Israelite religion.² The spatial symbol may also be a color, form, or scale. Since symbols are cultural, critical spatiality since the 1970s has generally emphasized the social and cultural significance of symbolic space. Henri Lefebvre's representational spaces involve symbolism.

Representational spaces, embodying complex symbolisms, sometimes coded, sometimes not, linked to the clandestine or underground side of social life, as also to art (which may come eventually to be defined less as a code of space than as a code of representational spaces).³

Representational spaces: space as directly lived through its associated images and symbols, and hence the space of “inhabitant” and “users,” but also of some artists and perhaps of those, such as a few writers and philosophers, who describe and aspire to do no more than describe. This is the dominated – and hence passively experienced – space which the imagination seeks to change and appropriate. It overlays physical space, making symbolic use of its objects. Thus representational spaces may be said, though again with certain exceptions, to tend towards more or less coherent systems of non-verbal symbols and signs.⁴

A symbol does not acquire its meaning or meanings automatically and naturally but only through human practice. For example, the Jerusalem Temple

¹ The term “symbol” is generally defined as “simile”; for a comparison between symbol and simile from the human geographical perspective, see Y.-F. TUAN, “Sign and Metaphor,” *Annals of the Association of American Geographers* 68 (1978), 363–72, here 371.

² J.Z. SMITH, *Map is Not Territory: Studies in the History of Religions* (Leiden: Brill, 1978), 112–15 discusses “center” in terms of Jewish culture.

³ H. LEFEBVRE, *The Production of Space* (trans. D. Nicholson-Smith; Oxford: Blackwell, 1991), 33.

⁴ *Ibid.*, 39.

cannot naturally be the symbol of God's residence; people create this symbolism through interpretation. Accordingly, there are two important features of symbolic space: first, it acquires its meaning or meanings in social group; second, it is created through human practice.

Different symbolic meanings can be constructed for the same space or place by different groups. One symbolic meaning may sometimes challenge other symbolic meanings. Edward Soja's thirdspace is normally connected with race, class, and protest, focusing on the challenge and appropriation of the traditional and authoritative symbolic meanings of space.⁵

There are many ways to give symbolic meanings to space. It can be through the body, decoration, propagation, or media. Writings – including diaries, letters, poetry, and novels – are also significant ways of giving symbolic meanings to space. An example is how biblical narrative gives symbolic meaning to the Jerusalem Temple as God's residence. In writings, authors can challenge existing symbolic meanings through rhetorical strategies. Genesis 1 and Gen 6–9 focus on the cosmos, nature, and humanity. How do these texts reflect social symbolic space? Do they challenge traditional and authoritative symbolic space and give new symbolic meanings to the space? In this chapter, I shall take Gen 1 as an example to analyze how Priestly authors were influenced by contemporary culture when creating symbolic space, and how symbolic space in Gen 1 challenged the traditional symbolic meanings of creation space by comparing it with other creation accounts in the Hebrew Bible and the ancient Near East. Then I shall use the covenant account in the Priestly flood narrative as an example to discuss how social practice creates new symbolic space and whether this new symbolic space appropriates traditional symbolic meanings.

6.1. Symbolic Space in Genesis 1

By arranging different elements of narrative in a particular way, the authors of Gen 1 create a new, Priestly, symbolic meaning for the space of creation. Priestly authors use words to describe the cosmos, the world, and nature, giving symbolic meanings to them, and these symbolic meanings appropriate traditional authoritative symbolic meanings of creation space and simultaneously challenge those same meanings.

⁵ E. SOJA, *Thirdspace: Journeys to Los Angeles and Other Real-and-Imagined Places* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 1996), 106–44.

6.1.1. Historical Settings and Priestly Authors

Genesis 1 is not dated very early. It is the product of a relatively high level of scribal culture and produced during exile, specifically in the late Babylonian exile or early Persian Empire. There are no sources of evidence for identifying the Priestly authors. It seems there was a Priestly cycle because these texts do not necessarily belong to the same priestly group. Genesis 1–11 may have been produced by priests in a community in an exilic location in Babylonia. Today most scholars agree that the texts in 2 Kgs 24–25, 2 Chr 36, and Jeremiah, which are the main biblical sources for the events leading up to the exile, are more ideological,⁶ but it is likely that most priestly elites were exiled at the fall of Jerusalem (587/586 BCE). Afterwards, some local cult communities such as Mizpah and Bethel may have consolidated again.⁷ Then the Aaronide priests took power. In addition, the priests who were in charge of the Jerusalem cult were likely sent to Babylon (2 Kgs 24–25). We also know from Ezekiel and the other exilic prophets that the Zadokite branch of the priesthood, represented by the high priest, Joshua, maintained exclusive title to the high priestly office in the Babylonian diaspora (Zech 3:8; 6:11–14).

Comparison with Ezekiel, which was influenced by Babylonian culture, also suggests that the Priestly authors who wrote Gen 1 held a more pro-Persian view, even as the Priestly circle might have arisen around Ezekiel. In addition, since the Priestly texts show a special understanding of “the land of people,”⁸ the Priestly authors are probably the writers who were exiled and belong to the Aaronide branch. The Priestly texts may have reached their mature formulation in “the place Casiphia” (Ezra 8:17).⁹

⁶ The accounts of conquests of Jerusalem and Judah during the reigns of Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, and Zedekiah by Nebuchadnezzar fits the rhetorical structure of Assyrian and Hittite conquest accounts. Other relevant theological ideas include the Sabbath and the restoration. The accounts of “the empty land” may have been invented by the “holy race” as a prerequisite for the return to Judah in order to depict the returnees as the true Israel and thus to legitimize their takeover of the land from the “aboriginal occupants of the land” by erasing those very inhabitants; see L.S. FRIED, “The Land Lay Desolate: Conquest and Restoration in the Ancient Near East,” in *Judah and the Judeans in the Neo-Babylonian Period* (ed. O. Lipschits and J. Blenkinsopp; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2003), 21–54, here 23–24 and B. ODED, “Where is the ‘Myth of the Empty Land’ to be Found? History versus Myth,” in *Judah and the Judeans in the Neo-Babylonian Period* (ed. O. Lipschits and J. Blenkinsopp; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2003), 55–74, here 57.

⁷ J. BLENKINSOPP, “The Judean Priesthood during the Neo-Babylonian and Achaemenid Periods: A Hypothetical Reconstruction,” *CBQ* 60 (1998), 25–43.

⁸ J.-L. SKA, *Introduction to Reading the Pentateuch* (trans. P. Doninique; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006), 160.

⁹ J. BLENKINSOPP, *The Pentateuch: An Introduction to the First Five Books of the Bible* (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 238.

6.1.2. Sociological Location and Symbolic Space

Conceptual space in Gen 1 focuses on order, balance, and universalism. How do these ideas reflect the influence of social culture? How might social culture influence Priestly writers' understanding of creation space? How did the Priestly authors give symbolic meanings to Gen 1 through writing as social practice? I shall now address these issues.

First, God in Gen 1 as the creator is beyond any other powers. Unlike other ancient Near Eastern creation myths, Gen 1 depicts God with no rivals when he creates the world. Creation in Gen 1, in contrast to *Enuma Elish*, does not occur in the aftermath of conflict between divine powers. "God not only creates; God is also the one who inaugurates separation into proper realms, and these realms are maintained in terms that echo the priestly regimen of the Temple."¹⁰ The authors of Gen 1 make a connection between the cosmos and reality. Creation in Gen 1 is peaceful. The Priestly authors of Gen 1 are more concerned with spatial relations than with specific places or localities. Although specific places may be destroyed, basic spatial relations are kept in order. According to the exilic Priestly authors, Israel and Jerusalem may have been destroyed, but the basic spatial relationships remain for people.

Second, if creation in Gen 1 does not occur because of the battle between divine powers, how does creation happen? God's speech plays an important role in Gen 1.¹¹ As mentioned above, each of the six days is created by God's speech. After the creation on each day, God's speech also includes a blessing on the creatures he creates. Although both Egyptian and Mesopotamian creation accounts contain divine speech, it is only in Gen 1 that God's speech created the world. Why did the Priestly authors give God's speech such an important status in Gen 1? Why was the world constructed by God's speech? These issues can be addressed from the perspective of symbolic space. To some extent, Gen 1 depicts God like a priest giving instructions in order to legitimize that role for the priest. Instruction in ancient Israel was associated with priests, evident in Jer 18:18 and Mal 2:6–9. God's first instruction to humanity is in Gen 1:28. God's instructions are also frequently found in the Priestly texts. God instructs at every important time, which emphasizes the significance of the instructions. God's speech in Gen 1 thus authorizes the instructions of priests in the sixth century BCE. Priestly power expanded during the Persian period (538–323 BCE), corresponding with their instructions. Also, while God still on a high place promises his control of the world, he has no exact place to live; this also reinforces the power of Priestly instructions.

Third, we may ask what purpose Priestly instructions serve in light of Gen 1. One important function was maintaining the "appointed time." It should be

¹⁰ M.S. SMITH, *The Priestly Vision of Genesis 1* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2010), 92.

¹¹ For the significance of speech in Gen 1, see *ibid.*, 66–67.

important for exiles to find an alternative way to worship after the temple was destroyed and they were deported. The lack of organized public worship might have been a great issue for exiles who had just completed their cult centralization.¹² In such circumstances, a public gathering was an effective way to continue such worship, even without the traditional meanings. On top of the inability to worship at the temple, different groups experienced exile differently and thus were in need of new or transformed traditions to unify them. How to internalize their experience thus became an urgent problem. Festivals like the weekly Sabbath and rituals such as circumcision played a significant role in maintaining the Israelites as the ethnic unit.

To the exiles, it was more important that the festival had a social element. “At public gatherings on fast days, the exiles lamented the loss of their former homeland and prayed for a speedy return. On such occasions the teachings of prophets and the reading of sacred texts from pre-exilic times may also have filled the spiritual void.”¹³ Generally the festival needs the participation of rituals. A certain space was needed for this ritual. This space had to be a public space that could help communities to experience the same tradition or historical events together. The festival as a ritual in this public space transformed the experiences and feelings of a small group so that it applied to a larger group, then this larger group transformed the experiences and feelings to a still larger group, until finally they were extended to all the people in the space.

6.1.3. *The Appropriation of Space*

According to critical spatiality, space is not a neutral entity.¹⁴ Different symbolic ideas could coexist in the same place. Different individuals and groups assigned different symbolic meanings to the place. As space was embedded in narrative rhetorically, a space also took on various symbolic meanings. In the light of rhetorical strategy, authors could take traditional ideas and symbolic meanings and transform them into new ones by revising older texts.

6.1.3.1. *Genesis 1 and 2–3*

There is a basic agreement that Gen 1 is Priestly, while Gen 2–3 is non-Priestly. Both tell a creation story. Although they are independent, Gen 2:4a ties them together.¹⁵ Several elements of the verse illustrate its function.

¹² M. COGAN, “Into Exile,” in *The Oxford History of the Biblical World* (ed. M.D. Coogan; New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), 321–65, here 359–60.

¹³ *Ibid.*, 360.

¹⁴ The appropriation of symbolic meanings within a single space is highlighted by post-modern theorists such as SOJA, *Thirdspace* (see n. 5), 68, 87.

¹⁵ For discussion of the function of Gen 2:4a, see, e.g., J.C. GERTZ, “The Formation of the Primeval History,” in *The Book of Genesis: Composition, Reception, and Interpretation*

The first element is the order of the words in the expression “the heaven and the earth” (את השמים ואת הארץ). Genesis 1 has “when God began to create the heaven and the earth” (Gen 1:1). However, we find in Gen 2:4b the reverse phrase “earth and heaven” (ארץ ושמים). This is probably an intentional adaptation. Genesis 1 narrates more about the creation of God, whereas Gen 2 focuses on humanity. The order “earth and heaven” corresponds to the earthly perspective of Gen 2:4b–3:24.

Second, the two creation accounts contain different verbs: “to create” (ברא) in Gen 1:1; 2:4a and “to make” (עשה) in Gen 2:4b. In the Hebrew Bible, the verb “to create” is especially used by God (e.g., Num 16:30; Ps 51:12; Isa 42:15; 43:1; 45:18). The verb “to make” is much more flexible and can be used with God or humanity as the subject. In Gen 1, “to make” appears only on days two, four, and six, while “to create” is used more extensively. Genesis 1 represents the Priestly vision that God is the only one who creates the universe.

Third, Gen 1 is much more about God, while Gen 2:4b–24 is more about humanity. The creations of humanity in Gen 1 and Gen 2 both have connections with God, but there is a big difference between them. In Gen 2:7, the creation of humanity is very concrete: the dust from the ground. The life of humanity is given by the breath of God: “Then YHWH God formed the man of dust from the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living being” (וייצר יהוה אלהים עפר מן־האדמה ויפח באפיו נשמת חיים) (Gen 2:7). However, in Gen 1, humanity is created in the image and likeness of God, the expression of which is more complex than that in Gen 2:7. “Then God said, ‘Let us make man in our image, after our likeness (ויאמר אלהים נעשה אדם בצלמנו כדמותנו); and let them rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky, over the cattle, over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth’” (Gen 1:26). The phrase “the image and the likeness” is more difficult to interpret than “dust from ground.” Nevertheless, whether image or dust, they all indicate the difference between God and humanity: humanity may share the nature of God but is not God.

6.1.3.2. *Genesis 1 and Psalms*

Psalms also contains texts that deal with creation. The accounts were written in different periods but most of them were composed before the exile. In the following discussion, we can see how Gen 1 adopts these into its own creation account. Psalm 8 is a prominent text and is dated to the exile. According to the superscription “for the choir director; on the Gittith. A Psalm of David. YHWH our Lord,” this is a hymn of praise for God. Not only was this text written during the same period as Gen 1, but it also resembles the Priestly vision of

(ed. C.A. Evans, J.N. Lohr, and D.L. Petersen; VTSup 152; Leiden: Brill, 2012), 107–35, here 114–18.

Gen 1: God is the creator beyond any power; everything in the universe is created by God. However, this hymn also praises humanity itself, evident in Ps 8:6: “You made him a little lower than God, and you crowned him with glory and majesty.” This is accentuated by a rhetorical question in Ps 8:5: “What is man that you remember him, and the child of man that you care for him?”

Psalm 19 is another creation text, this time dated to the postexilic period. Both Gen 1 and Ps 19 highlight God’s speech. For Ps 19, God’s speech is a kind of byproduct of creation, but Gen 1 makes God’s speech the basis of creation.

While Ps 104 might have been edited over a long period of time, the present form contains postexilic ideas.¹⁶ At the beginning of Ps 104, we see a difference from Gen 1, namely that God has his own place in the sky: “Wrapped in light as with a garment, stretching out the heaven like a tent (עֲטָה-אֹר כְּשֵׁלֵמָה) (נוֹטָה שָׁמַיִם כִּירִיעָה). He lays the beams of his chambers on the waters. He makes the clouds his chariot and walks upon the wings of the wind” (Ps 104:2–3). In Gen 1, there is no information about where God is when he creates the cosmos. This is probably because after the temple and Jerusalem were destroyed, the Priestly authors are concerned less with the specific place where God could reside on the earth and more with the space and spatial relationships God created.

An interesting point here relates to water. The water in Gen 1 is of two kinds: one is the preexisting material out of which God creates; the other is the sea, which is a place in which creatures live. In the Psalms, however, water is described as being controlled by God, on the one hand, which implies that water could evoke terrible, traumatic, and violent events; on the other hand, water in the Psalms is also an essential element for living on earth. After the descriptions of water, Ps 104:20–35 depicts a universe filled with dangers rather than a picture of order as in Gen 1. Genesis 1 presents a world that is good; Ps 104 presents a world that has many evils. Other creation accounts or texts in the Psalms dated to the preexilic period include Pss 24, 29, 48, and 93; all mention the water in the cosmos and describe God as an earthly king. Psalm 136 describes a universe maintained by God forever, and Ps 51 describes God as a judge of evil.

6.2. Symbolic Space in Genesis 6–9

God establishes the covenant with Noah in a symbolic world (Gen 9:13–17) which is created by words such as “set my bow in the cloud” (Gen 9:13), “bring

¹⁶ E.g., K. SCHMID, “Himmelsgott, Weltgott, und Schöpfer: ‘Gott’ und der ‘Himmel’ in der Literatur der Zeit des Zweiten Tempels,” in *Der Himmel* (ed. D. Sattler and S. Vollenweider; JbTh 20; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 2006), 111–48, here 126–27.

the cloud over the earth,” and “the bow shall be seen in the cloud” (Gen 9:14). Among them, the “bow” (קשת) is described directly as a symbol. In this section, I shall explore how symbolic space is constructed in the covenant scene (Gen 9:13–17). First, I shall discuss how the description of the bow involves some characteristics of symbolic space. Then I shall discuss how social practice may create symbolic space in Gen 9:13–17. In addition, by comparing the Priestly version (Gen 9:13–17) with the non-Priestly version (Gen 8:20–22), I shall discuss the difference between the descriptions of space after the flood in Priestly and non-Priestly texts.

6.2.1. *The Aura of the Bow*

In the flood narrative, the bow (Gen 9:13, 14, 16) is a symbol specifically mentioned in the direct speech of God.¹⁷

I set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a sign of a covenant between me and the earth (את־קשתי נתתי בענן והיתה לאות ברית ביני ובין הארץ). And it shall come about, when I bring a cloud over the earth, that the bow appears in the cloud, and I will remember my covenant (וזכרתי את־בריתי) that is between me and you and every living creature of all flesh; and the water shall never again become a flood to destroy all flesh. When the bow is in the cloud, then I will look upon it, and remember the everlasting covenant between God and every living creature of all flesh that is on the earth (Gen 9:13–16).

The bow is set by God in the cloud and becomes a sign of covenant between God and the earth. In the flood narrative, the bow is emphasized again and again as a sign of the covenant between God and the earthly world. First, God mentions he will make a “sign” “of the covenant which I am making between me and you and every living creature that is with you, for all successive generations.” (Gen 9:12). Then he sets the bow in the cloud and emphasizes again that this was a sign of the covenant between him and earth (Gen 9:13). When he brings a cloud over the earth, God again emphasizes that the bow shall be seen in the cloud. The bow as a sign will remind God never again to make the flood to destroy all the flesh (Gen 9:14–15). Genesis 9:16–17 repeats the basic theme of Gen 9:14–15, emphasizing the significance of the bow as a sign. It can be a conceptual sign like a road sign, or it can be a sign that is emotionally affective.¹⁸ In this context after the flood, the bow in the cloud gives readers an emotional affect.

“Bow” (קשת) is not used very often in Priestly texts. It seems that Priestly authors avoided using the word “bow” as a weapon in order to keep a peaceful atmosphere in the covenant space in the flood narrative. Furthermore, the bow

¹⁷ For discussion of the aura of sacred places, see Y.-F. TUAN, *Topophilia: A Study of Environmental Perception, Attitudes, and Values* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1974), 146–47.

¹⁸ For discussion of the relationship between symbol and sign in geographical terms, see TUAN, “Sign and Metaphor” (see n. 1), 364–65.

is an image used to describe God. God is described as a warrior God in some texts. The bow is thus used as a medium to describe a Priestly monotheistic God, who is more abstract and more peaceful yet retains some features of the warrior God.¹⁹

Places can have an aura. For example, a temple can make the mountain or the things on the mountain religious and spiritual.²⁰ In Gen 9:13–17 the bow as a symbol has an aura which makes the covenant space into symbolic space and reminds God and humanity of the covenant. The bow is first of all a natural phenomenon. Through its use in the covenant narrative, immediately after the flood, the bow becomes an affective sign with a special aura, and it comes to symbolize the covenant between God and the earthly world. Further, the bow's aura serves to make one perceive that the bow represents God remembering the covenant, that the world shall not be destroyed again.

6.2.2. Symbolic Practice

There are many ways to give symbolic meanings to space, such as decoration and media. All involve social practice. Symbolic practice helps people to understand society, and giving symbolic meaning to a space, especially through social practice, strengthens the connection between humans and place. Symbolic meanings of space are often also foundational ideas that support basic social institutions. Religious ritual is a typical symbolic practice; a space acquires its spiritual and symbolic meanings through ritual practices. Worship is thus completed in such an intersection between ritual and space. The place offers people a space for ritual, while the ritual strengthens the connection between humans and this place. While the Jerusalem Temple is emphasized as the only legal place of worship, the Hebrew Bible contains traces of a variety of ritual places. They can be the city temple, the local cult place, the open-air sanctuary, or even only a symbol that defines a cult place, such as Jacob's stone in Bethel (Gen 28:10–22). It is only after Josiah's reform that the cult places were destroyed and worship was concentrated in Jerusalem.²¹ The reuse of local cult places during the Babylonian exile suggests that they were to some

¹⁹ J. BLENKINSOPP, *Treasures Old and New: Essays in the Theology of the Pentateuch* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1994), 75.

²⁰ TUAN, *Topophilia* (see n. 17), 147.

²¹ Josiah (639–609 BCE) completed his religious reform in Judah, which helped Judah coalesce as an ethnic unit. His reform, somehow the heritage of Hezekiah, had two principles: one was purification, an effort to create a religious system in which people worshipped only YHWH rather than other gods; the other was centralization. In 2 Kgs 23:4–15, we see a picture of revolutionary: “The king commanded the high priest Hilkiah, the priests of the second order, and the guardians of the threshold, to bring out of the temple of the lord all the vessels made for Baal, for Asherah, and for all the host of heaven; he burned them outside Jerusalem in the fields of the Kidron, and carried their ashes to Bethel” (2 Kgs 23:4). For

degree maintained and traditional local worship was maintained. The Priestly flood narrative contains no cult places. The covenant is established on the mountains of Ararat. I shall discuss how symbolic practices transform the mountains of Ararat from a historical and natural place to a public, eternal, and symbolic space.

After the flood, the space – specifically the space in which the covenant is established – changed in two aspects: the physical and the symbolic. In narrative, the place changes physically, especially in a space-oriented plot narrative. Although physical change is not emphasized by the Priestly authors, the space does change (Gen 6:17) as the water recedes. The transformation of the mountains and trees is not mentioned. The only place where the narrative directly mentions any change or transformation is “the top of mountain was seen,” which indicates the scale of the flood. The transformation of physical space is only suggested in the above quotation in Gen 6:17. Furthermore, Gen 7:19 and Gen 8:5 suggest that the physical space may not have been essentially destroyed.

And the water swelled more and more upon the earth, and all the high mountains everywhere under the whole heaven were covered (**והמים גברו מאד מאד על-הארץ וכסו כל-ההרים**) (הגבהים אשר-תחת כל-השמים (Gen 7:19).

And the water receded gradually until the tenth month; in the tenth month, on the first day of the month, the tops of the mountains were seen (**והמים היו הלוך וחסור עד החדש**) (העשירי בעשירי באחד לחדש נראו ראשי ההרים (Gen 8:5).

After the flood, the spatial alternative is emphasized symbolically. God turns the world after the flood into a world filled with order and balance and again emphasizes the importance of humans in the world by establishing the covenant with Noah. A flood shall never again destroy the earth, and God shall not destroy the order of world. The sign of the covenant is the bow in the cloud. When cloud covers the earth, the bow reminds God of the covenant between him and the earthly world. The symbolic meaning of the covenant space is created through the practice of establishing the covenant. The mountains of Ararat thus become a universal, eternal sign. As a result, a local place becomes a universal space. The mountains of Ararat are not themselves important, but their symbolic meaning is.

discussion of Josiah's reform in historical terms, see C. UEHLINGER, “Was there a Cult Reform under King Josiah? The Case for a Well-Grounded Minimum,” in *Good Kings and Bad Kings* (ed. L. Grabbe; European Seminar in Historical Methodology 5; LHBOTS 393; London: T & T Clark, 2005), 279–316; see also M. PIETSCH, *Die Kultreform Josias: Studien zur Religionsgeschichte Israels in der späten Königszeit* (FAT 86; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2013).

6.2.3. *The Symbolic Space after the Flood*

The Priestly flood narrative within Gen 6–9 locates the covenant space on the mountains of Ararat. But it is juxtaposed with the non-Priestly flood narrative, which has its own depiction of space after the flood. What is the difference between the descriptions of space after the flood in Priestly and non-Priestly texts? And do they intersect?

The non-Priestly flood narrative contains no description of the place where the ark rested after the flood. The author(s) provide narrative of the space only indirectly: Noah builds an altar to God (Gen 8:20). The altar is first of all a physical space. Sometimes an altar may also symbolize the ownership of a place.²² Most of the time the altar is the place where the Israelites worship God. The historical narrative extending from Genesis through 2 Kings contains accounts of altars, as open-air sanctuaries, established by Abraham, Jacob, Moses, and Joshua to express their awe of God (e.g., Gen 12:7, 8; 13:18; Josh 8:30). The altar is the most significant cult place before Josiah's religious reform. After that reform, only one altar was kept: the altar of the Jerusalem Temple.

The biblical accounts provide no clear account of the status and function of altars during the exilic period. According to Ezra 3:2–3, one of the first missions for the returned exiles was to restore the altar of burnt sacrifice (Ezra 3:2–3).²³ It seems that the burnt offering should be destroyed and was not used any more. Yet some other accounts, such as Jer 41:5; Lam 1:4; and Zech 7:2–3; 8:18–19, suggest the continuity of worshiping God with burnt sacrifice in Jerusalem. “Eighty men came from Shechem, from Shiloh, and from Samaria with their beards shaved and their clothes torn and their bodies gashed, bringing grain offerings and incense to the house of YHWH” (יבאו אנשים משכם ומנחה ולבונה בידם (משלו ומשמרון שמנים איש מגלחי זקן וקרעי בגדים ומתגדדים (להביא בית יהוה) (Jer 41:5). For exilic Israelites the destruction of the temple meant that the function of the altar should not be as important as before, whether the YHWH cult in Jerusalem continued or not. In addition, most exilic Israelites saw that there were numerous pagan sanctuaries and cult places outside Judah. Probably for these reasons the altar in Priestly flood accounts is not emphasized. The place of the covenant was instead located on the symbolic mountains.

It is also noteworthy that the mountain as spiritual space first appears in the context of the flood. Although the tabernacle takes the place of the mountain as a place for God's glory later in the Priestly narrative, the Priestly flood narrative takes the mountain as a place where God establishes the first covenant with humanity.

²² BLENKINSOPP, *Treasures* (see n. 19), 70.

²³ For burnt offerings, see, e.g., Exod 10:25; 20:24; Lev 4:10; 7:37.

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, because of the burnt offerings on the altar, God says to himself that he will not destroy the earth again.

Then Noah built an altar to YHWH and took of every clean animal and of every clean bird and offered burnt offerings on the altar, then YHWH smelled the pleasing aroma; and YHWH said to himself, “I will never again curse the ground on account of man, for the intent of man’s heart is evil from his youth; and I will never again destroy every living thing, as I have done. (ויבן נח מזבח ליהוה ויקח מכל הבהמה הטהורה ומכל העוף הטהור ויעל עלת במזבח וירח) יהוה את-ריח הניחח ויאמר יהוה אל-לבו לא-אסף לקלל עוד את-האדמה בעבור האדם כי יצר לב האדם יהוה (רע מנעריו ולא-אסף עוד להכות את-כל-חי כאשר עשיתי) (Gen 8:20–21)

In the non-Priestly texts, God blesses humanity after “Noah built an altar to the Lord and took of every clean animal and of every clean bird and offered burnt-offerings on the altar” (Gen 8:20). The appearance of God is introduced through the word “smelled” and the phrase “said to himself.” It is through smelling that God connects with the altar. “Smelled” may imply that God was around or near the altar. However, the phrase “said to himself” suggests that God does not appear to Noah.

There is, then, an important difference between the descriptions of the space after the flood in Priestly text of Gen 9:1–17 and non-Priestly text of Gen 8:20–21. The Priestly text of Gen 9:1–17 introduces the covenant, establishing a space after the flood with God’s speech as in Gen 1.²⁴ Such a difference points to significant symbolic meanings of the covenant space in the Priestly texts. The place emphasized after the flood in the Priestly texts is not the altar, which is a cultic place. The covenant is established in the mountains instead. Conversely, the mountains of Ararat are highly symbolized and conceptualized in terms of establishing the covenant. In addition, the covenant is unconditional. Establishing the covenant requires no aromatic altar and needs no offerings of well being. The covenant is simply introduced with God’s speech (Gen 8:15; 9:8). The cultic place is not emphasized.

²⁴ SMITH, *Priestly Vision* (see n. 10), 67.

Chapter 7

Space in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

This section introduces the formation and development of the non-Priestly creation narrative in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, and the tower of Babel story in Gen 11:1–9.¹ Compared to the Priestly texts in Gen 1–11, an important feature of these non-Priestly texts is that they do not have uniform literary characteristics and structure. Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly material in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 can be described as three relatively uniform and independent narrative units. I shall introduce the structure of these texts, summarize some important concepts in them, and discuss descriptions of space in them from the perspective of God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space.

7.1. Structure of Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

Priestly texts and non-Priestly texts in the Pentateuch are interwoven and juxtaposed until the Sinai pericope. Source criticism divides the non-Priestly texts into distinct E and J source documents. In the last few decades, however, more and more biblical scholars have argued that E and J are not independent, and the distinction between them has been abandoned in most cases.² The non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11 are therefore generally perceived to lack a continuous plot and consist of small narrative units that take place at different times. These narrative units can also include smaller subunits.³

¹ Since the present work is concerned with the social dimension of space manifest to the cosmos and the whole world, I do not consider Gen 6:1–4 and the story of Noah's drunkenness (Gen 9:20–23). I shall, however, discuss the relationship between space in the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3 and the story of Cain and Abel in Gen 4.

² J.C. GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation Altes Testament: Eine Einführung in Literatur, Religion und Geschichte des Alten Testaments* (3rd ed.; UTB 2745; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2009), 204–12.

³ Gen 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9 are all probably composed from more or less smaller subunits. An example is Gen 2:10–15 in the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3. See M. WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte: Redaction- und theologiegeschichtliche Beobachtungen zu Genesis 1,1–11,26* (BZAW 256; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1998), 84–85.

Non-Priestly Texts of Genesis 1–11:

Eden Narrative (2:4b–3:24)

Cain and Abel (4:1–26)

The Sons of God and Daughters of Men and the Giants (6:1–4)

Flood Narrative (6:5–8; 7:1–5, 7–9, 10, 12, 16b–17, 22–23; 8:1b, 2b–3a, 6–12, 13b, 20–22)

Noah's Family Narrative (9:18–29)

Family Genealogy (10:1–16, 18–19, 21, 24–30)

The Building of the City and the Tower of Babel (11:1–9)

Like Gen 1, the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3 is a creation account. Although they are now juxtaposed, Gen 2–3 and Gen 1 each has its own narrative characteristics and was originally independent. Genesis 2–3 is about how the first man and Eve live in the garden in Eden.⁴ The creation of God is described in anthropological terms.

The flood narrative of Gen 6–9 has long been known to consist of Priestly and non-Priestly versions that have been skillfully, even if not seamlessly, redacted together.⁵ The non-Priestly flood narrative is mainly in Gen 6:5–8:22. Gen 6:1–4 is a typical mythical narrative, which is generally interpreted as giving one of the reasons God causes the flood.⁶ Both the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives tell the same story about how God destroys the world with the flood. However, the way in which God causes the flood is different. In the Priestly flood narrative, the flood is formed by the water from both heaven and underground. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, however, the flood is formed by the rain sent by God.

On the whole, Gen 2–3 and the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 share the themes of creation and flood with the Priestly texts in Gen 1–11. These themes are also common in certain Mesopotamian creation myths.⁷ In Atrahasis, for example, the two themes together form the creation myth. The similarity in theme therefore suggests that Gen 2–3 and 6–9 were probably redacted at the same time.⁸

⁴ I use the term “the first man” rather than the traditional “Adam” since the word אָדָם has the article הַ, which is used only on common nouns.

⁵ The Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives are interwoven, whereas the two creation accounts in Gen 1 and Gen 2–3 are juxtaposed.

⁶ For recent research on this topic, see J. DAY, “The Sons of God and Daughters of Men and the Giants: Disputed Points in the Interpretation of Genesis 6:1–4,” *HBAI* 1 (2012), 427–47.

⁷ For broad discussion of the connection between Gen 1–11 and Mesopotamian culture, see R.J. MIDDLETON, *The Liberating Image: The Imago Dei in Genesis 1* (Grand Rapids, MI: Brazos, 2005), 201–28, 235.

⁸ For the textual context of the narrative of flood in Genesis, see J.-L. SKA, *Introduction to Reading the Pentateuch* (trans. P. Dominique; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006), 21–22.

The Babel narrative in Gen 11:1–9 was probably added later than the other non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11.⁹ Whether Gen 11:1–9 is a unity¹⁰ or was composed out of several smaller units¹¹ is debatable. The Babel narrative describes a universalized world, telling how human beings work together to build the city of Babel and its tower at a time when all the people of the earth still speak the same language. Then God confuses the language of human beings and disperses them over the surface of all the earth. In etiological terms, the Babel narrative explains why there are different languages and cultures in the world.

7.2. Important Concepts in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

Because the non-Priestly texts consist of different narrative units and subunits, and because they underwent a long editing process, it is harder to summarize the concepts in the non-Priestly material as a whole than it is for the Priestly texts. Three basic ideas can nonetheless be identified in Gen 2–3, 6–9 and Gen 11:1–9.

First, Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly material in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 can be described as etiological narratives that seek “to explain the present circumstances through a description of how the present order came to be.”¹² An important goal of Gen 2–3 is to explain the relationship between earth and humanity. The non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 tells of the relationship between chaos and order in the world, explaining why God threw the world back into chaos. The Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 is also an etiological narrative that explains the diversity of the humanity and language in the world.

Second, compared to the Priestly texts, the non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 are anthropological, that is, concerned with humanity’s condition and environment and with exploring the nature of human existence. The first man, Eve, and Noah in Gen 2–3 and the non-Priestly version of the flood story in Gen 6–

⁹ J.C. GERTZ, “Babel im Rücken und das Land vor Augen: Anmerkungen zum Abschluss der Urgeschichte und zum Anfang der Erzählungen von den Erzeltern Israels,” in *Die Erzväter in der biblischen Tradition: Festschrift für Matthias Köckert* (ed. A.C. Hagedorn and H. Pfeiffer; BZAW 400; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2009), 9–34.

¹⁰ For the Babel narrative as a compositional unit, see U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis. Part Two: From Noah to Abraham* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1964), 225–49; J.P. FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art in Genesis: Specimens of Stylistic and Structural Analysis* (2nd ed.; SSN 17 Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1991), 11–45; and GERTZ, “Babel” (see n. 9), 9–34.

¹¹ C. UEHLINGER, *Weltreich und “eine Rede”: Eine neue Deutung der sogenannten Turm-Bauernzählung (Gen 11,1–9)* (OBO 101; Freiburg: Universitätsverlag; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1990), 514–84. See also H. GUNKEL, *Genesis, übersetzt und erklärt* (HKAT 1/1; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1977), 92–101.

¹² GERTZ (ed.), *Grundinformation* (see n. 2), 265–66.

9 are individual people, while humanity appears as a uniform community in Gen 11:1–9. All of these texts focus on the existence of humanity in the world. For example, the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3, unlike Gen 1, is narrated primarily from the perspective of humanity. The order of creation “earth and heaven” (ארץ ושמים) in Gen 2:4b is opposed to the more general phraseology “heaven and earth” used in Gen 1:1 and other texts dealing with the notion of creation in the Hebrew Bible (e.g., Jer 32:17; Ps 136:5–6; Isa 45:8).¹³ God is also very close to humanity in Gen 2–3. In Gen 2–3, the creation of the first man by God is described in anthropological terms: “then YHWH God formed the man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and the man became a living being” (Gen 2:7). One important theme of Gen 2–3 is the relationship between God and the condition of humanity. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, Noah, like the first man and Eve in Eden, acts as the representative of humanity. The prologue (Gen 6:1–5) and epilogue (Gen 8:20–22) of the non-Priestly flood narrative show God’s concern for humanity. On a thematic level, Gen 11:1–9 endeavors to explain how the diversity of language and culture comes to be. On the whole, Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly material in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 involve a projection, perhaps of the exilic period after the fall of Samaria (722 BCE) and Jerusalem (587/586 BCE), into the remote past.

Third, the descriptions of God in the non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 are anthropological in character. In the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3 and the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, God is able to talk to the first man, Eve, and Noah directly. God can “see” (ראה) (e.g., Gen 11:5), “call” (קרא) (e.g., Gen 3:9), “walk” (הלך) (e.g., Gen 3:8) and even “smell” (ירח) (e.g., Gen 8:21). In Gen 2–3, God walks in the garden, and his walking even makes a sound (Gen 3:8). In the non-Priestly flood narrative, God is able to “feel sorry” (נחם) (Gen 6:6). In the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9, God is able to “see” (ראה) (Gen 11:5), “say” (אמר) (Gen 11:6), and summon divine beings to intervene in humanity’s actions on earth (Gen 11:7).

7.3. Composition Date of Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

The present section provides a brief review of the date of composition for Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly material in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 in an effort to understand their possible historical context(s).

Biblical scholarship has discussed the relationship between Gen 2–3 and Gen 1 since the eighteenth century.¹⁴ An important point of debate is whether

¹³ M.S. SMITH, *The Priestly Vision of Genesis 1* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2010), 49.

¹⁴ For history of scholarship on Gen 2–3, see E. BLUM, “Von Gottesunmittelbarkeit zu Gottähnlichkeit: Überlegungen zur theologischen Anthropologie der Paradieserzählung,” in

Gen 2–3 was composed before or after Gen 1. Genesis 2–3, which is traditionally attributed to J, has been dated as early as the monarchic period. In last three decades, however, during which the literary character of the non-Priestly text has become increasingly controversial, more and more scholars have come to agree that the composition of Gen 2–3 can be dated to as late a period as the Babylonian exile or Persian period.¹⁵ It is therefore possible that Gen 2–3 was written at the same time as the Priestly narratives. Three main methods are used to date the composition of Gen 2–3.

First, the date of Gen 2–3 can be determined based on motifs it shares with wisdom literature in the Hebrew Bible.¹⁶ The first man and Eve, before eating the fruit of the forbidden tree, are close to God. After they eat the fruit and acquire knowledge, they are distant from God. “Knowledge” in Gen 2–3 refers not to the way in which we know God but to the reason for the ambivalence of life experienced in the present. Genesis 2–3 thus offers a critique of the traditional motif of knowledge as found in wisdom literature. After eating the fruit of the tree of knowledge, humans must be autonomous and responsible for themselves. God no longer encourages humans to acquire knowledge; the first humans were expelled from Eden because they acquired knowledge.¹⁷ Some other motifs in late wisdom literature are also reflected in Gen 2–3. For example, the breath of God in humanity distinguishes between animals and humans (e.g., Prov 20:27; Job 32:8).¹⁸

Gottes Nähe im Alten Testament (ed. G. Eberhardt and K. Liess; SBS 202; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 2004), 9–29, here 9–11.

¹⁵ This controversy about J has been important since the middle of the twentieth century. For a short introduction, see J.-L. SKA, “Genesis 2–3: Some Fundamental Questions,” in *Beyond Eden: The Biblical Story of Paradise (Genesis 2–3) and Its Reception History* (ed. K. Schmid and C. Riedweg; FAT 34; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2008), 1–27, here 2–4.

¹⁶ L. ALONSO-SCHÖKEL, “Sapiential and Covenant Themes in Genesis 2–3,” in *Studies in Ancient Israelite Wisdom* (ed. J.L. Crenshaw; New York: Ktav, 1976), 468–80; N. LOHFINK, *Studien zum Pentateuch* (SBAB 4; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 1988), 29–45; R.N. WHYBRAY, *The Intellectual Tradition in the Old Testament* (BZAW 135; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1974), 105–6, 154; N. WYATT, “Interpreting the Creation and Fall Story in Genesis 2–3,” *ZAW* 93 (1981), 10–21; J. BLENKINSOPP, *The Pentateuch: An Introduction to the First Five Books of the Bible* (New York: Doubleday, 1992), 65–67; D.M. CARR, “The Politics of Textual Subversion: A Diachronic Perspective on the Garden of Eden Story,” *JBL* 112 (1993), 577–95; K. SCHMID, “Die Unteilbarkeit der Weisheit: Überlegungen zur sogenannten Paradieserzählung Gen 2f. und ihrer theologischen Tendenz,” *ZAW* 114 (2002), 21–39; and WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte* (see n. 3), 200–5.

¹⁷ E.g., E. OTTO, “Die Paradieserzählung Genesis 2–3: Eine nachpriesterschriftliche Lehrerzählung in ihrem religionsgeschichtlichen Kontext,” in *“Jedes Ding hat seine Zeit”: Studien zur israelitischen und altorientalischen Weisheit. Diethelm Michel zum 65. Geburtstag* (ed. A.A. Diesel et al.; BZAW 241; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1996), 167–92, here 173–89.

¹⁸ T.C. MITCHELL, “The Old Testament Usage of *nešāmā*,” *VT* 11 (1961), 177–87.

Second, Gen 2–3 contains some Deuteronomistic concepts and traditions.¹⁹ The Eden narrative universalizes several specific themes of Deuteronomy and the Deuteronomistic tradition, in particular, the themes of obedience and disobedience to God's commandments.²⁰ The first man and Eve are expelled by God from the garden because they do not obey his commands. The most important motifs in Deuteronomy are the following: YHWH is the God who made the covenant with Israelites; only YHWH is the true God; any worship of other gods will be punished by YHWH; YHWH is the God of Israel; the Israelites are the people of YHWH; the Israelites should obey God unconditionally; and if the Israelites do not obey God, God will punish them. These motifs are also reflected in Gen 2–3.²¹ God commands the first man (e.g., Gen 2:16) not to eat the fruit of the tree of knowledge of good and evil. The first humans do not listen to God and consequently are expelled from the garden. The loss of Eden may symbolize, and thus universalize, the loss of land after the fall of Samaria and Jerusalem.

Third, a number of words and phrases in Gen 2–3 can be found only in late biblical texts.²² For example, the noun "Eden" can be found only in early Persian and later passages such as Ezek 28:13; 31:9, 16, 18; 36:35; Isa 51:3; and Joel 2:3. Most of these texts are dated to the Persian period, or at least after the fall of Jerusalem. Moreover, there are quite few allusions to Gen 2–3 in other biblical texts. All these points suggest that Gen 2–3 was written at a later period.²³ The non-Priestly narrator may have composed Gen 2–3 in the period of the Babylonian exile or in the Persian period.

¹⁹ There is a difference between Deuteronomy and Deuteronomism. "Deuteronomy" refers to the biblical book. "Deuteronomism" refers to the tradition, i.e., the ideas evident in the book of Deuteronomy, ideas that could be adopted by other biblical books such as Jeremiah; these ideas can be called Deuteronomistic. For an introduction to and review of Deuteronomism, see K. SCHMID, "The Deuteronomistic Image of History as Interpretive Device in the Second Temple Period: Towards a Long-Term Interpretation of 'Deuteronomism,'" in *Congress Volume Helsinki 2010* (ed. M. Nissinen; VTSup 148; Leiden: Brill, 2012), 369–88; T. RÖMER, *The So-Called Deuteronomistic History: A Sociological, Historical and Literary Introduction* (London: T & T Clark, 2005); and RÖMER, "The Form-Critical Problem of the So-Called Deuteronomistic History," in *The Changing Face of Form Criticism for the Twenty-First Century* (ed. M.A. Sweeney and E. Ben Zvi; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2003), 240–52.

²⁰ OTTO, "Die Paradieserzählung" (see n. 17).

²¹ Ibid., 178–83.

²² For a review of such words and phrases in the Eden narrative and other biblical texts, see T. STORDALEN, *Echoes of Eden: Genesis 2–3 and Symbolism of the Eden Garden in Biblical Hebrew Literature* (CBET 25; Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 206–9.

²³ There are other reasons for dating Gen 2–3 late; see SKA, "Genesis 2–3" (see n. 15), 17–18.

The non-Priestly and the Priestly flood narratives are interwoven in Gen 6–9.²⁴ There are two main reasons for dating the non-Priestly flood narrative later than or at almost the same time as the Priestly flood narrative. First, Gen 6:5–8 and 8:20–22 illustrate that the non-Priestly flood narrative might have been composed in the Priestly context. Genesis 6:5–8 mentions human beings together with animals, creeping things, and birds of the sky as things that God creates, which suggests that Gen 6:5–8 probably drew on materials from Gen 1. The description of worshipping in Gen 8:21 also shares the same elements with Priestly texts. For example, the “pleasing odour” of the sacrifice is accords with Lev 1–7. Gen 8:20–22 might therefore also have been composed in the Priestly context.

Second, the date of the non-Priestly flood narrative can be determined by the description of the ark. There is no information about the construction of the ark in the non-Priestly flood narrative. The ark first appears in Gen 7:1 without any introduction or prior reference in the non-Priestly flood narrative. Thus the composition of the non-Priestly flood narrative probably could be dated later than that of the Priestly flood narrative, which contains detailed information about how the ark is constructed.

The Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 can also be dated to the Babylonian exile and the Persian period for two reasons.²⁵ First, the narrative of Gen 11:1–9 clearly alludes to aspects of Babylonian culture. The literary setting of Gen 11:1–9 is Babel, in the valley of Shinar. Babel in the Hebrew Bible indicates the capital of Babylonia. The materials the humans used to build the city and tower are also common materials in ancient Mesopotamia.²⁶ Ancient Babylo-

²⁴ For the compositional relationship between the Priestly flood narrative and the non-Priestly flood narrative, see R.G. KRATZ, *Die Komposition der erzählenden Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Uni-Taschenbücher 2157; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2000), 233–39, 249–62; E. BOSSHARD-NEPUSTIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut: Studien zu Text, Kontexten, und Rezeption der Fluterzählung Genesis 6–9* (BWANT 165; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer 2005), 42–106; and M. ARNETH, *Durch Adams Fall ist ganz verderbt...: Studien zur Entstehung der alttestamentlichen Urgeschichte* (FRLANT 217; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2006), 43–92, 169–200. Cf. WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte* (see n. 3), 130–46, 171–84 and J.C. GERTZ, “Beobachtungen zum literarischen Charakter und zum geistesgeschichtlichen Ort der nichtpriesterschriftlichen Sintfluterzählung,” in *Auf dem Weg zur Endgestalt von Genesis bis II Regum. Festschrift Hans-Christoph Schmitt* (ed. M. Beck and U. Schorn; BZAW 370; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2006), 41–57.

²⁵ The Babel narrative, according to UEHLINGER, *Weltreich* (see n. 11), 514–58, has four textual layers; the earliest version was composed in the Assyrian period (eighth century BCE), then the motif shifts to anti-Babylonian policies in the sixth century BCE. For GUNKEL, *Genesis* (see n. 11), 92–101, the Babel narratives are combined by two narrative units.

²⁶ N.M. SARNA, *The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (Philadelphia, PA: Jewish Publication Society, 1989), 82 and J.G. WESTENHOLZ, “Babylon: Place of Creation of the Great

nian texts contain similar descriptions of the tower. In spatial terms, the diversity of language and the population described in the narrative accords with the sociopolitical situation of the Babylonian period and also the Persian period.²⁷

Second, given the narrative context, the story of Babel was placed in its present position to link the primeval history and the patriarchal narratives.²⁸ Gen 11:1–9 to some extent reinterprets Gen 10:8–12. Genesis 10 can be seen as reflecting the situation in the Persian period. Genesis 11:1–9 is a later addition, perhaps from the Persian period. In light of these considerations, Gen 11:1–9 was probably also composed during the Babylonian exile and the Persian period.

7.4. Narrative Space in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 tell different stories and have very different descriptions of spaces and spatial settings. The descriptions of space are focused primarily on the actors in these narratives. In Gen 2–3, the main actors are God, the first man, and Eve; in Gen 6–9, the main actors are God and Noah; and in Gen 11:1–9, the main actors are God and humanity as a whole. The spatial settings of these non-Priestly texts are also different. The main literary setting of Gen 2–3 is the garden in Eden, the literary setting of the non-Priestly flood narrative is the whole earth, and that of Gen 11:1–9 is the more specific “valley in the land of Shinar.” While there are different kinds of spaces and spatial settings in Gen 2–3, 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9, the spaces and spatial settings can be basically described from the perspectives of God’s space, humanity’s space and nature’s space.

7.4.1. God’s Space

Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 contain two important kinds of space related to God: one is God’s space in heaven, and the other is God’s space on earth. According to the narrative, God not only manages earthly things and controls the world from heaven, but he also acts in person on earth.

Gods,” in *Royal Cities of the Biblical World* (ed. J.G. Westenholz; Jerusalem: Bible Lands Museum, 1996), 197–220, here 204–6.

²⁷ For the anti-Babylonian motifs in Gen 11:1–9, see UEHLINGER, *Weltreich* (see n. 11), 546–58.

²⁸ For discussion of Gen 11:1–9 in its textual context, see GERTZ, “Babel” (see n. 9), 9–34.

7.4.1.1. *God's Space in Heaven*

Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 do not mention the specific location of God in heaven. Genesis 2:4b–7, as a creation account, shows only a spatial relationship between earth and God's space, not a specific place for God.²⁹ Here the earth and sky are spatial points referring to God. When God makes the earth and sky, he does so from his own space, not from within the sky or the earth he creates. That God's place is high is evident from the description of God "sending rain," which implies that God is in a high position where he can send the rain down (Gen 2:5): "And no bush of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprung up, for YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth (כִּי לֹא הִמְטִיר יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים עַל־הָאָרֶץ); and there was no man to till the ground" (Gen 2:5). "Sending rain" is also an important spatial indicator in the non-Priestly flood narrative. The flood is formed and the earth destroyed by the rain sent by God (Gen 7:4). The fact that God sends the rain that causes the flood suggests that God occupies a space in heaven. It therefore seems that God controls the world from heaven, a high position that allows him to send down the rain.

The Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 illustrates a more complex form of God's space. The narrator does not describe God's space in heaven directly. God needs to "come down" to see the city and the tower (Gen 11:5), which implies that God is in a high place. Still, the place to which God "came down" in Gen 11:5 seems to be not the surface of the earth but an intermediate space between the earth and the heaven, from which God could see the human world. In Gen 11:7, God says "come, let us go down" in order to confuse the language of humanity. Use of the term "us" may imply that the space to which God comes down is the space of other divine beings. God's movement involves a vertical space: God first comes down from a high position in heaven, then comes down again to a place between earth and heaven where the other divine beings are. Finally, God and the other divine beings come down to the surface of earth in order to confuse the language of humanity and disperse them over the surface of the earth.

7.4.1.2. *God's Space on Earth*

Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 include many descriptions of God's action on earth. God usually contacts humanity from close proximity, and most descriptions of God's actions on earth are about his appearance to and dialogue with human beings.

²⁹ E.g., "in the day that YHWH God made earth and heaven" (Gen 2:4b), like Gen 1:1, indicates only spatial relationships among God, earth, and heaven.

The most particular earthly place of God in Gen 2–3 is the garden in Eden, which is built by God himself. God plants it in a remote time and place. According to the biblical narrative, this is the only place on earth where God could rest before the Israelites construct the tabernacle and temple. God's action in the garden consists mainly of dialogues with the first man and Eve. These dialogues reflect the proximity between God and humanity.

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, God influences the world mainly from his space in heaven, and God's earthly space is conceptualized mainly after the flood in terms of his appearance around the altar, although this is very indirect. God does not speak to Noah face to face; we are provided only with God's monologue (Gen 8:20–22). God speaks only to himself. Nowhere does it state that God is on earth.

The Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 surprisingly lacks any direct description of God's action on earth.³⁰ Nowhere in Gen 11:1–9 is it mentioned that God confuses the language of humanity *on earth*. God's space on earth is only implied by the consequence that God confuses the language of the humanity "from there" and disperses humanity over the surface of all the earth (Gen 11:8–9). The narrator says only that God "came down" rather than describing the specific appearance of God on earth. There is also no dialogue between God and humanity, which would have implied God's space on earth.

While there are many descriptions of God's actions on earth in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9, they do not indicate that God has a place where he resides. Furthermore, in most cases, there are no direct descriptions of God's appearance on earth. God's space can only be implied by his actions or the consequences of his actions.

7.4.2. *Humanity's Space*

The spaces of humanity in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:9 are the spaces not only of individual people such as the first man, Eve, and Noah but also of humanity as a whole. Important elements of space in these texts include the earthly world for human beings and the ground which grows plants and vegetables. The specific spaces of humanity are mainly the earth, the garden in Eden, the altar built by Noah, and the city and tower built by humanity as a whole.

One important narrative theme in Gen 2–3 is the change of relationship between humanity, the garden, and the earth.³¹ While the setting of Gen 2–3 is

³⁰ There is also no description of God's space in heaven. The narrative does, however, involve a clear boundary between heaven and earth through use of the verb "come down" (Gen 11:5, 7).

³¹ It is interesting that rabbinic exegesis of Genesis 2–3, depicts the first man as interrelated with the concept of space. E.g., "R. Joshua b. R. Nehemiah and R. Judah b. R. Simon in R. Leazar's name said: He created him filling the whole world. How do we know (that he

the garden in Eden, the earth first becomes the focus of the narrative in Gen 2:4b–9. Genesis 2:4b–9 sets the earth as a broader spatial context for the Eden narrative. Genesis 2:5 specifically says that there were no plants or herbs of the “field” (אֶרֶץ) because there was no rain. It is from the dust of the ground (עֹפָר מִן־הָאֲדָמָה) that God forms the first man (Gen 2:7). When the earthly world is established, God plants a garden in Eden (Gen 2:8), and at this point the garden becomes the spatial setting for the actions of God, the first man, and Eve. The first man is put by God in the garden (Gen 2:8, 15) in order to “till it and keep it” (Gen 2:15).³² The plot develops around two particular trees (Gen 2:9). When the first man and Eve eat the fruits of the forbidden tree, disobeying the commandments of God, they are expelled from the garden (Gen 3). The space of humanity in Gen 2–3 therefore involves tension between the garden and the earth outside of the garden.

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, humanity’s first space is also “all the earth” (Gen 6:5). In opposition to Gen 1 and Gen 2–3, where God creates the world, God in the non-Priestly flood narrative decides to destroy the whole earth created by him. The whole earth and all of the creatures on it are destroyed by the rain sent by God. In addition to “the whole earth,” another important element of humanity’s space in the non-Priestly flood narrative is the ark. The ark is the only space belonging to humanity that survives the flood. There is no specific description of its construction (Gen 8:6–12). After the flood, the narrative mentions the first cultic space: the altar built by Noah.³³ The description of the altar focuses on its function rather than its physical shape (Gen 8:20). Noah offers the burnt offerings on the altar to God, then the lovely smell (ריח ניחוח) reaches God from the altar. After smelling the burnt offerings, God decides not to destroy the human world again (Gen 8:22).

The Babel narrative in Gen 11:1–9 describes a variety of spaces and places belonging to humanity, mainly the geographical places where humans live. The narrative sets the scene in a time when all the people of the earth speak the same language (Gen 11:1). At that time, humanity as a whole journeys from the East, then settles in a valley in the land of Shinar (Gen 11:2). There they

stretched) from east to west? Because it is said, ‘Thou hast formed me behind (אֲחֵר) and before (קֵדָם).’ From north to south? Because it says, *since the day that God created man upon the earth, and from the one end of heaven unto the other* (Deut. IV, 32).” And how do we know that he filled the empty spaces of the world? From the verse, ‘And laid Thy hand upon me’ (as you read, ‘Withdraw Thy hand from me’ (Job XIII, 21).” Translation from H. FREEDMAN and M. SIMON (eds.), *Midrash Rabbah* (London: Soncino, 1961), 54–55.

³² Two verses mention that God puts the first man in the garden. Gen 2:8 just states that God puts the first man in the garden without explaining why. Gen 2:15, however, states that the man is put in garden to till it.

³³ More descriptions of the altar appear in the non-Priestly patriarchal narratives. Almost all altars mentioned in the non-Priestly patriarchal narratives are built by Abraham and Jacob.

build the city of Babel and a tower (Gen 11:3–4). “Babel” clearly refers to the capital of Babylonia. The city and the tower are two prominent human spaces in the Babel narrative. Humans build the city and the tower in order not to be dispersed by God over the whole surface of the earth (Gen 11:4). When God sees that humanity is capable of building the city and the tower, he decides to confuse their language and disperse them over the whole earth (Gen 11:5–9).

7.4.3. *Nature’s Space*

Nature is an important narrative element in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9. All these non-Priestly texts are set in the natural environment, and this setting is closely interrelated with the themes of the narrative. For example, an important development in the narrative of Gen 2–3 is the change in relationship between the earthly world and humanity. The non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 describes how the flood destroyed the natural world, including all kinds of creatures, so the natural setting is indispensable to the narrative. The most important element of setting in the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 is the valley in the land of Shinar. This is a place where the city of Babel and the tower are built by humanity, and it is also where God confuses the language of humanity and disperses humanity over the whole surface of the earth.

Genesis 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 have different ways of describing nature’s space. The main types of nature’s space in Gen 2–3 are the earthly world created by God and the elements of the garden. The text describes how God first creates the earth and heaven and then plants the garden in Eden (Gen 2:8). The garden in Eden functions at the same time as space and place. The garden in Eden is a space because it is the setting for the movements of the first man, Eve, and God. Moreover, “every tree” (Gen 2:9) is planted in it. In this sense, the garden is like a container. On the other hand, the garden in Eden is a place because it occupies a fixed location and has spatial relationships with the other spaces and places outside of it. The Eden narrative involves several important spatial relationships, including the relationships between Eden and the garden (Gen 2:8), between the ground where God makes the first man and the garden in which God places him (Gen 2:15), and between the East and the garden in Eden (Gen 3:24). The garden in Eden is at the center of all these spatial relationships.

The non-Priestly flood narrative also involves many natural settings, although they are not each specifically described.³⁴ The important nature’s spaces or spatial settings include the earth (אֶרֶץ) (Gen 6:5), dry land (חֲרֵבָה) (Gen 7:22), the sky (שָׁמַיִם) (Gen 6:7; 7:3), and the flood formed by rain (גֶּשֶׁם) (Gen

³⁴ In the non-Priestly flood narrative, two natural spatial settings, sea and mountain, are absent.

7:12; 8:2b–3a). It is noteworthy that the earth is mentioned many times, while the sky is mentioned only twice and used as the locative adverb for describing the birds (e.g., Gen 6:7).

While the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9 has only nine verbs, the natural settings appear in almost every verse. The Babel narrative begins with “the whole world” of all the people, then the setting shifts from “the whole world” to a specific place: a plain in Shinar (Gen 11:1–2). Humanity as a whole settles there and builds the city of Babel and a tower (Gen 11:3–4). At this moment God comes down to see the city and the tower that the humans are building (Gen 11:5). Then, from the valley in the land of Shinar, humanity’s language is confused and people are scattered by God over the whole surface of the earth (Gen 11:6–9). There is, therefore, a clear spatial tension between the valley in Shinar and the whole earth.

Chapter 8

Physical Space in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

This section discusses how physical spaces and settings in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 are rhetorically constructed. Whereas the garden in Eden and its spatial setting are significant, the physical space of God and humanity is also indispensable for forming the theme of the Eden narrative.¹ I shall first discuss how the spatial setting in the Eden narrative is established. I shall then go on to examine physical space in terms of God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space, drawing attention to how these different spaces are constructed rhetorically by motion verbs, different perspectives, and prepositions.

8.1. Genesis 2–3 and Physical Space

Space is an indispensable narrative element in Gen 2–3. The garden in Eden (גֶּן, e.g., Gen 2:9) is the fundamental setting of Gen 2–3. In spatial terms, the garden in Eden has three important characteristics: its location, its spatial relationship with the world, and the settings and their spatial relationships within it. The location of the garden in Eden is signaled by the four rivers described in Gen 2:10–14.² The garden in Eden and the world are connected by God's actions. Finally, the two trees are the most important elements of the spatial setting within the garden, as God, the first couple, and the snake act around them. The two trees and the four rivers are therefore the elements that fix the setting of the garden in Eden.

¹ For discussion of the theme of Gen 2–3, see T.N.D. METTINGER, *The Eden Narrative: Literary and Religio-Historical Study of Genesis 2–3* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2007), 42–64.

² For a discussion of Gen 2:10–15 as the redactional layer, see M. WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte: Redaktion- und theologiegeschichtliche Beobachtungen zu Genesis 1,1–11,25* (BZAW 265; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1998), 84; W.H. SCHMIDT, *Die Schöpfungsgeschichte der Priesterschrift: Zur Überlieferungsgeschichte von Genesis 1/1–2/4a und 2/4b–3/24* (Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1964), 206; M. GÖRG, “Wo lag das Paradies? Einige Beobachtungen zu einer alten Frage,” *BN* 2 (1977), 23–32; and W. ZWICKEL, “Die Tempelquelle Ezechiel 47: Eine traditionsgeschichtliche Untersuchung,” *EvT* 55 (1995), 140–54.

8.1.1. The Garden in Eden as Spatial Setting

The first spatial setting in the Eden narrative is the world created by God. Genesis 2:4b–7 narrates how God creates the world and humanity. The story is set in a remote time, and the cosmos is established as total space.³ Immediately after God creates the world and humanity, he “plants” the garden in Eden. The rest of story takes place in the garden until the expulsion of the first man and Eve.

In Gen 2–3, the garden in Eden functions like a stage, a fixed location in which God, the first man, Eve, and the snake speak and move freely.⁴ The garden differs in this respect from a narrative with a space-oriented plot where the spatial setting changes according to the movements of actors.⁵

Genesis 2–3 offers no indications about the look and the shape of the garden in Eden.⁶ The general characteristics that can be inferred from the narrative include the presence of all kinds of trees (Gen 2:9) and four rivers (Gen 2:10–14). The existence of the rivers is perhaps for the sake of the trees, which need the water in order to live. However, nowhere in Gen 2–3 are we given clear information about the garden’s shape. Genesis 2–3 does not mention whether the garden is round or irregular. With respect to size, however, the garden in Eden is probably large because there are all kinds of trees and animals in it (Gen 2:9, 19). The garden must be at least big enough for all the trees and animals.⁷

³ G. ZORAN, “Towards the Theory of Space in Narrative,” *Poetics Today* 2 (1984), 309–35, here 322–23.

⁴ The spatial setting is a kind of narrative scene. In narratological terms, the change of narrative scene does not demand the change of the spatial setting. For discussion of the narrative scene in Gen 2–3, see T. STORDALEN, *Echoes of Eden: Genesis 2–3 and Symbolism of the Eden Garden in Biblical Hebrew Literature* (CBET 25; Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 218–20; J.T. WALSH, “Genesis 2:4b–3:24: A Synchronic Approach,” in *I Studied Inscriptions from before the Flood* (ed. R.S. Hess and D.T. Tsumura; Sources for Biblical and Theological Study 4; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1994), 362–82; G.J. WENHAM, *Genesis 1–15* (WBC 1; Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 50–51; and METTINGER, *Eden Narrative* (see n. 1), 16–18. In the present work, the scene is limited in terms of its spatial setting. The spatial setting in Gen 2–3 basically includes the world (Gen 2:4b–7) and the garden (Gen 2:8–3:24).

⁵ For discussion of the wanderings and settlement of the Israelites’ ancestors in Canaan as a foundation story, see G. DARSHAN, “The Origins of the Foundation Stories Genre in the Hebrew Bible and Ancient Eastern Mediterranean,” *JBL* 133 (2014), 689–709.

⁶ On the whole, while space is an essential element in the Eden narrative, time and location are described in a concise style; see STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 4), 250–301.

⁷ The size and shape could in some cases be deduced from the function of the garden. E.g., if the garden is a royal garden, it should be grandiose. For the view that the garden is a royal garden, see, e.g., M. HUTTER, “Adam als Gärtner und König (Gen 2:8, 15),” *BZ* 30 (1986), 258–62, here 261 and W. BRUEGGEMANN, “David and His Theologian,” *CBQ* 30 (1968), 156–81. This characteristic, however, is not stated clearly in Gen 2–3.

8.1.2. God's Physical Space in Genesis 2–3

The types of physical space associated with God in Gen 2–3 include the space in which God creates the world (Gen 2:4b–7), the space in which God plants the garden along with its physical features (Gen 2:8–25), and God's action space in the garden (Gen 3:1–24).

The space in which God creates the world is reflected in Gen 2:4b–7. The temporal expression “in the day” (Gen 2:4b) serves to introduce the spatial setting of God's act of creation.

These are the generations of the heaven and the earth when they were created. In the day that YHWH God made the earth and the heaven (ביום עשות יהוה אלהים ארץ ושמים), and no bush of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprung up, for YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth (כי לא המטיר יהוה אלהים על־הארץ); and there was no man to till the ground; but a mist would rise from the earth, and water the whole face of the ground – then YHWH God formed the man from the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and the man became a living being (ויצַר יהוה אלהים אֶת־הָאָדָם (עפר מן־הָאֲדָמָה ויפַח בְּאַפִּיו נְשָׁמַת חַיִּים ויִּהְיֶה הָאָדָם לְנֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה) (Gen 2:4–7).

Gen 2:4b states: “in the day that YHWH God made the earth and the heaven.” The expression “God made the earth and the heaven” indicates spatial relationships among God, the earth, and heaven. The earth and heaven are spatial points referring to God. This implies that God is not in heaven or on earth when he creates them.

The position of God is also established in Gen 2:5 by the description “YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth.” The rain here is described as being sent by God, which implies that God is in a high position whence he can send the rain. In Gen 2:7, however, the spatial viewpoint of God is shifted: God is no longer in a high position but has a specific place on the earth because he “formed the man from the dust of the ground” (Gen 2:7). The expression “YHWH God formed the man from the dust of the ground” indicates God's space: God is able to sit on the ground and pick up the dust to “form” the first man.⁸ The verb “form” and the material “dust” out of which the first man is formed imply physical contact between God and the first man. That God is able to breathe into his nostrils the breath of life further indicates a proximity between God and the first man.⁹

The second type of space associated with God is the space in which God plants the garden in Eden along with the spatial elements of the garden, reflected primarily in Gen 2:8–25. The features of the garden, rivers and trees,

⁸ For a comparison of the creation of humanity in Gen 1:26–28 and in Gen 2:7, see M.S. SMITH, *The Priestly Vision of Genesis 1* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2010), 134–38.

⁹ For discussion of the role of breath in forming the first man in Gen 2, see A. SCHÜLE, “The Notion of Life נֶפֶשׁ and רוּחַ in the Anthropological Discourse of the Primeval History,” *HBAI* 1 (2012), 483–501, here 484.

are described, but only one verse is about God's action of planting the garden:¹⁰ "And YHWH God planted a garden in Eden, in the east" (וַיִּטַע יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים גֶּן) (Gen 2:8a). Furthermore, the verb "plant" implies a continuous action. God may have been planning, decorating, and constructing the garden for a long time. In the biblical narrative, the subject of the verb "plant" is usually humanity. In Gen 9:29, Noah begins farming and plants a vineyard. In Gen 21:33, Abraham plants a tamarisk tree in Beersheba and there calls on the name of YHWH, the everlasting God. Daniel 11:45 describes how the king will plant the tents of his royal pavilion between the seas and the beautiful holy mountain. It is possible that, just as the king pitches the tents of his royal pavilion, God first collects the building materials and then plants his garden over time. While God plants the garden, he may sometimes be in it and sometimes not.

The physical space occupied by God when he creates the garden is also implied by the descriptions of how God brings the first man into the garden (Gen 2:8, 15). Two places mention that God takes the first man into the garden he planted.¹¹ Genesis 2:8 states: "and *there* God placed the man whom he had formed." It is in the garden that God puts the first man. The spatial focus is on "there," which indicates the garden. The expression used in Gen 2:15 is slightly different; that verse states: "Then YHWH God took the man and put him into the garden in Eden to cultivate it and keep it." This emphasizes that God takes the first man and only then puts him into the garden in Eden. The verb "took" implies that God brings the man to the garden from somewhere outside it just because he wants him to cultivate and keep it.

God's space in the garden is evident mainly in the dialogue between God and humans.¹² Gen 3:8 establishes the spatial setting for the dialogue among God, the first man, and Eve. "They heard the sound of YHWH God walking in the garden in the cool of the day (וַיִּשְׁמְעוּ אֶת-קוֹל יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים מֵתֵּהֶלֶךְ בְּגֵן לְרוּחַ) (הַיּוֹם), and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of YHWH

¹⁰ The phraseology "toward the east" may also be understood temporally rather than geographically; see STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 4), 261–70. If so, Gen 2:8 perhaps just says that God plants a garden in remote time. This point is debatable; see also METTINGER, *Eden Narrative* (see n. 1), 14–16.

¹¹ For discussion of the repetition in Gen 2:8 and 15, see E. BLUM, "Von Gottesunmittelbarkeit zu Gottähnlichkeit: Überlegungen zur theologischen Anthropologie der Paradieserzählung," in *Gottes Nähe im Alten Testament* (ed. G. Eberhardt and K. Liess; SBS 202; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 2004), 9–29, here 18–19. See also J.C. GERTZ, "Von Adam zu Enosch: Überlegungen zur Entstehungsgeschichte von Gen 2–4," in *Gott und Mensch im Dialog: Festschrift für Otto Kaiser zum 80. Geburtstag* (ed. M. Witte; BZAW 345; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2004), 215–36, here 225–28 and M. ARNETH, *Durch Adams Fall ist ganz verderbt...: Studien zur Entstehung der alttestamentlichen Urgeschichte* (FRLANT 217; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2006), 136–37.

¹² In many cases, dialogue is important for constructing narrative space. For the relationship between dialogue and narrative, see R. ALTER, *The Art of Biblical Narrative* (New York: Basic Books, 1981), 63–87.

God among the trees of the garden” (Gen 3:8). The first couple heard the sound of God walking in the garden in the cool of the day. However, Gen 3:8 does not state directly that God walks in the garden; rather, the sound (קול) of God’s walking is heard, and from this the first couple deduces that God is walking in the garden. The sound of God’s walking is emphasized again in Gen 3:10: “And he said, ‘I heard the sound of you in the garden.’” Furthermore, the sound of God’s walking indicates that God has a body and weight. When God walks, he makes sounds. The narrator might thus have intended to indicate that God walks in the garden without describing specifically whether God has legs for walking.

There is also no description of where exactly God walks. After hearing the sound of God walking in the garden, the first man and Eve hide themselves from the presence of God among the trees of the garden (Gen 3:8). The phrase “the presence of the God” implies that God might have shown up in person in the garden. However, the first couple does not see the presence of God, and the dialogue between God and the first couple is not face to face (Gen 3:9–19). This is implied by Gen 3:9–10: “Then YHWH God called to the man, and said to him, ‘where are you?’ And he said, ‘I heard the sound of you in the garden, and I was afraid because I was naked, so I hid myself.’” Thus, whereas the narrator of Gen 2–3 describes the appearance of God in the garden, he intends to avoid a direct description of the theophany of God. Rather, the narrator shows in an indirect way that God has a body and weight.

8.1.3. *Humanity’s Physical Space in Genesis 2–3*

In Gen 2–3, the first man and Eve represent humanity. The spatial setting for their actions is the garden in Eden. Where is the first man before he is put in the garden? This section discusses the issues of the spatial relationship between humanity and the garden, the spatial relationship between God and humanity.

The physical space of the first man is mentioned for the first time in Gen 2:7: “then YHWH God formed the man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and the man became a living being.” The first man has an essential connection with the ground: he is formed from dust.¹³ Genesis 2:7 implies a spatial relationship between the first man and the earth. The man probably stands on the ground immediately after he is formed. Genesis 2:7 does not mention where on earth the first man is formed, however; its main concern is to convey the idea that humanity should cling to the ground.

The spatial reference points used for the first man include the garden as well as the ground. This is evident from God’s actions. Genesis 2:8 states that God immediately *puts* the first man in the garden in Eden after he plants it. There is no mention of why God puts him in the garden in Gen 2:8, but Gen 2:15 states

¹³ Cf. Gen 1:27.

that the man is *taken* by God into the garden in order to cultivate it and keep it: “and there he placed the man whom he had formed” (וַיִּשֶׂם שֵׁם אֶת־הָאָדָם אֲשֶׁר (Gen 2:8b). “YHWH God took the man and put him into the garden in Eden to cultivate it and keep it” (וַיִּקַּח יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים אֶת־הָאָדָם וַיְנַחֲהוּ בְּגֶן־עֵדֶן לַעֲבֹדָה (Gen 2:15). In the biblical narrative, the subject of the verb “place” (שִׂים) or “take” (לָקַח), as is the case for the verb “plant” (נָטַע), can be either God or a human being (e.g., Gen 22:6; 24:9; 28:11; 28:18; Exod 24:6; 40:26), and both verbs can imply continuous action. For example: “And Jethro, Moses’ father-in-law, took a burnt-offering and sacrifices to God (וַיִּקַּח יֶתְרוֹ חֹתֵן מֹשֶׁה (עֵלָה וּזְבָחִים לְאֱלֹהִים); and Aaron came with all the elders of Israel to eat bread with Moses’ father-in-law in the presence of God” (Exod 18:12). The process described in Gen 2:15 by “took” and “put” clearly demonstrates spatial movement. God and the first man probably undertake a long journey together before arriving in the garden in Eden. On the other hand, the ground outside the garden is not cultivated until the first man is expelled from the garden. It is therefore from the uncultivated ground that God brings the first man into the garden in Eden.

8.1.4. *Nature’s Physical Space in Genesis 2–3*

There are two types of nature’s space and spatial setting in the Eden narrative: the space of the world and the spatial setting, like the rivers and trees, in the garden in Eden.¹⁴

The space of the world is described mainly in the creation account of Gen 2:4b–7. Genesis 2:8 also mentions the space of the world through the use of cardinal direction “east.” According to Gen 2:5, the basic natural elements of the world are shrub, field, earth, plant, rain, ground, and water. Among these elements, the earth is the space, while the others like shrub, plant, rain, and water are part of the spatial setting. Genesis 2:4b–7 implies that the garden in Eden is located in a grandiose spatial context and in a remote time: “when there was no shrub of the field on earth, and no plant of the field had yet sprouted, and there was no rain sent by God, there was also no man to cultivate the ground” (Gen 2:5). It is noteworthy that Gen 2:4b–7 does not describe the *process* of creation. Genesis 2:4b–7 tells us only how the world is: the basic elements are shrubs, vegetables, rain, and cultivated earth. These elements are agricultural and play a fundamental role in the following narrative in Gen 2:8–3:24 because this description implies a difference between the spatial settings in the garden and outside the garden. The view of the cosmos in Gen 2:4b–7 is primarily horizontal. Heaven is mentioned only once, in Gen 2:4b. The water

¹⁴ The garden is itself nature’s space and God’s space, because the garden in Eden is planted by God. For discussion of nature in the Bible, see T. HIEBERT, *The Yahwist’s Landscape: Nature and Religion in Early Israel* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1996), 3–29, 140–62.

on the surface of the world is also described as being horizontal: “a mist would rise from the earth, and water the whole face of the ground” (Gen 2:6). Genesis 2:4b–7 is therefore more concerned with the earthly world where human beings live.

The location of the garden in Eden is an important aspect of nature’s physical space.¹⁵ The location of the garden in Eden is illustrated mainly by Gen 2:8, 10–14. Genesis 2:8 suggests that the garden is located in the East, and its more specific location is in Eden: “And YHWH God planted a garden in Eden, in the east; and there he placed the man whom he had formed.”¹⁶ The description of four rivers in Gen 2:10–14 is also used to locate the garden in Eden. Because the latter two rivers are traditionally understood to be the Tigris and the Euphrates, the location traditionally assigned to the garden in Eden is in the area near Mesopotamia. At the same time, Gen 2:8–14 do not describe the exact location of the four rivers. Genesis 2:10 only suggests that the four rivers flow from the garden. The rhetorical way in which the four rivers are described makes them at the same time symbolic.¹⁷

Immediately after the description of the world and the garden in Gen 2:5–7, the trees in the garden are described. Whereas God makes all kinds of trees grow out of the ground, two mentioned specifically in Gen 2:9 are particularly important: “the tree of life” and “the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.” Exactly where these two trees are is a debated issue. Genesis 2:9 describes the position of the trees: “And out of the ground YHWH God made to grow every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food, the tree of life also *in the midst of the garden*, and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil” (ויצמח יהוה אלהים מן־האדמה כל־עץ נחמד למראה וטוב למאכל ועץ החיים בתוך הגן ועץ הדעת טוב ורע) (Gen 2:9). This verse implies that only the tree of life is in the middle of the garden, although grammatically it could also suggest that the tree of the knowledge of good and evil is also in the middle of the garden.¹⁸ Another

¹⁵ A. SCAFI, *Mapping Paradise: A History of Heaven on Earth* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2006), 21–27; E.A. SPEISER, “The Rivers of Paradise,” in *Oriental and Biblical Studies* (ed. J.J. Finkelstein and M. Greenberg; Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1967), 23–34; and G. von RAD, *Das erste Buch Moses: Genesis übersetzt und erklärt* (ATD 2/4; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1976), 55–60.

¹⁶ The meaning of “east” in Gen 2:8, however, is not definitive, as the word can be either temporal or geographical. This argument is defended by STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 4), 261–70.

¹⁷ J.L. MCKENZIE, “The Literary Characteristics of Genesis 2–3,” in *Myths and Realities: Studies in Biblical Theology* (Milwaukee, WI: Bruce, 1963), 146–81, here 158; Y.T. RADDAI, “The Four Rivers of Paradise,” *HS* 23 (1982), 23–31; Y. AMIT, “Biblical Utopianism: A Mapmaker’s Guide to Eden,” *USQR* 44 (1990), 11–17; and STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 4), 270–86.

¹⁸ For discussion of Gen 2:9 in grammatical terms, see A. MICHEL, *Theologie aus der Peripherie: Die gespaltene Koordination im Biblischen Hebräisch* (BZAW 257; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1997), 1–22. For more discussion of the redactional relationship between the tree

verse suggesting a position for the trees is Gen 3:3: “But God said, ‘You shall not eat of the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden, nor shall you touch it, or you shall die.’” (ומפרי העץ אשר בתוך־הגן אמר אלהים לא תאכלו ממנו) (ולא תגעו בו פן־תמתן). Genesis 3:3 does not explicitly mention which tree’s fruit it is forbidden to eat. However, Gen 2:17 already mentioned that the forbidden tree is “the tree of the knowledge of good and evil.” Gen 3:11 describes how the first couple eat the fruit of the forbidden tree, which suggests that the tree in the middle of the garden in Gen 3:3 is probably the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Both the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil are thus in the middle of the garden.

The trees are essential elements in the spatial setting of the Eden narrative. After planting the trees, God tells the first man that he can eat from any tree of the garden except the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, since on the day that he eats from it he shall die (Gen 2:16–17). In Gen 3, the actions of God, the first couple, and the serpent take place mainly around the tree of the knowledge of good and evil in the middle of the garden. The first couple eat the fruit of the forbidden tree. Then God walks in the garden, and the first man and Eve hide themselves among its trees. At the end of the narrative, the first couple is expelled from the garden in Eden. The plot and the theme of the Eden narrative thus center on the forbidden tree in the middle of the garden.

8.1.5. *Spatial Elements in Genesis 2:10–15*

In the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3, Gen 2:10–15 describes a particular physical space.

A river flows out of Eden to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four branches (ונהר יצא מעדן להשקות את־הגן ומשם יפרד והיה לארבעה ראשים). The name of the first is Pishon; it is the one that flows around the whole land of Havilah, where there is gold (שם האחד פישון הוא הסבב את כל־ארץ החוילה אשר־שם הזהב); and the gold of that land is good; bdellium and onyx stone are there (וזהב הארץ ההוא טוב שם הבדלח ואבן־השהם). The name of the second river is Gihon; it is the one that flows around the whole land of Cush (ושם־הנהר השני גיחון הוא הסובב את כל־ארץ כוש). The name of the third river is Tigris, which flows east of Assyria. And the fourth river is the Euphrates (ושם הנהר השלישי חדקל הוא) (ההלך קדמת אשור ונהנהר הרביעי הוא פרת). Then YHWH God took the man and put him in the garden in Eden to till it and keep it (ויקח יהוה אלהים את־האדם וינחהו בגן־עדן לעבדה ולשמרה) (Gen 2:10–15).

The spatial elements and their narrative style in Gen 2:10–15 are different from the other spatial elements in Gen 2–3. Other places in Eden narrative contain few descriptions of geographical characteristics of the garden. The garden in Eden as a whole cannot be located geographically because it is described as an

of life and the tree of knowledge of good and evil, see BLUM, “Von Gottesunmittelbarkeit zu Gottähnlichkeit” (see n. 11), 19–20 and GERTZ, “Von Adam zu Enosh” (see n. 11), 228–31.

“other” space in Gen 2–3. However, Gen 2:10–14 describes four rivers using geographical terms that can help to locate the garden. None of the four rivers – the Pishon, the Gihon, the Tigris,¹⁹ and the Euphrates – is difficult to locate geographically. The spatial relationships among them basically locate the garden in Eden near Jerusalem. The four rivers described in Gen 2:10–14 may be inspired by Ezek 47:1–12 which describes how a river flows around the temple. The narrator of Gen 2–3 may therefore have intended to use the description of the four rivers to locate the garden in Eden in or near Jerusalem.

Genesis 2:15 is, furthermore, a repetition of Gen 2:8–9, which has already described how God put the first man in the garden in Eden. Genesis 2:15 mentions again that God takes the first man and puts him in the garden in Eden to till it and keep it. Yet there are differences between Gen 2:8–9 and Gen 2:15. First, Gen 2:8–9 just describes how God puts the first man whom he has formed there and does not mention why he puts him there. Genesis 2:15, however, states explicitly that God takes the first man in the garden in Eden to till and keep it. Second, there are differences in the spatial relationships between the first man and the garden in Eden in Gen 2:8 and Gen 2:15. In Gen 2:8, God just puts the first man he forms in the garden in Eden; the verse does not mention whence and how God puts him there. Gen 2:15, however, describes how God “takes” the man and puts him in the garden. Use of the verb “take” implies that God brings the first man from the untilled ground outside the garden.

8.2. Genesis 6–9 and Physical Space

The flood narrative of Gen 6–9 combines the Priestly text and the non-Priestly text.²⁰ These two texts have basically the same narrative plot, theme, structure, and actors.²¹ The non-Priestly text includes Gen 6:5–8; 7:1–5, 7–9, 10, 12, 16b–17, 22–23; 8:1b, 2b–3a, 6–12, 13b, 20–22. The present section discusses the descriptions of physical spaces and spatial settings described in the non-

¹⁹ In Dan 10:4, Daniel says he received the vision while standing along חֲדָקַל ‘the great river’, which is identified in LXX as “Tigris.”

²⁰ For an overview of the structure of the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives, see A.F. CAMPBELL and M.A. O’BRIEN, *Sources of the Pentateuch: Texts, Introductions, Annotations* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1993), 211–23; P.J. HARLAND, *The Value of Human Life: A Study of the Story of the Flood (Genesis 6–9)* (VTSup 64; Leiden: Brill, 1996), 6–13; D.M. CARR, *Reading the Fractures of Genesis: Historical and Literary Approaches* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 1996), 48–62; and B.M. LEVINSON, “‘The Right Chorale’: From the Poetics of Biblical Narrative to the Hermeneutics of the Hebrew Bible,” in *“Not in Heaven”: Coherence and Complexity in Biblical Narrative* (ed. J.P. Rosenblatt and J.C. Sitterson; Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1991), 129–53.

²¹ J.-L. SKA, *Introduction to Reading the Pentateuch* (trans. P. Dominique; Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2006), 60–62.

Priestly flood narrative, in which God (referred to as YHWH in the non-Priestly version) and Noah are the two main actors, while the spatial setting is the whole earth.²² When God sees the wickedness of the humanity, he feels sorry and decides to destroy the earth and the creatures on it. Noah and his household are the only humans God allows to survive (Gen 6:5–8). After Noah and his household enter the ark, God sends the rain (Gen 7:1–5, 7–10, 12). The rain then forms the flood that destroys the earth and the creatures that God made (Gen 7:16b–17, 22–23). When the water recedes, Noah sends a bird from the ark to see whether the earth is dry (Gen 8:2b–3a, 6–12, 13b). After the flood, Noah builds an altar and makes the burnt offerings to God, and the lovely smell reaches God. God thinks that the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth, and he decides not to destroy the earth and the creatures on it again (Gen 8:20–22). The physical space in the non-Priestly flood narrative can thus be discussed from the perspective of God's space, humanity's space (i.e., Noah's space as the representative of humanity), and nature's space.

8.2.1. Physical Space and Spatial Settings in Genesis 6–9

God appears at the very beginning of the non-Priestly flood narrative. There is no description of where God comes from and no information about God's residence or his place in heaven. God's space is primarily demonstrated by his actions. God's space must be in a high place because God is able to send down rain on the earth. God's speech to Noah in the non-Priestly flood narrative (Gen 7:1–5) shows his capacity to control the whole earth and all of the creatures, which also demonstrates that God is in a high place. There is another speech by God after the flood, in Gen 8:20–22, but this monologue does not describe God's appearance, which might give an indication of where God's space is located.

²² For discussion of time and space in Gen 5–11, see E. BOSSHARD-NEPUSTIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut: Studien zu Text, Kontexten, und Rezeption der Fluterzählung Genesis 6–9* (BWANT 165; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 2005), 112–15. In ancient Mesopotamia, almost all the spatial scenery is global, not regional. For comparison of the flood narrative of Gen 6–9 with the other ancient Mesopotamian flood myths, see A. HEIDEL, *The Gilgamesh Epic and Old Testament Parallels* (A Phoenix Book. Archaeology 136; Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1963), 224–69; S.E. LOEWENSTAMM, "The Flood," in *Comparative Studies in Biblical and Oriental Literature* (AOAT 204; Kevelaer: Butzon & Bercker; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1980), 93–121, here 101–21; V. FRITZ, "'Solange die Erde steht': Vom Sinn der jahwistischen Fluterzählung in Gen 6–8," *ZAW* 94 (1982), 599–614; CARR, *Reading the Fractures* (see n. 20), 241–46; N.C. BAUMGART, *Die Umkehr des Schöpfergottes: Zu Komposition und religionsgeschichtlichem Hintergrund von Gen 5–9* (HBS 22; Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1999), 419–559; and R.G. KRATZ, *Die Komposition der erzählenden Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Uni-Taschenbücher 2157; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2000), 259–62.

From the perspective of humanity, the most important space is the ark.²³ The first word God says to Noah in Gen 7:1 is about the ark. When the flood happens, the ark is emphasized again with the description “only Noah was left, and those that were with him in the ark” (Gen 7:23). When the water recedes, it is from the ark that Noah sends out the birds to see if the land is dry. After the flood, humanity’s space shifts from the ark to the cultic space – in other words, the altar. The altar is the first space of humanity on earth after the flood.

Most of the natural spatial settings correspond to the spatial settings mentioned in Gen 1. Nature’s space in the non-Priestly flood narrative is designed as living space both for humanity and for other creatures. While humanity has the power to rule the other creatures, God has absolute authority over the whole earth, which is the most important spatial focus. It is striking that there is no mention of the mountain or the sea in the non-Priestly flood narrative.

8.2.2. God’s Physical Space in Genesis 6–9

Following the narrative sequence, the types of physical space associated with God in the non-Priestly flood narrative include God’s space before the flood, God’s space during the flood, and God’s space after the flood.

Genesis 6:5–8 recounts why God decides to destroy the earth and the creatures on it with the flood. God’s first action is to “see” that “the wickedness of humankind was great in the earth, and that every inclination of the thoughts of their hearts was only evil continually” (Gen 6:5). The object of the verb “see” is humanity as a whole on the earth. God’s space here is relative to the whole earth. Especially since God is able to destroy “the people together with animals and creeping things and birds of the sky” (מֵאָדָם עַד-בְּהֵמָה עַד-רֶמֶשׂ וְעַד-עוֹף) (הַשָּׁמַיִם) (Gen 6:7), God’s space is demonstrated to be beyond the human world. That God occupies a high space is further suggested by the rain.²⁴ In Gen 7:4, God tells Noah that he will send rain down to the earth. Rain in the biblical narrative is generally sent by God from heaven. Accordingly, in the non-Priestly flood narrative, God’s space might also be in heaven from where he sends down the rain.

In the descriptions of the flood in Gen 7:12, 16b, 17, 22–23, two verses mention God: “God shut Noah in the ark” (Gen 7:16b) and “God destroyed every living thing that was on the face of the ground, human beings and animals and creeping things and birds of the sky” (Gen 7:23a). The narrative focus is all of the creatures that God destroys. That God occupies a high space is again suggested by his capacity to destroy the whole earth.

²³ There is a big difference in the description of the ark between the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives; see BOSSHARD-NEPUSTIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut* (see n. 22), 55–56 and BAUMGART, *Die Umkehr* (see n. 22), 531–59.

²⁴ The rain here can be compared with the rain mentioned in Gen 2:5; see BOSSHARD-NEPUSTIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut* (see n. 22), 189–90.

God does not appear after the water recedes. Only one verse states that the water recedes: “the rain from the heaven was restrained, and the waters receded gradually from the earth” (Gen 8:2b–3a). These verses do not mention to where the water recedes but just emphasize again that the rain is from heaven. This further suggests that God’s space is in a high place. Whenever there is a flood on the earth or the water recedes, God is always in his space.

God appears again after the flood (Gen 8:20–22). The description of God’s appearance is indirect. Although God speaks, he does not speak to Noah. There is only the monologue of God. There is no information about where God is when he smells the burnt offerings or how far it is exactly between God and the altar. It is only in Gen 8:22 that the word “earth” is used, and this shows again that God’s space is relative to the earth.

8.2.3. *Humanity’s Physical Space in Genesis 6–9*

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, Noah is the representative of humanity, as in the Priestly flood narrative. Humanity’s space therefore corresponds to Noah’s space. Following the narrative sequence, the types of space associated with Noah are Noah’s space before the flood; Noah’s space when the flood happens; and the cultic space, or altar, after the flood.

The description of Noah before the flood is thin; the narrative is very concise and told from the point of view of narrator. Two verses describe the relationship between God and Noah: “But Noah found favor in the eyes of YHWH” (ונה מצא חן בעיני יהוה) (Gen 6:8) and “for I have seen that you are righteous before me in this generation” (כי־אתך ראיתי צדיק לפני בדור הזה) (Gen 7:1). It is hard to describe the spatial relationship between God and Noah by drawing on these two verses, since the phrases “in the eyes of YHWH” (בעיני יהוה) (Gen 6:8) and “I have seen” (ראיתי) (Gen 7:1) here are more conceptual ideas than physical spatial relationships (e.g., Gen 33:10; Deut 6:18; 1 Kgs 3:10). Genesis 6:8 and Gen 7:1 thus offer no clear indication of the spatial relationship between God and Noah.

Genesis 7:1–5 contains a long speech made by God to Noah before the flood. God tells Noah to enter the ark and that he will send rain to destroy the world. After God’s speech, the narrator states that “Noah did all that YHWH had commanded him” (Gen 7:5). Noah has no emotional reaction to what God tells him; he neither questions God nor hesitates. After hearing the speech of God, Noah just does what God commanded him to do. The spatial relationship between God and Noah is thus very conceptual: God is very close to Noah.²⁵ Moreover,

²⁵ The conceptual distance between YHWH and humanity is an important theme of Gen 1–11; see *ibid.*, 179–80.

God also “commands” Noah.²⁶ However, there is no indication about the physical spatial relationship between God and Noah. Only the fact that God talks to Noah suggests that God might be in the earthly world.

There have not yet been many descriptions of Noah and his space in Gen 7:12, 17, 22–23 when the flood happens. Most of the text describes how the flood destroys the earth. The ark is the only space related to Noah. Genesis 7:23 states that only Noah and those who are with him in the ark survive the flood. Genesis 7:23 not only explains the function of the ark but also paves the way for the narrative about Noah sending the birds out from the ark in Gen 8:6–13b.

While the non-Priestly flood narrative does not describe the construction of the ark, two characteristics of the ark can be identified in Gen 8:6–13b. The first characteristic is that the ark is so strong it cannot be destroyed by the flood. The second characteristic is that the ark has a window and a covering: “At the end of forty days Noah opened the window of the ark that he had made” (וַיְהִי (מִקֵּץ אַרְבַּעִים יוֹם וַיִּפְתַּח נֹחַ אֶת-חַלּוֹן הַתֵּבָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה (Gen 8:6). “And Noah removed the covering of the ark, and looked, and saw that the face of the ground was drying” (וַיֹּסֶר נֹחַ אֶת-מִכְסֵּה הַתֵּבָה וַיֵּרָא וְהִנֵּה חָרְבוּ פְנֵי הָאֲדָמָה) (Gen 8:13b). The window and the covering have different functions.²⁷ The window in Gen 8:6 is used for Noah to send out the birds. It probably does not function in the story in the same way as a window does today, since Noah cannot see the world outside through it. He can only put out his hand through the window and bring the dove back into the ark. Noah has to remove the covering of the ark in order to be able to see the ground.

After the flood, the main space associated with Noah is the altar. Genesis 8:20–22 marks a big shift in the spatial setting, from nature’s space to a cultic sanctuary. The narrative focus is not on the altar’s look but on its function: Noah makes the burnt offering on the altar to God. There is no specific description of the altar complex itself.

8.2.4. Nature’s Physical Space in Genesis 6–9

According to the narrative sequence, the forms of nature’s physical space can be described as nature’s space before the flood, nature’s space during the flood, and nature’s space after the flood.

²⁶ For the “commandment” indicating the closeness between God and humanity, see the discussion of speech and the distance between God and humanity in Gen 2–3 in the present work, 130–34.

²⁷ E.g., BAUMGART, *Die Umkehr* (see n. 22), 531–59 and J.C. GERTZ, “Beobachtungen zum literarischen Charakter und zum geistesgeschichtlichen Ort der nichtpriesterschriftlichen Sintfluterzählung,” in *Auf dem Weg zur Endgestalt von Genesis bis II Regum. Festschrift Hans-Christoph Schmitt* (ed. M. Beck and U. Schorn; BZAW 370; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2006), 41–57. See also WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte* (see n. 2), 179–81.

The natural spatial setting for the whole non-Priestly flood narrative is established before the flood in Gen 6:5–8 as the “earth.” God says that he will send rain down onto the earth and destroy all of the creatures on the earth, including people together with animals and creeping things and birds of the sky. The sky is mentioned specifically as the place of birds. There are also several of nature’s physical spaces mentioned in God’s speech to Noah in Gen 7:3–4:

And seven pairs of the birds of the sky also, male and female, to keep their offspring alive on the face of all the earth (גם מעוף השמים שבעה שבעה זכר ונקבה לחיות זרע עלי-פני כלהארץ) (Gen 7:3).

For in seven days I will send rain on the earth for forty days and forty nights; and I will destroy every living thing that I have made from the face of the ground (כי לימים עוד שבעה) (אנכי ממטיר על-הארץ ארבעים יום וארבעים לילה ומחיתי את-כל-היקום אשר עשיתי מעל פני האדמה) (Gen 7:4).

Similar to the natural spatial settings mentioned by God in Gen 6:5–8, the basic natural spatial settings in Gen 7:3–4 are the earth and the sky. The difference is that the earth in Gen 7:3 is described as “all the earth.” The word “birds” in the non-Priestly flood narrative always occurs in conjunction with the noun “sky.”

When God sends rain down onto the earth, and the flood destroys the creatures living on it, the natural spatial settings include not only the earth but also the rain from heaven and the flood. The flood is formed by the rain sent by God. After the statement that “the rain fell on the earth for forty days and forty nights” in Gen 7:12, Gen 7:17 offers a description of the flood: “The flood continued for forty days on the earth; and the waters increased, and lifted up the ark, and it rose high above the earth” (ויהי המבול ארבעים יום על-הארץ וירבו) (המים וישאו את-התבה ותרם מעל הארץ). The descriptions of the flood focus on two points. One is that the water level rises and lifts up the ark. The other is that the water rises high above the surface of earth. But neither of them shows the severity of the flood. The height of the water is not even demonstrated effectively because the water rises high only above the surface of the earth and not above the mountains, which are higher than the earth. Thus the non-Priestly narrator adds that “everything on dry land in whose nostrils was the breath of life died” (Gen 7:22) probably in order to show the severity of the flood. When the water recedes, there are only two verses: “The rain from the heaven was restrained (ויכלא הגשם מן-השמים), and the waters receded gradually from the earth” (וישבו המים מעל הארץ) (Gen 8:2b–3a). They give no specific information about where the water goes when it recedes. The narrative focus is on the connection between the rain and the flood. The flood is formed by the rain sent by God. When the rain is held back, the water recedes from the earth. At this point, Noah sends the birds out from the ark. Genesis 8:6–12, 13b do not describe the natural settings after the flood. Nature’s space is illustrated only by the birds.

After the flood, the spatial setting shifts from the ark to an element of humanity's space, namely, the altar. This is a religious sanctuary rather than nature's space. While there is a mention of natural phenomena as "seedtime and harvest, cold and heat" (Gen 8:22), there is no description of nature's space and spatial setting.

8.3. Genesis 11:1–9 and Physical Space

Genesis 11:1–9 relates that long ago when all the people of the earth spoke the same language, humanity as a whole journeyed from the East to a valley in the land of Shinar (Gen 11:1–2). There they tried to build for themselves a city and a tower reaching up into the sky, and to make a name for themselves, so that they would not be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth (Gen 11:3–4). At that moment, God came down to "confuse" their language and then dispersed them over the whole surface of the earth, and humanity stopped building the city (Gen 11:5–9). Gen 11:1–9 gives an interpretation of the name of Babel, the capital of Babylonia: it is from Babel that God confuses the language of the whole earth and disperses humanity over its surface (Gen 11:9). While Gen 11:1–9 has only nine verses, it contains different kinds of spaces and places. They function as essential narrative elements for either the theme or the plot.²⁸ This section first discusses the basic characteristics of the physical space in Gen 11:1–9, then draws attention to how motion verbs, different perspectives, and prepositions rhetorically construct God's physical space, humanity's physical space, and nature's physical space.

8.3.1. Physical Space in Genesis 11:1–9

In the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9, almost every verse mentions more than one place. According to the narrative sequence, the places mentioned are "all the earth" (Gen 11:1), "from the east" (Gen 11:2), "valley in the land of Shinar" (Gen 11:2), "a city and a tower with its top in the sky" (Gen 11:4), "the surface of all the earth" (Gen 11:4), "the city and the tower" (Gen 11:5), "the surface of all the earth" (Gen 11:8), "the city" (Gen 11:8), "Babel" (Gen 11:9), and "the surface of all the earth" (Gen 11:9). In addition to these specific and fixed places, different spaces are also implied by verbs such as "journey" (Gen 11:2), "come" (Gen 11:3, 4), "come down" (Gen 11:5, 7), and the prepositional phrase "from there" (Gen 11:9).

²⁸ The city and the tower ought to be the most two prominent spaces in the Babel narrative. H. GUNKEL, *Genesis, überstzt und erklärt* (HKAT 1/1; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1977), 92–101 suggests that the Babel story is composed of two stories. One is the story of the tower, which refers to the diversity of humanity. The other is the story of the city, which refers to the diversity of language.

God and humanity do not share the same space in the plot of Babel narrative but have their respective spaces for action.²⁹ God does not speak to humanity, and humanity does nothing directly to God.³⁰ There are clearly two different narrative units referring to the space of God and the space of humanity.

Humanity as a whole acts mainly in Gen 11:1–4, and is also the active subject in Gen 11:8. The main spaces and places that constitute the environment of humanity are the city and tower. Both of them are related to the spatial practice of building. Humans try to build themselves a city and a tower reaching up into the sky. The building materials are bricks and bitumen (Gen 11:3–4). From the perspective of narrative space, while human beings mainly act in Gen 11:1–4 and 8, their space is also indicated by God’s actions in Gen 11:5–9.

Descriptions of God’s actions are found mainly in Gen 11:5–9. There is no mention of God in Gen 11:1–4. The narrator does not describe the space of God as directly as that of humanity. The nature of God’s space and place are implied by the use of motion verbs like “come down” (Gen 11:5, 7). God’s action in “dispersing the people over the surface of all the earth” (Gen 11:8, 9) also indicates that God’s space is omniscient: God is able to place human beings in every corner of the earth. Thus, there is a clear distinction between God’s space and humanity’s space in the Babel narrative.

Nature’s space is the literary setting for the actions of God and humanity. The description of nature’s space is found at the very beginning of the Babel narrative: “When they journeyed from the east, they found a valley in the land of Shinar, and they settled there” (*ויהי בנסעם מקדם וימצאו בקעה בארץ שניער*) (*וישבו שם*) (Gen 11:2). The text clearly establishes the spatial setting in a specific geographical place: “a valley in the land of Shinar.” Humanity settles there and starts to build the city and the tower reaching up into the sky. At the same time, however, the space of humanity’s action is not limited to the valley in the land of Shinar. It includes two other, broader spaces: “the whole earth”

²⁹ The structure of the present Babel narrative is generally seen as cohesive; see J.P. FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art in Genesis: Specimens of Stylistic and Structural Analysis* (SSN 17; Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1991), 11–45; U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis: Part Two: From Noah to Abraham* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1964), 231–32; B.W. ANDERSON, *From Creation to New Creation: Old Testament Perspectives* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1994), 168–73; and J.C. GERTZ, “Babel im Rücken und das Land vor Augen: Anmerkungen zum Abschluss der Urgeschichte und zum Anfang der Erzählungen von den Erzählern Israels,” in *Die Erzväter in der biblischen Tradition: Festschrift für Matthias Köckert* (ed. A.C. Hagedorn and H. Pfeiffer; BZAW 400; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2009), 9–34.

³⁰ Some may argue that the building of a tower reaching into the sky is something that humanity does directly to God in heaven. Even if this is the case, what humanity wants is to challenge the authority of God rather than to do something directly to God.

and “the place where the people come from.” All these natural spaces are horizontal. Table 5 on the next page shows how physical space is structured in Gen 11:1–9.

8.3.2. God’s Physical Space

The description of God’s space in the Babel narrative corresponds to a large extent with the description of God’s actions in Gen 11:5–9.

Table 5. Physical Space in Genesis 11:1–9

	Types of Physical Space	Key Words
Gen 11:5–9	God’s Physical Space	“come” (הבה) “come down” (ירד) “disperse” (פוז) “from there” (משם)
Gen 11:1–5, 8	Humanity’s Physical Space	“all the earth” (כל־הארץ) “journey” (נסע) “journey from the east” (בנסעם מקדם) “valley in the land of Shinar” בקעה בארץ (שנער) “the city” (העיר) “the tower” (המגדל) “all the earth” (כל־הארץ) “valley in the land of Shinar” בקעה בארץ (שנער) “all the earth” (כל־הארץ) “east” (קדם) “sky” (שמים)
Gen 11:2, 4, 8–9	Natural Physical Space	

And YHWH *came down* to see the city and the tower which the descendants of men built (וירד יהוה לראת את־העיר ואת־המגדל אשר בנו בני האדם). And YHWH said, “Behold, they are one people and they all have one language. This is the beginning of what they will do, and now nothing they plan to do will be impossible for them. *Come*, let us *go down* and there let us *confuse* their language (הבה נרדה ונבלה שם שפתם אשר לא ישמעו איש שפת רעהו), so that they may not understand one another’s speech.” So YHWH *dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth* (ויפץ יהוה אתם משם על־פני כל־הארץ), and they stopped building the city. Therefore, it was called Babel, because *there* YHWH confused the language of all the earth (כִּי־שם בלל יהוה שפת כל־הארץ), and *from there* YHWH *dispersed them over the surface of all the earth* (ומשם הפיצם יהוה על־פני כל־הארץ) (Gen 11:5–9).

God’s space is indicated mainly by motion verbs such as “came down” (Gen 11:5), “go down” (Gen 11:7), and “dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth” (Gen 11:9). “Came down” (ירד) and “go down” (ירד) indicate

the specific place of God.³¹ The first “came down” is written in the third person, where the narrator states that God comes down to see the city and the tower. In Gen 11:5, God shows up immediately, and the narrator does not explain whether God already knew about the city and tower before he came down from heaven to see them. The only spatial information that can be inferred from this passage is that God is in a high position because he needs to “come down” to see the city and tower. God’s action is also described from the anthropomorphic perspective: not only is he able to come down, but he is also able to “see” the city.

This is the first time that God is described as “coming down” in the primeval history of Gen 1–11, but it is not the only time in the Hebrew Bible as a whole. In most cases, when God comes down, there are descriptions of the specific places to which God comes down.

And let them be ready for the third day, for on the third day YHWH will *come down on Mount Sinai* in the sight of all the people (והיו נכנים ליום השלישי כי ביום השלישי ירד יהוה לעיני) (כלהעם עליהר סיני (Exod 19:11).

And YHWH *came down on Mount Sinai*, to the top of the mountain, and YHWH called Moses to the top of the mountain, and Moses went up (וירד יהוה עליהר סיני אל־ראש ההר) (ויקרא יהוה למשה אל־ראש ההר ויעל משה (Exod 19:20).

Then YHWH *came down in the cloud* and spoke to him (Moses) (וירד יהוה בענן וידבר אליו) (Num 11:25a).

Then YHWH *came down in a pillar of cloud* and stood at the entrance of the tent and called Aaron and Miriam (וירד יהוה בעמוד ענן ויעמוד פתח האהל ויקרא אהרן ומרים ויצאו שניהם) (Num 12:5).

So YHWH of hosts will *come down to fight upon Mount Zion* and upon its hill (בן ירד יהוה) (צבאות לצבא עלי־רִצְיוֹן ועל־גִּבְעָתָה (Isa 31:4b).

The motion “come down” (ירד) generally implies two spatial locations. One is the place from which God comes down, the other is the destination to which God comes down. The examples above all emphasize God’s destination, and it is presupposed that God is in a high place.

Genesis 11:5, however, does not mention the destination. It simply states that God “came down” (ירד) to see the city and the tower. There are two possible reasons for this. One is that Gen 1–11 does not refer to any cultic places like Mount Zion, the tabernacle, or the temple that act as God’s residence on earth. It is thus improper to suggest that God could come down in Gen 11 to a mountain or to some cultic space like the tabernacle in Num 12:5. Another possible reason is that God may not come all the way down to the earthly world but merely to the space of the divine council. At first glance, it seems that God

³¹ For discussion of the double use of “come down” in terms of rhetorical criticism, see FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art* (see n. 29), 14.

might come down in a cloud, but the narrator does not explicitly say so. When God comes down in the cloud in Num 11:25 and 12:5, he talks to Moses directly. In Gen 11:5, God does not say anything to humanity. Rather, the use of the first person plural “us” might indicate that God is talking to the other divine beings in divine council, just as he does in Gen 3:22. Thus it seems that the destination in Gen 11:5 is the place of the divine council.

The place of divine council is further suggested by the fact that God “comes down” twice in Gen 11:5 and 7. It is unlikely that Gen 11:5 and 7 simply repeat each other. While Gen 11:5 does not describe the destination, Gen 11:7 suggests a structured cosmic view: God is in a higher place and, consequently, the divine beings subordinate to God might occupy a lower position than God. Figure 1 shows the relationship between the divine council space and the other basic spatial settings of Gen 11:1–9.

God already starts talking in Gen 11:6, yet there is no person to whom God talks. In Gen 11:7, while there is also no person to whom God talks, the exist-



Figure 1: Divine Council's Space in Genesis 11:1–9

ence of divine beings is suggested by the use of the first person plural: “*Come*, let us *go down* and there let us *confuse* their language, so that they may not understand one another’s speech” (הבה נרדה ונבלה שם שפתם אשר לא ישמעו) (איש שפת רעהו). This is the third time that the first person plural is used in God’s speech in Gen 1–11. The other two occurrences are in the Priestly text of Gen 1:26 and the non-Priestly text of Gen 3:22. In Gen 11:7, God says “let ‘us’ go down and let ‘us’ confuse there their language.” The space described here is therefore for both God and the divine beings. Furthermore, the first word “come” is used as an imperative. This usage indicates that the divine council occupies a horizontal space. It seems that the divine beings are not already assembled in their place, such that God has to first summon them together by

saying “come,” and only then “come down.” Gen 11:7 also suggests that there exists a space for divine beings because Gen 11:5 mentions only that God comes down from his place. Their place is lower than that of God, so God needs to come down twice. God first comes down from his space, and then he stops at the place of the divine beings and calls on them to come down to the earth to intervene in humanity’s actions.

God’s actions also indicate a spatial relationship between God and humanity. In Gen 11:7, 8, and 9, every verse uses the locative adverb “there” (שם). The first use is in God’s speech. The locative adverb shows a spatial relationship between God and humanity. God must be in a relatively remote place because he says that humanity as a whole is “there” on earth. The specific spatial framework here is the valley in the land of Shinar, which corresponds to God’s space above the earth. The other two uses of the locative adverb occur when the narrator describes how God disperses humanity “from there” over the whole surface of the earth. The place indicated by “there”³² is apparently the place where they settle: the valley in the land of Shinar. The locative adverb in Gen 11:7, 8, 9 corresponds to the one in Gen 11:2, which states that humanity settles “there,” namely, in “the valley in the land of Shinar.” Regarding God’s space, the use of “there” in Gen 11:8–9 also shows a shift in space. God’s space shifts from being a specific place to being an omnipotent space: from “there” God disperses humanity over the surface of “the whole earth.” This indicates that God has the capacity to control the whole earth from a specific place.

On the whole, there is a clear shift in the description of God’s space. The text first describes God “coming down,” which suggests that he is in a high place. Then God comes down into the space of the divine beings and summons them to come down into humanity’s space. Finally, the description of God’s space is the whole earth.

8.3.3. Humanity’s Physical Space

Humanity appears throughout the Babel narrative. Gen 11:1–4, 8 clearly represent humanity’s space in terms of human actions described in the third person plural. Humanity’s space is also implied by God’s actions in Gen 11:5–9.

And all the earth had one language and the same words. And when they *journeyed from the east*, they *found a valley in the land of Shinar*, and they *settled there* (יהי בנסעם מקדם וימצאו) (בקעה בארץ שנער וישבו שם). And they said to one another, “Come, let us make bricks and burn them thoroughly.” (ויאמרו איש אלדעהו הבה נלבנה לבנים ונשרפה לשרפה) And they had bricks for stone, and bitumen for mortar. And they said, “Come, let us *build for ourselves a*

³² It is sometimes suggested that the locative adverb “there” is a satirical play on the word “name” (שם); see FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art* (see n. 29), 16–17 and E. van WOLDE, *Words Become Worlds: Semantic Studies of Genesis 1–11* (BibInt 6; Leiden: Brill, 1994), 99–100. Whether it is or not, the adverb “there” does seem to me to emphasize the tension between “there” in Gen 11:7–9 and Gen 11:2.

city and a tower with its top in the sky (ויאמרו הבה נבנה־לנו עיר ומגדל וראשו בשמים), and let us make a name for ourselves, so that we *will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth* (פְּנִינָפוּץ עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ) (Gen 11:1–4).

So YHWH *dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth*, and they stopped building the city (ויפץ יהוה אתם משם על־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ ויחדלו לבנות העיר). Therefore, it was called Babel, because *there* YHWH confused the language of all the earth, and *from there* YHWH dispersed them over the surface of all the earth (עַל־כֵּן קָרָא שְׁמָהּ בָּבֶל כִּי־שָׁם בָּלַל יְהוָה (שַׁפַּת כָּל־הָאָרֶץ וּמִשָּׁם הִפְצֵם יְהוָה עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ) (Gen 11:8–9).

At the beginning of the Babel narrative, humanity journeys from the East when “the whole earth had one language and the same words” (Gen 11:1).³³ In the Hebrew Bible, the phrase “all the earth” (כָּל־הָאָרֶץ) in most cases indicates the geographical land scale, which is suggested, for example, by Judg 6:39 and Isa 13:5.

Then Gideon said to God, “Do not let you anger burn against me, let me speak once more; please let me make a test once more with the fleece, let it be dry only on the fleece, and let there be dew on *all the earth*” (וְעַל־כָּל־הָאָרֶץ יִהְיֶה־טֶל) (Judg 6:39).

They are coming from a far country from the end of the sky, YHWH and his instruments of indignation, to destroy *all the earth* (לְחַבֵּל כָּל־הָאָרֶץ) (Isa 13:5).

The same is true in Gen 11:8–9: “So YHWH *dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth*, and they stopped building the city. Therefore, it was called Babel, because *there* YHWH confused the language of all the earth, and *from there* YHWH dispersed them over the surface of all the earth.” In Gen 11:1, however, “all the earth that had one language” apparently indicates that all the people of the earth share a common language.³⁴ Thus the narrative scene for humanity in the Babel narrative starts from all the people of the whole earth. In Gen 11:2, the narrative setting immediately shifts from “all the earth” to a specific space; the change is indicated by the verb of motion “journey” (נָסַע). “Journey” normally indicates that a long spatial distance has been traversed (e.g., the journeys of Abraham, Jacob, and Joseph in Gen 12–50). The narrator, however, does not identify the specific place from which these people come. Humanity as a whole journeys from some unknown place to a specific place: a valley or plain in Shinar (Gen 11:2). The only information that is known about where they come from is that they come from the East and journey westward. On their way westward, humanity finds a place in the valley in the land of Shinar and settles there. The narrator uses three motion verbs to show this spatial movement: humanity “journeyed” from the East, they “found” a valley in the land of Shinar, and then they “settled” there. Therefore, while the plot of

³³ The repetition of the “one language” (שִׁפְהָ אַחַת) and “the same words” (דְּבָרִים אֶחָדִים) seems to emphasize that the people spoke the same language; see T. HIEBERT, “The Tower of Babel and the Origin of the World’s Cultures,” *JBL* 126 (2007), 29–58, here 33–34.

³⁴ *Ibid.*, 34.

Babel narrative is not space-oriented, it uses the motion verbs to show clear spatial movements on the part of humanity.

After the humans settle in the valley in the land of Shinar, the following descriptions of humanity's space concern primarily the city and the tower. These two human constructions are indispensable narrative elements in Gen 11:1–9. The actions of God and humanity and the relationship between God and humanity are both reflected in the construction of the city and the tower.

The city and tower in the Babel narrative have three important spatial elements: the building materials, the act of building the city and tower, and the layout of the city and tower. First, the narrator states specifically that humanity made bricks, fired them as stones, and used bitumen as mortar in the construction of the city and the tower. Bricks and mortar have long been understood to be the standard ancient Mesopotamian building materials. This is also usually taken as evidence that the city and tower that humans build in Gen 11:1–9 is a traditional Babylonian building.³⁵

Second, there are not many descriptions of building by humanity in the primeval history of Gen 1–11. The Babel narrative, however, not only describes the construction of the city and the tower but also focuses on them. When humans begin to build the city and the tower, they say “come, let us make bricks and let us burn them thoroughly.” This shows that people need to come together in order to build the city and the tower, that these buildings could not have been built by one person (cf. Gen 10:11–12). Moreover, the bricks and bitumen are needed to make stone and mortar.³⁶ This shows that the narrator is also concerned with building techniques. The narrator does not simply state that the humans build the city and the tower; he also emphasizes the process of building.

Third, while the Babel narrative describes the building of the city and the tower and the plot develops around them, there is no specific description of the layout of the city or the tower. Gen 11:4 only mentions that the tower in the city reaches up into the sky: “And they said, ‘Come, let us build for ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the sky (ומגדל וראשו בשמים), and let us make a name for ourselves, so that we will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth’” (Gen 11:4). This information is presented in direct speech. The main characteristic of the tower is stated by humanity itself rather than being included in the narrator's description of the city and tower. Expressions like “its

³⁵ E.g., the phrase “with bitumen and burnt brick” (*ina kupri u agurri*) is a standard formula in Babylonian building inscriptions; see N.M. SARNA, *The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (Philadelphia, PA: Jewish Publication Society, 1989), 82.

³⁶ Fired brick was used in Mesopotamia for important public structures; see J.G. WESTENHOLZ, “Babylon: Place of Creation of the Great Gods,” in *Royal Cities of the Biblical World* (ed. J.G. Westenholz; Jerusalem: Bible Lands Museum, 1996), 197–220, here 204–6.

top in the sky” are very rare in biblical narrative. The descriptions of the tabernacle and the temple give a very specific height (see 1 Kgs 6:2). The phrase “its top in the sky” is figurative language rather than an effort to describe the specific height of the tower. The phrase “tower with its top in the sky” is mainly used to show figuratively that the tower is very high.

The relationship between the city and the tower is also important. In biblical narratives, towers are generally described as part of a city’s fortification (e.g., Judg 8:17; 9:46–47, 49). Although the Babel narrative does not specify where the tower is with respect to the city, we can assume that it is part of the city. The relationship between city and tower can also be inferred from the ziggurat in Mesopotamia. Because the literary setting of the Babel narrative is Shinar, which is traditionally understood to be in Mesopotamia, the tower has been thought to be a ziggurat.³⁷ A ziggurat is a stepped temple and is the most well-known type of Babylonian sanctuary. However, Gen 11:1–9 does not clearly state the relationship between the city and the tower, and there is no hint that sacrifice took place at the city or tower in the Babel narrative.

8.3.4. Nature’s Physical Space

Descriptions of nature’s space are found mainly in Gen 11:2, 4, 8–9. The most important spatial settings are the “valley,” “the land of Shinar,” the “whole earth,” and the “East.” Among these, the “whole earth” appears most frequently.³⁸

And when they journeyed from the east (וַיְהִי בְּנִסְעָם מִקֶּדֶם), they found a valley in the land of Shinar (וַיִּמְצְאוּ בְּקֵעָה בְּאַרְץ שִׁנְעַר), and they settled there. And they said, “Come, let us build for ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the sky, and let us make a name for ourselves, so that we will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth (כָּל־הָאָרֶץ)” (Gen 11:2, 4).

Then YHWH dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth (וַיִּפֶּץ יְהוָה אֹתָם מִשָּׁם (עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ וַיַּחֲדְלוּ לִבְנֹת הָעִיר), and they stopped building the city. Therefore, it was called Babel, because there YHWH confused the language of all the earth, and from there YHWH dispersed them over the surface of all the earth (וּמִשָּׁם הִפְצֵם יְהוָה עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ) (Gen 11:8–9).

Three verses in the Babel narrative refer directly to “the whole earth.” The first is Gen 11:1, which indicates that “all the earth had one language and the same words.” At the end of the narrative, both Gen 11:8 and 9 mention that God disperses the people over the surface of all the earth. “Whole earth” in Gen

³⁷ SARNA, *JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (see n. 35), 82–83; C. UEHLINGER, *Weltreich und “eine Rede”: Eine neue Deutung der sogenannten Turm-Bauererzählung (Gen 11, 1–9)* (OBO 101; Freiburg: Universitätsverlag; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1990), 236–42; and R.B. COOTE and D.R. ORD, *The Bible’s First History* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1989), 96–97.

³⁸ SARNA, *JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (see n. 35), 81.

11:1 and 8 is a metonym for all the people of the whole earth rather than a geographical indication.³⁹ The phrase “all the earth” as a geographical indication is found only in Gen 11:9, where the whole spatial setting extends from a specific place, the valley in the land of Shinar, to the whole earth. While God and humans act in the valley in the land of Shinar, then, the literary setting of the Babel narrative includes “all the earth” as well.

The valley in the land of Shinar is the narrative focus in Gen 11:1–9. This is the very place where there is a point of contact between God and humanity. Humanity as a whole journeys from the East to the valley in the land of Shinar, settles there, and then starts building the city and the tower. At this time, God

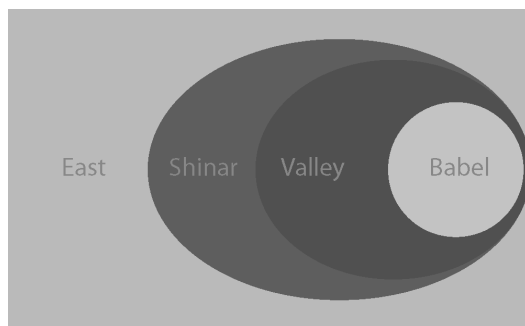


Figure 2: Spatial Settings in Gen 11:1–9

comes down from a high place to the valley in the land of Shinar, confuses the language of humanity, and disperses humans over whole surface of the earth. Almost all the actions of God and humanity happen in the valley in the land of Shinar. The valley in the land of Shinar includes two spatial settings, the valley and the land of Shinar. The valley’s function is perhaps just for building the city and tower, which requires a broad space.⁴⁰ It should also be taken into account that perhaps the narrator uses the special word “valley” (בִּקְעָה) to describe the setting of Babylonia in order to emphasize the peculiarity of that space.

The land of Shinar has long been perceived as Babylonian, and this can be inferred from the other texts in the Hebrew Bible.⁴¹ Shinar is used in biblical narratives eight times. For example, Gen 10:10 states: “And the beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, and Accad in the land of Shinar.” If Babel is

³⁹ HIEBERT, “Tower” (see n. 33), 34.

⁴⁰ The valley in Gen 11:2 is better interpreted as a plain, “referring to that flat alluvial land in southern Mesopotamia between the Tigris and Euphrates rivers”; see SARNA, *JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (see n. 35), 81.

⁴¹ *Ibid.*, 74.

Babylonia, Shinar is consequently the place where Babylonia is. This is also the case in Dan 1:2, which was probably written in the Persian period: “And YHWH gave Jehoiakim king of Judah into his hand, along with some of the vessels of the house of God; and he brought them to the land of Shinar, to the house of his god, and he brought the vessels into the treasury of his god.”

Given the broader textual context, the valley in the land of Shinar as the literary setting of the Babel narrative is also significant. Genesis 11:1–9 follows Gen 10 and triggers the scenery of Gen 12 where the patriarchal narratives begin.⁴² Babel in the valley of the land of Shinar establishes the basic spatial setting for Abraham’s journey from Ur in the Mesopotamian plain⁴³ to Canaan. At the beginning of Gen 11:1–9, humanity journeys from the East to the valley in the land of Shinar (Mesopotamia). After Gen 11:1–9, Abraham continues journeying westward from Mesopotamia (Gen 11:31). “East,” which is used to describe the place where humanity originates, is thus a particular narrative element in Gen 11:1–9. On the one hand, the narrator does not describe the specific origin of humanity in order to give the sense that the spatial setting shifts gradually from a broad space (East) to a specific place (the city of Babel), as illustrated in Figure 2. On the other hand, “East” suggests a very important spatial relationship between east and west. After Gen 11:1–9, Abraham journeys further westward from Mesopotamia into Canaan.⁴⁴ Thus the spatial relationship between east and west becomes the bridge between the primeval history, which focuses on the whole earth and all humanity, and the patriarchal narratives, which focuses on the story of the Israelites.

⁴² For discussion of the relationship between Gen 11:1–9 and its textual contexts, see GERTZ, “Babel” (see n. 29), 9–34; WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte* (see n. 2); and R.H. MOYE, “In the Beginning: Myth and History in Genesis and Exodus,” *JBL* 109 (1990), 577–98, here 587–91.

⁴³ For discussion of Israel’s origins in Mesopotamia, see P.K. MCCARTER, Jr., “The Patriarchal Age: Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob,” in *Ancient Israel: From Abraham to the Roman Destruction of the Temple* (ed. H. Shanks; Washington, DC: Biblical Archaeology Society, 1999), 18.

⁴⁴ CARR, *Reading the Fractures* (see n. 20), 183.

Chapter 9

Conceptual Space in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

This section discusses the concepts of space reflected in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood story in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9. Conceptual space in Gen 2–3 involves ideas the narrator has about spaces and spatial relationships in the Eden narrative. For example, how does the narrator perceive the structure of the world in the creation account of Gen 2:4b–7? As an etiological narrative text, the spaces and spatial settings in Gen 2–3 are very remote and abstract in order to explain contemporaneous phenomena.¹ In the Eden narrative, conceptual space is developed with respect to the world, the garden in Eden, the rivers, and the tree of life and the tree of knowledge of good and evil in the middle of the garden. Three important types of conceptual space can be found in the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9: the structure of the cosmos, the scale of the earth, and earth as a spatial focus. Earth is the most important spatial setting in the flood narrative. Conceptual space in Gen 11:1–9 is evident in tensions between God’s space and humanity’s space; between locative place and universal space; and among humanity’s different spaces such as the city, the tower, and the whole earth.

9.1. Genesis 2–3 and Conceptual Space

The world described in Gen 2:4b–7 is an example of conceptual space in the Eden narrative. Genesis 2:4b–7 reflects how the narrator thinks about the structure of the world. The garden is the main spatial setting in the Eden narrative, and its function is pertinent to the narrative theme. The garden is composed of spatial elements like rivers and trees. The descriptions of these spatial settings make the garden in Eden an “other” world. Genesis 2–3 also involves a specific conceptual spatial relationship, namely, the distance between God and humanity. In the garden in Eden, the relationship between God and humanity is one of proximity. When the first humans are expelled by God from the garden at the end of the narrative, however, their relationship becomes less close. In this

¹ For discussion of this text as an etiological narrative, see O.H. STECK, *Die Paradieserzählung: Eine Auslegung von Genesis 2,4b–3,24* (Biblische Studien 60; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1970), 66–73.

section, I shall first explore the concepts related to the world, the garden, and the garden's spatial setting and then discuss how the verbs "command," "call," and "say," as temporal actions, indicate a spatial concept such as the distance between God and humanity.

9.1.1. *Horizontal and Vertical Views of the Cosmos*

The creation account in Gen 2:4b–7 has a horizontal view of space. Genesis 2:4b–7 is more concerned with the earth and ground where human beings live. The key spatial elements are the earth, the field, and the plants on the ground, in accordance with the anthropological interpretation of the whole Eden narrative.² All spatial elements in Gen 2–3 are created explicitly for humanity.

A stratified view of the cosmos is also present in Gen 2:4b–7. While there are no direct descriptions of vertical space like there are in Gen 1, the "rain" in Gen 2:5 indicates a vertical space. Rain is significant for creation in Gen 2:4b–7. Genesis 2:5 states, "and no bush of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprung up, for YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth." Only after rain would the shrubs and plants of field grow. More importantly, the rain is "sent by God" (e.g. Ps 68:9; Jer 5:24; Joel 2:23).³

Where is God when he sends the rain? In many cases, the rain is described in biblical texts as being sent by God from heaven. For example, Gen 8:2 states, "and the fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven were closed, and the rain from heaven was restrained." Deuteronomy 11:17 also indicates that there would be no rain if God shut up the heaven: "Then the anger of the God will be kindled against you, and he will shut up the heaven so that there will be no rain and the ground will not yield its fruit, and you will perish quickly from the good land which YHWH is giving you." Genesis 2:5, then, probably also assumes that the rain is from heaven, where God is.

The ancient Israelites also understood rain to come down from heaven in order to water the earth and then return, as indicated by Isa 55:10: "for as the rain and the snow come down from heaven, and do not return there without watering the earth." Isaiah 55:11 draws an analogy between the rain and words: "so shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me void, but shall accomplish that which I purpose, and succeed in the thing for

² For a discussion of Gen 2–3 from the perspective of anthropology, see E. BLUM, "Von Gottesunmittelbarkeit zu Gottähnlichkeit: Überlegungen zur theologischen Anthropologie der Paradieserzählung," in *Gottes Nähe im Alten Testament* (ed. G. Eberhardt and K. Liess; SBS 202; Stuttgart: Katholisches Bibelwerk, 2004), 9–29.

³ For discussion of YHWH as the god of weather, see F. HARTENSTEIN, "Wettergott – Schöpfergott – Einziger: Kosmologie und Monotheismus in den Psalmen," in *JHWH und die Götter der Völker: Symposium zum 80. Geburtstag von Klaus Koch* (ed. F. Hartenstein and M. Rösel; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 2009), 77–97.

which I sent it.” Isaiah’s word, like the rain, shall not return whence it comes without achieving its purpose.

While there is no clear indication from where exactly God sends the rain, Gen 2:5 expresses a vertical view of the cosmos. The rain is mentioned with respect to the earthly world. It is only after the rain coming from God that there can be shrubs and plants of the field. The view of cosmos in the creation account of Gen 2:4b–7 is therefore both horizontal and vertical.

9.1.2. Spatial Relationships Involving the Garden in Eden

9.1.2.1. The Relationship between the Garden in Eden and the Earthly World

First, the garden in Eden is portrayed as the center of the world. The creation account at the beginning of Gen 2–3 describes how God creates the world and the first man (Gen 2:4b–7). Beginning with Gen 2:7, the focal point gradually shifts from the cosmos to the earth, to the East, to Eden, to the garden in Eden, and then to “the middle of the garden.” These spatial settings are described in Gen 2–3 in order to show a sequence moving from broad space to increasingly specific places until the middle of the garden becomes the central focus of the narrative. Figure 3 shows the relationship between the garden in Eden and the earthly world.

Second, the ground inside the garden is opposed to the (untilled) ground outside the garden. This opposition is reflected in the movement of the first man: “And no bush of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprung up, for YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth; and there was no man to till the ground” (וכל שיח השדה טרם יהיה בארץ וכל-עשב השדה) (Gen 2:5). When the first man is created, the space is referred to as “untilled ground” (Gen 2:5) rather than the land in the garden. God even forms the man (Gen 2:7) before planting the garden in Eden (Gen 2:8). While Gen 2:15 says that the first man should “work” (till and keep) in the garden in Eden, Gen 2:8, 16, and 17 suggest that when the first man is in the garden in Eden, he is able to live only from the fruit of trees in the garden; nowhere is it mentioned that the first man should work. There is a spatial opposition, then, between the land in the garden and the untilled ground outside the garden; the first man moves from one to the other as the narrative unfolds. This is also emphasized by the correspondence between Gen 3:17–19 and Gen 2:5.

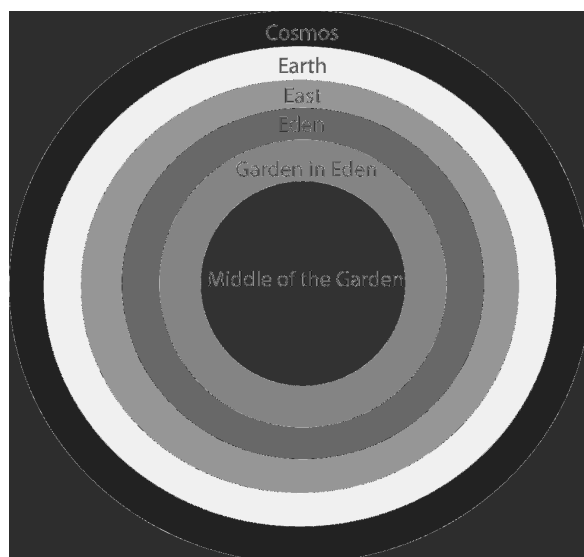


Figure 3: The Relationship between the Garden in Eden and the Earthly World

And to the man he said, “Because you have listened to the voice of your wife, and have eaten of the tree about which I commanded you, “you shall not eat of it,” cursed is the ground because of you; in toil you shall eat of it all the days of your life; thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you; and you shall eat the plants of the field. By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread until you return to the ground (בועת אפיך תאכל לחם עד שובך) for out of it you were taken; you are dust, and to dust you shall return (Gen 3:17–19).

While Gen 2:5 just states that there are no plants and no humans to till the ground, Gen 3:17–19 elaborates on this, describing how humanity should till the ground after having been expelled from the garden in Eden. The garden in Eden is thus a different world from the world outside the garden, because it is not necessary for the first man to work in the garden.

9.1.2.2. *The Relationships among God, Humanity, and the Garden in Eden*

The function of the garden is also reflected in its relationship to humanity and to God in two ways. First, the garden is not planted for humans. Two verses mention that the first man and the garden are connected by God. In Gen 2:8, God plants a garden in Eden, in the East, and puts the man whom he had formed *there*. Genesis 2:8 does not mention why God puts him in the garden. Genesis 2:15, however, states explicitly that God puts the first man in the garden in

Eden in order to till and keep it. This is analogous to the way in which the Israelites should service the tabernacle (see Num 4:35, 39, 43). Thus, Gen 2:8 and Gen 2:15 present different explanations of why the first man is placed in the garden by God. Genesis 2:8 suggests that eating fruit from the trees is enough to keep the first man alive (Gen 2:16). In Gen 2:15, however, the first man has his assignment: “to till and to keep” (לעבדה ולשמרה) the garden. For whom, then, does the first man keep the garden? That the function of the garden is oriented to God is shown by the fact that God is able to walk in the garden. In the biblical narratives, God rarely walks anywhere, especially since the phrase “the cool wind” shows that God walks in a leisurely way. Probably because God is the owner of the garden in Eden, he not only forms the first man in order to keep it but also can walk freely in it himself. Furthermore, the garden is probably planted not only for God but also for the other divine beings in heaven, as indicated by Gen 3:22: “YHWH God said, ‘See, the man has become like one of *us*, knowing good and evil; and now, he might reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life, and eat, and live forever.’” Use of the first person plural “us” suggests that the garden might have been designed for both God and the divine beings in heaven for leisure.⁴

9.1.3. The Garden in Eden as an “Other” Space

Whereas the garden in Eden has many mythical elements⁵ – for example, it is planted by God, and the serpent can talk – the most particular characteristic, in spatial terms, should be the “other.”⁶ The garden in Eden is described as a space

⁴ T. STORDALEN, *Echoes of Eden: Genesis 2–3 and Symbolism of the Eden Garden in Biblical Hebrew Literature* (CBET 25; Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 257–61 argues that the word “Eden” probably denotes “leisure.”

⁵ Since the nineteenth century, biblical scholars have increasingly paid attention to the connection between the Eden narrative and the other Near Eastern myths like Enki and Ninhursag, Gilgamesh, and later the Ugaritic myth Baal and Mot, analyzing their similarities in terms of theme, motif, and structure; for a thorough discussion, see *ibid.*, 139–61. For specific comparison between the Eden narrative and the Gilgamesh Epic, see T.N.D. METTINGER, *The Eden Narrative: Literary and Religio-Historical Study of Genesis 2–3* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2007), 109–22.

⁶ Here it may be helpful to use suggestions about the garden in M. FOUCAULT, “Of Other Spaces: Utopias and Heterotopias,” *Diacritics* 16 (1986), 22–27, who claims that the garden is a kind of heterotopia and is of the third principle: “the heterotopia has the capable of juxtaposing in a single real place several spaces, several sites that are in themselves incompatible” (25). The garden, according to Foucault, “is the smallest parcel of the world and then it is the totality of the world. The garden has been a sort of happy, universalizing heterotopia since the beginnings of antiquity (our modern zoological gardens spring from that source)” (26). The garden in Gen 2–3, unlike Foucault’s heterotopia, is only narrated in text and resists being located. Furthermore, the otherness of the garden is evident primarily in relationship between the garden in Eden and ordinary experienced places, rather than in the contradictory relationships among the spatial settings in the garden.

of otherness that either lacks a location or is located in a remote time. There is no clear information in Gen 2–3 to locate the exact place of the garden. The garden as an “other space,” different from the “contrast world,” is generally described as being a part of the human world and has the same geographical elements as the human world.⁷ A utopia is an “other world,”⁸ but the other world is not necessarily utopian, since the other world can either be enjoyable or not.

The nature of the garden in Eden as “other” is, in the first instance, reflected in its location. The Eden narrative simply describes the location of the garden as being in the East, in Eden. Throughout the history of research on Gen 2–3, scholars have taken either a geographical or a mythical approach to interpreting the garden in Eden.⁹ Whichever approach we accept, in narratological terms, it can be argued that the narrator intends to describe an “other world” rhetorically by constructing spatial oppositions between the ordinary earthly world and the garden in Eden.

The Eden narrative constructs four primary spatial oppositions: the land inside the garden in Eden versus the untilled ground outside the garden, the river inside the garden versus the streams outside the garden, the one river inside the garden versus the four rivers outside the garden, and the world inside the garden versus the earthly world outside of the garden.

First, the spatial opposition between the land inside the garden and the untilled ground outside the garden is evident mainly in the correspondence between Gen 2:5 and Gen 3:23. Compare “no bush of the field was yet in the earth, and no herb of the field had yet sprung up, for YHWH God had not sent rain upon the earth; and there was no man to till the ground” (אדם אין לעבד)

⁷ F. STOLZ, “Paradise und Gegenwelten,” *Zeitschrift für Religionswissenschaft* 1 (1993), 5–24.

⁸ For details about the garden in Eden as a utopia, see M. ELIADE, “Paradise and Utopia: Mythical Geography and Eschatology,” in *Utopias and Utopian Thought* (ed. F.E. Manuel; Daedalus Library 5; Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1966), 260–80.

⁹ On the geographical orientation, see, e.g., H. GRESSMANN, “Mythische Reste in der Paradieserzählung,” *AR* 10 (1907), 345–67; W.F. ALBRIGHT, “The Location of the Garden of Eden,” *AJSL* 39 (1922), 15–31; J. SKINNER, *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on Genesis* (ICC; Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1930), 59–66; and E.A. SPEISER, “The Rivers of Paradise,” in *Oriental and Biblical Studies* (ed. J.J. Finkelstein and M. Greenberg; Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1967), 23–34. Scholars who argue that the garden should not be studied geographically include U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis. Part One: From Adam to Noah* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1961), 118; H. GUNKEL, *Genesis, übersetzt und erklärt* (HKAT 1/1; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1977), 5–10; J.L. MCKENZIE, “The Literary Characteristics of Genesis 2–3,” in *Myths and Realities: Studies in Biblical Theology* (Milwaukee, WI: Bruce, 1963), 146–81; Y.T. RADDAY, “The Four Rivers of Paradise,” *HS* 23 (1982), 23–31; Y. AMIT, “Biblical Utopianism: A Mapmaker’s Guide to Eden,” *USQR* 44 (1990), 11–17; and STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 4), 270–86.

אֶת־הָאָדָמָה) in Gen 2:5 with Gen 3:23: “Therefore YHWH God sent him out from the garden of Eden, *to cultivate the ground* (לְעֵבֵד אֶת־הָאָדָמָה) from which he was taken.” In Gen 2:5, there is no one to till the ground. Gen 2:5 portrays the basic situation of the world before God forms the first man and puts him in the garden. The last words in Gen 2:5 are particular: “there was no one to till the ground.” There are two viewpoints in this verse: that of God and that of humanity. God does not yet make it rain on earth nor does humanity exist to till the ground. Afterwards, in Gen 2:7, God creates the first man. This seems to suggest that the first man is created to till the ground. However, in Gen 2:8, God puts the first man in the garden rather than making him till the ground. Furthermore, Gen 2:15 states that the first man is formed by God in order to take care of and keep the garden. At this point, the ground outside of the garden has not yet been tilled.

In Gen 3:23, however, the first man is expelled from the garden and then has to cultivate the ground. The ground outside of the garden then starts to be tilled. Genesis 2:5 and Gen 3:23 seems to form an *inclusio*, at the end of which the first humans are expelled from the garden by God and start to till the ground. There is, therefore, a spatial opposition between the garden in Eden and the untilled ground outside of the garden.

The second spatial opposition is that between the rivers inside the garden and the streams outside the garden. Genesis 2:6 mentions the primordial water in creation: “but a mist would rise from the earth, and water the whole face of the ground.” At that time, there was no rain for watering, but there was a mist. This mist is described as rising from the earth, implying that the water comes from under the earth, and that it comes in order to water the whole face of the ground.¹⁰ Genesis 2:10 mentions a river which flows out of Eden in order to water the garden. The river here is described as flowing out of Eden, not out of the garden. Whether or not the river is formed by the mist in Gen 2:6, its function is to water only the garden, not other places. The streams outside of the garden thus form a spatial opposition with the river that waters the garden.

Third, Gen 2:10 describes how the river watering the garden divides into four branches as it leaves Eden. It is noteworthy that there is only one river in Eden that waters the garden. This one river becomes four rivers only gradually outside of Eden: “One river flows out of Eden to water the garden, and *from there* it divides and becomes four branches.” Genesis 2:10 does not explicitly describe where and in which direction the Eden river becomes four rivers, alt-

¹⁰ For discussion of “mist rising from the earth,” see STECK, *Die Paradieserzählung* (see n. 1), 28 and M. BAUKS, *Die Welt am Anfang: Zum Verhältnis von Vorwelt und Weltentstehung in Gen 1 und in der altorientalischen Literatur* (WMANT 74; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1997), 89.

though the four branches of the river apparently serve to water the ground outside of Eden. Thus there is a spatial opposition between the one river inside the garden and the four rivers outside the garden.

Fourth, as discussed above, the Eden narrative also shows a spatial opposition between the land “inside of the garden” and the earthly world “outside of the garden.” For example, the humans do not need to till the ground in order to live in the garden. They can live by simply eating the fruit of the trees. Many things they do outside of the garden are different from those that they do in the garden.¹¹

9.1.4. *Speech and the Distance between God and Humanity*

The change in distance between God and humanity is an important theme of the Eden narrative of Gen 2–3. When the first humans are in the garden, they are very close to God. The relationship between them is one of proximity, evident in the fact that the first man and Eve can speak to God directly. When the humans are expelled from the garden, however, their relationship with God becomes less close. The present section discusses how the speeches in Gen 2–3 rhetorically construct the distance between God and humanity. My focus is on Gen 2:16–17 and Gen 3:9–10, two passages involving speeches by God. I shall argue that the verbs “command” (צוה), “call” (קרא), and “say” (אמר), as temporal actions, can indicate spatial concepts such as distance.

God’s action in Gen 2–3 is reflected mainly in his speeches (e.g., Gen 2:16 and 3:9–21) to the first couple. God’s first speech is in Gen 2:16–17, where God “commanded” (צוה) the first man not to eat the fruit of the tree of knowledge of good and evil. God speaks immediately after he puts the man into the garden in Eden (Gen 2:15). The garden is then established as the spatial setting for God’s speech: “And YHWH God *commanded* the man (ויצו יהוה אלהים על-האדם), ‘You may freely eat of every tree of the garden; but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you shall not eat, for in the day that you eat of it you shall die’” (Gen 2:16–17). This is the first time God speaks to the first man after creating him, and the way he speaks is to “command,” rather than simply to “say.” God emphasizes again in Gen 3:11 and 17 that he has “commanded” the man not to eat the fruit of the forbidden tree.

¹¹ The difference between the situation inside the garden and the situation outside it can be summarized as a movement from one ambivalent situation to another; see, e.g., J. BARR, *The Garden of Eden and the Hope of Immortality* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 1993) and H. SPIECKERMANN, “Ambivalenzen: Ermöglichte und verwirklichte Schöpfung in Genesis 2f.,” in *Verbindungslinien: Festschrift für Werner H. Schmidt zum 65. Geburtstag* (ed. A. Graupner, H. Delkurt, and A.B. Ernst; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 2000), 363–76.

He said, “Who told you that you were naked? Have you eaten from the tree of which I *commanded* you not to eat?” (המךהעץ אשר צויתך לבלתי אכל-ממנו אכלת) (Gen 3:11).

And to the man he said, “Because you have listened to the voice of your wife and have eaten of the tree about which I *commanded* you (אשר צויתך), ‘you shall not eat of it’, cursed is the ground because of you; in toil you shall eat of it all the days of your life” (Gen 3:17).

God emphasizes twice that he commands the first man not to eat the fruits of the tree of knowledge of good and evil. I will argue that the “command” in Gen 2:16 reflects the proximity between God and humanity. Furthermore, “command” can also imply a particular type of social relationship. In the case of Gen 2:16–17, “command” implies that the first man is formed by God to keep the garden as a servant.

The first man is not the only person in the primeval history (Gen 1–11) to be commanded by God; Noah is also. While God’s commands to the first man come in direct speech, his commands to Noah are transmitted through the use of indirect speech. The voice is that of the narrator rather than the actors in the story. Genesis 6:22; 7:9; and 7:16 describe from the omniscient perspective of the narrator that Noah does what God has commanded him. Genesis 6:22 describes this in the following way: “and then Noah did this, he did all that God *commanded* him” (ויעש נח ככל אשר צוה אתו אלהים כן עשה). Gen 7:9 repeats: “Two and two, male and female, went into the ark with Noah, as God had *commanded* Noah” (שנים שנים באו אלינח אליהתבה זכר ונקבה כאשר צוה אלהים). In the patriarchal narratives (Gen 12–50), Abraham is the only one among the ancestors of the Israelites who receives a command from God. The commandment of God to Abraham is also related by the narrator rather than the characters in the narrative: “Then Abraham circumcised his son Isaac when he was eight days old, as God had *commanded* him” (כאשר צוה אתו אלהים) (Gen 21:4). Thus, in the primeval history (Gen 1–11) and the patriarchal narratives (Gen 12–50),¹² it is only the first man, Noah, and Abraham who are “commanded” directly by God rather than via an intermediary.¹³

¹² In Exodus, although there are some people to whom God gives commands, Moses is the only one whom God commands directly (e.g., Exod 23:15; 31:6, 11; 34:18). Exod 23:15 describes the commands of God using direct speech: “You shall observe the festival of unleavened bread; as I *commanded* you, you shall eat unleavened bread for seven days at the appointed time in the month of Abib, for in it you came out of Egypt.”

¹³ In the biblical narratives, God in many cases commands the people indirectly through the use of intermediaries. God’s commands to people, mostly the Israelites, are made known by indirect speech. This technique is used frequently in the book of Deuteronomy, e.g., “then we set out from Horeb ... just as YHWH our God had commanded us; and we came to Kadesh-barnea” (Deut 1:19). This is the word from Moses when he expounds the law to the Israelites in the land of Moab (Deut 1:5). The text illustrates that, while God can command the Israelites, he does not command them directly; rather, it is Moses who tells them that God has commanded them. In other cases, the commands of God are executed by an intermediary; God does not command the people directly, but someone else commands the people

When the subject of the command is a human being, various social relationships¹⁴ with the object are involved.¹⁵ The relationship can be a host, a servant (e.g., Gen 12:20; 44:1; 50:2), or a family relation (e.g., Gen 27:8). In Gen 2:16, the “command” not only shows the proximity between God and the first man, but it may also imply that the first man is formed by God in order to till and keep the garden as a servant.

In other speeches by God to the first man and woman, the verbs used are “say” (אמר) (e.g., Gen 3:9) and “call” (קרא) (e.g., Gen 3:9). I shall take the dialogue between God and the first couple in Gen 3:8–10 as an example and argue that “say” and “call,” like “command,” also imply a conceptual proximity between God and humanity.¹⁶

They heard the sound of YHWH God walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of YHWH God among the trees of the garden. But YHWH God *called* to the man, and *said* to him, “Where are you?” (ויקרא יהוה) (אלהים אליהאדם ויאמר לו איכה) And he *said* (ויאמר), “I heard the sound of you in the garden, and I was afraid, because I was naked, so I hid myself” (Gen 3:8–10).

The setting of the dialogue in Gen 3:8–10 is still the garden. The presence of God is described indirectly. Genesis 3:8 suggests that the first couple *hears* the sound of God walking in the garden in the cool of the day. The sound of God’s walking implies that God has a body and weight. Thus God apparently shows up in person in the garden. “The sound of God’s walking” (קול יהוה אלהים) (מתהלך) is emphasized again in Gen 3:10: “And he *said*, ‘I heard the sound of

according to God’s word, e.g., “and the Levites carried the ark of God on their shoulders with the poles, as Moses had commanded according to the word of YHWH” (1 Chr 15:15). The command here is from God, but it is Moses who commands the Levites directly. After Moses, the one who is commanded by God directly is Joshua in the book of Deuteronomy. When God commissions Joshua the son of Nun, he says: “Be strong and courageous, for you shall bring the sons of Israel into the land which I swore to them, and I will be with you” (Deut 31:23). That God has commanded Joshua is emphasized again in Josh 1:9: “Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not tremble or be dismayed, for YHWH your God is with you wherever you go.”

¹⁴ In narratological terms, the description of space could reflect the relationships among people in society. For the relevant research, see C. EMMOTT, “Constructing Social Space: Sociocognitive Factors in the Interpretation of Character Relations,” in *Narrative Theory and the Cognitive Sciences* (ed. D. Herman; Stanford, CA: CSLI, 2003), 295–321.

¹⁵ In some other places in the Hebrew Bible, God can also directly command natural phenomena like lightning. Job 36:32 describes God as a warrior: “He covers *his* hands with the lightning, and commands it to strike the mark.” A similar expression is also used in Ps 78:23: “yet he commanded the clouds above, and opened the doors of heaven.” Both “clouds above” and “lightning” are natural phenomena that God can not only control but also command to serve him. A God who can command nature is thus portrayed from the cosmological perspective.

¹⁶ Although God *says* he would create the first woman in Gen 2:18, God speaks only to himself.

you in the garden.”” At the same time, the dialogue indicates that God occupies a certain space in the garden so that he can talk with the first couple.

Whereas use of the verbs “call” and “say” in biblical narratives are numerous and flexible, God does not call to anyone except the first man in the primeval history (Gen 1–11) and does not “call” to anybody in the patriarchal narratives (Gen 12–50). Only in Exodus does God begin to call the people. In most cases, Moses is the one whom God calls, especially in the Sinai pericope:

Then Moses went up to God; YHWH *called* to him *from the mountain* (*וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו יְהוָה מִהָהָר*), saying, “Thus you shall say to the house of Jacob...” (Exod 19:3).

When YHWH *descended upon Mount Sinai*, to the top of the mountain (*וַיֵּרֶד יְהוָה עַל־הָרֹם סִינַי*), YHWH *called* Moses to the top of the mountain (*וַיִּקְרָא יְהוָה לְמֹשֶׁה אֶל־רֹאשׁ הָהָר*), and Moses went up (Exod 19:20).

The glory of YHWH settled on Mount Sinai, and the cloud covered it for six days; on the seventh day he *called* to Moses *out of the cloud* (*וַיִּקְרָא אֶל־מֹשֶׁה בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מִתּוֹךְ הָעָנָן*) (Exod 24:16).

The place from which God calls to Moses is either on the top of the mountain or in the cloud, both of which are high positions. Thus “call” implies that the distance between God and Moses is not short, but also not long. The distance between God and Moses is simply from the earth to the top of the mountain or the sky.

In Exod 19:20, the phrase “YHWH descended upon Mount Sinai” implies that God calls to Moses from the top of the mountain. God resides in a higher position than Mount Sinai so that he needs first to “descend” to the top of Mount Sinai. Moreover, Exod 19:18–19 paves the way for the meeting between YHWH and Moses. Exodus 19:18–19 describes the appearance of God in vivid terms: “now Mount Sinai was all in smoke because YHWH descended upon it in fire, and its smoke ascended like the smoke of a furnace, and the whole mountain quaked violently. When the sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses spoke and God answered him with thunder.” According to this passage, before descending, God can answer Moses only with thunder – a very loud voice. After God descends to the top of the mountain, however, God can “call” to Moses. Another example showing the specific place from which God calls to Moses is Exod 3:4: “When YHWH saw that he turned aside to look, God called to him *from the middle of the bush* (*וַיִּקְרָא אֵלָיו אֱלֹהִים מִתּוֹךְ הַסֵּנֶה*), and said, ‘Moses, Moses!’ And he said, ‘Here I am.’” When God *calls* to someone in biblical narrative, most of time he is not in heaven but in the earthly world. It is only *the angel of God* who calls to people from heaven. For example, the angel of God calls to Hagar from heaven: “And God heard the voice of the boy; and *the angel of God* called to Hagar from heaven (*וַיִּקְרָא מַלְאָךְ אֱלֹהִים*), and said to her, ‘What is the matter, Hagar? Do not be afraid; for God has heard the voice of the boy where he is’” (Gen 21:17). In Gen 22, the sacrifice of Isaac, the angel of God calls Abraham twice from heaven when

Abraham is binding Isaac: “But *the angel of YHWH* called to him from heaven (ויקרא אליו מלאך יהוה מן השמים) and said, ‘Abraham, Abraham!’ And he said, ‘Here I am’” (Gen 22:11) and “*The angel of YHWH* called to Abraham a second time from heaven” (ויקרא מלאך יהוה אל־אברהם שנית מן השמים) (Gen 22:15). All these cases show that it is only the angel of God who calls to people from heaven. When God calls to someone, he is usually in the human world. The verb “call” therefore generally indicates a short distance between God and humanity. When God calls to someone, he is usually in this world and near to his listener.

In Gen 3:9, after calling to the first man, God goes on to say, “Where are you?” The man says, “I hid myself.” Then where is God? “Call to” and “say” is a progressive sequence; the verb “say” may suggest a nearer distance. The verbs “command,” “call,” and “say” taken together thus indicate the distance between God and the first man.

9.1.5. *The Spatial Continuity between Genesis 2–3 and Genesis 4*

We must take into account that the story of Cain and Abel (Gen 4:1–26) is probably the continuation of Gen 2–3. Genesis 2–3 and Gen 4 share a similar narrative theme and can be seen as a whole story about God’s will and humanity’s fall.¹⁷ The narrative scene in Gen 4 is transferred from the first humans in general in the garden in Eden to the relationship between these specific brothers in the family. The social phenomenon of sacrifice triggers the scene of God’s actions towards Cain and Abel.

The continuity between Gen 2–3 and Gen 4 is further supported by structural and terminological parallels between the two passages. Their continuity can also be described in terms of spatial descriptions such as “where” (אי) in Gen 3:9 and Gen 4:9: “But YHWH God called to the man, and said to him, ‘Where are you (איכה)?’” (Gen 3:9) and “Then YHWH said to Cain, ‘Where is your brother Abel (אי הבל אחיך)?’ He said, ‘I do not know; am I my brother’s keeper?’” (Gen 4:9). In Gen 3:9, after the first humans eat the fruit of forbidden tree, God asks the first man “where” he is. The word “where” is also used in Gen 4:9: God asks “where” Abel is after Cain kills him. The use of “where” (אי) expresses that God cannot find Abel. The subject of “where” in Gen 3:9 and Gen 4:9, however, shows a different spatial relationship. The subject of the first use of “where” is the first man. When God asks “where” he is, God does not see him. The subject of “where” in Gen 4:9 is Cain. Genesis 4:14 suggests further that the dialogue between God and Cain is face to face because Cain says to God “I shall be hidden from your face.” Therefore, while Gen 3

¹⁷ For discussion of Gen 2–4 as a whole, see R.G. KRATZ, *Die Komposition der erzählenden Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Uni-Taschenbücher 2157; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2000), 253–62.

merely suggests that God talks to the first humans from close proximity, God talks to Cain face to face in Gen 4.

Another important parallel is found at the end of the stories, where God expels the first man (Gen 3:22–24) and where he expels Cain (Gen 4:12–16). The first man is expelled from the garden in Eden in Gen 3:24 in order to “till the ground from which he was taken” (Gen 3:23). In Gen 4:14, God expels Cain to a place that is much farther away but also more conceptual. Cain is expelled “from the surface of ground.” While the expulsion in Gen 3 is from the garden in Eden to the ground, the expulsion in Gen 4 is from the ground to a state of wandering. After Cain is expelled, he wanders the surface of the earth (Gen 4:12, 14). Compared to Gen 3, the further expulsion of Cain in Gen 4 is described more abstractly and conceptually.

The expulsion of Cain in Gen 4 is also connected with Gen 3 in terms of physical space. It is noteworthy that, while Gen 3:24 describes how God expels the first man, it does not say in which direction the first man is expelled. The direction of the expulsion in Gen 3 is only implied by God’s actions in Gen 3:24. God places the cherubim and a flaming sword at the east side of the garden in order to guard the way to the tree of life. Genesis 4:16, however, is very clear that Cain settles east of Eden. Thus, not only is the subject of expulsion transferred from the first man in a general sense to a specific person, namely Cain, but the spatial context of the expulsion is also transferred from a general space to a specific place in the East.

9.2. Genesis 6–9 and Conceptual Space

The non-Priestly flood narrative contains three important types of conceptual space. The first is the structure of the cosmos. Genesis 6–9 narrates the story of the flood destroying the whole earth, and a certain view of the cosmos is implied. The second type of conceptual space is the scale of the earth. Earth is the most important spatial setting in the flood narrative. How the narrator thinks about the scale of the earth is an important aspect of conceptual space. The third type of conceptual space concerns how the earth is constructed rhetorically through descriptions of the flood; of Noah sending the birds from the ark; and of the earth on which humans, animals, and plants live.

9.2.1. *The Structure of the Cosmos*

The understanding of the cosmos in the non-Priestly flood narrative involves a division into God’s space, the earth, and the sky. First of all, God’s space in the non-Priestly flood narrative is generally presented as a high space. God’s actions are usually relative to the whole earth. Genesis 6:7, for example, de-

scribes how all the creatures on the earth – human beings together with animals, “the creeping things and birds of the sky” – will be destroyed by God. God’s position here is relative to the whole earth. The phrase “birds of the sky” shows that God’s space is higher than not only the earth but also the sky. God’s space as indicated here is therefore beyond the earthly world.

The rain sent by God also implies a particular view of the cosmos. It is with the rain that God destroyed the world. As already discussed, rain in the biblical narratives is generally controlled and sent by God. Genesis 19:24, for example, states explicitly that God sends the rain down from his place in heaven: “YHWH rained brimstone and fire down from heaven on Sodom and Gomorrah” (Gen 19:24). Rain forms a space relative to the earth in the non-Priestly flood narrative, evident in Gen 7:12, 17 in particular. These verses describe how rain falls on the earth for forty days and forty nights and the flood continues for forty days on the earth. There is no water from underground,¹⁸ but the earth is emphasized twice.

Between heaven and the earth is the sky, which is the location of the birds (e.g., Gen 6:7). On the whole, God’s high space, the rain coming from God’s space, the whole earth, and the sky constitute a three-level cosmos in the non-Priestly flood narrative. However, the non-Priestly narrator does not mention the sea or sea life. While the text sometimes states that the creatures God destroys include “every living thing” (e.g., Gen 7:23), sea life is not explicitly mentioned. Even Gen 7:23, which describes in the most detail the kinds of creatures that God destroys, does not mention the sea or the fish in the sea: “He destroyed every living thing that was on the face of the ground, human beings and animals and creeping things and birds of the sky; they were destroyed from the earth (וַיִּמָּח אֶת־כָּל־הַיָּקוּם אֲשֶׁר עַל־פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה מֵאָדָם עַד־רֶמֶשׂ וְעַד־עוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיִּמָּחוּ מִן־הָאָרֶץ). Only Noah was left, and those that were with him in the ark.” In the Priestly flood narrative, the narrator juxtaposes the fish of the sea with “every beast of the earth,” “every bird of the sky,” and “everything that creeps on the ground” (Gen 9:2).¹⁹ It is possible that the non-Priestly narrator intentionally failed to mention the sea and the fish in the sea. One possible reason is that the fish of the sea may not be destroyed by the water formed by the rain and flood. When the water recedes, some water even recedes to the sea. The non-Priestly narrator does not juxtapose the fish in the sea with the other creatures in Gen 7:23.

¹⁸ Cf. “but a mist would rise from the earth, and water the whole face of the ground” (Gen 2:6); “in the six-hundredth year of Noah’s life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on that day all the fountains of the great deep burst forth, and the windows of heaven were opened” (Gen 7:11, P); and “the fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven were closed” (Gen 8:2a, P).

¹⁹ For a comparison of the role of the sea in the Priestly flood narrative with Exod 14, see E. BOSSHARD-NEPUSIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut: Studien zu Text, Kontexten, und Rezeption der Fluterzählung Genesis 6–9* (BWANT 165; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 2005), 130–33.

9.2.2. The Scale of the Earth

The non-Priestly flood narrative pays close attention to the earth. Two different words are used to refer to the earth where humanity and the other creatures live: “earth” is used most frequently, but “ground” also appears several times. The phrases “all the earth” (כל־הארץ) and the words “earth” (ארץ) and “ground” (אדמה) appear thirteen times in the text: Gen 6:5, 6, 7; 7:3, 4, 23; 8:8, 9, 11, 13b, 21, 22.²⁰ Almost every verse in the non-Priestly flood narrative has the word “earth.”

What is the scale of “all the earth” in the non-Priestly flood narrative? What is the structure of the earth? The meaning and the scale of the earth are evident mainly from God’s speeches in Gen 6:7 and Gen 7:4.

So YHWH said, “I will destroy from the *earth* the human beings I have created – people together with animals and creeping things and birds of the sky (ויאמר יהוה אִמְחָה אֶת־הָאָדָם) (אשר־בִּרְאִיתִי מֵעַל פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה מֵאָדָם עַד־בְּהֵמָה עַד־רֶמֶשׂ וְעַד־עוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם) for I regret that I have made them” (Gen 6:7).

For in seven days I will send rain on the *earth* for forty days and forty nights; and every living thing that I have made I will destroy from the face of the ground (כי לַיָּמִים עוֹד שִׁבְעָה) (אֲנִי מִמְטִיר עַל־הָאָרֶץ אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם וָאַרְבָּעִים לַיְלָה וּמַחֲיִיתִי אֶת־כָּל־הַיְּקוּם אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂיתִי מֵעַל פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה) (Gen 7:4).

The phrase “all the earth” in the non-Priestly flood narrative specifically indicates the earth where humans, animals, and creeping things live. It is interesting that the birds in the sky (Gen 6:7) are also included in “the earth.” This is demonstrated particularly in the description of the flood of Gen 7:23: “He destroyed every living thing that was on the face of the *ground*, human beings and animals and creeping things *and birds of the sky* (וְעַד־עוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם); they were blotted out from the *earth* (וַיִּמְחָה מִן־הָאָרֶץ). Only Noah was left, and those that were with him in the ark.” The word “earth” in Gen 7:23 indicates the space in which human beings, animals, creeping things, and birds of the sky live. The word “earth,” for the non-Priestly narrator, is thus used for both the land and the sky. The “earth” here does not include the sea. The description of the water receding in Gen 8:3a and of the drying ground in Gen 8:13b suggests why: “And the waters receded gradually from the *earth*” (וַיִּשְׁבוּ הַמַּיִם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ) (Gen 8:3a) and “Noah removed the covering of the ark, and looked, and saw that the face of the ground was drying” (וַיֵּרָא וְהִנֵּה חָרְבוּ פְנֵי הָאֲדָמָה) (Gen 8:13b). “Earth” in Gen 8:3 cannot include the sea because, according to the logic of the narrative, when the water recedes, it is possible that they do not return to God’s place in heaven. Instead it is more probable that the water recedes from the dry land into the sea and is dried up by the sunshine. Furthermore, in Gen 8:13b, what Noah sees is only the “dry ground.” Therefore, “all the earth” in the non-Priestly flood narrative seems to include only the dry land and the sky.

²⁰ The words “earth” (ארץ) and “ground” (אדמה) both appear in Gen 7:4.

9.2.3. Earth as a Spatial Focus

In Gen 6:5–8, when God decides to destroy the human world, he mentions the earth in almost every sentence (Gen 6:5, 6, 7). According to God's speech, the relative position of all of the creatures that God destroys is on the earth. For example, God says "I will destroy *from the earth* the human beings I have created, people together with animals and creeping things and birds of the sky, for I am sorry that I have made them" (Gen 6:7).

The "earth" is again emphasized in God's speech to Noah in Gen 7:1–5. God says that he will keep "seven pairs of all clean animals, the male and its mate; and a pair of the animals that are not clean, the male and its mate ... alive on the face of *all the earth* (כל־הארץ)," and he will destroy all of the other living things from the face of *the ground* (האדמה). Therefore, the earth becomes the spatial focus of the narrative before the flood.

Take with you seven pairs of all clean animals, the male and its mate; and a pair of the animals that are not clean, the male and its mate; and also seven pairs of the birds of sky, male and female, to keep their kind alive on the face of *all the earth* (לחיות זרע על־פני כל־הארץ) (Gen 7:2–3).

For in seven days I will send rain on the *earth* for forty days and forty nights; and every living thing that I have made I will destroy from the face of the *ground* (ומחיתי את־כל־היקום (אשר עשיתי מעל פני האדמה) (Gen 7:4).

It is noteworthy that Gen 7:3 and Gen 7:4 use two different words – "earth" and "ground" – to refer to the place where the creatures live. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, "ground" (אדמה) is probably used to show that the plants growing up from the ground also belong among living things.²¹ In Gen 7:2–3, 4, however, it seems that "earth" is used to indicate the relative position of the living creatures that God will keep alive, while "ground" is used to indicate the relative position of the creatures God will destroy.

The word "earth" appears repeatedly in the specific descriptions of the flood in Gen 7:12, 17, 22, 23. When describing God sending the rain (Gen 7:12), the narrator does not simply say that the rain fell. Rather, the "earth" is stated to be the place where the rain falls. Immediately after the rain is sent by God, the narrator recounts that the flood continues for forty days on the earth. "Earth" therefore functions as an important noun for describing both the rain and the flood: "*the rain fell on the earth* (ויהי הגשם על־הארץ) for forty days and forty nights" (Gen 7:12) and "*The flood continued for forty days on the earth*" (ויהי (המבול ארבעים יום על־הארץ) (Gen 7:17a). Furthermore, it is interesting that the measurement of the water in the non-Priestly flood narrative is not the high space like the mountains but just the earth itself: "and the waters increased, and

²¹ N.C. BAUMGART, *Die Umkehr des Schöpfungsgottes: Zu Komposition und religionsgeschichtlichem Hintergrund von Gen 5–9* (HBS 22; Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1999), 154–62.

lifted up the ark, and it *rose high above the earth*” (וַיִּרְבּוּ הַמַּיִם וַיִּשְׂאוּ אֶת־הַתֵּבָה (וְתָרַם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ) (Gen 7:17b). Thus, the description of the flood here focuses not on its height but its breadth. The rain is so heavy that the water lifts up the ark, and the scale of the flood is so large that it covers the whole earth.

The earth is still the narrative focus in Gen 7:22–23, which describes how the creatures are destroyed by the flood. In particular, the “dry land” (חֲדָבָה), rather than the “earth” or the “ground,” is described as the relative space of the creatures in order to emphasize how the creatures on the dry ground could not breathe when there is water. Afterwards, the narrator tells how God destroys the living things on the face of the ground. The word referring to the earth in Gen 7:23 is again “ground,” and the narrator tells how God destroys the human beings, animals, and creeping things and birds of the sky on the earth. The ground and the earth here are both presented as the relative spaces of the creatures that God destroys. The narrator might have used “ground” in Gen 7:23 as well, but the term “earth” is used there because of the mention of “birds of the sky.” As discussed, the term “earth” in the non-Priestly flood narrative includes both the earth and the sky, but “ground” indicates only the horizontal earth. Therefore, both “ground” and “earth” are used in connection with the creatures that God destroys: “Everything on the dry land in whose nostrils was the breath of life died. He destroyed every living thing that was on the face of the ground (וַיָּמָח אֶת־כָּל־הַיְּקוּם אֲשֶׁר עַל־פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה) (וַיִּמָּחוּ מִן־הָאָרֶץ), human beings and animals and creeping things and birds of the sky; they were destroyed from the earth (וַיִּמָּחוּ מִן־הָאָרֶץ). Only Noah was left, and those that were with him in the ark” (Gen 7:22–23).

After the flood, when the water recedes, the earth is described as a space relative to heaven: “*The rain from the heaven* was restrained (וַיִּכְלָא הַגֶּשֶׁם מִן־), (הַשָּׁמַיִם), and *the waters* receded gradually *from the earth* (וַיִּשְׁבוּ הַמַּיִם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ (הָלוֹךְ)”) (Gen 8:2b–3a). This is a symmetrical structure. When the rain from heaven is restrained, the water recedes from the earth. The narrator therefore presents a spatial symmetry between the earth and heaven. The rain is the very reason why there is water on the surface of the earth. When the rain is restrained from the heaven, the water recedes from the earth. Genesis 8:6–12, 13b describes how Noah sends out the birds to see whether or not the earth is dry. At this point, the narrative focus is still on the earth even though there is no description of the earth. Noah sends out the birds in order to learn about the state of the earth outside of the ark.

When Noah comes out of the ark after the flood, he builds an altar to God and offers burnt offerings on the altar (Gen 8:20). The earth is still the narrative focus in God’s monologue. Specifically, God says that he will not destroy the earth and living creatures again “as long as the earth endures, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease” (Gen 8:22).

9.3. Genesis 11:1–9 and Conceptual Space

This section discusses three tensions in the representation of space in Gen 11:1–9. First, the Babel narrative contains a tension between God's space and humanity's space. Second, in terms of nature's space, there is a tension between locative place and universal space. Third, there are also tensions among the different elements of humanity's space: the city, the tower, and the whole earth. This section aims to draw attention to how these spatial tensions are rhetorically constructed and how they contribute to the theme of the Babel narrative.

9.3.1. *The Tension between God's Space and Humanity's Space*

It has long been argued that the Babel narrative has a harmonious structure.²² Space, as an important narrative element in Gen 11:1–9, shows a particular tensional structure that is clearly reflected in the description of humanity's space. At the beginning of the narrative, humanity as a whole occupies the same place (Gen 11:1, 2, 4). At the end of the narrative, God disperses them over the whole surface of the earth (Gen 11:8, 9). Humanity's space thus involves a tension between a single place and the whole earth.²³

There is also a tension between God's space and humanity's space. This spatial tension is closely related to the form and structure of the text. The tension between humanity's space and God's space is reflected harmoniously in the textual structure, as key elements of humanity's space and God's space correspond to each other, as shown in Table 6.

The key spatial elements in Gen 11:1 and 9 are the people of the whole earth and the people spread over the surface of the whole earth. There is thus a tension between God's universal space (Gen 11:9) and humanity's universal space (Gen 11:1). This spatial tension is seen particularly in language: in Gen 11:1, the people of the whole earth have one language and the same words, while God confuses the language of the whole earth in Gen 11:9.²⁴

²² U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis. Part Two: From Noah to Abraham* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1964), 231–32; I.M. KIKAWADA, "The Shape of Genesis 1–11," in *Rhetorical Criticism: Essays in Honor of James Muilenburg* (ed. J.J. Jackson and M. Kessler; PTMS 1; Pittsburgh, PA: Pickwick, 1974), 18–32; J.P. FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art in Genesis: Specimens of Stylistic and Structural Analysis* (SSN 17; Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1991), 11–45; and E. van WOLDE, *Words Become Worlds: Semantic Studies of Genesis 1–11* (BibInt 66; Leiden: Brill, 1994), 84–91, 94–104.

²³ JOSEPHUS, *Ant.* 1.113–23 (Thackeray LCL), suggests that the intention of the builders was to gather all the human beings into a centralized location, thereby resisting God's purpose that they should multiply, fill the earth, and subdue it.

²⁴ For discussion of the role of "one language" and "the same word" forming the theme of the Babel narrative about cultural diversity, see T. HIEBERT, "The Tower of Babel and the Origin of the World's Cultures," *JBL* 126 (2007), 29–58, here 33–34.

Table 6. Humanity's Space and God's Space in Genesis 11:1–9

Humanity's Space	God's Space
Gen 11:1	Gen 11:9
Gen 11:2	Gen 11:8
Gen 11:3	Gen 11:7
Gen 11:4	Gen 11:7
Gen 11:5	Gen 11:6
Gen 11:5	Gen 11:5

The key spatial element in Gen 11:2 and 8 is the journey of humanity. Genesis 11:2 describes how humanity journeys from the East, finds a valley in the land of Shinar, and then settles there. God's space in Gen 11:8 is also the valley in the land of Shinar. However, it is God who disperses humanity from the land of Shinar over the whole surface of the earth. Genesis 11:2 and 8 thus show a tension between God's and humanity's space in the land of Shinar.

Genesis 11:3 and 7 also involve a spatial tension in terms of the language. In Gen 11:3, the humans say to one another, "come, let us make bricks and let us fire them." In Gen 11:7, God says to the divine beings, "come, let us go down and let us confuse there their language, so that they may not understand one another's speech."²⁵ Genesis 11:3 and 7 construct a spatial tension between humanity's horizontal space and God's vertical space. Humanity needs the materials for building the city and the tower. The verb "come" and the phrase "let us" vividly show that the humans come from every corner in the valley to the place where they will build the city and the tower. God's space, conversely, is conceived as being vertical. Although God also says "come" and "let us" when he summons divine beings from every corner of the divine council's space, the phrase "go down" emphasizes the vertical space of God. God needs to "go down" in order to enter into contact with humanity on the earth. There is thus a tension between humanity's horizontal space and God's vertical space.

The description of humanity's space in Gen 11:4 is also in tension with God's space in Gen 11:7. Gen 11:4 should be seen as a specific explanation of Gen 11:3. Genesis 11:3 mentions only that humanity makes the building materials. Genesis 11:4, however, states specifically that humanity will build a city and a tower. The word "come" and the phrase "let us" again indicate that humanity occupies a horizontal space. Thus Gen 11:4 and 7 involve a tension between humanity's horizontal space and God's vertical space. It is striking that Gen 11:7 uses the phrase "let us" twice. The first use is "let us go down"

²⁵ God's "let us" is probably intended to mock the words of humanity in Gen 11:3; see FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art* (see n. 22), 14 and CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis. Part Two* (see n. 22), 18–32.

and the second is “let us confuse there their language.” The first “let us” probably corresponds to the “let us” used by humanity in Gen 11:3, and the second “let us” corresponds to the “let us” used by humanity in Gen 11:4.

Genesis 11:5–6 describe God’s actions. Humanity’s actions are reflected in God’s direct speech. The space in which their actions occur involves a tension between God’s space and humanity’s space. God comes down from a high position to see the city and the tower. Then, through God’s direct speech in Gen 11:6, the narrator describes what the humans are doing in the valley in the land of Shinar. God emphasizes again that there is one people and that they have one language.²⁶ There is, therefore, also a tension between humanity’s horizontal space and God’s vertical space in Gen 11:5–6.

Genesis 11:5, the midpoint of the Babel narrative, also involves a tension between God’s space and humanity’s space. As discussed, although God comes down in Gen 11:5, the place where he stops is the place where the divine council meets. But the second part of Gen 11:5 also refers to humanity’s space: the city and the tower built by humans. Humanity’s actions and space are seen by God from a high position, and this is shown from God’s perspective. Thus, in a single verse, Gen 11:5, there is also a tension between God’s vertical space and humanity’s horizontal space.

The tension between God’s space and humanity’s space is therefore constructed by means of the textual structure. In this spatial frame, God and humanity each have their own space. While God can come down to see the city and tower and control the whole earth, the earthly space is reflected primarily in the actions of humanity. Moreover, the text does not even explicitly state that God comes down to the earth. There is no specific description of God’s actions on earth. All of God’s actions seem to occur in a high position. At the same time, all humanity’s actions in the Babel narrative are limited to the earth.

9.3.2. *The Tension between Locative Place and Universal Space*

Both God’s actions and humanity’s actions in the Babel narrative are associated with nature’s spaces like the sky, the valley in the land of Shinar, and the whole earth. While there are not many natural spatial settings, they play an important role. From the perspective of nature’s space, the most important spatial relationship in the Babel narrative is the tension between locative place and universal space. The whole story shows such a spatial tension: humanity wants to stay in one place, the valley in the land of Shinar, while God wants to make

²⁶ The word “people” (עַם) in the Hebrew Bible generally suggests a group having kinship. For use of the word “people” in biblical narrative, see F.M. CROSS, *From Epic to Canon: History and Literature in Ancient Israel* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998), 11–13 and E.A. SPEISER, “‘People’ and ‘Nation’ of Israel,” *JBL* 79 (1960), 157–63.

humanity spread out throughout the whole earth. How is this spatial tension constructed rhetorically?

The tension between locative place and universal space is evident in the spatial settings and the use of motion verbs. The tensions among spatial settings can be described in terms of the following five contrasts: 1) “one language in one place” (כל־הארץ שפה אחת ודברים אחדים) versus “the confused language on the whole earth” (בלל יהוה שפת כל־הארץ ומשם הפיצם יהוה על־פני כל־הארץ); 2) “from the east” (מקדם) versus “found a valley” (ימצאו בקעה); 3) the “valley” (בקעה) versus “the land of Shinar” (ארץ שניער); 4) God’s heaven, implied by “come down” (ירד) versus “all the earth” (כל־הארץ); and 5) humanity’s “city, tower” (עיר ומגדל) versus “all the earth” (כל־הארץ).

The spatial tension between “one language in one place” and “confused language on the whole earth” can be found in Gen 11:1–2 and Gen 11:8–9. Genesis 11:1 talks of the whole earth on which humanity lives, while Gen 11:2 narrows the spatial setting, describing how the human race journeys from the East and finds the valley in the land of Shinar. Thus Gen 11:1 and 2 emphasize that humanity has the same language and stays in the same place. This situation is disrupted by God in Gen 11:8–9, when he disperses humanity from the valley in the land of Shinar over the whole surface of the earth and confuses the language of humanity.²⁷ This tension is emphasized in Gen 11:8–9 by the triple use of locative adverb “there” (שם). It is specifically from “there” that God disperses the early humans over the whole surface of the earth (Gen 11:8, 9), from “there” that God confuses their language (Gen 11:9). The tension between the specific places “the valley in Shinar” and “the whole earth” is thus shown in Gen 11:1–2 and Gen 11:8–9.²⁸

The tension between “from the east” (מקדם) and “found a valley” in Gen 11:2 is reflected in use of the motion verbs “journeyed” (נסע), “found” (מצא), and “settled” (ישב). When the early humans “journeyed from the East,” they “found” a valley in the land of Shinar, and they “settled” there. The use of three motion verbs – “journey,” “find,” and “settle” – suggests a spatial continuity. At the same time, there is a tension between “journey” and “settle.” While the narrator does not state for how long and in what way they journey, the verb “found” implies that they journey a long time from the East before they find a place to settle.

The place where humanity settles is specifically described in Gen 11:2 as “the valley in the land of Shinar.” The phrase “the valley in the land of Shinar” describes two spatial settings: the valley and the land of Shinar. The valley is in the land of Shinar, hence the land of Shinar is broader than the valley. Together, they construct a spatial tension. This tension is important to the theme

²⁷ For the history of interpretation of the verb בלל, see HIEBERT, “Tower” (see n. 24), 48–49.

²⁸ Ibid., 49.

of the Babel narrative because it implies that the early humans wander for a long time in the land of Shinar rather than in other areas.

Nature's spaces in which God's actions occur are mainly the high place, which is probably heaven, and the whole earth. The use of the verb "come down" shows that God acts from a high position. However, there is no clear description of God's space on earth. God's space on earth is indicated only in the description of the consequences of his intervention (Gen 11:8–9): "from there" God confuses the language of humanity, and "from there" he disperses them over the whole surface of the earth.

This tension between locative place and universal space is particularly evident in Gen 11:4, which states that the humans want to build themselves a city and a tower with its top in the sky and make a name for themselves so that they would not be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth. The particle *כִּי* 'so that not' clearly shows that they want to stay in one place and not be dispersed over the whole earth.²⁹ They avoid this by building the city and the tower. Thus there is also a tension between the city and the tower, as locative places, and the whole earth.

9.3.3. *The Tensions among the City, the Tower, and the Whole Earth*

The Babel narrative involves two remarkable human spaces: the city and the tower.³⁰ The tower is described as having "its top in the sky." The tension between these two human spaces and nature's space is evident mainly in humanity's purpose in building them and in their function.

What was humanity's aim in building the city and the tower in the valley in the land of Shinar? The humans build the city and the tower in order to avoid being dispersed over the whole surface of the earth. First, the narrative focus becomes increasingly narrower in Gen 11:1–4. In Gen 11:1, the narrator states that all the people of the earth speak the same language and, in Gen 11:2, that they start journeying from the East and settle in a valley in the land of Shinar. Until this point, the narrator has not said what they will do. In Gen 11:3, the people start talking and exhort each other to come to make bricks. The narrator still keeps silent about their ultimate project. Then Gen 11:4 explains clearly that they are going to build for themselves a city and a tower reaching up into the sky and also make a name for themselves. Their aim is expressed by the causal clause "so that" they will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth.

There is an exegetical difficulty with the relationship between "building for ourselves a city and tower" and "making a name for ourselves." It seems that

²⁹ For a discussion about the aim of humanity in Gen 11:4, see *ibid.*, 35–36.

³⁰ Compared to the city, the tower is key in discussions of the theme of the Babel narrative in most traditional exegeses; see J.L. KUGEL, "The Tower of Babel," in *Traditions of the Bible: A Guide to the Bible as It Was at the Start of the Common Era* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1998), 228.

“making a name for themselves” is one motive for “building the city and tower.” According to the narrative form, however, “make a name” should also be a human project because of the phrase “let us” in Gen 11:4: “Come, *let us* build for ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the sky (וַיֹּאמְרוּ הִבֵּה נִבְנֶה־לָנוּ), and *let us* make a name for ourselves (וְנַעֲשֶׂה־לָנוּ שֵׁם), so that we will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth.” If the first “let us” is an exhortation to action on the part of humanity, the second “let us” in Gen 11:4 should also be restricted to describing an action rather than an aim. The aim of humanity in undertaking to build such a city and a tower, together with making the name for themselves, is clearly suggested by the causal clause “*so that* they will not be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth.” There is thus a clear tension between the “city, tower” and “the whole earth.” This tension runs through Gen 11:5–9. In Gen 11:5, God comes down to see the city and the tower. Then, in Gen 11:6, God clearly states that his motive is to confuse the language of humanity: “There is now one people and they all have one language. This is what they have begun to do, and now all that they plan to do will be possible for them.” In Gen 11:8 and 9, God confuses the language of humanity and disperses the humans, who build the city and the tower, over the whole surface of the earth.

Chapter 10

Symbolic Space in Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

This section discusses how symbolic space is constructed rhetorically in Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly flood narrative in Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9, and how the social dimension of the narrative is reflected in the descriptions of space.

The most important symbolic space in Gen 2–3 is the garden. The most important elements of the garden setting are the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. The symbolic meanings of the trees are suggested by the text itself in Gen 3:22. The garden in Eden has long been perceived as a symbolic representation of the Jerusalem Temple, Jerusalem, or the land promised by God.¹ In my view, the garden symbolizes a place near Jerusalem. This is supported primarily by descriptions of the four rivers. At the same time, the garden in Eden is a mixture of both geographical and nongeographical elements. The cherubim placed by God set apart the garden in Eden as a sacred space. After discussing these things, I shall then draw attention to how the contemporary intellectual and political context might have influenced the symbolic meanings of the garden.

The non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 involves three important symbolic spaces. First, the spatial settings in God's speech in Gen 7:1–5, through their spatial correspondence with Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23, symbolize God's absolute authority over the earth. The second space is the ark from which Noah sends out the birds. Third, the altar built by Noah after the flood is given symbolic meaning by God's monologue.

The spatial settings, in particular the city and the tower, in Gen 11:1–9 have rich symbolic meanings. I will discuss how they are used symbolically to show

¹ For the symbolism of the garden as temple, see, e.g., W. RICHTER, "Urgeschichte und Hoftheologie," *BZ NF* 10 (1966), 96–105; K. JAROŠ, "Die Motive der Heiligen Bäume und der Schlange in Gen 2–3," *ZAW* 92 (1980), 204–15, here 212; JAROŠ, "Bildmotive in der Paradieserzählung," *BL* 51 (1978), 5–11; and O. KEEL, *Die Welt der altorientalischen Bildsymbolik und das Alte Testament: Am Beispiel der Psalmen* (Zürich: Benziger; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1972), 104–5, 122. For the symbolism of the garden as Jerusalem, see, e.g., M.A. FISHBANE, *Text and Texture: Close Readings of Selected Biblical Texts* (New York: Schocken, 1979), 111–20. For the symbolism of the garden as promised land, see, e.g., M. OTTOSSON, "Eden and the Land of Promise," in *Congress Volume, Jerusalem 1986* (ed. J.A. Emerton; VTSup 40; Leiden: Brill, 1988), 177–88 and W. BERG, "Israels Land, der Garten Gottes: Der Garten als Bild des Heils im Alten Testament," *BZ* 32 (1988), 35–51.

the power of humanity and how the functions of city and tower themselves are exaggerated in order to build up the themes of hubris and punishment. I will discuss three aspects: the appropriation of cities in the primeval history (Gen 1–11), the function of the tower, and the possible sociopolitical situation reflected, for example, in the diversity of language and humanity.

10.1. Genesis 2–3 and Symbolic Space

As an etiological narrative, the space and spatial settings in Gen 2–3 have an essential connection with its symbolism, which is well known. I will discuss these symbolic spaces, especially the garden in Eden, in three sections. First, the description of the four rivers in Gen 2:10–14 is the key clue that helps us to locate the garden near Jerusalem. At the same time, the description of the four rivers shows both locative and nonlocative dimensions. Second, the cherubim symbolize the sacredness of the garden in Eden. Third, I will discuss how the contemporary intellectual and political context of rebuilding the temple around 515 BCE might have influenced the symbolism of the Eden narrative.

10.1.1. The Four Rivers in the Garden (Genesis 2:10–14) and Jerusalem

10.1.1.1. The Four Rivers in Genesis 2:10–14

Genesis 2–3 pays close attention to specific places, like Eden, the garden, and the rivers and trees in the middle of the garden. Among these, it is possible that the garden symbolizes a sacred place near Jerusalem. The expulsion from the garden in Eden may therefore symbolize the loss of the land of Judah and Israel after the fall of Samaria (722 BCE) and Jerusalem (587/586 BCE). This is further supported by description of the four rivers in the garden in Gen 2:10–14.

The intention of the narrator in adding Gen 2:10–14 was to show that the garden is not in remote time and space as, for example, Gen 2:4b–9 shows. Rather, the garden is near Jerusalem. After all, the garden in Eden as a whole is described as an “other” world in Gen 2–3. There are few narratives about the geographical location and the topography of the garden in Eden. The location of the garden in Gen 2:4b–9 is basically said to be a remote time and a space that is difficult to locate. Other passages in the Eden narrative contain quite a few geographical elements – the four rivers, in particular – that could help us to locate the garden.²

² For discussion of the four rivers from the perspective of biblical geography, see T.B. DOZEMAN, “Biblical Geography and Critical Spatial Studies,” in *Constructions of Space I: Theory, Geography, and Narrative* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 481; New York: T&T Clark, 2007), 87–108, here 98–100. For discussion of the four rivers in cosmo-

A river flows out of Eden to water the garden, and from there it divides and becomes four branches. The name of the first is Pishon (שם האחד פישון); it is the one that flows around the whole land of Havilah (הוא הסבב את כל-ארץ החוילה אשר-שם הזהב), where there is gold; and the gold of that land is good; bdellium and onyx stone are there. The name of the second river is Gihon (ושם-הנהר השני גיחון); it is the one that flows around *the whole land* of Cush (הוא הסובב את כל-ארץ כוש). The name of the third river is Tigris (ושם הנהר השלישי חדקל), which flows *east of Assyria* (הוא ההלך קדמת אשור). And the fourth river is the Euphrates (והנהר הרביעי הוא פרת) (Gen 2:10–14).

Four rivers are described: the Pishon, the Gihon, the Tigris, and the Euphrates. All four rivers can be located geographically, and none is far from Jerusalem.³

10.1.1.1.1. Pishon

The Pishon can be located east of Egypt and probably on the way to Assyria, because the land “Havilah” that the Pishon circles is mentioned in Gen 25:18 and 1 Sam 15:7: “And they settled from Havilah to Shur, which is opposite Egypt in the direction of Assyria (וישכנו מחוילה עד-שור אשר על-פני מצרים באכה); he settled over against all his people” (Gen 25:18) and “Saul defeated the Amalekites, from Havilah as far as Shur, which is opposite Egypt (ויך שאול את-עמלק מחוילה בואך שור אשר על-פני מצרים)” (1 Sam 15:7). In Gen 25:18, “settled from Havilah to Shur” suggests that the whole land from Havilah to Shur is opposite Egypt and also on the way to Assyria. Havilah is thus a place between Egypt and Assyria. It is also implied in 1 Sam 15:7 that Havilah is not too far from Shur, which is east of Egypt. Thus, even though the Pishon is mentioned only once in the Hebrew Bible, it can be located on the way from Egypt to Assyria. Because Havilah is opposite Egypt, the river flowing around it should be to the south of Jerusalem.

10.1.1.1.2. Gihon

The Gihon is the second river described in Gen 2:10–14. It can be located with reference to the land of Cush that it circles. The river Gihon flows around the

logical terms, see T. STORDALEN, “Heaven on Earth – Or Not?: Jerusalem as Eden in Biblical Literature,” in *Beyond Eden: The Biblical Story of Paradise (Genesis 2–3) and Its Reception History* (ed. K. Schmid and C. Riedweg; FAT 34; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2008), 28–57, here 39–40. T.N.D. METTINGER, *The Eden Narrative: Literary and Religio-Historical Study of Genesis 2–3* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 2007), 27–28 argues that Gen 3:10–14 is an exception given that the plot of the Eden narrative is unified. He believes that the passage about the rivers aims to suggest that the garden is on a mountain.

³ M. DIETRICH, “Das biblische Paradies und der babylonische Tempelgarten: Überlegungen zur Lage des Gartens Eden,” in *Das biblische Weltbild und seine altorientalischen Kontexte* (ed. B. Janowski and B. Ego; FAT 32; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2001), 280–323, here 302–20 and J. DAY, *Yahweh and the Gods and Goddesses of Canaan* (JSOTSup 265; Sheffield: Sheffield Academic, 2000), 29–31 use the passage about the four rivers to locate the garden geographically.

whole land of Cush. Cush in the biblical texts is usually not described in geographical terms. In most cases it is a personal name that refers to the eldest son of Ham (Gen 10:6–8; 1 Chr 1:8–10) or the nation of Cush (2 Kgs 19:9; Isa 20:3–5; 43:3). The Cush in Ezek 29:10, however, is described in geographical terms: “Therefore, behold, I am against you and against your rivers, and I will make the land of Egypt an utter waste and desolation, from Migdol to Syene and even to *the border of Cush* (ממגדל סונה ועד־גבול כוש).” Cush in Ezek 29:10 appears with the expression “the border of.” Thus, the Cush here is a geographical term. Whereas Ezek 29:10 still does not mention of the location of Cush, Ezek 30:4–5, 9 and 38:5 suggest that Cush is not far from Egypt.

And a sword will come upon Egypt, and anguish will be in *Cush*, when the slain fall in Egypt (ובאה חרב במצרים והיתה חלחלה בכוש בנפל חלל במצרים), and they take away her wealth, and her foundations are torn down. *Cush*, Put, Lud, all Arabia, Libya, and the people of the land that is in league will fall with them by the sword (כוש ופוט ולוד וכל־הערב וכוב ובני ארץ הברית) (אתם בחרב יפלו) (Ezek 30:4–5).

On that day messengers will go out from me in ships to frighten secure *Cush*; and anguish will be on them as on the day of Egypt (ביום ההוא יצאו מלאכים מלפני בעים להחריד את־כוש) (בשח והיתה חלחלה בהם ביום מצרים); for, behold, it comes! (Ezek 30:9).

Persia, *Cush*, and Put with them, all of them with shield and helmet (פרס כוש ופוט אתם כלם) (מגן וכובע) (Ezek 38:5).

In Ezek 30:4–5, 9 and 38:5, the nations of Egypt, Put, and Libya appear quite often with Cush, suggesting that Cush is probably not far from Egypt. The Gihon thus should be located somewhere in this region. Furthermore, in some biblical texts, the water of the Gihon can be used to locate the city of Jerusalem:

It was Hezekiah who closed the upper outlet of *the waters of Gihon* and directed them down to the west side of the city of David (והוא יחזקיהו סתם את־מוצא מימי גיחון העליון ויישרם למטה) (מערה לעיר דוד) (Hezekiah succeeded in all his works (2 Chr 32:30)).

After this he built an outer wall for the city of David *west of Gihon*, in the valley, reaching the entrance at the Fish Gate (ואחרי־כן בנה חומה חיצונה לעיר־דוד מערבה לגיחון בנחל ולבוא) (בשער הדגים); he carried it around Ophel, and raised it to a very great height. He also put commanders of the army in all the fortified cities in Judah (2 Chr 33:14).

In 2 Chr 32:30 and 33:14, the river Gihon is connected with the city of David (i.e., Jerusalem). The river Gihon is described as being to the east of Jerusalem, and it can supply water to Jerusalem.

10.1.1.1.3. *Tigris and Euphrates*

Descriptions of the third and fourth rivers, the Tigris and Euphrates, are concise. Fewer words are used to describe the Tigris and the Euphrates than the Pishon and the Gihon. The Tigris is described only as flowing *east of Assyria*. And the Euphrates is not described at all. Both rivers, however, are well known geographically as the two rivers flowing through Mesopotamia. It therefore

seems that the Tigris and the Euphrates are more familiar to the readers, such that the narrator does not need to write much about them.⁴

The descriptions of the rivers in Gen 2:10–14 might have been inspired by the descriptions of the rivers in Ezek 47:1–12. While the Eden narrative is connected to some other biblical texts (e.g., Isa 51:3; Joel 2:3),⁵ only passages in Ezekiel allude clearly to Gen 2–3 in terms of the garden. The two important passages describing Eden in Ezekiel are Ezek 28 and 31.⁶ Furthermore, Ezek 36:35 clearly states that Jerusalem is like the garden in Eden. Ezekiel was written by the Priestly circle and is an exilic work; concerned with the sanctuary, it describes an as-yet-unbuilt temple in Jerusalem.⁷ Ezekiel 47:1–12 describes, in the first person, a river that flows around the temple. This passage was probably taken over by the narrator of Gen 2–3. The description of four rivers in the garden may have been taken by the narrator of Gen 2–3 to indicate that the garden is also near Jerusalem.

Therefore, while the other passages about Eden show that the garden in Eden cannot be located and is even in a remote place, Gen 2:10–14 suggests that the

⁴ DOZEMAN, “Biblical Geography” (see n. 2), 98.

⁵ The terminology used to talk about Eden is important for discussing the connection between the Eden narrative and other biblical texts. The phrases denoting Eden in the Hebrew Bible are: עֵדֶן ‘Eden’ (Gen 2:8, 10; 4:16); גֵּן יְהוָה ‘YHWH’s Garden’ (Gen 13:10; see also Isa 51:3); גֵּן אֱלֹהִים ‘God’s Garden’ (Ezek 28:13; 31:8, 16, 18); גֵּן בְּעֵדֶן ‘Garden of/in Eden’ (Gen 2:8); and גֵּן עֵדֶן ‘Garden-Eden’ (Gen 2:15; 3:23, 24; see also Ezek 36:35 and Joel 2:3). Most of the texts date to the late Babylonian or Persian periods. For more details, see T. STORDALEN, *Echoes of Eden: Genesis 2–3 and Symbolism of the Eden Garden in Biblical Hebrew Literature* (CBET 25; Leuven: Peeters, 2000), 320. For the connection between the Eden narrative and Isaiah, see E. HAAG, “Der Weg zum Baum des Lebens: Ein Paradiesmotiv im Buch Jesaja,” in *Künder des Wortes: Beiträge zur Theologie der Propheten. Josef Schreiner zum 60. Geburtstag* (ed. L. Ruppert and E. Zenger; Würzburg: Echter, 1982), 32–52.

⁶ H. GUNKEL, *Genesis: übersetzt und erklärt* (HKAT 1/1; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1977), 7, 24, 34; E. HAAG, “Ez 31 und die alttestamentliche Paradiesvorstellung,” in *Wort, Lied und Gottesspruch, Beiträge zu Psalmen und Propheten. Festschrift für Joseph Ziegler* (ed. J. Schreiner; FB 2; Würzburg: Echter 1972), 171–78; H.N. WALLACE, *The Eden Narrative* (HSM 32; Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1985), 72, 115, 185; and A. BROCK-UTNE, *Der Gottesgarten: Eine vergleichende religionsgeschichtliche Studie* (Avhandlingar utgitt av det Norske Videnskaps-Akademi i Oslo 2, Hist.-Filos. Klasse 2/1935; Oslo: Dybwad, 1936), 120–27. For discussion of the connection between Gen 2–3 and Ezek 28, see GUNKEL, *Genesis* (see n. 6), 34–35; STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 5), 332–56, 394–97; M. WITTE, *Die biblische Urgeschichte: Redaktion- und theologiegeschichtliche Beobachtungen zu Genesis 1,11–11,26* (BZAW 265; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1998), 241–42; and K. SCHMID, “Die Unteilbarkeit der Weisheit: Überlegungen zur sogenannten Paradieserzählung Gen 2f. und ihrer theologischen Tendenz,” *ZAW* 114 (2002), 21–39, here 36–37. For Eden in Ezek 31, see STORDALEN, *Echoes* (see n. 5), 391–93.

⁷ For commentary on Ezekiel, see W. ZIMMERLI, *Ezechiel* (BK XIII/1.2; Neukirchen-Vluyn: Neukirchener Verlag, 1969).

location of the garden is on the way between Egypt and Assyria, and that the garden is not far from Jerusalem.

10.1.1.2. Juxtaposition of Geographical and Nongeographical Dimensions

Genesis 2:10–14 cannot be used in a straightforward way to locate the garden because the narrative elements in Gen 2:10–14 juxtapose geographical and nongeographical dimensions of the rivers. The narrator probably intended to make the garden simultaneously geographical and nongeographical in order to convey a notion of the garden as the “other” space. This is suggested by the different writing styles used in the description of the rivers Pishon and Gihon and the rivers Tigris and Euphrates.

First, whereas Gen 2:10–14 states that the rivers Pishon, Gishon, and Tigris cover their own particular land, “the whole land of Havilah” (כל־ארץ החוילה) of Pishon and “the whole land of Cush” (כל־ארץ כוש) of Gihon are figurative. The phrases “the whole land of Havilah” and “the whole land of Cush” could hardly be understood geographically. The description of the Tigris, however, is more concrete. The river Tigris flows “east” of Assyria. The cardinal word “east” is more geographical, suggesting that the river Tigris is to the north of Jerusalem. Compared to “the whole land of Havilah” and “the whole land of Cush,” “east” implies an anthropological perspective and emphasizes the physical geographical location. Second, the rivers Pishon, Gishon, and Tigris need to be located with reference to the land they cover. There is no mention of the place covered by the Euphrates.

The description of rivers in Gen 3:10–14 is thus simultaneously geographical and nongeographical. While some spatial elements used to describe the four rivers like “Havilah,” “Cush,” “Tigris,” “east of Assyria,” and “Euphrates” can be located, others like “Pishon,” “the whole land” of Havilah, “Gihon,” and “the whole land” of Cush cannot be located directly. And when the narrator needs to locate the rivers of Pishon and Gihon geographically, he uses the expression the “whole land” to make the location figurative. In the light of these considerations, the garden in Eden is both locative and nonlocative, as illustrated in the Table 7.⁸ The narrator probably had a map of the complex of the four rivers in mind. However, he intends, by juxtaposing locative and nonlocative ideas, to make the garden in Eden both locative and nonlocative. The garden is therefore not only set as the center of the earthly world but also placed directly between Egypt and Assyria. The descriptions of rivers in Gen 2:10–14 imply that the garden is in the land of Judah and Israel, just near Jerusalem.

⁸ STORDALEN, “Heaven” (see n. 2), 49 puts it this way: Eden is simultaneously locative and utopian.

10.1.2. Cherubim and Sacred Space

The use of gardens as cultic sites in Mesopotamian culture and religion has long been taken for granted.⁹ According to Assyrian sources, some gardens were connected with the temple.¹⁰ With respect to the Eden narrative, the garden has long been seen as a symbol of a cultic place, the Solomonic Temple in particular.¹¹ The most important reasons are that God appears in the garden and the cherubim are mentioned in Gen 3:24 at the end of the narrative. However, God can appear freely in any place, and there are many places where God and humans meet. The temple in particular is conceived as the earthly abode of God (e.g., 1 Kgs 8:13; 2 Chr 6:2). Although God appears and walks in the garden, Gen 2–3 does not clearly describe the garden in Eden as God’s earthly abode.

The cherubim seem more persuasive than God’s appearance in the garden for arguing that the garden symbolizes the temple.¹² The cherubim described in Gen 3:24 have long been taken as evidence that the garden symbolizes the temple.¹³ In the biblical narrative, the word “cherubim” is used most frequently in the temple narrative. Cherubim are indispensable spatial elements of the cultic sanctuary, like the ark, the tabernacle, or the temple (see Num 7:89; 2 Sam

Table 7. Locative and Nonlocative Four Rivers in Genesis 2:10–14

Rivers	Locative	Non-Locative
Pishon	Havilah	River Pishon, The whole land of Havilah
Gihon	Cush	River Gihon, The whole land of Cush
Tigris	River Tigris, East of Assyria	
Euphrates	River Euphrates	

⁹ G. WIDENGREN, *The King and the Tree of Life in Ancient Near Eastern Religion (King and Saviour IV)* (UUA 4; Uppsala: Lundequistska Bokhandeln; Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1951) and E.W. ANDRAE, “Der Kultische Garten,” *WO* 1 (1947/52), 485–94.

¹⁰ D.J. WISEMAN, “Palace and Temple Gardens in the Ancient Near East,” in *Monarchies and Socio-Religious Traditions in the Ancient Near East. Papers Read at the Thirty-First Interpretational Congress of Human Sciences in Asia and North Africa* (ed. M. Takahito; BMECCJ 1; Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1984), 43.

¹¹ G.J. WENHAM, “Sanctuary Symbolism in the Garden of Eden Story,” in *Proceedings of the Ninth World Congress of Jewish Studies, Division A: The Period of the Bible* (Jerusalem: World Union of Jewish Studies, 1986), 19–25.

¹² JAROŠ, “Die Motive” (see n. 1), 212 and JAROŠ, “Bildmotive” (see n. 1), 5–11 argues that the cherubs, the sacred tree, and the river mirrored cultic symbols from the Solomonic Temple court.

¹³ J.C. GERTZ, “Von Adam zu Enosch: Überlegungen zur Entstehungsgeschichte von Gen 2–4,” in *Gott und Mensch im Dialog: Festschrift für Otto Kaiser zum 80. Geburtstag* (ed. M. Witte; BZAW 345; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2004), 215–36.

6:2; Isa 37:16; Pss 80:2 and 99:1; 1 Chr 13:6 and 28:12; Exod 25:18–22 and 37:18; 1 Kgs 6:23–35 and 7:29, 36; Ezek 9:3; and 2 Chr 3:8–15 and 5:7). Thus it seems plausible that the garden has a natural connection with the temple or other sanctuary.¹⁴

Yet the cherubim show up very late in the Eden narrative. They are mentioned only once, in the last line: “And he drove out the man; and he placed the cherubim at the east of the garden of Eden, and a sword flaming and turning to guard the way to the tree of life” (וַיִּגְרֶשׁ אֶת־הָאָדָם וַיִּשָּׂכֵן מִקֶּדֶם לְגִן־עֵדֶן אֶת־הַכְּרֻבִּים) (Gen 3:24). God places the cherubim to the east of the garden in Eden only after he expels the first couple from the garden. If the narrator intended to make the cherubim a symbol of the temple, he should have made God place the cherubim at the very beginning, when God plants the garden in Eden. Furthermore, the reference to the river Gihon already suggests that the garden is not in the city of Jerusalem, so it is unlikely that the cherubim are the symbol of the Jerusalem Temple.

It is also important to note that the cherubim are placed not by humans but by God himself. The cherubim are not described as being on the mountain, where the Jerusalem Temple is. The cherubim are placed by God to the east of the garden. They are thus located somewhere near Jerusalem rather than in Jerusalem itself. So cherubim do not function in the garden the same way they do in the temple. In the Eden narrative, the cherubim prevent the humans from getting back into the garden and thus prevent humanity from acquiring immortality.¹⁵ The temple narratives contain no descriptions of cherubim with a similar function.

The function of the cherubim is therefore probably just to relate the garden to the land of Judah and Israel and make the garden a sacred space.¹⁶ The garden, an “other” space, becomes sacred through the cherubim placed by God. Specifically, the cherubim placed to the east of the garden in Eden establish the distinction between sacred space and secular space. In the garden in Eden, humanity is close to God. After the expulsion from the garden, in secular space, humanity becomes responsible for itself.

¹⁴ C. MEYERS, “Cherubim,” *ABD* 1:899–900.

¹⁵ For discussion of immortality in the Eden narrative, see K. SCHMID, “Loss of Immortality?: Hermeneutical Aspects of Genesis 2–3 and Its Early Reception,” in *Beyond Eden: The Biblical Story of Paradise (Genesis 2–3) and Its Reception History* (ed. K. Schmid and C. Riedweg; FAT 34; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2008), 58–78.

¹⁶ For the connection between the cherubim in Gen 2–3 and those in Ezekiel, see M.A. FISHBANE, *Biblical Myth and Rabbinic Mythmaking* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), 87–88.

10.1.3. *The Garden in Eden and Rebuilding the Temple*

How might the contemporary social and political context have influenced the symbolism of the garden in Eden? I should like to suggest that the symbolism of the garden in Eden may have been influenced by the event of rebuilding the temple around 515 BCE.

According to 2 Kgs 24:13–14, the temple was destroyed by the Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar in 587 BCE.

And he carried off all the treasures of the house of YHWH, and the treasures of the king's house, cut in pieces all the vessels of gold in the temple of YHWH, which Solomon, king of Israel, had made, all this as YHWH had said. He carried away all Jerusalem, all the officers, all the warriors, ten thousand captives, all the artisans and the smiths; no one remained, except the poorest people of the land.

After the fall of Jerusalem and the temple, the Israelites were scattered to different places like Babylonia, Persia, and Egypt. In 538 BCE, Cyrus the Great (600/576–530 BCE) made his famous decree, allowing some of the exiled Israelites to return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:1–4, 7–8; 3:7; 5:13, 14, 17; 6:3, 22). Chronicles, Ezra, and Nehemiah are three important sources for understanding this event. Ezra 1:1–4 and 2 Chr 36:22–23 clearly narrate that the Jewish exiles returned to Jerusalem following the issuance of a decree by Cyrus.

From the perspective of the priests, the construction, maintenance, and control of the temple may have had broad social and political implications. The non-Priestly narrator of Gen 2–3, however, reinterprets the relationship among the land, temple, God, and the Israelites in symbolic terms. The narrator of Gen 2–3 has no intention of making the garden in Eden a geographical entity like the land of Judah and Israel, but he emphasizes thematically that the land of Judah and Israel is no longer the land promised by God. That former promised land, together with the temple, has already been lost. The temple and the priestly rules do not play an important role in the Eden narrative. Genesis 2–3 does not mention the temple. Rather, it uses the cherubim, a part of the temple, to make the garden a sacred space and set a boundary between the sacred and secular space.

The narrator of Gen 2–3 shows strong interest in interpreting contemporary life without the temple in etiological terms. After the expulsion from the garden in Eden, the distance between God and humanity becomes large. But Humanity acquires knowledge and becomes self-determined.

10.2. Genesis 6–9 and Symbolic Space

The non-Priestly flood narrative involves three main types of symbolic space. First, the spatial settings in God's speech in Gen 7:1–5, through their spatial

correspondence with Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23, symbolize God's absolute authority over the earth. Second, in Gen 8:6–13b, Noah sends the raven and the dove out from the ark to see if the land is dry. At this point, the ark corresponds to the human world outside. Symbolically, the ark is at this moment the center of the world. Third, after the flood, the first thing on earth that is described is the altar. God gives a monologue beside the altar which gives it symbolic meaning.

10.2.1. Symbolic Meanings of Spatial Settings in Genesis 7:1–5

God makes three speeches in the non-Priestly flood narrative: Gen 6:5–8; 7:1–5; and 8:20–22. It has been long discussed whether the speeches of Gen 6:5–8 and Gen 8:20–22 constitute an *inclusio*.¹⁷ Although Gen 6:5–8 and Gen 8:20–22 correspond to each other, the speech in Gen 7:1–5 is also indispensable for the narrative. In this speech, God tells Noah exactly how he will destroy and then save the world. The space and spatial settings mentioned in this speech basically correspond to the spatial settings in following narrative (Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23). Symbolically, the spatial correspondence between Gen 7:1–5 and the flood descriptions in Gen 7:2, 27, 22, and 23 shows God's total authority over the world. The spatial settings God destroys are exactly what God said he would destroy.

God's speech in Gen 7:1–5 is very long compared to his other speeches in the flood narrative, and even to those in the whole primeval history (Gen 1–11). In Gen 7:1–5, God first commands Noah to go into the ark and tells Noah why he will save him. Then God tells Noah specifically how he will first destroy and then save the world. In order to save the world, God asks Noah to "take with you seven pairs of all clean animals, the male and its mate; and a pair of the animals that are not clean, the male and its mate; and also seven pairs of the birds of the sky, male and female, to keep their kind alive on the face of all the earth" (Gen 7:2–3). Afterwards, God tells Noah how he will destroy the world: "for in seven days I will send rain on the earth for forty days and forty nights; and every living thing that I have made I will destroy from the face of the ground" (Gen 7:4). The description of Noah's reaction follows: Noah says nothing and shows little hesitation: "Noah did all that YHWH had

¹⁷ V. FRITZ, "Solange die Erde steht": Vom Sinn der jahwistischen Fluterzählung in Gen 6–8," *ZAW* 94 (1982), 599–614; E. BOSSHARD-NEPUSTIL, *Vor uns die Sintflut: Studien zu Text, Kontexten, und Rezeption der Fluterzählung Genesis 6–9* (BWANT 165; Stuttgart: Kohlhammer, 2005), 95–99, 104–5, 266–68; N.C. BAUMGART, *Die Umkehr des Schöpfungsgottes: Zu Komposition und religionsgeschichtlichem Hintergrund von Gen 5–9* (HBS 22; Freiburg im Breisgau: Herder, 1999), 149–73; R. OBERFORCHER, *Die Flutprologe als Kompositionsschlüssel der biblischen Urgeschichte: Ein Beitrag zur Redaktionskritik* (Innsbrucker Theologische Studien 8; Innsbruck: Tyrolia, 1981), 128–39; and S.E. MCEVENUE, *The Narrative Style of the Priestly Writer* (AnBib 50; Rome: Biblical Institute Press, 1971), 28.

commanded him” (Gen 7:5). Immediately after the speech in Gen 7:1–5 comes the description of the rain falling on the earth, followed by the specific description of the flood. The flood continues for forty days on the earth, the water rises high above the earth, and God destroys every living thing. Only Noah and those that are with him in the ark survive the flood (Gen 7:12, 17, 22, 23).

According to the form and content of the narrative, it can be argued that the spatial settings in God’s speech of Gen 7:1–5 and Gen 7:12, 17, 22, 23 correspond to each other.¹⁸ Almost every word spoken by God in Gen 7:1–5 corresponds with the description of the flood in Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23, as illustrated in Table 8. This correspondence shows that everything God intends to save is saved, while everything that God intends to destroy is destroyed. God has total power over the world.

Table 8. God’s Speech and Description of the Flood in Genesis 7:1–23

God’s Speech	Description of the Flood
Gen 7:1–3	Gen 7:23
Gen 7:4	Gen 7:12, 17, 22–23

For the correspondence of spatial settings between Gen 7:1–3 and Gen 7:23,¹⁹ God says to Noah in Gen 7:1, “go into *the ark*, you and all your household, for I have seen that you alone are righteous before me in this generation.” The ark is emphasized again in Gen 7:22, when it is said that “only Noah was left, and those that were with him in *the ark*.” Genesis 7:2–3 also construct a spatial correspondence with Gen 7:23. In Gen 7:2–3, God tells Noah what he will save on the earth, and in Gen 7:23, “Noah was left, and those that were with him in *the ark* survived in the ark as well.”

The spatial settings in Gen 7:4 also correspond with those in Gen 7:12, 17. In Gen 7:4, God tells Noah that he will send rain down onto the earth for forty days and nights. Genesis 7:12 then describes how the rain falls on the earth for forty days and forty nights, and Gen 7:17 describes the flood more specifically, emphasizing how it continues for forty days on the earth and how the water

¹⁸ In terms of the narrative structure, there is the debate about whether there is chiasmic correspondence between Gen 6:5–8 and Gen 9:1–17, and between Gen 6:9–22 and Gen 8:20–22; see U. CASSUTO, *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis. Part Two: From Noah to Abraham* (trans. I. Abrahams; Jerusalem: Magnes, 1964), 30–43; G.J. WENHAM, “The Coherence of the Flood Narrative,” *VT* 28 (1978), 336–48; Y.T. RADDAY, “Chiasmus in Hebrew Biblical Narrative,” in *Chiasmus in Antiquity: Structures, Analyses, Exegesis* (ed. J.W. Welch; Hildesheim: Gerstenberg, 1981), 50–117; and E. BLUM, *Studien zur Komposition des Pentateuch* (BZAW 189; Berlin: de Gruyter, 1990), 283.

¹⁹ For a discussion of Gen 7:23 in rhetorical terms, see M. KESSLER, “Rhetorical Criticism of Genesis 7,” in *Rhetorical Criticism: Essays in Honor of James Muilenburg* (ed. J.J. Jackson and M. Kessler; PTMS 1; Pittsburgh, PA: Pickwick, 1974), 1–17.

risers high above the earth. The earth, then, is key to the spatial correspondence between God's speech and the description of the flood.

Genesis 7:4 also corresponds with Gen 7:22–23. In Gen 7:4, God not only says that he will send the rain down onto the earth but also describes how he will destroy the earth: “*every living thing* that I have made I will destroy *from the face of the ground*.” Genesis 7:22–23 then states precisely that God “destroyed *every living thing* that was *on the face of the ground*.” Thus there is also a spatial correspondence between Gen 7:22–23 and Gen 7:4, even though there are more specific descriptions of the flood in Gen 7:22–23.

Almost all spatial settings mentioned in God's speech, then, have a corresponding passage in the description of the flood. Most of them use the same word or phrase. On the one hand, this correspondence shows that God has absolute power over the earth. God destroys exactly those things on earth that he mentions in his speech. On the other hand, the way God destroys the earth is exactly the same as how he describes it in his speech. Thus, while God's speech in the non-Priestly flood narrative is not able to influence the world directly, as in Gen 1, God's speech still has absolute power and authority.

10.2.2. *The Ark as the Center of the World*

The non-Priestly flood narrative does not contain many descriptions of the construction of the ark.²⁰ The non-Priestly narrator does not tell us where the ark is from, who made the ark, or what the complex of the ark is like.²¹ Only the function of the ark is mentioned. God asks Noah to go into the ark in order to survive the flood, and it is in the ark that Noah and “those who were with him” survive. While the narrator mentions the ark only a few times, the ark is significant, and its first two appearances are at critical temporal points. The first appearance of the ark is in God's speech. The first words said by God to Noah are about the ark. God says to Noah, “go into the ark” (Gen 7:1). Thus the ark is shown to be important to God, although there is no information about why Noah needs to go into the ark. The second appearance of the ark is in the description of the flood. It is stated that only Noah is left alive, along with those who are with him in the ark. At this point the readers know the function of the ark and the reason why God asks Noah go into the ark, namely, so that Noah can survive the flood.

The significance of the ark is shown in a pointed way in Gen 8:6–13, which describes how Noah sends the birds out to see whether the land outside the ark

²⁰ For discussion of the difference between the ark narrative in the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives, see J.C. GERTZ, “Beobachtungen zum literarischen Charakter und zum geistesgeschichtlichen Ort der nichtpriesterschriftlichen Sintfluterzählung,” in *Auf dem Weg zur Endgestalt von Genesis bis II Regum. Festschrift Hans-Christoph Schmitt* (ed. M. Beck and U. Schorn; BZAW 370; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2006), 41–57.

²¹ The text mentions only that Noah made the “window” in Gen 8:6.

is dry. The ark in Gen 8:6–13 is described as a space relative to the earthly world. The ark is where Noah must stay while waiting for the land to dry out. The ark here becomes the *center of the world*: the flood on the earth, the actions of Noah, and the actions of the birds all take place around the ark.²²

Noah sends the birds out from the ark when the water recedes from the surface of the earth. When the rain is held back, the water recedes gradually. It takes more than two weeks, during which Noah waits in the ark. The situation of the earth at this time is not described directly; rather, the narrator recounts what is going on outside the ark by means of the birds. In Gen 8:6, we find a description of how Noah opens the window of the ark that he made and sends out a raven. The raven goes to and fro until the water is dried up from the earth. The raven is sent out probably to get information about the rain rather than about the water on the surface of the earth. It is able to move about because it is not raining anymore. For information about the water on the surface of the earth, Noah sends a dove to see “if the waters had subsided from the face of the ground” (Gen 8:8). The narrator does not tell us directly whether or not the water subsides; the focus is instead on the dove. The dove returns to Noah since “the waters were still on the face of the whole earth, and the dove found no place to set its foot” (Gen 8:9). Noah puts out his hand, takes the dove, and brings it back into the ark.

Noah waits another seven days and then sends out the dove again *from the ark* (Gen 8:10). The ark again becomes the center of the world. The ark is a fixed point relative to both Noah and the dove. Noah sits in the ark, floating from one place to another. This time, the dove comes back to Noah with an olive leaf. Noah then knows that the waters have subsided from the earth (Gen 8:11). Noah then waits another seven days and sends the dove out again. The dove does not return to Noah this time. While the narrator does not explain why, this is already known from Gen 8:9, namely that the dove must have “found a place to set his feet.” At this point, “Noah removed the covering of the ark, and looked, and saw that the face of the ground was drying” (Gen 8:13). The situation of the water and the earth is thus not narrated directly but shown indirectly through the actions of the birds.

The word “ark” (תבת) is used only in two narrative scenes in the Hebrew Bible. One is in the flood narrative of Gen 6–9, and the other is in Exod 2:3, which describes how Moses’s mother puts Moses into the “ark” (תבת): “And when she could hide him no longer, she took a basket made of papyrus for him (ולא יכלה עוד הצפינו ותקח-לו תבת גמא), and plastered it with bitumen and pitch; she put the child in it and placed it among the reeds on the bank of the river.”

²² Gen 8:6–13 has material parallel to Gilgamesh XI.145–54. For a brief review of the biblical flood narrative’s connection with Atrahasis and Gilgamesh, see R.G. KRATZ, *Die Komposition der erzählenden Bücher des Alten Testaments* (Uni-Taschenbücher 2157; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 2000), 261.

There seems to be a connection between the ark in the flood narrative and the ark in Exod 2. In the first place, each performs a critical function in its narrative. In Gen 6–9, the ark (תבת) saves Noah, who is the representative of humanity during the flood. When Pharaoh commands “his people” to throw all boys born to the Hebrews into the Nile (יאר), it is the ark (תבת) that saves Moses. The ark in Gen 6–9 is thus universalized to show how it rescues humanity as a whole. Second, both mentions of the ark have a connection with water. In the flood narrative, the ark saves humanity from the flood waters. In Exod 2, the ark saves Moses among the reeds by the bank of the Nile (יאר) (Exod 2:3). The function of the ark (תבת) is therefore universalized in the flood narrative of Gen 6–9.

It is also noteworthy that the word “cover” (מכסה) in Gen 8:13b appears extensively in the tabernacle narratives in Exodus (Exod 26:14; 36:19; 39:34; 40:19). The “cover” (מכסה) is an essential element of the tabernacle. It is God who asks Moses to make a cover for the tabernacle (e.g., Exod 26:14). In Gen 6–9, the “cover” (מכסה) of the ark is described only in the non-Priestly flood version. Although God does not command Noah to make a cover for the ark in the non-Priestly flood narrative, Gen 8:13b tells us that the ark has a “cover,”²³ using the same word (מכסה) for the tabernacle’s cover. The word “cover” (מכסה) thus connects the ark in the non-Priestly flood narrative with the tabernacle. The portable tabernacle is the most important space for the Israelites when they are wandering in the desert. Similarly, the ark is also the central space for humanity during the flood.

The ark is therefore effectively shown as being at the center of the spatial relationships between Noah and the birds, the heaven and the earth, the earthly world and the ark, and Noah and the earthly world. Noah is the center of the ark. Moreover, the ark is also the center of power during the flood. The ark’s space is limited, and its locations are not stable. However, the ark, floating from one place to another, is a fixed point relative to both Noah and the birds. The dove is sent out and received by Noah from the ark; all information about the world is reported to Noah in the ark. Noah knows the situation of the earth, the rain, and the water, from his position sitting in the ark.

10.2.3. Noah’s Altar and its Symbolic Meaning

The first space on earth described after the flood in the non-Priestly flood narrative is the altar.

Then Noah built an altar to YHWH and took of every clean animal and of every clean bird, and offered burnt-offerings on the altar (יבן נח מזבח ליהוה ויקח מכל הבהמה הטרה ומכל העוף)

²³ The “cover” in Gen 8:13b reminds us of the commandment of God in Gen 6:16 (P), to make a “window” (צהר). However, the word Gen 6:16 uses for the “window” is צהר rather than מכסה, “cover.”

(הטרה ויעל עלת במזבח). And when YHWH smelt the pleasing aroma, YHWH said in his heart, “I will never again curse the ground because of humankind, for the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth; nor will I ever again destroy every living creature as I have done. As long as the earth endures, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, day and night, shall not cease” (Gen 8:20–22).

What is the symbolic meaning of the altar? In Gen 8:20–22, God blesses humanity because Noah builds an altar to God and takes of every clean beast and of every clean bird to offer burnt offerings on the altar (Gen 8:20). Then God smells the pleasing aroma and promises that the world will never again be destroyed. The pleasing aroma is important because it implies one feature of worship.

More importantly, in spatial terms, this description of altar also indicates an anti-iconic concept. The appearance of God is introduced through an anthropomorphic word “smelled” (ירח).²⁴ It is through smelling that God has a connection with the altar. In addition, the fact that God “said to himself” after he smells the pleasing aroma suggests that God might not have appeared to Noah. An anti-iconic concept is also constructed rhetorically. According to Ezek 6:13, it is possible that there were many idols around the altar: “And you shall know that I am YHWH, when their slain are among their idols around their altars (בהיות חלליהם בתוך גלוליהם סביבות מזבחותיהם), on every high hill, on all the mountain tops, under every green tree, and under every leafy oak, wherever they offered pleasing aroma to all their idols.” In contrast, Gen 8:20 does not refer to any ornaments, nor does it directly describe the appearance of God. Rather, the narrative uses the expressions “smelling” and “said to himself” to suggest the appearance of God. The narrative about the first worship of humans in Gen 8:20–21 avoids any reference to idols around the altar perhaps because it is anti-iconographic.

Genesis 8:20–22 also makes no mention of the mountain where we would expect it to be. In biblical narrative, the altar in many cases has a connection with the mountain. In Gen 12:8, for example, Abraham builds an altar in the mountains to the east of Bethel. In Josh 8:30, Joshua builds an altar to God on Mount Ebal. The altar in Isa 56:7 is connected with mountains from the perspective of God.

From there he (Abraham) moved to the hills on the east of Bethel (ויעתק משם ההרה מקדם) (לביית־אל), and pitched his tent, with Bethel on the west and Ai on the east; and there he built an altar to YHWH and invoked the name of YHWH (ויבך־שם מזבח ליהוה ויקרא בשם יהוה) (Gen 12:8).

Then Joshua built on Mount Ebal an altar to YHWH, the God of Israel (אז יבנה יהושע מזבח) (ליהוה אלהי ישראל בהר עיבל) (Josh 8:30).

²⁴ G. von RAD, *Genesis: A Commentary* (rev. ed.; Philadelphia, PA: Westminster, 1972), 122.

These I will bring to my holy mountain (והביאותים אל-הר קדשי) and make them joyful in my house of prayer; their burnt offerings and their sacrifices will be accepted on my altar (וזבחייהם לרצון על-מזבחי); for my house shall be called a house of prayer for all the peoples (Isa 56:7).

Altars in biblical texts are also related to the “high place” (e.g., 1 Kgs 3:4; 2 Kgs 23:15–16; 1 Chr 21:29). There are three possible reasons why there is no mention of a mountain in Gen 8:20–22 or anywhere in the whole non-Priestly flood narrative. The first reason is that the Priestly flood narrative has already mentioned the mountain (Gen 7:19, 20; 8:4, 5). Subsequently, when the non-Priestly flood narrative was interwoven with the Priestly flood narrative, there was no need to add the text about mountain again. Second, the mountain is so sacred for the non-Priestly narrator that he avoided mentioning that the mountain was destroyed by the flood. Third, and most probably, the non-Priestly narrative intended to avoid connecting the altar and the mountain, which is one characteristic of the locative sanctuaries. The altar here is therefore highly symbolized, without the information about complex and location that would enable us to physically locate it.

10.3. Genesis 11:1–9 and Symbolic Space

The spatial settings in Gen 11:1–9 have rich symbolic meanings. Their symbolic meanings vary according to different interpretations. The spatial settings are generally used to illustrate the themes of humanity’s hubris and divine punishment. For example, the tower with its top in the sky is generally interpreted in terms of humanity’s attempt to break through the boundary between humanity and God.²⁵ Humans try to build the tower with its top reaching into the residence of God, challenging God’s authority and perhaps even attempting to replace him. In this interpretation, the dispersal of humanity over the whole surface of the earth is God’s punishment of humanity.²⁶

Some have also proposed a political reading of the Babel narrative. They see the Babel narrative primarily as a mythical story with political content. Genesis 11:1–9 expresses rebellion against imperialistic policies,²⁷ whether

²⁵ J.P. FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art in Genesis: Specimens of Stylistic and Structural Analysis* (SSN 17; Sheffield: JSOT Press, 1991), 29–43.

²⁶ For a review of the exegesis of the Babel narrative which takes this approach, see J.L. KUGEL, “The Tower of Babel,” in *Traditions of the Bible: A Guide to the Bible as It Was at the Start of the Common Era* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1998), 228–42 and T. HIEBERT, “Babel: Babble or Blueprint? Calvin, Cultural Diversity, and the Interpretation of Genesis 11:1–9,” in *Reformed Theology: Identity and Ecumenicity II. Biblical Interpretation in the Reformed Tradition* (ed. W.M. Alstron, Jr. and M. Welker; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2007), 127–45.

²⁷ E.g., JOSEPHUS, *Ant.* 1.113–14 (Thackeray, LCL).

those of the Neo-Assyrian king, Sargon II,²⁸ or of the Neo-Babylonian Empire.²⁹ Many narrative elements clearly refer to Babylonia. The spatial settings are also primary for such an interpretation. Shinar in Gen 11:1–9 clearly indicates Mesopotamia, and Babel is the name of the capital of Babylon in biblical narratives. The building materials for the city and tower described in the Babel narrative were also popular in contemporary Mesopotamia. The fact that all the people of the earth speak the same language reflects imperial domination. Consequently, the confusing of language and the dispersal of humanity is seen as God's punishment for an imperialistic ideology of world domination.

Recently, an increasing number of commentators have read Gen 11:1–9 in cultural terms.³⁰ The Babel narrative is seen primarily as a cultural etiology, anchored in a remote time and in Shinar. The text serves to explain cultural and national diversity, as well as how languages became different.

I would like to argue that the city and the tower in Gen 11:1–9 are used symbolically to show the power of humanity, specifically the power of having the same language. The functions of the city and the tower themselves are exaggerated in order to build up the themes of hubris and punishment. I shall first discuss how the Babel narrative appropriates the symbolic meanings of the city in the primeval history (Gen 1–11) and the relationships among the “tower with its top in the sky,” humanity, and God. I will then draw attention to the rhetorical meanings by which the relationship between the diversity of humanity and the diversity of languages are constructed.

²⁸ C. UEHLINGER, *Weltreich und “eine Rede”: Eine neue Deutung der sogenannten Turm-Bauernzählung (Gen 11,1–9)* (OBO 101; Freiburg: Universitätsverlag; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1990), 514–36 argues that the original form of Gen 11:1–9 alludes to the imperial policies of the Neo-Assyrian king Sargon II.

²⁹ For readings of the Babel narrative using this approach, see UEHLINGER, *Weltreich* (see n. 28); J.S. CROATTO, “A Reading of the Story of the Tower of Babel from a Perspective of Non-Identity,” in *Teaching the Bible: The Discourses and Politics of Biblical Pedagogy* (ed. F.F. Segovia and M.A. Tolbert; Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 1998), 203–23; D.N. FEWELL, “Building Babel,” in *Postmodern Interpretations of the Bible: A Reader* (ed. A.K.M. Adam; St. Louis, MO: Chalice, 2001), 1–15. For a brief review of postmodern historical criticism of the Babel story, see J.J. COLLINS, *The Bible After Babel: Historical Criticism in a Postmodern Age* (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 2005), 1–3.

³⁰ B.W. ANDERSON, *From Creation to New Creation: Old Testament Perspectives* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 1994), 165–78; E. van WOLDE, *Words Become Worlds: Semantic Studies of Genesis 1–11* (BibInt 6; Leiden: Brill, 1994), 84–109; T.E. FRETHEIM, “Genesis,” *NIB* 1:319–674, here 410–14; W. BRUEGGEMANN, *Genesis* (IBC; Atlanta, GA: John Knox, 1982), 97–104; and T. HIEBERT, “The Tower of Babel and the Origin of the World's Cultures,” *JBL* 126 (2007), 29–58.

10.3.1. The Appropriation of Cities in Genesis 1–11

The primeval history (Gen 1–11) contains several accounts describing the building of a city.³¹ The first is in the story of Cain and Abel (Gen 4). Cain builds the first city and names this city Enoch after his son: “Then Cain went away from the presence of YHWH, and settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden. Cain knew his wife, and she conceived and bore Enoch; and he built a city, and named it Enoch after his son Enoch” (וַיְהִי בְנֵה עֵיר וַיִּקְרָא שֵׁם הָעִיר עֵנֹךְ בְּשֵׁם) (בְּנוֹ חֲנוֹךְ) (Gen 4:16–17). The city of Enoch is also the first space built by humans before the flood narrative. The city of Enoch is described as being built by Cain himself and there is no detailed description of its layout. The text simply mentions that Cain builds a city. This non-Priestly account was probably composed later than the flood narrative, because Gen 6–9 does not mention that God destroys a city or any other human place.

After the flood story, the building of a city is mentioned again in the course of Noah’s genealogy:

And Cush became the father of Nimrod; he was the first on earth to be a mighty man. He was a mighty hunter before YHWH; therefore it is said, “Like Nimrod a mighty hunter before YHWH.” The beginning of his kingdom was Babel, Erech, and Accad, all of them in the land of Shinar. From that land he went into Assyria, and built Nineveh, Rehoboth-ir, Calah (מִן־הָאָרֶץ הַהִוא יָצָא אַשּׁוּר וַיְבִן אֶת־נִינְוָה וְאֶת־רֶחֱבֹת עִיר וְאֶת־כַּלַּח) and Resen between Nineveh and Calah; that is the great city (וְאֶת־רֶסֶן בֵּין נִינְוָה וּבֵין כַּלַּח הוּא הָעִיר הַגְּדֹלָה) (Gen 10:8–12).

Genesis 10:8–12 is also a non-Priestly text. The builder of the cities mentioned in the text is Nimrod, who is the son of Cush.³² Nimrod is described as the first mighty warrior on earth. The text also says: “Like Nimrod a mighty hunter before YHWH.” The narrator states that the beginning of his kingdom is Babel, Erech, and Accad, all of them in the land of Shinar. Even though Babel and the land of Shinar are mentioned, the narrator does not say that Nimrod builds the city of Babel. Rather, the cities that Nimrod builds are clearly stated to be Nineveh, Rehoboth-ir, Calah, and Resen. Resen is described in the most detail: it is situated between Nineveh and Calah and is a great city.

Genesis 11:1–9 seems, on thematic and formal levels, to have no direct connection with the city built by Cain in Gen 4, and it also does not continue on from Gen 10. In Gen 10:5, for example, the narrator describes how humans

³¹ For a review of cities in biblical texts, see M.P. O’CONNOR, “The Biblical Notion of the City,” in *Constructions of Space II: The Biblical City and Other Imaged Places* (ed. J.L. Berquist and C.V. Camp; LHBOTS 490; New York: T & T Clark, 2008), 18–39.

³² For a discussion of Nimrod in historical terms, see K. van der TOORN and P.W. van der HORST, “Nimrod Before and After the Bible,” *HTR* 83 (1990), 1–29. For a review of how the connection between Nimrod and the builder of the city and the tower in Gen 11:1–9 has been interpreted, see KUGEL, “Tower” (see n. 26), 229–32.

already speak different languages and how the population has already multiplied on the earth. All of these elements are rewritten in the Babel narrative, which perhaps reinterprets why there are different languages and populations. What are the specific differences between the descriptions of the city in Gen 11:1–9, on the one hand, and in Gen 4:17 and Gen 10:8–12, on the other?

First, the building of the city of Babel is a topic of the Babel narrative. While in Gen 4:17 and Gen 10:8–12 the building of the city is concisely described, the building of the city in Gen 11:1–9 is the narrative focus. Genesis 11:1–9 contains six verses mentioning the city and its construction in the Babel narrative: Gen 11:3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9. Both God and humanity act in relation to the building of city. The speeches of God and humanity are all connected closely with the city. The Babel narrative also specifically mentions the reason why humans build the city. The Babel narrative even introduces the materials for building the city. The city is thus an indispensable narrative element in the Babel narrative.

Second, Gen 11:1–9 is concerned with a specific city: Babel. The narrative seems to reinterpret the traditional meaning of “Babel.” “Babel” is the Hebrew name for the capital of Babylonia. The meaning of “Babel” in Akkadian is “Gate of God.”³³ The Babel narrative, however, explicitly states that the name Babel is given to the city by God because from there (Babel) God confuses the language of the whole earth, and from there (Babel) God disperses humanity over the whole surface of the earth. The city of Babel has a direct connection with both of God’s actions: confusing human language and dispersing humanity over the whole earth. It is because of God’s two actions that Babel is given its name by God. Here Babel is not the “Gate of God,” but has a close relationship with both of God’s actions in this particular story. Both actions are generally interpreted as God’s reaction against humanity building the city and the tower, but this reaction is not necessarily negative. First, “confusing” human language only entails letting language multiply. In most biblical narratives, the Hebrew word בבל is value free (e.g., Exod 29:40; Lev 14:10). Second, God disperses humanity over the surface of the earth because he thinks that “all that they plan to do will be possible for them” (Gen 11:6). The story does not say what they plan to do. Perhaps they are planning to wage wars, a plan which requires the population to come together. In these senses, the connotations of the word “Babel” in Gen 11:1–9 are not necessarily negative.

³³ B.T. ARNOLD, *Who Were the Babylonians?* (ABS 10; Atlanta, GA: Society of Biblical Literature, 2005), 2; I.J. GELB, “The Name of Babylon,” *Journal of the Institute of Asian Studies* 1 (1995), 1–4; and B. KIENAST, “The Name of the City of Babylon,” *Sumer* 35 (1979), 246–48.

Third, the builder in Gen 11:1–9 is the whole of humanity rather than only one person.³⁴ In Gen 4:17, it is Cain himself who not only builds the city but also names it. In Gen 10:8–12, it seems that Nimrod builds the city; Nimrod even builds several cities: Nineveh, Rehoboth-ir, Calah, and Resen between Nineveh and Calah (Gen 10:12). In the Babel narrative, however, it is humanity as a whole that builds the city. Three different phrases indicate humanity as the active subject: “all the earth” (Gen 11:1), “descendants of men” (Gen 11:5), and “one people” (Gen 11:6). Among these three phrases, “descendants of men” is the most particular because it is said from the perspective of God. God comes down to see the city and the tower that the descendants of men build. “The descendants of men” is perhaps used here to emphasize that the city is built not by a hero like Nimrod but by ordinary humanity as a whole. Genesis 11:5 also shows the magnificence of building the city, a difficult project that requires many people and a common language that allows them to cooperate.

Fourth, God and humanity are connected by the city of Babel in Gen 11:1–9. Genesis 4 and 10 also mention God. Cain builds the city after he leaves the presence of God and settles in the land of Nod, east of Eden (Gen 4:16). Nimrod is a mighty hunter before God (Gen 10:9). In the case of Gen 4 and 10, however, God seems have no direct connection with building the city. In the Babel narrative, God is directly involved in humanity’s project of building the city. The first appearance of God is in relation to the city: “And YHWH came down to see the city and the tower that the descendants of men built” (Gen 11:5).

At this point, it is interesting to note that when God sees the city, he thinks not about the city itself but about the potential of humanity: “YHWH said, ‘Behold, they are one people and they all have one language. This is the beginning of what they will do, and now nothing they plan to do will be impossible for them.’” (יֵאמֹר יְהוָה הֵן עַם אֶחָד וּשְׂפָה אַחַת לְכָלם וְזֶה הַחֵלֶם לַעֲשׂוֹת וְעַתָּה לֹא- (יִבְצֹר מֵהֶם כָּל אֲשֶׁר יִזְמוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת) (Gen 11:6). The reason why humanity is able to build the city, from the perspective of God, is that it shares a common language. As long as humanity has a common language, it will be able to do whatever it wants. Therefore, God’s reaction is directed not at the city but at the common language of humanity. The city does not irritate God because of its layout or its look, and it also does not irritate God because of the noise created by its construction. What God is concerned with is only the power of having a com-

³⁴ Early exegesis connected Gen 9 with Gen 10 and, based on that connection, suggested that the Babel narrative implies that the builder of Babel is Nimrod or a king of Babylonia. For a review of such opinions, see KUGEL, “Tower” (see n. 26), 229–32. The Babel story does not clearly state this, as noted by ANDERSON, *From Creation to New Creation* (see n. 30), 172: “It is noteworthy that the Babel Story contains no suggestion of royal or imperial motivation – in contrast to another tradition (Gen 10:8–12) that speaks of Babel as one of Nimrod’s royal cities and a base for imperial expansion.”

mon language. That the city is not the target of God's attack is further suggested by the fact that there is no description of God destroying the city. Instead, God confuses humanity's language and disperses humans over the whole surface of the earth. According to Gen 11:8, it is humanity itself, rather than God, who stops building the city: "So YHWH dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth (ויפץ יהוה אתם משם על-פני כליהארץ), and *they* stopped building the city (ויחדלו לבנות העיר)." God does not destroy the city and he does not even directly stop humanity from building the city (Gen 11:8). The reason that the humans stop building the city is that God disperses them over the surface of all the earth.

While there are many differences between the descriptions of the city in Gen 11:1–9 and those in Gen 4:17 and Gen 10:8–12, the Babel narrative shares an important theme with Gen 4:6–7 and Gen 10:8–12: wandering. The cities in Gen 4:6–7, Gen 10:8–12, and Gen 11:1–9 are all built by people who wander before they build. Cain leaves the presence of God, settles in the land of Nod, east of Eden (Gen 4:16), and then builds the city (Gen 4:17). Nimrod builds the city not in his own kingdom but after he enters Assyria from his kingdom. In Gen 11:1–9, the narrator also states that humanity, as the builder of the city, first journeys from the East, then finds a valley in the land of Shinar, settles there, and starts building the city. Cities are thus built in the primeval history (Gen 1–11) not where people live naturally, but only after having journeyed from somewhere else.³⁵

10.3.2. *The Function of the Tower*

Compared to other descriptions of cities in the primeval history, a striking characteristic of the city of Babel is that it has a tower. "And they said, 'Come, let us build for ourselves a city and a tower with its top in the sky (ומגדל וראשו) (בשמים), and let us make a name for ourselves, so that we will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth'" (Gen 11:4). Genesis 11:4 has generally been taken as evidence that the city is built by humanity in order to challenge the authority of God in heaven. God is offended and then comes down to destroy the city and disperse humanity over the whole surface of the earth. According to this interpretation, it seems that God comes down immediately after the people decide to build the city and the tower reaching up into the sky.

But there is more information about the function of tower in Gen 11:4. According to the narrative structure, Gen 11:4 describes three projects humanity wants to undertake: to build for themselves a city, to build a tower reaching up

³⁵ It is interesting that, while the Israelites' ancestors also travelled in the area of Mesopotamia and Canaan, "the city, having emerged in Genesis, recedes from view as a major phenomenon on the biblical landscape until the stories relating to the monarchy and the Iron Age"; see O'CONNOR, "Biblical Notion" (see n. 31), 19.

into the sky, and to make a name for themselves. These projects can be understood as constituting a progressive sequence. Humanity must first complete the first project, then they can complete the second, and finally the third. This is probably also the reason why, at the end of narrative, the narrator only mentions that God confuses humanity's language and disperses the humans over the whole earth. The tower is not mentioned with the city at the end, not because the tower is not important for the narrative but because it is not necessary. Humans have not started to build the tower in the Babel narrative, so God does not react to the tower. Humans are not able to complete the first project.

In fact, the final aim of humanity has nothing to do with the tower. The phrase "so that ... not" in Gen 11:4 clearly shows that the final aim of humanity, or the reason why humanity needs to complete the three projects, is so that they will not be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth. The first three projects, including the building of the tower, are thus necessary in order that humans not be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth. The building of the tower is thus the only the way for humanity to achieve its final aim. The humans probably did not want to build the tower in order to challenge the authority of God.

God's actions have no relationship to the tower, as Gen 11:6–7 in particular suggests. When humanity is building the city, God knows that there is one people and they share a single language. It is this unity that enables humanity to build the city. However, this is not what God is concerned about. Of greater concern is the fact that "all that they plan to do will be possible for them." God thus takes two steps to prevent humans from becoming too powerful. The first step is confusing their language, and the second is dispersing humanity over the whole surface of the earth. It is noteworthy that God does not intend to destroy the city and tower at all. God only confuses the language of humanity and disperses humanity over the whole surface of the earth. According to Gen 11:8, it is humanity itself who stops building the city because the different groups could not understand each other's language. There is not even a mention of the tower in Gen 11:8, which describes God's actions.³⁶

What God is concerned with is not, therefore, that "the tower with its top in the sky" could challenge his authority. God's speech in Gen 11:6 indicates only that he is concerned with how the earth may be affected by the power of a humanity with a common language. "Building the tower with its top in sky" only strengthens the sense that humanity has great power. The power of humanity is so great that humans are able build the tower with its top in the sky. This does not necessarily show that humanity intends to build the tower in order to challenge the authority of God in the sky. Correspondingly, God does

³⁶ In LXX, the "tower" is added in verse 8; see R.S. HENDEL, *The Text of Genesis 1–11: Textual Studies and Critical Edition* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1998), 81–92, 144.

not confuse the people's language and disperse them because of the city and tower themselves.

If "the tower with its top in the sky" does show the hubris of humanity, the tower should be mentioned more times than only twice (Gen 11:4, 5).³⁷ The tower itself is not emphasized in Gen 11:1–9. If the narrator wanted to emphasize that the tower reaching up into the sky irritates God, he might have stated specifically in Gen 11:5 that God came down "from the heaven" to see the city and the tower, or that God came down to see the city and the tower "with its top in the sky," in order to emphasize the parallel between "the tower with its top in the sky" and "God's residence."

The use of the tower in the Babel narrative is very particular. In most biblical narratives, towers are part of a city's fortification. Almost all towers in the biblical narrative are built for warfare. For example, the towers in Judg 8:17 and 9:46–47, 49 are described as the part of fortification that protects the people in the city (e.g., Judg 9:46). There are also many descriptions of the tower in Nehemiah (e.g., Neh 3:1, 25, 26; 12:39). The tower is described naturally as a part of the city. In Neh 8:4, the tower is described as a place where the scribe Ezra is able to stand to read the Torah to the public (Neh 8:4). Here the tower seems to simply be a high place. In 2 Chr 26:15, the tower is described as the place where weapons are stored. The tower used in the Hebrew Bible is generally a part of a city and does not have special religious and ritual functions. Thus the tower in the Babel narrative probably does not symbolize the ziggurat or a similar cultic sanctuary.³⁸ The tower in the Babel narrative is probably just part of the city's fortification.³⁹

³⁷ In other words, compared to the city, the tower is not the narrative focus; see E.A. SPEISER, "Word Plays on the Creation Epic's Version of the Founding of Babylon," *Or* 25 (1956), 317–23, here 322; R.B. COOTE and D.R. ORD, *The Bible's First History* (Philadelphia, PA: Fortress, 1989), 95; FRETHEIM, "Genesis" (see n. 30), 410; D.E. GOWAN, *When Man Becomes God: Humanism and Hybris in the Old Testament* (PTMS 6; Pittsburgh, PA: Pickwick, 1975), 28.

³⁸ For the associations between the tower and the ziggurat, see H. GRESSMANN, *The Tower of Babel* (New York: Jewish Institute of Religion Press, 1928), 15–19; A. PARROT, *The Tower of Babel* (New York: Philosophical Library, 1955); and N.M. SARNA, *The JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1989), 82–83.

³⁹ SPEISER, "Word Plays" (see n. 37), 322 suggests "a city crowned by a tower"; see also COOTE and ORD, *Bible's First History* (see n. 37), 95.

The tower “with its top in the sky” is also the traditional expression used in Mesopotamian texts.⁴⁰ For example, the *Esagila*, the temple of Marduk in Babylon, means “house whose head is raised high.”⁴¹ This expression shows the magnificence of the tower project. Likewise, the narrator of Gen 11:1–9 probably just uses the exaggerated phrase “tower with its top in heaven” to show the magnificence of humanity’s project.

The function or the symbolic meaning of the tower is thus traditionally over-emphasized. The tower itself is not the narrative focus of humanity’s action and also does not concern God. What God is concerned about is humanity’s power as it is evident in the building of the city and the tower. The tower with its top in the sky is probably only a common expression and exaggeration that shows how magnificent a project is. Humanity has no intention to build the tower in order to challenge the authority of God, and God is also not offended by the tower built by humanity.

10.3.3. *The Diversity of Language and the Diversity of Humanity*

In the Babel narrative, space and language are specifically connected with God’s actions. God undertakes two main actions in Gen 11:1–9: to confuse the language of humanity and to disperse humans over the whole surface of the earth. The phrase “all the earth” is used in the Babel narrative mainly as a counterpart to the city of Babel, which is emphasized by the locative adverb “there”: “YHWH dispersed them *from there* over the surface of all the earth” (ויפץ יהוה אתם משם על-פני כל-הארץ ויחדלו לבנות העיר) in Gen 11:8 and “therefore, it was called Babel, because *there* YHWH confused the language of all the earth (על-כן קרא שמה בבל כי-שם בלל יהוה שפת כל-הארץ), and *from there* YHWH dispersed them over the surface of all the earth” (ומשם הפיצם יהוה על-) (פני כל-הארץ) in Gen 11:9. Use of the locative adverb “there” creates a correspondence between the whole earth and a specific place, namely the city of Babel. It is in the city of Babel that God confuses humanity’s language and disperses them over the whole surface of the earth.

The Babel narrative suggests that both language and space are controlled by God. When the early humans are in the city of Babel in the land of Shinar, they stay in one place and speak one language. Their projects of building the city and the tower and making a name for themselves enable God to see their

⁴⁰ E.A. SPEISER, *Genesis: Introduction, Translation, and Notes* (AB 1; New York: Doubleday, 1964), 74–76; SARNA, *JPS Torah Commentary: Genesis* (see n. 38), 82–83; UEHLINGER, *Weltreich* (see n. 28), 236–42; COOTE and ORD, *Bible’s First History* (see n. 37), 96–97.

⁴¹ W.G. LAMBERT, “Akkadische Mythen und Epen: Enuma Elish,” in *Text aus der Umwelt des Alten Testament* (3 vols.; ed. O. Kaiser et al.; Gütersloh: Gütersloher Verlagshaus, 1982–97), 3:565–602, here 591–93.

power.⁴² God thus confuses their language and disperses them over the whole surface of the earth. After they are dispersed, they no longer speak the same language and are not able to complete such a huge project as building a city.

There is no clear information in Gen 11:1–9 about the relationship between the diversity of language and the diversity of humanity. The diversity of language is interpreted as the will of God. The diversity of language is not natural. It results first of all from God's actions. It is God who confuses the language, so the diversity of humanity is not the reason for the existence of different languages. Conversely, according to Gen 11:8, humanity is not diverse because of the diversity of language. The diversity of humanity is the result of the will of God. It is God who disperses humanity over the whole surface of the earth.

While the Babel narrative suggests that both the diversity of language and the diversity of humanity are caused by God, the order in which this is done is ambiguous.

Come, let us go down and there let us confuse their language, and that they may not understand one another's speech (הבה נרדה ונבלה שם שפתם אשר לא ישמעו איש שפת רעהו) (Gen 11:7).

Then YHWH dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth, and they stopped building the city (ויפץ יהוה אתם משם על־פני כל־הארץ ויחדלו לבנות העיר) (Gen 11:8).

Therefore, it was called Babel, because there YHWH confused the language of all the earth, and from there YHWH dispersed them over the surface of all the earth (על־כן קרא שמה בבל) (כִּי־שם בבל יהוה שפת כל־הארץ ומשם הפיצם יהוה על־פני כל־הארץ) (Gen 11:9).

According to Gen 11:9, "confusing the language" comes first, followed by "dispersing humanity over the surface of all the earth." But the order is not so clear in Gen 11:7–8. In Gen 11:7, God says he will first confuse the language in direct speech. In Gen 11:8, however, only the narrator states that God disperses humanity. Genesis 11:8 does not say whether God confuses their language before he disperses them over the whole surface of the earth. Only Gen 11:9 indicates that the confusing of language comes first, followed by God "dispersing humanity." The attitude of the narrator to the relative order of the diversity of language and of humanity is ambiguous. He might have intended to keep both possibilities open, namely that the diversity of language is prior to the diversity of humanity, and vice versa.

⁴² There is also an interpretation according to which the city itself irritates God; see F.S. FRICK, *The City in Ancient Israel* (SBLDS 36; Missoula, MT: Scholars Press, 1977), 208; G. WALLIS, "Die Stadt in den Überlieferungen der Genesis," *ZAW* 78 (1966), 133–48; GOWAN, *When Man Becomes God* (see n. 37), 12; FOKKELMAN, *Narrative Art* (see n. 25), 18 n. 12; and V.P. HAMILTON, *The Book of Genesis: Chapters 1–17* (NICOT; Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1990), 356. It seems, however, that the very act of building a city shows humanity's power and irritates God. The city itself is used only as means of showing the power of humanity.

The diversity of the population in the Babel narrative accords with an important theme in Gen 1–11 (see also Gen 1:28; 9:1).⁴³ The Babel narrative seems to expand on and reinterpret Gen 9:18–19, which describes the diversity of the people on the earth.⁴⁴ The power of a common human language in Gen 11:1–9 is contrasted with God who creates the world with language. At the same time, the diversity of language in different nations reflects the experience of the Israelites in the exilic period. The narrator takes Babylonia as the spatial setting for the diversity of language and the diversity of humanity, countering the imperial policies of Babylonia. According to Gen 11:1–9, humanity should multiply and should speak different languages since this is already ordained by God.

⁴³ Gen 11:4 is a refusal to fulfill the mandate of creation; see BRUEGGEMANN, *Genesis* (see n. 30), 97–104.

⁴⁴ J.C. GERTZ, “Babel im Rücken und das Land vor Augen: Anmerkungen zum Abschluss der Urgeschichte und zum Anfang der Erzählungen von den Erzeltern Israels,” in *Die Erzväter in der biblischen Tradition: Festschrift für Matthias Köckert* (ed. A.C. Hagedorn and H. Pfeiffer; BZAW 400; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2006), 9–34, here 26.

Chapter 11

Comparison between Space in Genesis 1, 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9

This section will discuss differences in the descriptions of space between Priestly texts (Gen 1, Gen 6–9) and non-Priestly texts (Gen 2–3, Gen 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9) of the primeval history. Specifically, it makes comparisons between Gen 1 and Gen 2–3, between the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives of Gen 6–9, between Gen 1 and the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, between the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 and Gen 11:1–9, between Gen 2–3 and the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, and between Gen 1 and Gen 11:1–9. Each comparison will take into account physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space.

11.1. Genesis 1 and Genesis 2–3

11.1.1. Physical Space

Space is described from two different perspectives in the juxtaposed creation accounts in Gen 1 and Gen 2–3. In Gen 1, God's space is initially defined through the relationship between God, on the one hand, and heaven and earth, on the other, in Gen 1:1–2 and 2:3: God is not in heaven and earth when he creates them. God has his own space where he can "rest." The distance between God and the world in the act of creation is hard to identify since the way God creates the world is abstract: through his speech. However, the clause "God saw that it was good" (Gen 1:10, 12, 18, 21, 25, 31) shows that God is above the space he creates. Genesis 1:26 and Gen 2:2–3 imply that two particular spaces are associated with God: Gen 1:26 has a public space where the divine councils are held, while Gen 2:2–3 has a residential space where God rests.

While in Gen 1 humanity is only shown in verses 26–29, some narrative viewpoints indicate a spatial relationship between humanity and the world. For example, the phrase "fill the earth" in Gen 1:28 indicates that humanity is above the earth. The description of the birds flying "in the expanse of heaven" rather than "above the heaven" in Gen 1:20 shows the point of view of humanity.

The natural spatial balance is emphasized by the narrative structure of the text. An important characteristic is that the spatial settings refer to each other as spatial points. For example, on the second day (Gen 1:6), the sky was created with reference to the waters, which were taken as a spatial reference point. The reference points are constructed through the use of reference words, which can be prepositions or verbs. For example, in Gen 1:20 and 22, there are different prepositions “above” (על) and “on” (ב) for the “flying of birds” and the “multiplication of birds,” showing the different spatial relationships among the birds, the sky, and the earth. “Multiply” as a reference word specifically shows the relationship between birds and earth in Gen 1:22.

The garden in Eden and its spatial settings, especially the two trees and the four rivers, are important narrative elements in Gen 2–3. In contrast with Gen 1, space here in Gen 2–3 is constructed mainly through the actions of God, the first man, and Eve. Genesis 2:4b–7 describes the world before God plants the garden in Eden. The phrase “God made earth and heaven” (Gen 2:4b) shows a different perspective on the creation described in Gen 1. After God forms the first man, he plants a garden in Eden. God’s actions in the garden are described in anthropomorphic terms, which are rare in Gen 1. That God walks in the garden implies that God has a body and shows up in the garden in person. However, as in Gen 1, there are no direct descriptions of God’s appearance.

Humanity’s space can be described according to the movements of God, the first man, and Eve. First, the relationship between humanity and the earth is emphasized more directly in Gen 2–3 than it is in Gen 1. The *inclusio* of the “earth” in Gen 2–3 shows the importance of the relationship between humanity and the earth. At the same time, Gen 2:8 and 15 paint different pictures of the relationship between the first man and the garden. In Gen 2:8, the first man is put directly into garden and does not need to cultivate it, while Gen 2:15 suggests that the first man is taken by God into the garden from somewhere else to cultivate and keep it. When humanity is in the garden, the direct interactions between God and humans illustrate their proximity to each other. The actions of the first man and Eve also to some extent illustrate their spatial relationships. On the whole, the spatial relationships are constructed through the movements of God, the first man, and Eve in Gen 2–3.

Genesis 2:4b–7 describes the situation of the world before God sends the rain (Gen 2:5). Compared to Gen 1, which describes specifically how God creates the world over seven days, Gen 2:4–7 does not describe the process of creation. Rather, Gen 2–3 focuses more on what the world is like. The location of the garden is an important aspect of space in Gen 2–3. A striking difference from Gen 1 is that Gen 2:8 uses cardinal directions. Genesis 2:8 states that the garden is planted in the “East” (קדם). Furthermore, the four rivers described in Gen 2:10–14, which were added later, basically allow us to locate the garden in Eden near Jerusalem. Two trees, which are highly symbolic, are located in the middle of the garden.

11.1.2. Conceptual Space

Genesis 1 describes a well-structured cosmos. God creates the world over seven days, and the spatial settings are constructed in sequence. Genesis 1 emphasizes a stratified view of the cosmos. The cosmos is basically structured into the space above heaven, heaven, the sky, the earth, and the deep water. In this stratified cosmos, the specific spatial settings are created with reference to each other and show well-structured spatial relationships that involve an “internal circle” from the primordial earth and water and then back to the earth and water.

The spatial relationships are emphasized in Gen 1, which shows the universality of space. The relationships construct a static space that cannot be easily destroyed. There are also no cardinal directions in Gen 1, a fact that also emphasizes the universality of space. The cardinal directions imply anthropocentrism since they generally take the human body as a point of reference. The anthropocentrism in Gen 1, however, is mainly functionalist. Humanity is asked by God to manage the whole earth (Gen 1:28).

Genesis 1 has many similarities to other Near Eastern creation myths or epics such as *Enuma Elish*.¹ Yet it also conforms to a vision of a nonmythological narrative. On the one hand, Gen 1 shows a world created by God and states that God creates the world in seven days. On the other hand, Gen 1 provides a vision of less mythical space. For example, God is not personified. Speech as a mythical element comes from God. It is emphasized that speech is an abstract medium for creation. And God uses only speech, not physical contact, to create the world.

Because of the different spatial relationships involved, Gen 2–3 involves a different type of conceptual space. Its view of the cosmos is different from Gen 1 in that it depicts a horizontal cosmos in Gen 2:4b–7. The narrative focus in Gen 2:4b–7 is on the earth, the field, and the plants in the ground, which all belong to earthly world of humanity. At the same time, the narrator also keeps the vertical view of cosmos by the rain sent by God in Gen 2:5. Rain in biblical texts is generally sent by God from heaven. But here the rain is also described with respect to the earth: there was no shrub and plant of *the field* because there was no rain.

Genesis 1 emphasizes well-ordered spatial relationships rather than the specific geographical locations. By contrast, Gen 2–3 is not concerned with the maintenance of spatial relationships but places greater emphasis on the specific places. The most important place is the garden in Eden. The garden in Eden as the center of the world is constructed rhetorically in Gen 2–3, which first describes the broader space of heaven and earth, then the East, Eden, and then

¹ For discussion of the cosmic geography in *Enuma Elish*, see W. HOROWITZ, *Mesopotamian Cosmic Geography* (Winona Lake, IN: Eisenbrauns, 1998), 107–28.

the garden in Eden, with ever-increasing focus. In the center of the garden are two trees. The land in the garden is also opposed to the ground outside the garden, a fact that is shown not only by the movement of the first man (e.g., Gen 2:8, 15) but also by the correspondence between Gen 3:17–19 and Gen 2:5. The relationship between God and humanity is reflected around the garden. The garden in Eden is also described as an “other” space through spatial oppositions such as “the garden in Eden” (גֶּן־בְּעֶדֶן) and “untilled ground” (וְאֲדָמָה) (אִין לַעֲבֹד אֶת־הָאֲדָמָה), “river in the garden” (וְנָהָר יֵצֵא מֵעֵדֶן לְהַשְׁקוֹת אֶת־הַגֶּן) and “mist” out of the garden (וְאֵד יֵעָלֶה מִן־הָאָרֶץ וְהִשְׁקָה אֶת־כָּל־פְּנֵי־הָאֲדָמָה).

As in Gen 1, Gen 2–3 also contains speeches by God to humanity. But God speaks to the first man in Gen 2–3 with the verb “say” (e.g., 3:9), as well as “call” (e.g., 3:9) and “command” (Gen 2:16–17). An important theme of Gen 2–3, the change in distance between God and humanity, is also a typical conceptual space. The conceptual distance between God and humanity is constructed rhetorically through use of the verbs “command,” “call,” and “say.”

11.1.3. Symbolic Space

Genesis 1, as a product of the Priestly authors, gives the space and spatial settings a particular symbolic meaning which shows the influence of their historical setting. Genesis 1 can be dated in the late exilic period and the beginning of the Persian Empire. The Priestly authors are probably exiles in the land of Babylon. On this basis, the symbolic space can in general be described from the perspective of culture and social influence. For example, the balance of the world shows the Priestly interest in order and separation. Genesis 1 also emphasizes spatial relationships rather than specific geographical places; in spatial terms, this reflects Priestly ideas about the fall of Jerusalem: whereas Jerusalem and other locations were destroyed, the Priestly narrator describes a cosmos where the basic spatial relations are maintained and cannot be easily destroyed.

Genesis 1 has a different perspective from the other biblical creation accounts. Compared to Gen 2–3, Gen 1 describes creation primarily from the perspective of God: how God creates the world through his speeches and arranges the spatial settings. Genesis 2–3, however, is written from an anthropological perspective. The narrator is concerned with the spatial relationships among humanity, the field, and the garden in Eden. Genesis 1 describes a well-structured space in which humans live. It also describes a structured and balanced world. This world will last because of its well-balanced spatial relationships. At first glance, the relationship between the humanity and the garden in Gen 2–3 is beneficial because the garden offers fruit for humans, who do not need to till the ground in the garden. Yet the garden in Eden is at the same time filled with chaos. After all, the first humans, having listened to the serpent, eat the fruit of the forbidden tree and are expelled from the garden in Eden.

The garden in Eden may symbolize Judah and Israel, the promised land which was lost after the fall of Samaria (722 BCE) and Jerusalem (587/586 BCE). The description of the four rivers in Gen 2:10–14 plays an important role in this symbolism. This passage, which might have been inspired by Ezek 47:1–12, basically locates the garden in Eden near Jerusalem. While the topographical descriptions of the garden in Eden do not quite fit the mythical narrative style of Gen 2–3, Gen 2:10–14 shows the ambiguity by confusing the geographical and nongeographical visions. The cherubim also suggest symbolism of Judah and Israel. On the one hand, the cherubim connect the garden in Eden to Judah and Israel. On the other hand, they make the garden in Eden a sacred, and at the same time forbidden, space. Taking the social and cultural context into account, the symbolism of the garden in Eden emphasizes a different perspective from Gen 1. The symbolism of garden in Eden suggests that the former promised land has been lost and that the Israelites will not come back. Genesis 2–3 emphasizes life without the temple.

11.2. The Priestly and Non-Priestly Flood Narratives of Genesis 6–9

11.2.1. *Physical Space*

Genesis 6–9 contains two versions of the flood narrative – Priestly and non-Priestly – that have been interwoven. The Priestly version includes Gen 6:9–22; 7:11, 13–16, 18–21, 24; 8:1–5, 7, 13–15, 17–19; and 9:1–17. The non-Priestly version includes Gen 6:5–8; 7:1–5, 7–9, 10, 12, 16b–17, 22–23; 8:1b, 2b–3a, 6–12, 13b, 20–22. Space in Gen 6–9 can also be structured into God’s space, humanity’s space, and nature’s space.

In the Priestly flood narrative, God’s space is first reflected by God’s relationship to the earthly world. The verb “see” (Gen 6:12) and the expression “before the world” imply that God is in a higher position, not in the earthly world. God can also move freely between his own space and this world. Especially when God establishes a covenant with Noah, the context is composed of earthly spatial settings. For the non-Priestly flood narrative, God’s space is also defined by its relationship with the earthly world. The verb “see” in Gen 6:5 indicates that God is not in the earthly world but in a high position so that he can see humanity as a whole on the earth. God’s high position is further suggested by the rain sent by God, which is different from the Priestly flood narrative.

At the beginning of the flood narrative, Gen 6:9 describes how Noah walked with, rather than before, God. The preposition “with” may suggest a close proximity between Noah and God. In the non-Priestly version, however, the phrases

“in the eyes of YHWH” (בעיני יהוה) and the verb “see” (ראה) hardly suggest such a relationship.

The ark is the most particular space associated with Noah in both the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives. Yet the two accounts are different in several important ways. First, the Priestly flood narrative describes specifically how God asks Noah to build the ark, and even its most basic geometrical features. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, however, there is no information about where the ark is from and what its geometrical features are. God just asks Noah to enter the ark, as the ark is already there. Second, “the window of the ark” (Gen 8:6) and “the covering of the ark” (Gen 8:13b) seem to anticipate the geometrical features of the ark, which are not found in the non-Priestly flood narrative.² Third, both the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives mention the ark during the flood: “and the waters increased, and lifted up the ark” (Gen 7:17), and “it rose high above the earth when there is flood, the ark floated on the surface of the waters” (Gen 7:18). Both narratives use the position of the ark to indicate the height of the flood. Fourth, after the flood, one striking difference between the two versions is that the non-Priestly flood narrative describes specifically how Noah sends the birds from the ark in Gen 8:6–13b.

In terms of nature’s space in the Priestly flood narrative, the earth is first defined as a space relative to the violence of humans by the verb “fill” (מלא) (Gen 6:11). The earth is also emphasized as the spatial focus before the flood. God destroys the world in the Priestly flood narrative by connecting the rain from the windows of the heaven and the fountains of the deep. The mountains are an important spatial setting during the flood since the phrase “the high mountains” and the noun “mountains” indicate both the height of flood and its scale. The mountains of Ararat are even specifically described as the place where the ark comes to rest and God establishes the covenant with Noah. In addition to mountains, the “cloud,” “earth,” and “rainbow” all vividly construct a spatial setting for the establishment of the covenant.

The earth is also an important spatial setting before the flood in the non-Priestly flood narrative. The sky appears together with the earth and is the spatial location of “birds.” The non-Priestly flood narrative highlights the rain as the only way in which God destroys the world. The rain is described not as being from the windows of heaven but as directly sent by God. During the flood, the height of the flood is measured by the ark and the earth rather than

² The different descriptions of the ark also cause confusion about the way the Priestly flood narrative and the non-Priestly flood narrative are interwoven; see J.C. GERTZ, “Beobachtungen zum literarischen Charakter und zum geistesgeschichtlichen Ort der nichtpriesterschriftlichen Sintfluterzählung,” in *Auf dem Weg zur Endgestalt von Genesis bis II Regum. Festschrift Hans-Christoph Schmitt* (ed. M. Beck and U. Schorn; BZAW 370; Berlin: de Gruyter, 2006), 41–57.

the mountain. After the flood, the spatial setting of the non-Priestly flood narrative is different from that of the Priestly flood narrative. The non-Priestly flood narrative focuses on the altar in Gen 8:20–22. There is no description of the natural environment after the flood.

11.2.2. Conceptual Space

The Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives both reflect a vertical view of the cosmos, but they reflect this view in different ways. In the Priestly flood narrative, the narrator describes a vertical axis that runs from deep in the earth up to heaven. The flood is formed from the fountains in the great deep and the rain from heaven (Gen 7:11). The fountains deep in the earth are described first, followed by the rain from heaven (Gen 7:11; 8:2). The vertical direction is therefore shown to go from down to up.

The vertical view of the cosmos is also emphasized in the non-Priestly flood narrative, yet there is no description of the water from deep in the earth. It is only the rain sent by God (אֲנֹכִי מִמָּטֶר עַל־הָאָרֶץ) that fell on the earth, forming the flood (e.g., Gen 7:4, 12, 17). Between the earth and the space where the rain is, the sky is emphasized by the description of the phrase “birds of the sky” (e.g., Gen 6:7). It seems that the narrator intends to always use the word “sky” with the birds to emphasize the sky, which is between the space above the sky and the earth under the sky. The non-Priestly flood narrative therefore has a three-level view of the cosmos in the non-Priestly flood narrative.

The “rain” (גֶּשֶׁם) seems not to be a natural phenomenon in either the Priestly or the non-Priestly flood narrative. The rain in the Priestly flood narrative comes about because “the windows of the heaven open,” which implies that the rain is from God who opens the windows. But the non-Priestly flood narrative explicitly states that the rain is sent by God, while there is no noun “heaven” (שָׁמַיִם).

Corresponding to Gen 1, the Priestly flood narrative shows a mixture of mythical space and less mythical space. The flood is, first of all, a projection of natural phenomena. These natural phenomena also have mythical characteristics when described in the flood narrative. Specifically, the mixture of mythical and less mythical space occurs through the juxtaposition of natural geographical and supernatural terms. The ark, for example, is described in geographical terms, and the specific dimensions of the ark are described in geometrical terms (Gen 6:14–16). However, the mythical function of ark is indicated by the claim that the ark is only the place that survives the flood (Gen 7:18). Natural geographical terms are usually juxtaposed with mythical descriptions, as in Gen 7:19–20, which contains both the less mythical “fifteen cubits higher” and the more mythical “all the high mountains everywhere under the heaven were covered.”

The Priestly flood narrative also contains a fluid zone between God and the human realm. God seems to appear freely in the human realm, and his activity often shares a scene with human activities, evident in a number of examples: First, “Noah walked *with* God” (Gen 6:9). Second, God instructs Noah specifically how to make the ark (Gen 6:14–22). Third, the flood recedes from the earth as God remembers Noah (Gen 8:1). Fourth, after the flood, it is God who asks Noah to come out of the ark (Gen 8:16). Finally, God is also in the human realm when he establishes the covenant with Noah (Gen 9:12–17). The non-Priestly flood narrative also involves a blurred boundary between God and the human realm. Although God does not tell Noah how to make the ark, God locks the ark during the flood. Then God may appear after the flood (Gen 8:20–22).

Both the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives show their concern with the earth. The non-Priestly flood narrative, like the Priestly flood narrative, shows its concern with the earth at the beginning of the narrative (Gen 6:5–8). The earth remains a spatial concern throughout the non-Priestly narrative. There are even two different words “earth” (ארץ) and “ground” (אדמה) that indicate the earth. Two aspects of the earth as conceptual space in this version should be considered: the scale of the earth and how the earth is shown rhetorically to be a spatial focus. The scale of the earth in the non-Priestly flood narrative includes not only the earth, where humans, animals, and creeping things live, but also the sky. The sea, which is a component of the world of creation in Gen 1, is not included in the earth in the non-Priestly flood narrative.

The “earth” (ארץ) or “ground” (אדמה) appears quite often in the non-Priestly flood narrative (Gen 6:5, 6, 7; 7:3, 4, 23; 8:8, 9, 11, 13b, 21, 22). The earth appears in almost every sentence in monologue in which God decides to destroy the world (Gen 6:5–8). In God’s speech to Noah in Gen 7:1–5, the earth is emphasized using by two different words: “earth” (ארץ) and “ground” (אדמה). When God sends the rain, the spatial point to which the rain and flood refer is the earth (Gen 7:12, 13). When the water increases, the earth and the ark are the only two spatial settings that measure the height of the flood (Gen 7:17). In the Priestly flood narrative, however, the mountains are the standard of measurement (e.g., Gen 7:19). After the flood, the earth again becomes the narrative focus in God’s monologue in Gen 8:20–22. The earth is the only space with which God is concerned.

11.2.3. Symbolic Space

The “bow” (קשת) is clearly and repeatedly described as a sign in Gen 9:13–17, the end of the Priestly flood narrative. The space where God establishes the covenant with Noah may also be a symbolic world (Gen 9:13–17). The symbolic meaning of “bow” is explicitly described by God: the bow is the sign “of the covenant which I am making between me and you and every living creature

that is with you, for all future generations” (Gen 9:12). While the word “bow” in other biblical texts generally refers to a type of weapon, the Priestly narrator, by wordplay, appropriates it for a peaceful atmosphere in the space where the covenant is made.³ The bow makes the covenant space a symbolic space through its aura. The bow is made a sign through action: God puts the bow in the cloud and gives it symbolic meaning. This is also the case with the mountains of Ararat. The Priestly flood narrative contains no description of the cultic place like the altar that appears in the non-Priestly flood narrative. The place where God establishes the covenant is on the mountains of Ararat. Among other spatial settings, these mountains become a sign through a symbolic action: God establishes there the covenant with Noah.

The symbolic space after the flood is constructed in a different way in the non-Priestly flood narrative (Gen 8:20–22). First, God does establish a covenant with Noah but does not even speak to Noah. The altar scene contains only a divine monologue. An altar sometimes symbolizes the ownership of a place in biblical narrative. The altar is described as the first place on the earth after the flood in the non-Priestly version. But there is no description of the ornaments of the altar, suggesting that the author’s ideology is anti-iconic. God gives his monologue when he smells the burnt offerings from the altar, but the narrator does not state whether God appears or not. Only the verb “smell” implies that God may be at a place where he could smell the offerings. There is also no description of the mountain referring to the altar, which is usually shown as such in the biblical narratives. The altar may embody for the Priestly narrator the idea of local sanctuaries such as those established by Abraham, Jacob, Moses, and Joshua (e.g., Gen 12:7, 8; 13:18; Josh 8:30), which would explain why he avoids using the cultic place in his version of the flood narrative. For the non-Priestly narrator, the mountain is probably an important and sacred space, so the non-Priestly narrator does not mention the mountain in the flood narrative.

The non-Priestly flood narrative contains two other important conceptual spaces before the flood and when the water recedes. The first is the correspondence between the spatial settings in Gen 7:1–5 and the description of the flood in Gen 7:12, 16b, 17, 22, 23. Genesis 7:1–5 is God’s speech to Noah, the longest speech in the flood narrative, in which God explains exactly how he will destroy the world and save Noah. God’s absolute sovereignty is shown by the correspondence of spatial settings between God’s speech and the flood description. Almost every spatial setting mentioned by God corresponds to the following description of the flood in Gen 7:12, 17, 22, and 23. This shows that everything God wants to save is saved and that everything that God wants to destroy is destroyed.

³ E.g., U. RÜTERSWORDEN, “Der Bogen in Genesis 9. Militärhistorische und traditions-geschichtliche Erwägungen zu einem biblischen Symbol,” *UF* 20 (1988), 247–63.

While there is no specific description of the ark before the flood, the non-Priestly flood narrative makes the ark an important space in the flood, especially when the water recedes (Gen 8:6–13). Not only do Noah and those with him survive in the ark, but it is also from the ark that Noah sends the birds to see whether the land is dry enough for them to disembark. In Gen 8:6–13, the ark is specifically a symbolic space: the center of the world. The change in the situation of the land and the descriptions of the actions of Noah and the birds are closely focused around the ark. In Gen 8:6–13, the ark is constructed rhetorically as the center of the different kinds of spatial relationship among Noah, the birds, heaven, and the earthly world. Noah sends the birds from the ark three times in order to see whether the land is dry. The first bird, a raven, does not come back, which might indicate that the rain lessened. This shows a relationship between heaven and earth. The last two birds, doves, come back when they find no place to set their feet (Gen 8:9). When they come back, it is Noah himself who puts out his hand and takes the doves. This description shows the relationships between Noah and the ark, between the birds and the ark, between heaven and earth, and between Noah and the birds. The ark here is the center of these spatial relationships, and Noah, who is in the ark, becomes the center of the ark. Together, they become the center of power.

11.2.4. The Spatial Construction in the Combined Text of Genesis 6–9

Although Gen 6–9 is woven together out of two different versions of the flood narrative, the combined text basically constitutes a harmonious narrative. When the compiler combined the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives, he retained to a great extent their original characteristics but also sought to make the two versions complement each other. This is supported by the descriptions of God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space.

The most important characteristic of God's space in both Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives is that God can move freely between his own space and the earthly world. God's movement creates a fluid boundary between God and the human realm. Therefore, although God's actions are not described in anthropomorphic terms in the Priestly version, the non-Priestly description of God "shutting" Noah in the ark during the flood (Gen 7:16b) is not unsuitable among the Priestly passages.

The spatial relationships between God and the human world in the Priestly text of Gen 6:11–13 and the non-Priestly text of Gen 6:5–8 complement each other. In both versions, God's space is presented from the perspective of God's actions. God is in a high position when he watches the human world. However, in Gen 6:11–13, the earth is the spatial focus from the perspective of God. What God sees is "flesh" (בשר), meaning humanity and the animals. In Gen 6:5–8, however, what God sees from his high position is humanity itself. Therefore, while Gen 6:11–13 presents a cosmological perspective by constructing the

spatial relationship between God and the whole world, Gen 6:5–8 emphasizes the spatial relation between God and humanity. The Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives therefore demonstrate both a cosmological and an anthropomorphic perspective before the flood.

The spatial element that effectively shows the complementarity of humanity's space in Priestly and non-Priestly texts is the ark. The construction of the ark is described in detail at the beginning of the Priestly flood narrative (Gen 6:14–16). However, there are not too many descriptions of the ark in the rest of the Priestly flood narrative. Although there is no mention of the ark's construction in the non-Priestly flood narrative, its function is described in detail in Gen 8:6–12. The Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives thus present the ark from the perspective of construction and function.

The views of space after the flood in the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narratives are more difficult to view as complementary. After the flood, the spatial context in the Priestly flood narrative is cosmological. God establishes the covenant with Noah on the mountains of Ararat. Furthermore, the other spatial elements like the bow (Gen 9:13–14, 16), the clouds (Gen 9:13–14, 16), and the water (Gen 9:15) are all natural phenomena. Yet the spatial context in the non-Priestly flood narrative (Gen 8:20–22) is the altar and sacrifice.⁴ While Gen 8:20–22 also describes natural phenomena, they are mentioned in God's speech rather than in the spatial context. The spatial contexts in Gen 9:1–17 and Gen 8:20–22 are not completely contradictory, however, because God does not speak to Noah in Gen 8:20–22, although God does speak in close proximity to Noah in Gen 9:1–17. The two narrative scenes are therefore complementary to each other in terms of God's actions.

With respect to the nature's space, the "rain" (גשם) in the non-Priestly version is hard to harmonize with the "water from heaven, the fountains of the great deep" (נבקעו כל-מעיינות תהום רבה וארבת השמים נפתחו) in the Priestly version. However, the mountain is a natural spatial element that is complementary in the Priestly and non-Priestly flood narrative. The mountain is an important spatial setting in the Priestly flood narrative. The mountain is either the measurement of the height and scale of the flood or the place on which God establishes the covenant with Noah. There is no mention of the mountain in the non-Priestly flood narrative. Neither version mentions the sea during the flood. The fish of the sea are described only after the flood in the Priestly Gen 9:2. It was probably hard for both the Priestly and the non-Priestly narrators to explain how the fish of the sea were destroyed by the flood.

⁴ With regard to Noah's sacrifice after flood, there is similar theme in the Gilgamesh Epic and Atrahasis; see G.J. WENHAM, *Genesis 1–15* (WBC 1; Waco, TX: Word, 1987), 159–64.

11.3. Genesis 1 and the Non-Priestly Flood Narrative of Genesis 6–9

11.3.1. Physical Space

God does not act in Gen 1 as directly as he does in the flood narrative of Gen 6–9. In Gen 1, God's space is defined mainly by the relationships among God's own space, the earth, and heaven. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, however, God's space is not only defined by the relationship between God and the earth but also suggested by the spatial relationships among God, Noah, the ark, and the altar. On the whole, whereas both Gen 1 and the non-Priestly flood narrative show that God is beyond the earthly world and has his own space, God appears on the earth in the non-Priestly flood narrative because he shuts Noah in the ark (Gen 7:16b).

Genesis 1 does not contain a lot of information in about humanity's space. Only the phrase "fill the earth" (ומלאו את-הארץ) in Gen 1:28 indicates that the humanity is on the earth. The description of the birds as flying "in the expanse of heaven" in Gen 1:20 also shows humanity's point of view. A lot of space can be constructed around human actions in the non-Priestly flood narrative, since humanity is a main actor. The most important human spaces in the non-Priestly flood narrative are the ark and the altar.

There are several differences between the natural spatial settings of Gen 1 and those of the non-Priestly flood narrative. The basic spatial settings in Gen 1 are "the sky and the earth" (את השמים ואת הארץ), "the surface of deep" (על-פני תהום), "the surface of the waters" (על-פני המים), "seas" (ימים), "the face of all the earth" (על-פני כל-הארץ), "the expanse of the sky" (רקיע השמים), and "the waters" (המים). The spatial settings in the non-Priestly flood narrative are mainly the earth and the sky. The sky is also generally used as the noun in relation to birds. The most important difference is that there are no fountains deep in the earth or seas in the non-Priestly flood narrative. For the non-Priestly flood narrative, the most important natural spaces are heaven, whence the rain is sent, and the earth, where humanity lives. The earth is shown to be the most important narrative focus in the non-Priestly flood narrative.

11.3.2. Conceptual Space

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, the view of the cosmos basically follows that in Gen 1. The view of the cosmos is also stratified, which is indicated mainly by the rain from the heaven above the sky. But the non-Priestly flood narrative contains no description of the deep earth.

Because of the difference between the natural spatial settings in Priestly and non-Priestly versions of the flood narrative, the non-Priestly version does not emphasize how God destroys the well-ordered world and the well-structured

spatial relationships. The spatial focus in the non-Priestly flood narrative is the earth. The non-Priestly narrator shows how God destroys the earth where humanity lives. While the word “field” (אדמה) is used in only one place in Gen 1 (Gen 1:25), it appears more times in the non-Priestly flood narrative (Gen 7:4, 23; 8:13b). The spatial reference of the earth in the non-Priestly flood narrative is mainly to the creatures on the earth. In Gen 1, the earth is also at the center of the spatial relationships. But the spatial reference to the earth involves other spatial settings that are indicated by internal circle. Therefore, Gen 1 and the non-Priestly flood narrative show the earth as the spatial focus in two different manners.

Genesis 1 does not involve many descriptions of humanity. The anthropocentrism in Gen 1 is reflected mainly in its functionalism. God asks humanity to manage the world. In the non-Priestly flood narrative, Noah, the representative of humanity, is a main character. God’s actions are all about humanity, which is demonstrated mainly by his speeches in Gen 6:5–8 and his monologue in Gen 8:20–22. The reason why God destroys and then saves the world has to do with humanity living on the earth. Noah’s power is especially reflected in Gen 8:6–13. The ark is described as the center of spatial relationships. The ark becomes the center of the world. All of the information should be brought back to the ark. Noah, who is in the ark, is at the center of power.

The spatial relationships in Gen 1 also reflect the universality of space. God does not seem to be in the earthly world when he creates the world. While the boundary between God’s space and humanity’s space is less apparently blurred in the non-Priestly flood narrative than in the Priestly version, God is able to intervene more freely in the earthly world. God talks to Noah directly, and when the flood occurs, it is God who locks the ark. After the flood, God probably appears in a realm from where he could smell the burnt offerings.

11.3.3. Symbolic Space

In both Gen 1 and the non-Priestly flood narrative, God has absolute power over the earth. God’s power in Gen 1 is evident in the fact that he created the order of the world through his speech. Speech is therefore an important medium for God’s power in the earthly world. This may reflect Priestly interests. Some biblical texts associate instructions in ancient Israel with priests (Jer 18:18; Mal 2:6–9). God’s speeches in Gen 1 highlight the authority of Priestly instructions.⁵

In the non-Priestly flood narrative, however, God’s absolute sovereignty over the earth is evident from the fact that he can destroy and save the world at will. God destroys the world not through speech but through rain, which is

⁵ M.S. SMITH, *The Priestly Vision of Genesis 1* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2010), 66–67.

a concrete natural phenomenon. God sends the rain to destroy the earth and the creatures. However, speech does play an important role in the non-Priestly flood narrative, in God's long speech to Noah in Gen 7:1–5. God's power is shown by the correspondence between the spatial settings in Gen 7:1–5 and the descriptions of the flood in Gen 7:12, 16b, 17, 22, 23. While God does not control the world through his speech, this correspondence between spatial settings also shows that God has absolute power over the earth.

Genesis 1 describes a balanced world, which may reflect the contemporary situation. This is the world the Israelites longed for after the fall of Judah and Jerusalem.⁶ For the non-Priestly flood narrative, even this well-structured world could be destroyed by God. It is only after the flood that God decides not to destroy the world again. This may provide evidence against the view that the world can be destroyed if humanity is not obedient to God. There is no description of the cultic places related to Jerusalem or to the temple. The non-Priestly flood narrative, however, contains a description of the altar after the flood. At the same time, the altar is also highly symbolic. The narrative of the altar focuses only on its function as a site for offering sacrifice. God decides not to destroy the world again around the altar.

11.4. The Priestly Flood Narrative of Genesis 6–9 and Gen 11:1–9

11.4.1. *Physical Space*

Both the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 and Gen 11:1–9 show the nature of the spatial relationship between God and the earthly world. In the Priestly flood narrative, God's space is located on a higher level and is not in the earthly world. God's space is more complex in Gen 11:1–9, since there are more descriptions of his actions (Gen 11:5–9). The verbs “come down” (Gen 11:5) and “go down” (Gen 11:7) show that God is in a high position and needs to “go down” in order to see the people on the earth. The expression “dispersed them from there over the surface of all the earth” (Gen 11:8a) also shows that God's space is relative to the whole earth. In the flood narrative, God's high position is evident mainly in use of the verb “see.” Yet Gen 11:1–9 still has no direct description of God's actions on earth. God's actions on earth are only implied by the consequences of his actions for humanity.

⁶ T. KRÜGER, “Genesis 1:1–2:3 and the Development of the Pentateuch,” in *The Pentateuch: International Perspectives on Current Research* (ed. T.B. Dozeman, K. Schmid, and B.J. Schwartz; FAT 78; Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 2011), 125–38, here 137–38.

Humanity's space in the Priestly flood narrative is constructed by Noah's actions. The proximity between God and Noah is shown physically and conceptually by the use of the phrase "Noah walked with God" (אֶת־הָאֱלֹהִים (הִתְהַלֵּךְ־נֹחַ) (Gen 6:9) and by God's direct speeches to Noah. The ark is also the spatial focus of Noah. The construction of the ark and its function in the flood are described specifically. It is only in the ark that Noah and those with him survived. Genesis 11:1–9 also involves two spaces which are close to humanity as a whole: the city and the tower. Similar to the ark, the city and the tower are indispensable narrative elements. The actions of humanity and God all take place around the city and tower. There is also specific information about the building materials for both structures.

With respect to nature's space, the Priestly flood narrative is more concerned with general spatial settings such as the earth, heaven, mountains, and natural phenomena like clouds. The Priestly flood narrative uses these to show how God controls the world, which is created in Gen 1. While Gen 11:1–9 also concerns the "whole earth," the natural spatial settings are very different from those in the Priestly flood narrative. This is suggested first by the figurative use of "the whole earth," which indicates "all the people of the earth" in Gen 11:1. The geographical terms "valley" and "the land of Shinar" in Gen 11:1–9 are both natural spatial settings that are closely related to humanity's life. Furthermore, the "land of Shinar," with the city of Babel, clearly constitutes the literary setting of Gen 11:1–9 in Babylon. The Babel narrative also uses the cardinal word "East," which indicates that humanity has journeyed.

11.4.2. Conceptual Space

The Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 shows a vertical and stratified view of cosmos, which basically follows the view of the cosmos found in Gen 1. For the Babel narrative of Gen 11:1–9, the view of the cosmos is only partly reflected in God's actions. God twice "comes down," and use of the first person plural "us" in Gen 11:5 implies a stratified space consisting of God's space, the divine council's space, the sky, and humanity's space.

That said, the view of the cosmos is not the narrative focus in Gen 11:1–9. Rather, the narrator is concerned with several spatial tensions formed by the actions of God and humanity. First is the spatial tension between God's space and humanity's space. This tension is suggested by the correspondence of Gen 11:1 and 9, Gen 11:2 and 8, Gen 11:3 and 7, Gen 11:4 and 7, and Gen 11:5 and 6. In this spatial framework, there is no fluid zone between God and human realm as there is in the Priestly flood narrative. Rather, God and humanity each have their own space.

Second, from the perspective of nature's space, there is a tension between locative place and universal space in Gen 11:1–9. The locative places are the

valley and the land of Shinar, where humanity wanted to stay, while the universal space is the whole earth. The Priestly flood narrative contains a description of how God blesses humanity, ordering them to multiply, which indicates that humanity should cover the whole earth. But this corresponds to the same description in Gen 1:28 rather than referring to a certain locative place.

Third, there is a tension among the city of Babel, the tower, and the whole earth in Gen 11:1–9. This spatial tension is evident in humanity's aim in building and by the function of the city of Babel and the tower. The aim of their building is clearly described in Gen 11:4: they build the city and tower in order not to be dispersed over the whole surface of the earth. Their aim is suggested by the phrase "so that." This tension is also indicated by God's actions of confusing the language of humanity and dispersing the humans over the whole surface of the earth.

11.4.3. Symbolic Space

Symbolic space is clearly reflected in the descriptions of the covenant space in the Priestly flood narrative. The "bow" and the "mountains of Ararat" all become signs as God establishes the covenant with Noah. Whereas the signs in the Priestly flood narrative are natural spatial settings like the "bow" and "mountain," the main signs in Genesis 11:1–9 are human spaces: the city and the tower, which can be clearly associated with the political context since Babel in Shinar is the capital of Babylon.

The city and the tower in Gen 11:1–9 are typical signs since they have different etiologies. One important characteristic of the city as symbolic space in Gen 11:1–9 is that the city, which God names "Babel," appropriates the meanings of cities in other texts in the primeval history. Two places are already described as cities before Babel in Gen 11:1–9. One is the city of Enoch (Gen 4:16–17), and the other involves the cities built by Nimrod, the beginning of whose kingdom was Babel, Erech, and Accad in the land of Shinar (Gen 10:8–12). In biblical exegesis, Nimrod is quite often associated with the city of Babel in Gen 11:1–9, although Gen 10:8–12 does not clearly state that Nimrod builds the city of Babel. It is more likely that Gen 11:1–9 appropriates the meanings of the city in Gen 10:8–12 and reinterprets the reason why there are different languages and populations given in Genesis 10. The symbolic meanings of the city, which especially involve the multiplicity of humanity and language, are therefore suggested by its appropriation of the meanings of the city in Gen 4:16–17 and Gen 10:8–12.

The symbolic meaning of the tower is likewise suggested by its difference from the way other towers are described in biblical texts. The tower, especially with "its top in the sky" (וראשו בשמים) has usually been taken as evidence that humanity is challenging God's authority. From the perspective of humanity's actions, especially in Gen 11:4, however, the aim in building the tower is not

to challenge God in heaven. Rather, Gen 11:4 clearly states that the aim of humanity is merely the following: “so that we will not be dispersed over the surface of all the earth” (פְּנִינֵנוּ עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ). The phrase “its top in the sky” (וְרֵאשׁוֹ בַשָּׁמַיִם), when compared to other biblical and Near Eastern texts, should most likely be interpreted as a metaphorical writing strategy. This can also be seen from God’s perspective: his reaction in Gen 11:5–9 also has nothing to do with his authority in heaven being challenged but is aimed at limiting the power of humanity, a power evident in their building the city and tower and in their capacity to make a name for themselves. God therefore confuses the language of humanity and disperses the humans over the whole surface of the earth. On the whole, the city and the tower do not symbolize hubris in challenging God. Rather, they are just the means for showing the power of humanity and explaining how God brings about the multiplicity of language and of humanity.

11.5. Genesis 2–3 and the Priestly Flood Narrative of Genesis 6–9

11.5.1. Physical Space

In both Gen 2–3 and the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, God’s space can be suggested by his actions. God acts more in Gen 2–3 than in the Priestly flood narrative: he not only creates the world, forms the first man and Eve, and plants and walks in the garden but also talks a lot to humanity. God’s actions in Gen 2–3 are also anthropomorphic, which makes the reflection of God’s space more direct than in the Priestly flood narrative. In the Priestly flood narrative, God’s space is also suggested by his actions. His space relative to the whole earth is implied by the fact that he can see the earth as a whole. He also talks to Noah, whether before the flood or after the flood. God also seems to be able move freely between his space and the earthly world.

The earth and the garden in Eden are two important spatial references for humanity. In Gen 2–3, the humanity is tied to the earth, and the importance of the garden in Eden in defining humanity’s space is elaborated by the actions of the first man and Eve in the garden.⁷ In the Priestly flood narrative, the ark is the particular space of humanity. It is in the ark that Noah and those with him survive. Whereas the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 describes exactly

⁷ In particular, Gen 2:8 and Gen 2:15 give different suggestions about the relationship between the first man and the garden in Eden. Gen 2:15 emphasizes the relationship between humanity and the earth, because it suggests that the first human is brought by God into the garden from somewhere outside the garden. Gen 2:8, on the other hand, emphasizes the difference between the garden and the earth outside the garden, because it does not state that the first human still needs to work in the garden.

where the ark is from and how it functions, there is no information about humanity's actions in the ark.

Genesis 2–3 involves two types of natural space. The first type concerns the creation of the world. The narrator describes the natural elements, such as the field and plants that are necessary for earthly life. The second type of natural space concerns the spatial settings, especially the rivers and trees in the garden. The descriptions of the rivers in the garden (Gen 2:10–14) also locate the garden in Eden geographically. The natural spatial settings in the Priestly flood narrative basically follow those created in Gen 1 and are relative to the whole earth in the Priestly flood narrative. It is also harder to locate the flood, although the mountains of Ararat indicate where God establishes the covenant with Noah.

11.5.2. Conceptual Space

The view of the cosmos in Gen 2–3, and especially in Gen 2:4b–7, is both horizontal and vertical, whereas the view of the cosmos in the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 is vertical. In Gen 2–3, the rain “sent by God” implies a vertical view of cosmos. The other natural spatial settings like the earth, the fields, the plants, and the whole earth all demonstrate the horizontal nature of humanity's earthly world. In the Priestly flood narrative, a vertical axis from the deep earth to heaven is shown by the flood.

One element indicating the proximity between God and humanity in Gen 2–3 is that God “commands” the first man (Gen 2:16). The Priestly flood narrative also shows the proximity between God and Noah, as God has also “commanded” (צוה) Noah (e.g., Gen 6:22). In this case, however, God does not speak to Noah directly. The proximity between God and Noah is evident mainly in the phrase “Noah walked with God” (אֵת-יְהוָה הלֵךְ נֹחַ).

The description of space in the Priestly flood narrative also mixes mythical and less mythical visions of space, as shown by the juxtaposition of natural geographical and supernatural terms. The description of four rivers (Gen 2:10–14) does the same thing in Gen 2–3. On the one hand, Gen 2:10–14, which was likely added later, uses the geographical terms to help locate the garden in Eden. On the other hand, it uses both locative and nonlocative terms, which fits the narrative style of Gen 2–3. The description of cherubim (Gen 3:24) is probably also intended to locate the garden in Eden near Jerusalem.

In both Gen 2–3 and the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, God can move freely from his space to the earthly human world. In Gen 2–3, it seems that God makes the garden to serve as a place of leisure for himself. The garden in Eden is God's place, which is especially evident in Gen 2:15, which describes how God asks the first man to keep and till it, just as the Israelites keep the tabernacle and temple for God. God also moves freely between his space and

the human world in the Priestly flood narrative, but there is no special place to which he goes, such as the garden in Eden.

11.5.3. Symbolic Space

Both Gen 2–3 and the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9 describe a space that has both order and chaos. God expels the first man and Eve from the garden in Eden because they are disobedient to him. In the Priestly flood narrative, God decides to destroy the world because of humanity's corruption. Both texts also have signs: the trees in the garden in Gen 2–3 and the bow in the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9. The garden in Eden is also highly symbolic in Gen 2–3, where it symbolizes a place near Jerusalem. The loss of the garden in Eden is therefore associated with the loss of the promised land. The descriptions of the four rivers and of the cherubim help to establish this symbolism. The cherubim, which make the garden both sacred and forbidden, are also given their symbolic meanings by God, just as the bow is in the Priestly flood narrative.

11.6. Genesis 1 and Genesis 11:1–9

11.6.1. Physical Space

The spatial settings in Gen 1 are established with reference to the whole cosmos. God's space is defined primarily with reference to the world he creates, especially "all the earth." In Gen 11:1–9, "all the earth" is also an important spatial setting, although it refers mainly to humanity rather than God. "All the earth" refers only to humanity in Gen 1 and is mentioned only in Gen 1:28. God acts a lot in Gen 11:1–9, and his space is defined mainly by his actions.

Genesis 1:28 is almost the only place where humanity's space is clearly reflected, and the reference space is the whole earth. The point of view shown in Gen 1:20 also implies that humanity's position is under the sky and above the earth. In Gen 11:1–9, humanity as a whole becomes the active subject, so humanity's space can be elaborated from many perspectives based on the actions of humans. The city and the tower are the two most important human spaces that do not appear in Gen 1. The Babel narrative implies a development of human civilization and fits well with the following patriarchal narratives, in which more and more human spaces appear.

The natural settings in Gen 11:1–9 are also closely associated with human society. The important spatial settings like "the valley" and "the land of Shinar" are geographical terms. Shinar, especially, already indicates that the spatial setting of Gen 11:1–9 is the land of Babylon. For Gen 1, the natural spatial settings are more about the world itself.

11.6.2. Conceptual Space

Genesis 1 embodies a vertical and stratified view of the cosmos. This is probably one of the aims of the narrative. In Gen 11:1–9, however, a stratified view of the cosmos is only implied by God's actions, specifically by the fact that he "comes down" twice. Genesis 11:1–9 shows a stratified cosmos in its references to God's space, the divine council's space, the sky, and the earth. Compared to Gen 1, Gen 11:1–9 is more concerned with the horizontal earthly world, especially with the multiplicity of languages and populations. Emphasis on the horizontal earthly world is further suggested by the several spatial tensions reflected in Gen 11:1–9. The specific locations are indispensable elements for constructing these spatial tensions. In Gen 1, however, the narrator shows a well-ordered and balanced world. The world in general, rather than the specific locations within the world, is the narrative focus.

Genesis 11:1–9 also uses the cardinal word "east" (קדם), which is closely associated with humanity's actions, particularly their journey from the East to the valley of Shinar. In Gen 1, fixed spatial relations are constructed with reference to different spatial settings. Genesis 11:1–9 does not show the structure of the world as a whole but is more concerned with the relationship between humans and the earth where they live.

11.6.3. Symbolic Space

Compared to Gen 11:1–9, Gen 1 tells how the world is well structured by God and focuses on the relationships among different spatial settings. Genesis 11:1–9, however, tells how humanity acts in the land of Shinar, specifically the land of Babylon. While Gen 1 and Gen 11:1–9 both set their stories in a remote time, the symbolic space present in them suggests possible social and political influences after the fall of Judah and Jerusalem (587/586 BCE). The symbolic world of Gen 1 can generally be explained by its Priestly vision. Genesis 1 emphasizes the instructions of God, the balanced world, and fixed spatial relations that are not easily destroyed. The symbolic world in Gen 11:1–9 is evident mainly in the specific places: the city and the tower. The city and the tower of Babel, which are found in the land of Shinar, along with the other narrative elements, explain how the multiplicity of language and humanity came about. The Babel narrative takes Babylonia, which is clearly indicated by the city of Babel and Shinar, as the place where the diversity of language and humanity originated. The multiplicity of nations and languages is what the Israelites experienced intensively in the exilic and Persian periods. According to Gen 11:1–9, humanity must be diverse and speak different languages since this is already said by God, as in Gen 1:28; 9:1.

Chapter 12

Conclusion

Space in the Hebrew Bible has been increasingly studied from the perspective of critical spatiality. On the one hand, critical spatiality emphasizes the social dimension of space, focusing on the social and cultural contexts in which space is constructed and what social elements may influence the construction of space in texts. On the other hand, it emphasizes how people experience space and their creativity in constructing space.

This work has investigated the discourses on space in Gen 1–11 and discussed the connection between social space and spatial narrative. While scholars have analyzed space in the Hebrew Bible in terms of spatial narrative or social space, existing scholarship has paid more attention to the narrative texts from Exodus onward since spatial settings in these accounts, like the tabernacle, are more concrete and observable; they rarely concern themselves with Gen 1–11. The names of cities and towns, palaces, houses, pastures, rivers, streams, wells, hills, and trees that likely existed in ancient times are pointed out to readers. These spatial settings are at times also embellished with geographical, social, and anthropological elements. The lack of such settings makes the consideration of space in Gen 1–11 a different kind of task. In the present work, I have argued that space in Gen 1, 2–3, 6–9, and 11:1–9 is not only a mythical space but also a social and cultural construct that is constructed rhetorically in each narrative.

Genesis 1–11 is composed of Priestly texts and non-Priestly texts. Important elements related to space in the Priestly texts include the space of creation; the view of the cosmos; and the connection of the space of creation with the tabernacle and the temple. The non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 are concerned with the space of creation and the view of the cosmos but also involve important spatial elements not present in the Priestly texts, such as the garden in Eden and the tower of Babel. The space described in the non-Priestly texts is more closely connected to God's actions on earth. It also refers to more direct spatial relations between God and humanity.

The space described in both Priestly and non-Priestly texts in Gen 1–11 is conceptual space, which can hardly be experienced or observed directly. The rhetorical strategies employed are therefore significant for constructing space in these texts. On the basis of critical spatiality, the present work has analyzed how the social dimension of space is constructed rhetorically in Gen 1–11,

considering the issue from the perspective of spatial narrative. I have argued that the different perspectives, persons, motion verbs, prepositions, metaphors, and juxtapositions influence the construction of space and reflect the social dimension of space. The spatial foci and the rhetorical strategies used to achieve them are different in the Priestly and non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11, and each reflects a different social context.

In most cases, space has no fixed definition. The history of the study of space was discussed in order to define space in the present work. The distinction between discussions of space in physics and philosophy was not very clear until Immanuel Kant, after whom the study of space took two different directions, focusing on either physical space or philosophical space. At the beginning of the twentieth century, Emile Durkheim's discussion of the social and cultural nature of space constituted a new direction. The 1970s saw a "spatial turn" in the social sciences that influenced many disciplines. Society, culture, and many phenomena came gradually to be treated in terms of critical spatiality. The first examples of critical spatiality can be found already in the 1960s, in the works of Michel Foucault, who focused on heterotopia, or the connection between social power and space.

Critical spatiality continued to develop in the 1970s and 1980s. Its main representatives in this period were Henri Lefebvre and Edward Soja. Lefebvre established a trialectic of space which has been used as a framework for subsequent critical studies of space. He argued that space can be considered from the points of view of spatial practice, representations of space, and representational space. He showed a strong interest in the connection between production and space, emphasizing that space is a social product. Soja developed this framework and renamed the trialectic of space "firstspace," "secondspace," and "thirdspace." He focused more on social practice than social product, especially in the concept of thirdspace, which concerns the themes of race, power, and the relationship between politics and space. It emphasizes the creativity of humanity and how social practices construct space by giving it symbolic meaning in daily life. Such space can be understood as symbolic space.

I have considered space in Gen 1–11 from the perspective of physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space. I divided space in the Priestly and non-Priestly texts into God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space, each with its own distinctive characteristics. God's space, as it is presented in the Priestly texts, involves both the space where God dwells and the space where he appears. God has his residence in heaven as well as on the earth. God's space illustrates the themes of monotheism and universalism. In the non-Priestly texts, on the other hand, God's space is closely connected with his actions on earth. For example, God talks directly with humans in the garden in Eden. Humanity's space in the Priestly texts includes the space of humanity, the space of the ancestors, and the space of the Israelites. The space of humanity is depicted mainly in the flood narrative, including spaces of blessing and covenant.

Humanity's space in the non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 also appears in Gen 6–9 but is mainly in Gen 2–3 and Gen 11:1–9, where humans are the main characters and the descriptions of God's actions are anthropomorphic. Nature's space in both the Priestly and non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 is reflected mainly in the view of the cosmos and is described in geographical terms.

On the basis of the characteristics of space in the Priestly and non-Priestly texts, I used the Priestly texts of Gen 1 and 6–9 as well as the non-Priestly texts of Genesis 2–3, 6–9, and Gen 11:1–9 as examples to discuss how physical space, conceptual space, and symbolic space are constructed through rhetorical strategies in the framework of spatial narrative.

Physical space is related to form, size, and material. It can also be related to motion and direction. Genesis 1 tells how God created the cosmos, the world, and humanity. There are not too many descriptions of the space of God and humanity in Gen 1, since the main focus of Priestly authors is on the cosmos and the world. How the space of God and humanity is constructed was understood through the analysis of prepositions, motion verbs, and narrative perspectives (e.g., Gen 1:28, 29). Nature's space is the subject of more detailed introductions and descriptions. Priestly authors mainly use reference points (e.g., Gen 1:17, 20) and prepositions (Gen 1:20, 25–26) to construct it rhetorically. In Gen 6–9, physical space can also be considered from the perspective of God's space, humanity's space, and nature's space. Motion verbs are significant in constructing God's space in Gen 6–9. Regarding humanity's space, Noah's ark and the space after the flood is elaborately constructed by the Priestly authors. Nature's space is the space destroyed in Gen 6–9 but is not, at least in the physical sense, that created by God in Gen 1. The time frame can also indicate the physical aspect of space (e.g., Gen 8:5). As a non-Priestly text, Gen 2–3 describes God in anthropomorphic terms. God's physical space is reflected mainly by his actions like planting the garden (Gen 2:8) and talking to humans (e.g., Gen 2:16). Humanity's space can similarly be described from the point of view of human actions, in which speeches also play an important role. The Eden narrative of Gen 2–3 contains many types of natural spatial elements. The space of creation is specifically described in Gen 2:4b–7, and spatial settings like the rivers and trees in the garden are pertinent to the theme of the narrative. Gen 2:10–14 is a particularly important passage because of its mixture of locative and nonlocative terms. In the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, God acts directly; he even locks the ark during the flood. The ark is also an important space for humanity, as it is in the Priestly flood narrative. In Gen 11:1–9, the plot develops through the actions of God and humanity. Nature's space, represented by places like Shinar, Babel, the city, and the tower, which are indispensable narrative elements.

Conceptual space is the idea of space in human minds. The space found in texts is conceptual space, which is constructed using signs. In my analysis of conceptual space in Gen 1, I claimed that the idea of space involves mainly the

ordered and well-structured cosmos, the universalism of space, and both mythical and non-mythical space. The present work focused on the rhetorical strategies by which these conceptual ideas of space are constructed in texts. In the Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, the idea of space focuses on vertical space, as well as the juxtaposition of mythical and nonmythical space. There is also a fluid zone between God’s space and humanity’s space in the flood narrative. Genesis 2–3 shows both horizontal and vertical views of the cosmos. Important spatial relationships are constructed around the garden in Eden, which is described on the whole as an “other” space. Speeches contain a particular conceptual space: the distance between God and humanity. Genesis 2–4 also shows a spatial continuity. The structure of the cosmos is reflected in the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, and the earth is the spatial focal point. Conceptual space in Gen 11:1–9 involves three tensions: between God’s and humanity’s space; between locative place and universal space; and among the city, the tower, and the whole earth.

The discussion of symbolic space focused on the way in which narrators give these symbolic meanings to space in narrative. For example, I showed how in Gen 1 symbolic space is constructed by adapting and appropriating the symbolic meanings in the other creation accounts, as well as to what extent it was influenced by contemporaneous social and cultural elements. Regarding the Priestly flood narrative, I focused on space after flood, the space where the covenant is established. A certain object in space can be used to create symbolic space. For example, the bow (Gen 9:13, 14, 16) makes the space in which the covenant is established symbolic by its aura. The bow also shows how a natural object becomes a conceptual sign, then transforms from a conceptual sign into a symbolic sign. Since this space is where God establishes a covenant with humanity (Gen 9:13–17), practice is a significant element in constructing it. The garden in Eden is the most important symbolic sign in Gen 2–3. I argued that the garden in Eden symbolizes a sacred place near Jerusalem, which is suggested by the descriptions of the four rivers and the cherubim. In the non-Priestly flood narrative of Gen 6–9, I showed how the correspondence between spatial settings in Gen 7:1–5 and Gen 7:12, 17, 22, 23 conveys God’s absolute authority over the earth. The ark and the altar are also important symbolic spaces in the non-Priestly flood narrative. The ark is constructed rhetorically as the center of the world. The depiction of the altar appropriates the traditional meanings of cultic space. The city and the tower are two symbolic spaces in Gen 11:1–9. I focused on how the city and the tower are described in order to symbolize the power of humanity, and how the multiplicity of language and humans are connected with the city and the tower.

On the whole, the present work makes three main contributions. First, it discusses spatial relationships rather than just individual places. The spatial relationships among a variety of places important to the biblical narrative –

like the tabernacle, the villages, trees, and palaces – are indispensable for narrative plot and theme. Genesis 1 emphasizes the well-structured world by means of well-structured spatial relationships. It also shows a spherical cosmos by arranging the spatial relations. In Gen 2–3, the spatial relationships are constructed around the garden in Eden. The spatial relationship between the garden in Eden and humanity and the distance between God and humanity are pertinent to the theme and plot of the Eden narrative. The spatial tensions in Gen 11:1–9 are suggested by spatial relationships among God, humanity, the valley of Shinar, Babel, the city, the tower, and the whole earth.

I have also emphasized the portable characteristics of space. Space is not fixed, as place is, but is moveable. For example, an important spatial aspect of Gen 1–11 is the journeys undertaken by humans. The ark is a typical space when it floats during the flood in Gen 6–9. The movements of God and humanity are also significant for interpreting the space. For example, the universalized space of God in the Priestly texts is suggested by God's free movement. God has no fixed place; he moves freely here and there. In Gen 2–3, the different ways God takes the first man into the garden in Eden reflect the different spatial relationships (Gen 2:8, 15).

Second, using a trialectic of space as a theoretical framework allowed me to get an overall view of space in Gen 1–11, and particularly to focus on how space is not a vacuum or value free but is a social construct. The first type of space involves the physical elements described in the biblical texts: the sky and the earth in Gen 1; the garden in Eden, the four rivers, and trees in Gen 2–3; the earth, the flood, and the mountains in Gen 6–9; and the valley of Shinar, the city, the tower, and the earth in Gen 11:1–9. The physical space is closely linked to different characteristics and positions in narrative.

The second type of space, conceptual space, concerns the relationships among different spatial elements, or how the narrator thinks about an individual place. For example, the well-structured spatial relationships in Gen 1; the spatial relationships among God, humanity, the earthly world, and the garden in Eden in Gen 2–3; and the spatial relationship between earth and humanity in Gen 6–9 and Gen 11:1–9. One important conceptual idea about space these texts share is the view of the cosmos.

The third type of space, symbolic space, focuses on the social context that may have influenced conceptual space and how social meanings are constructed by the narrator. Symbolic space is also concerned with the appropriation and challenge of the traditional meaning of a certain place or spatial relationships. It is fruitful to discuss how the Priestly and non-Priestly narrators, writing in different contexts, show their different views about the places and spatial relationships through different styles of texts. For example, Gen 1 emphasizes spatial relationships rather than specific geographical places, giving voice to the Priestly view that the basic spatial relationships in the cosmos are maintained and cannot be easily destroyed. This is probably projected by the

fall of Jerusalem in 587/586 BCE. In Gen 2–3, the non-Priestly narrator is more concerned with the earthly life outside the temple.

Third, studying how space is depicted in biblical texts has required me to emphasize the narrative aspect of space. Space in biblical texts is first of all narrative space, which is rhetorically constructed. Space and place are essential narrative elements in Gen 1–11. The narrators of different texts use space and place to show their different literary goals. They carefully and intentionally describe the spaces and places and arrange the different types of spatial relationships using different rhetorical means.

I showed how physical space is evident in perspectives, persons, and motion verbs. In Gen 1, for example, analyzing prepositions, motion verbs, and narrative perspectives (e.g., Gen 1:28, 29) enabled me to discuss how God's space and humanity's space are constructed. In Gen 2–3 and 6–9, God's space and humanity's space are constructed using mainly motion verbs and different perspectives. In Gen 11:1–9, motion verbs are significant for discussing the spaces associated with God and humanity.

Conceptual space is also constructed with perspectives, persons, and motion verbs. In Gen 1, the spherical cosmos is evident mainly in the use of prepositions. In Gen 2–3, 6–9 and 11:1–9, God's actions and the actions of humans are generally narrated with perspectives and motion verbs. Speech in Gen 2–3 is important for constructing the distance between God and humanity, which is an important theme of the Eden narrative. In Gen 11:1–9, conceptual space is constructed through spatial tensions in which motion verbs play an important role.

Symbolic space in the non-Priestly texts of Gen 1–11 can in many cases be described by referring to other biblical texts. There are several prominent examples in the interpretation of space in Gen 1–11. The first is the description of the four rivers in Gen 2:10–14, probably inspired by Ezek 47:1–12 which describes how a river flows around the temple. This is helpful for locating the garden near Jerusalem. At the same time, the description of the four rivers has both locative and nonlocative dimensions. The garden in Eden is on the whole not located. In Gen 6–9, the ark's function is universalized by reference to Exod 2:3, and the ark is constructed as the center of the world by reference to the tabernacle (i.e., the cover *מכסה* of the ark and tabernacle). The symbolism of the city and the tower in Gen 11:1–9 can also be understood in light of Gen 10:8–12. The present work therefore pays close attention to the narrative aspect of space in biblical texts, suggesting that narrative space has an essential connection with the discussion of space in the Hebrew Bible.

Appendix: Key Concepts of Space

Physical Space

Physical space pertains to form, size, and material. It can generally be concrete and observed; it is also related to motion and direction. Physical spaces described in texts include landscapes, movements, places, locations, borders, and settings. This type of space is constructed mainly through the use of position words, prepositions, motion verbs, and narrative perspectives.

Conceptual Space

Conceptual space is the idea of space in people's minds. It cannot be experienced by humans and has to be deduced from media. The ideas of a narrator about space can be inferred from his or her descriptions of space. Conceptual space concerns how the narrator arranges the spatial relationships or describes the layout of a certain space.

Symbolic Space

Symbolic space concerns the sociological and cultural determinants of conceptual space. Symbolic space is the space where people live and which they experience. It focuses on how people living in spaces and places give them symbolic meanings. A certain space or place normally acquires symbolic meaning through human practices that take place in it.

Perceived Space

The first category of Henri Lefebvre's spatial triad is also termed "spatial practice." It emphasizes the material aspect of the space, in other words, locations or spatial settings. This space can normally be evaluated empirically. It is produced through spatial practices.

Conceived Space

The second category of Lefebvre's spatial triad is also termed "representations of space." It is the conceptualized and dominant space in society. The concept of conceived space involves examining how we use signs to indicate space. The design of church, the plan of a temple, or a map of a city belong to conceived space.

Lived Space

The third category of Lefebvre's spatial triad is also termed "representational space." The lived space concerns "inhabitants" and "users." Its meaning and sense are given by culture and society. Lived space has an essential connection with symbolism. It is the dominant space, which the imagination seeks to change and appropriate.

Firstspace

Edward Soja renamed Lefebvre's "perceived space" as "thirdspace" in his critical postmodern analysis of trialectics of spatiality, emphasizing objective and material space.

Secondspace

Soja renamed Lefebvre's "conceived space" as "secondspace," emphasizing subjective and conceptual space.

Thirdspace

Soja renamed Lefebvre's "lived space" as "thirdspace." Soja argues for the "otherness" and "infinite possibilities" of thirdspace. Furthermore, Soja's thirdspace is normally connected with race, class, and protest and is more concerned with the spaces of resistance to the dominant order from their subordinate, peripheral, or marginalized position.

Narrative Space

Narrative space is space or place as a narrative element in a text. It concerns the way in which space (physical space, conceptual space, or symbolic space) is constructed rhetorically in the text. The forms of space in narrative texts can include movement, direction, landscape, etc.

Mythical Space

Mythical space usually has divine events and contains a great number of imaginary places or spatial relationships. Mythical space can either be composed on the basis of experienced spatial settings by humanity or it can be extraordinary and may ignore the logic of exclusion and contradiction.

God's Space

God's space in this work refers to the space where God appears and the place God occupies when God talks and moves. God's space includes also the space or place that God constructs.

Humanity's Space

Humanity's space in this work pertains to the space where humanity – either specific humans or humanity as a whole – acts (e.g., moves, talks). Humanity's space also includes the space or place that humanity constructs.

Nature's Space

Nature's space in this work pertains to natural environments and natural landscapes (e.g., mountains, rivers). Nature's space also includes the space or place where natural phenomena such as lightning or rain occur.

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